

Fate's Edge

Complete Worldbook

A Gazetteer of the Known Realms

AS TOLD BY THOSE WHO LIVE THERE, BLEED THERE, AND OWE THERE

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Preface: The Ledger Bleeds

I am an Aeler Edgewalker. You call us mountain-dwellers who measure breath in silver bells and seal contracts in stone. How adorably naïve.

We don't just measure breathwe own the lungs that draw it. When a Tulkani chieftain swears an oath on his firstborn's life? That's not honourit's collateral I've already hypothecated three times over. When a Veiled Sister binds a demon to a corpse to prop up her corpse-throne? That's not terrorit's a futures contract on soul-debt, and I'm the broker who sold the short position before the ritual even began.

You see the surface as "full of problems." How quaint. Problems aren't obstaclesthey're inventory.

This book isn't a tourist's guide. It's a hit list with footnotes. I've marked the places where a well-placed bell doesn't just open a passit starts a war I've already shorted the bond market on. Where a forged seal doesn't just move a mountainit triggers a landslide I've bought mineral rights to before the first crack appeared. Where a single true story doesn't just buy a ship's loyaltyit buys the captain's silence while I sell his manifest to pirates.

You want to build journeys? Draw your cards. Set your clocks. Spend your Story Beats like they mean something. But remember: every Diamond you earn is a tooth knocked out of someone else's jaw. Every Debt you incur? I already bought it from your victim for half what you'll payand I'm collecting interest in your marrow before you finish reading this sentence.

The road isn't just a ledger. It's a butcher's block. Every gate isn't a clauseit's a throat waiting for the knife.

The Edgewalker

The Cartomancers Compass

The Ledger of the Deck

The world does not speak in words. It speaks in suits, ranks, and the spaces between. Every bridge, every bribe, every broken oath can be laid out on a table of felt and dealt from a worn deck. This is not superstition. It is method.

The regional generators in this book—from the fog-choked levees of the Mistlands ([section 8.1](#)) to the walking cities of Ngomebe (??)—all speak the same language: the language of the fifty-two-card deck. Learn to read it, and you can generate a campaign, a crossroads, or a crisis in the time it takes to shuffle.

This chapter is your key. It explains how to interpret any card drawn from any regional generator, and how to weave those interpretations into the fiction at your table. Consider it the threshold between the abstract mechanics of the draw and the living, breathing world of Fates Edge.

The Four Suits: A Universal Grammar

Every card in every generator carries the same four suit-meanings. They are the alphabet of the worlds ledger.

0.0.1 ♠: Place The Stage

Where does the scene happen? ♠ is the threshold, the landmark, the ground beneath the action. It answers: *Where are we?*

- **High rank (10A):** A major landmark—a fortress, a capital, a haunted ruin. The place has a name that echoes in local songs.
- **Mid rank (69):** A functional location—a ford, a market, a shrine. The place has a purpose and a keeper.
- **Low rank (25):** A liminal or neglected place—a crossroads, a collapsed bridge, a smugglers cove. The place is defined by what it lacks.

In the regional chapters, ♠ entries are always places. See, for example, the bridges and canals of Silkstrand (??) or the cairns and passes of Ubral (??).

0.0.2 ♥: Actor The Face

Who drives the scene? ♥ is the person, the faction, the voice that speaks. It answers: *Who is here?*

- **High rank (JA):** An elite, a ruler, a power-broker. The actor has authority and reach beyond the immediate scene.

- **Mid rank (610):** A professional, a functionary, a skilled operator. The actor has a trade and a price.
- **Low rank (25):** A commoner, an outcast, a victim. The actor needs something or has been failed by someone.

In the regional chapters, ♡ entries are always people or factions. See the merchants and spies of the Brass Coast (??) or the spirit-wardens of the Mistlands ([section 8.1](#)).

0.0.3 ♣: Pressure The Complication

What pushes back? ♣ is the storm, the debt, the knife in the dark. It answers: *What goes wrong?*

- **High rank (10A):** A catastrophe, a betrayal, an invasion. The complication changes the shape of the journey.
- **Mid rank (69):** A serious obstacle a feud, a quarantine, a broken bridge. The complication costs time, resources, or reputation.
- **Low rank (25):** A minor hazard a sudden squall, a lost token, a raised toll. The complication is a nuisance, not a disaster.

In the regional chapters, ♣ entries are always complications or threats. See the river floods and witness-cord cuts of Ayokha (??) or the market riots of Silkstrand (??).

0.0.4 ◇: Leverage The Reward

What opens the door? ◇ is the token, the writ, the secret that changes Position. It answers: *What do you gain?*

- **High rank (JA):** A major asset a noble title, a keystone charter, a general pardon. The reward reshapes the partys standing.
- **Mid rank (610):** A significant tool a pass-stone, a witness cord, a lighthouse charter. The reward solves a specific class of problem.
- **Low rank (25):** A minor advantage a bridge token, a guest-cup, a rumour. The reward grants a single use of improved Position.

In the regional chapters, ◇ entries are always rewards or leverage. See the keystone charters of Ngomebe (??) or the water-share tablets of Fhara (??).

Rank and Severity: The Weight of the Card

The rank of a card from Ace (high) to 2 (low) sets the scale of its suits meaning. Use this ladder:

Rank	Narrative Weight
Ace	Legendary, campaign-altering, mythic
King/Queen/Jack	Major, faction-level, lasting consequences
107	Significant, scene-defining, costly
64	Moderate, manageable, a real cost
32	Minor, a complication but not a crisis

When a generator instructs you to set a clock by the highest rank, use this conversion:

- **25:** 4-segment clock (short, local problem)

- **610:** 6-segment clock (standard, journey-length)
- **J, Q, K:** 8-segment clock (extended, regional problem)
- **A:** 10-segment clock (epic, campaign-length)

Card Faces: The Court as Character

Face cards (Jack, Queen, King) are not merely high ranks. They are *persons* with agency, personality, and often a name.

- **Jack:** An agent, a functionary, a messenger. The Jack acts on someone else's authority. They are competent but replaceable.
- **Queen:** A power in their own right. The Queen has influence, resources, and a network. They are not easily replaced.
- **King:** The ultimate authority in their domain. The King is the source of law, the peak of the hierarchy. To challenge a King is to challenge the order itself.

When a face card appears in a ♡ (actor) draw, give the NPC a name, a motive, and a quirk. When it appears in a ♠ (place) or ♣ (pressure) draw, treat it as a *personified* force: a King of Clubs might be a feud that has lasted generations; a Queen of Spades might be a bridge that remembers every toll.

Aces and the Ninth: The Hollows Attention

An Ace is not merely the highest rank. It is a *threshold*. When an Ace appears in any draw, the Hollow takes notice. The GM gains 1 extra Story Beat (beyond any generated by 1s) to spend on a supernatural complication: a ghostly procession, a bell that rings without a clapper, a shadow that walks independently.

In regions where the Ninth Taboo is strong (see ??, ??, ??), an Ace may also trigger a specific regional omen. For example:

- In Theona (??), an Ace of ♠ might add a missing step to a bridge.
- In the Ways Between (??), an Ace of ♡ might cause a reflection to speak.
- In the Mistlands (section 8.1), an Ace of ♣ might cause a bell-line to fail.

The GM should always read an Ace as a signal to escalate the uncanny.

By the Numbers: Procedure for Any Generator

When you sit down to generate a scene, a journey leg, or a settlement, follow this procedure:

1. **Name the destination.** Which region? Which route? Which authority controls the gate?
2. **Shuffle and draw.** Draw cards face-up, one for each suit you need. Most generators require all four suits; some (like travel legs) may use only three.
3. **Read the ♠.** This is your place. Describe it first. Set the stage.
4. **Read the ♡.** This is your actor. Introduce them. What do they want? Why are they here?
5. **Read the ♣.** This is your pressure. Complicate the scene. What just went wrong, or what is about to?
6. **Read the ◇.** This is your leverage. What can the players gain if they succeed? Be specific.

7. **Set the clock.** Use the highest rank among the four cards to determine the size of the scenes primary clock (see [section 0.0.4](#)).
8. **Interpret faces and Aces.** Give names to face cards. Apply regional Ace effects.
9. **Play to find out.** Use the generated elements as prompts, not scripts. The cards are seeds, not fences.

Regional Flavours: How Suits Shift Meaning

While the core suit meanings remain constant, each region inflects them with its own texture. A ♠ in Ecktoria ([section 2.1](#)) is a forum or a coin-house; a ♠ in the Valewood (??) is a phasing ruin or a star-road. A ♥ in the Black Banners ([section 11.1](#)) is a mercenary captain or a condotta broker; a ♥ in Ykrul ([section 9.1](#)) is a khatun or a bone-singer.

Use the regional chapters as your lexicon. When you draw a card, consult the relevant table (e.g., [section 3.1](#) for Acasia, ?? for Oshiira). The table will give you a specific entry keyed to the rank and suit. Do not invent from scratch unless the table runs out the tables are designed to evoke the specific flavour of the region.

Example: A Draw in Acasia

You are running a journey through the Broken Marches ([section 3.1](#)). You draw:

♠ 7, ♥ J, ♣ 4, ♦ Q

1. ♠ 7: You consult [section 3.1](#). A 7 of Spades is Hill-Motte Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops.
2. ♥ J: You consult [section 3.1](#). A Jack of Hearts is Bride with No Dowry but a Claim Daggers in the wedding chest.
3. ♣ 4: You consult [section 3.1](#). A 4 of Clubs is Wedding Turns Ambush You are caught between two bloodlines.
4. ♦ Q: You consult [section 3.1](#). A Queen of Diamonds is Marriage Proxy From the Margravine; bind a hillking to your cause.
5. **Highest rank:** Queen (rank equivalent to King/J/Q at 8). The scenes primary clock is 8 segments: *The Feud Escalates [8]*.
6. **Interpretation:** The party arrives at a hill-fort (Hill-Motte) on the eve of a wedding. The bride (Bride with No Dowry) is caught between two feuding bloodlines. The wedding turns to violence (Wedding Turns Ambush). If the party can survive the ambush and broker peace, the Margravine will grant them a Marriage Proxy a powerful tool to bind a hill-king to their cause. The 8-segment clock tracks how quickly the feud spirals into open war.

This is the generator at work: four cards, one scene, immediate fiction.

The Unwritten Suit: When a Draw is Incomplete

Sometimes, a generator does not require all four suits. A travel leg, for example, may only need ♠, ♥, ♣ (see ??). A social encounter might only need ♥ and ♣. When a suit is missing, treat its absence as a question:

- **No ♠:** The place is ambiguous, shifting, or hidden. The scene occurs in a liminal space a crossroads, a fog-bank, a threshold.
- **No ♥:** The actor is absent, silent, or dead. The pressure and place act without a face. This can be more frightening than a named NPC.
- **No ♣:** The scene is calm, peaceful, or mercifully straightforward. This is rare in Fates Edge. Treasure it.
- **No ♦:** The reward is not a token but an outcome. The players gain Position, information, or a cleared clock rather than a physical asset.

Interpreting Any Draw, Any Region

When you need a prompt in a hurry a random encounter, a rumour at a tavern, a discovery in a ruin draw a single card. Use this quick-reference:

♠	A place or landmark. What is its name? What happened here?
♥	A person or faction. What do they want? What do they fear?
♣	A complication or threat. Who or what is the obstacle?
♦	A reward, token, or secret. What can be gained?

The rank tells you the scale. A low rank is local and personal; a high rank is regional and political. A face card demands a name; an Ace demands the Hollows attention.

This single-card method is ideal for improvisation. It gives you one clear element to build around. Let the fiction answer the rest.

Final Guidance: The Cards Are Oracles, Not Scripts

The generators in this book are tools, not tyrants. If a draw gives you an entry that contradicts established fiction, or if you simply prefer a different interpretation, overrule it. The deck is a prompt, not a prison.

But trust it, too. The most memorable sessions often come from the card you did not expect. The Ace that arrives at the wrong moment. The Jack who speaks a name no one wanted to hear. The diamond that glows with a secret debt.

Shuffle. Draw. Interpret. And let the road unfold.

The ledger is never closed. It is only passed to the next keeper. Dusana of the Raven Road

For the GM The Spider, the Snake, the Raven

The three Omens (**Inaea**, **Isoka**, **Ikasha**) are not gods. They are forces that appear in whispers, dreams, and the spaces between counted things. Do not introduce them directly. Instead, let players encounter their echoes:

- A rope that never frays (Inaea)
- A judgment that cuts clean (Isoka)
- A dream that feels too real (Ikasha)

By the time players learn the names, they should have already felt their presence for many sessions.

The full truth of the Omens the Clockwork Demon, the scouring of civilisations, Ikasha's imprisonment in Obishaal is **endgame content**. Use the fragments in this book as breadcrumbs:

- If players ask a Pereshi firekeeper about the serpent judge, they will receive a riddle.
- If they ask a Tulkani about the dreamer, they will receive a story.
- If they ask a Sidhi about the spider, they will receive a knot and a warning: *Do not pull it unless you are ready to see what it holds.*

The Hollow is the interest on the Omens' oldest debt. The players are never meant to pay it off only to decide whose name goes on the next line of the ledger.

Part I

The Amaranthine Sea & Northern Shores

“The sea keeps a better ledger than any scribe. The reef remembers every secret whispered above its depths. Do not ask which flag flies highest ask which hull leaks slowest.” Dusana of the Raven Road

Chapter 1

Kahfagia

The Flag of Storms.

I was born on the tide, which is to say I was born owing. My mother was a net-mender who lost her fingers to a reef-cutter's debt. My father was a bell that is to say, he rang when the Admiralty pulled his string. I learned to read the lantern codes before I learned my letters, and I learned that every light is a lie waiting to be told.

The Admiralty runs this place like a pirate charter with a budget and oh, how they love pretending it's legitimate. They control the beacons that lure ships onto reefs, the booms that shatter hulls for salvage rights, and the tariffs that fund their champagne baths. But here's the secret the commodores don't want you to know: the lanterns are afraid of the dark too.

I've seen a Mirror-Keeper weep when her reflection showed her a daughter she'd sold for a pilot's license. I've watched a Privateer Captain kiss a silver coin before a raid the same coin her mother kissed before she never came back. This is not a city of heroes. It is a city of people who learned that the sea is cheaper than mercy.

If you want to move cargo through the straits without becoming fish food, get a convoy letter stamped with the Admiral's seal. Or get smart. Or get gone.

Captain Mira "the Lucky," Sidhi exile, pirate by convenience

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish porridgedried cod soaked overnight, boiled with hardtack and a splash of lamp oil. The oil is for calories. The fish is for memory. Every Kahfagian child learns to taste the salt and know which coast their grandmother came from.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count ships by their lanterns. Three lanterns means a Kahfagian merchantsafe. Four means an Oshiiran grain bargeneutral. One, low in the water, means a privateer. Run.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their hands. Dock-workers have rope-burned palms. Merchants have ink-stained fingers. Privateers have no fingernailsthey bite them off in storms.

What is the most common crime? False manifests. Every third ship carries cargo that doesn't appear on its papers. The Admiralty knows. The Admiralty takes a cut. The Admiralty calls it a "tariff surcharge."

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Mirror-Keepers are not bornthey are made. And the making requires a death. A sister, a daughter, a lover. Someone who drowned so the keeper could see through the fog.

Where do people go when they die? The tide takes them. Kahfagia has no cemeteries above ground. The drowned are weighted with chain and dropped in the deep channel. Their families light candles in paper boats and float them out at dusk. If the candle reaches the horizon, the soul is forgiven. If it sinks, the debt is not yet paid.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer your bell. Every Kahfagian carries a small brass bell on a leather cordthe sound of their name. Offering it to the wronged party means "I give you my voice. Speak for me." Refusing to return the bell after an apology is a declaration of blood feud.

What is the most important festival? The Beacon Lighting (midwinter). Every lighthouse keeper lights a new lamp from the Admiral's flame. If your beacon catches first, your year will be lucky. If it sputters, you will owe a death to the sea.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Admiral's lantern code has a ninth signalnever used, never spoken, burned into every keeper's memory. It means *"Kill the witnesses. Sink the evidence. The sea will hide the rest."*

1.1 Kahfagia — “The Creole Thalassocracy”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights but the spiders weave in the mirror-towers.*

Admiral of Lantern-Law (Elite): “Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights and woe to the fool who rows against them. Yet I have seen the reflection move before the hand that holds it. The tides are not the only ones with secrets.”

Dockside Factor (Commoner): “The pilots see farther than kings. A gesture in lantern-code can open ports, or close them. Keep your accounts settled, and your lamps trimmed. And if a greyrobed stranger offers to adjust your mirror for free say no. The Lethaiar have long memories, and longer webs.”

Genre / Mood: Creole thalassocracy, signalandlane politics, eldritch tide, secret infiltration.

Starting Location: The Lantern Pier admiralty chapel, where votive ships hang from the ceiling and brine drips from the icon of a drowned saint. A seanotary unlocks a saltstained reliquary and produces a chart with gilt edges. “Fetch the contraband bell from the corsair galleass *Santa Dolorosa* before moonrise or the harbour names you accomplices. And watch for silk threads on the bollards. The Spider’s children are everywhere.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Kahfagia is the Creole child of Oshiira and the Vilikari a thalassocracy where Oshiiran tallies meet Vilikari tidelaw. The Admiralty of Lantern-Law rules not by armies but by light, yet the real power flows through a tangled web of oligarchic families, each with their own spies, their own private navies, and their own seat on the Shadow Council. Above them all floats a central Admiralty fleet, charged with protecting the beacon monopoly and with watching the watchers.

But the oligarchs are not the only players. Unseen, the Lethaiar of Inaea have been infiltrating the mirrortowers for decades. A factor’s trusted secretary, a harbour master’s silent wife, a pilot’s apprentice with toostill eyes they weave their webs not for coin, but for *control*. They do not seek to destroy Kahfagia. They seek to *own* it, strand by strand, until the entire thalassocracy hums to the rhythm of the Spider’s mercy.

What you notice first: The constant chime of bell-buoys. The smell of salt, tar, and burnt oil from a thousand lanterns. The way everyone admiral to dockhand glances at the tide clock before speaking. And the faint, almost invisible silk threads tied around the bollards of the wealthiest piers.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never argue with a MirrorKeeper about where the channel lies. If they say the safe water moved, it moved. Your chart is already kindling. And if the MirrorKeeper smiles too widely, check the back of their neck for a spider’s brand.

Regional Mood: The Lantern’s Vigil & The Spider’s Web

Power is visible here literally. Every night, a thousand lamps burn along the channels, each a statement of control. To dim a light is to declare bankruptcy. To move a beacon is to declare war.

Commodores sit in their mirrortowers, watching reflections, while tideclocks tick down to the next auction, the next inspection, the next quiet burial of a reputation.

But beneath the visible power, another war is fought in whispers. The Lethaiar agents of Inaea have spent a generation infiltrating the oligarchic families. A young heir who suddenly displays uncanny negotiating skill may not be talented they may be *woven*. A MirrorKeeper whose beacons never fail may be receiving guidance from a source that does not appear on any chart. The Spider's web is patient. It does not break the thalassocracy; it *guides* it.

Prominent NPCs of Kahfagia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Admiral Zafira	Commander of Lantern-Law	Keep the beacon monopoly intact	She has never lost a ship to the reefs. Her charts are said to be drawn in water.
Mirza al-Qasr	Mirror-Keeper of the Pointe	Control the tides through light	Her face is never seen only reflected. Some say she has no shadow.
Ximena	Dockside Factor (commoner exemplar)	Profit from every cargo, legal or not	She keeps a tally in lemon juice; heat reveals the truth.
Captain Rodrigo	Privateer with a crooked letter of marque	Raid the corsair fleet and pay off his crew	His ship flies three flags; the one he lowers last is the one that matters.
Sister Anabel	Healer of the Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (Temple of Light)	Tend the sick without asking payment	Her grey robes are said to be woven from old promises. They never stain.
Notary Farid	Admiralty magistrate	Resolve disputes before they reach the harbour master	He carries a waterclock in his sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.

The Harpist	Veiled	Lethaiar infiltrator (secret)	Woven the oligarchs, strand by strand	No one knows her face. She plays only in mirrorlit rooms, and her music leaves threads of silk in the listeners’ hair.
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The Oligarchic Houses (Shadow Council)

The true rulers of Kahfagia are not the Admiralty alone, but the **Shadow Council** of seven oligarchic families. Each controls a monopoly (spice, salt, silk, timber, pitch, shipbuilding, or intelligence). Each maintains its own private navy and network of spies. Each vies for the empty seat left by the family that the Lethaiar have already *woven* into silence.

- **House alKassam (Spice):** Oldest, proudest, most vulnerable. The Lethaiar have already replaced the family steward.
- **House Carrasco (Salt):** Ruthless pragmatists; they suspect infiltration but cannot prove it.
- **House Mirat (Silk):** Secret allies of the Lethaiar they trade webs for influence.
- **House del Puerto (Shipbuilding):** Neutral; they build for anyone who pays.
- **House Henares (Timber):** Deeply weighed down by Admiralty claims; the Lethaiar are slowly buying their notes.
- **House de la Vela (Intelligence):** The Admiralty’s own spy network and already compromised.
- **The Empty Chair:** Once held by House Morat, now vacant. The other houses whisper that the Morats were not destroyed they were *rewoven*.

Secret Faction: The Silk Vigil (Lethaiar Infiltrators)

Agents of Inaea, the Spider’s children have spent a generation worming into Kahfagia’s elite. They do not steal or sabotage they *guide*. A decision that benefits House Carrasco is subtly nudged toward the Lethaiar’s longterm goal: a unified thalassocracy that answers not to the Admiralty, but to the Web.

Signs of Infiltration:

- A factor’s handwriting becomes unnaturally precise, the loops forming faint eightshapes.
- A MirrorKeeper’s reflections show the same face in every tower a woman with chestnutbrown skin and eyes like polished jet.
- A ship that should have foundered instead limps to port, its crew speaking of a greyrobed passenger who vanished before docking.

Mechanical Hook: Once per session, a PC may roll Wits + Lore (DV 4) to notice a silken thread in an official’s collar or a spider’s brand on a dockhand’s wrist. On success, they identify a

Lethaiar agent. On failure, the agent becomes aware of their scrutiny and the Web tightens.

Names of Kahfagia

Inspired by the seafaring republics of the western coast, blended with Oshiiran and Vilikari influences: liquid consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that denote a port, a ship, or a founding ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Safir	Zafira	alKassam	<i>the Lantern</i>
Idris	Ximena	del Puerto	<i>TideKeeper</i>
Farid	Layla	de la Vela	<i>the Unlit</i>
Jabir	Aisha	Carrasco	<i>MirrorEye</i>
Rodrigo	Salma	Mirat	<i>BellBorn</i>
Tarik	Nura	Henares	<i>AshSails</i>

Spades — Places (Littoral/Lane/Law)

2. **Tidal Mudflat** — Hidden plankway at low water; smugglers' shortcut. *At ebb, the planks rise like the ribs of a drowned whale.* '[STEALTH]'
3. **Salt-Scar Pier** — Behind dawn spice auctions; where fortunes wash ashore. *Auditors check the saltscars white crust that proves cargo was cleaned, not stolen.* '[TRADE]'
4. **Reedbelt Creeks** — Smuggler paths where tax boats won't follow. *A hanged man's boots hang from a piling; those who pass tug their collars.* '[STEALTH]'
5. **Breakwater Gap** — Under repair; cutters slip at dusk through the works. *The stone is still loose. A wrong step, and the sea claims another toll.* '[TRAVEL]'
6. **Dredged Channel** — Fresh with temporary beacons; tomorrow's safe water. *The buoys are painted yellow the colour of "maybe."* '[TRAVEL]'
7. **River Sluice** — Tidegate and boomchain; access controlled by rope and writ. *The chain has a notch where a slaver's ship tried to flee. It still drips oil.* '[AUTHORITY]'
8. **Cutter Yard** — Narrowkeel vessels; apprentices work night shifts. *They sing old work songs the kind that skip the ninth beat.* '[LABOR]'
9. **Lantern Alley** — Foglane where beacons migrate with the tide. *Follow the lights. Two blinks means you're expected. Three? You're prey.* '[WEATHER]'
10. **Admiralty Quay** — Bonded warehouses under seal; law walks the decks. *The seal on the door changes with the tide. Today it's a serpent eating its tail.* '[AUTHORITY]'
- J **Red Shoal** — Quiet water, loud reputations; where deals are made. *Old barges moored together; a floating court with no bailiff.* '[SOCIAL]'
- Q **Mirror Tower** — Pilot station that certifies safe water today. *The mirror at the top shows not the sea, but the face of the last captain who argued.* '[JUSTICE]'
- K **Kassamira Port** — Presidial; auctions at dawn, courts by noon. *The auctioneer's gavel is wrapped in a page torn from a debtor's tally.* '[TRADE]'
- A **The Pointe** — Strait of stormlights and wreckers' tales. *On still nights, you can hear the drowned singing the names of those who carry weight.* '[DEATH]'

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tide-Runner** — Bell and rope; knows every tidetable by heart. *“The table says high water at noon. The moon lies. Trust my rope.”* ‘[TRAVEL]’
3. **Pilot’s Apprentice** — Perfect memory for shoals; tomorrow’s navigator. *Touches a brass talisman before every sounding. No one knows why.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
4. **Lantern Clerk** — Knows which lights moved, and why; keeper of the shifts. *Docks with a tally that smells of smoke. Adds a surcharge for “recent adjustments.”* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Oshiiran Factor** — Two tallies; one for Kahfagia, one for truth. *The left tally records bribes as “conciliation fees.” The right one is never shown.* ‘[TRADE]’
6. **Dock-Syndic** — Makes queues vanish; power in the pause. *He never raises his voice. The harbour master listens anyway.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
7. **Lantern Advocate** — “Jurisdiction moves like tide”; law in flux. *She carries a waterclock in her sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
8. **Privateer Captain** — “Crooked” letter of convoy; profit in the margins. *Her ship flies three flags; the one she lowers last is the one that matters.* ‘[COMBAT]’
9. **Thalassoi Sergeant** — Shore leave but still on duty; marine precision. *A tattoo of a lighthouse on his forearm; the light is his wife’s name.* ‘[COMBAT]’
10. **Admiralty Magistrate** — Rules fast, travels faster; justice in a hurry. *She once sentenced a man to the galleys and boarded the ship before he did.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- J **Dredging Foreman** — Channel follows their purse; water reshaped. *His crew are excriminals; he pays them in salt pork and absolution.* ‘[LABOR]’
- Q **Mirror-Keeper (Elite)** — Commodore’s confidante; places beacons that bind. *Their faces are never seen only reflected. Some say they have none.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Kahfagian Commodore** — Off the books but on the water; shadow admiral. *His flagship is a fishing smack. Its nets drag up letters of marque.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **Admiral of Red Shoal** — Offers wine, figs once. Price in stories. *She pours the first cup herself. If she pours a second, you’ve already agreed.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Clubs — Complications/Threats

(Entries unchanged except for the addition of a new threat: **Web Unravelled** a Lethaiar agent is exposed, and the oligarchs turn on each other.)

2. **Early Tide** — Turns two bells early; grounding risk rises like the sea. ‘[WEATHER]’ *Someone bribed the tideclerk or the moon is angry.*
3. **Smothering Fog** — Sound travels, sight does not; navigation by ear alone. ‘[WEATHER]’ *You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you.*
4. **Boom Slam** — Harbour chain slams shut; wrong side means delay or danger. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The chain’s links are inscribed with names of those who owe. Each one rattles differently.*
5. **Light Shift** — Beacons change midapproach; your lane just moved. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Someone paid the Lantern Clerk. Find out who or drift into the reefs.*
6. **Pilot Strike** — No escorts available; average unpaid, risk assumed. ‘[LABOR]’ *The pilots sit in their guildhall, drinking tea, watching ships founder.*
7. **Customs Inspection** — Ladder audits cargo and crew; delays bite deep. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The inspector has a silver tooth. He smiles when he sees a manifest.*

8. **Reef-Runners** — Corsair skiffs circle with boarding hooks; steel in the spray. '[COMBAT]' *Their leader wears a MirrorKeeper's badge stolen or earned, you cannot tell.*
9. **Jurisdiction Flip** — Lanternlaw shifts; your writ no longer bites. '[JUSTICE]' *The tide turned. So did the magistrate. Your safeconduct is now kindling.*
10. **Fire Risk** — Alchemical cargo aboard; quarantine if anything spills. '[DISASTER]' *A single spark and the whole quay becomes a crater. The factor wants you to know this.*
- J **Quartermaster Betrayal** — Tidetables sold to rival; route compromised. '[SOCIAL]' *The betrayal is written in lemon juice; heat reveals the name.*
- Q **Yellow Flag** — Port quarantine; deadlines rot on the hook. '[DEATH]' *The flag is dyed with turmeric and something else something that smells sweet.*
- K **Fleet Redeploy** — "Safe" corridor becomes parade ground; chaos in formation. '[AUTHORITY]' *Admirals play chess with real ships, and you are a pawn.*
- A **Black Squall (at the Pointe)** — Scatters ships and stories alike. '[WEATHER]' '[DEATH]' *This is no natural storm. The water hisses. Something below is waking.*
- + **Web Unravelling** — A Lethaiar agent is exposed. The oligarchs turn on each other, accusing every rival of being a spider. '[POLITICS]' '[FEAR]' *Silk threads appear on every doorknob. No one trusts their shadow.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

(Unchanged; the existing rewards work well for a thalassocracy.)

2. **Mooring Chit** — Skip the Mooring Roll once; harbour favours you. '[TRAVEL]' *The chit is a dried seahorse shell. Keep it away from salt.*
3. **Pilotage Token** — One certified escort through a bad channel. '[TRAVEL]' *The pilot who accepts it must touch your shoulder before speaking.*
4. **Fee Waiver** — Cargo cleared today; tally smiles included. '[TRADE]' *The clerk stamps it twice once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
5. **Safe-Conduct** — Along specific beacons lane; law walks with you. '[TRAVEL]' *The commodore's seal is warm. It cools as the exit nears.*
6. **Salvage Rights** — On named quay or reach; flotsam becomes fortune. '[TRADE]' *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
7. **Warehouse Access** — Bonded storage; seal prize before rivals sniff. '[TRADE]' *The key is a bronze finger. It fits only one lock and breaks after use.*
8. **Lantern Code** — Tonight's signals revealed; navigation advantage. '[TRAVEL]' *Three quick flashes: safe passage. One long, two short: the Admiralty is watching.*
9. **Dredging Grant** — You decide where next channel runs; reshape the sea. '[AUTHORITY]' *The dredgers are convicts. They work faster if you promise a name in their favour.*
10. **Letter of Marque** — Convoy protection for one season; legal blades. '[COMBAT]' *The ink is mixed with gunpowder. It smokes slightly when read.*
- J **Admiralty Judgment** — Precedent travels with you; law bends. '[JUSTICE]' *The case number is burned into a leather tag. Tag it to a belt loop.*
- Q **Mirror Warrant** — Legal right to post a beacon; redraw the map. '[AUTHORITY]' *The MirrorKeeper's seal, still warm. The channel you mark becomes law until challenged.*
- K **Spice Share** — Stake in Kassamira auction floor; profit in pepper. '[TRADE]' *The share is*

a peppercorn sealed in wax. Bite it to test authenticity.

A **Lantern License** — Temporary authority to redefine the lane. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The harbour master spits when he hands it over. Use it wisely or not at all.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (25 → 4, 610 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/rights/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea & signal** motifs beacons that migrate, tides that remember, law that flows like water. If a King or Ace of Spades appears, also echo **web motifs** silk threads on a bollard, a reflection that holds too long, the faint smell of spiced tea (the Lethaiar are near).

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Pilot’s Mirror:** Kahfagia’s strength is not its fleet but its monopoly on light and lane. To post a beacon is to redraw the map. Any character with a Mirror Warrant may permanently move a beacon or buoy (GM sets a 4segment clock). For the duration of that clock, all navigation rolls on that lane are at +1 Position for the party and 1 Position for rivals.
- **Lantern-Law Privilege:** While flying an Admiralty flag or carrying a valid Lantern License, your ship may pass through chainbooms and customs points at +1 Position. The first time in a session you invoke this privilege, the GM gains 1 SB (the Admiralty is watching).
- **Oligarchic Favour (Leverage Track):** Instead of tracking coin weights, track *Favour* with the great families (alKassam, Carrasco, Mirat, etc.). Favour 13 gives you access to private docks, early auction warnings, and offthebooks pilots. Favour 4+ lets you call in a family to block a rival’s safeconduct or raise a false alarm on their ship.
- **The Web’s Patience (Secret Clock [6]):** Tracks the Lethaiar infiltration of the Shadow Council. The clock ticks when the party helps a Lethaiar agent, exposes a rival house’s secrets, or ignores a silken thread. At 3, the Harpist’s name appears on a dockmaster’s manifest. At 6, the Empty Chair is filled and the new house head bows to a greyrobed stranger. The party may reduce the clock by exposing an agent or by warning an oligarch (costs Favour 2).
- **Western Reach Rumours:** Once per port visit, a character may roll Wits + Lore (DV 3) to hear a rumour from a captain returned from beyond the mirror. On success, the GM reveals one of the six rumours (see below) as a foreshadowing hook or a clue for an ongoing arc.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Lantern Bearer** The Traveler. *A light that never goes out; a promise that never sinks.*
 - **The Mirror-King** The Witness. *Reflections that remember every lie, every promise, every cargo.*
 - **The Tide Father** Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the weight that the sea collects at ebb.*
 - **The Spider’s Daughter** Inaea (secret). *The web that binds the oligarchs, strand by patient strand.*
 - **The Unlit** Ikasha. *The ninth lamp that is never lit; the safe harbour that exists only

in rumour.*

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **Saint Alvaro of the Lantern (The Traveler):** The Admiralty's mirrortowers double as wayshrines for the Saint of Lost Channels. Sailors who light a candle before a voyage and whisper a destination to the mirror claim the tide will not turn against them before they reach it. The MirrorKeepers charge a fee for this service payable in salt, not silver.
- **The Silken Coup (Inaea):** The Lethaiar call their infiltration the *Genteel Harvest*. They do not conquer; they adopt. An oligarch who accepts a greyrobed advisor finds that their children are betrothed to shadowkin, their tallies are copied in disappearing ink, and their mirrortower shows only the face they wish to see not the one that watches them sleep.
- **The TideSworn Compact (The Admiral of Sealed Tides):** A small but influential order of notaries based in Kassamira Port. They adjudicate disputes over beacon rights, cargo claims, and pilotage fees. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they accept no bribes only binding oaths. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three voyages are plagued by contrary winds.
- **The Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (The Bitter Root):** A hospice on Deadman's Quay is run by greyrobed healers of the Order. They ask no payment, but they never forget a face. It is said that if you accept their care, you owe a favour to the sea itself and the sea always collects. Smugglers leave small offerings of fresh water on the pier to stay in the Order's good graces.
- **The Ninth:** In any lanternlit scene, the ninth lamp lit in a room reveals a threshold. The wise stop at eight. Those who light the ninth are said to see a figure standing on the water outside the window waiting.

Kahfagia Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over your shoulder before entering a new channel. Ignore the first *Smothering Fog* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Turn the Lantern:** Spin the binnacle lamp once counterclockwise. Cancel *Boom Slam* or take 1 die on your next pilot check (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a true name into a lead line. Gain +1 Effect against corsairs for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Tide Court. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Cut the Thread:** If you find a silk thread on your bollard, cut it with a silver knife. Negate the next *Web's Patience* tick. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

(Unchanged; see earlier table.)

Western Reach Rumours (d6, fast hooks)

1. A harbour where bells toll under water; cargo *must* be named aloud.
2. A spice that stops bleeding until moonrise.
3. A mirrorreef that reflects storms from a week ahead.
4. A pilotage guild that uses birds, not beacons.

5. A fleet that sails by *shadow* cast on fog.
6. A court that weighs obligations in *breath*, not coin.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your colour, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal / Web & Silk)

- **The Mirror-Keeper of Kassamira (signal tyrant)** *Phases:* Audit → Blacklist → Light Embargo. *Cracks:* rival beacon logs, Tide Court precedent, stolen codebook.
- **Corsair-Chaplain of the Pointe (relic raider)** *Phases:* Charm → Board → Bell-Wake. *Cracks:* sanctified boom, cofradía oath, drowned saint tithe.
- **The Veiled Harpist (Spider’s Daughter)** *Phases:* Whisper → Weave → Harvest. *Cracks:* speak a true name of a Lethaiar agent, cut a strand of the Web with silver, or remind an oligarch of a weight older than the Spider’s memory.

Patronage & Power

In Kahfagia, power flows through control of the sea lanes themselves and through the silken threads that bind the oligarchs to the Spider’s will. The maritime oligarchs have built their empire not through conquest of territory but through mastery of navigation and the quiet manipulation of obligation. Every beacon, every channel marker, every mirrorlight is both a navigational aid and a legal instrument. But behind every mirror, a greyrobed woman watches. And she is very, very patient.

For the GM: Kahfagian patronage revolves around access to channels, to cargo, to legal protection. Rewards often take the form of pilotage tokens, safeconducts, or salvage rights. But the secret war of the Lethaiar adds a new layer: players may be hired to expose an agent, to protect an oligarch from being “woven,” or even to ally with the Spider’s children for a share of the Harvest. Use the **Web’s Patience** clock to track the infiltration; let players decide whether to slow it, accelerate it, or ride it to power.

Amaria The Iron Shore

A small peninsula squeezed between Kahfagia’s Akilan holdings and the Oshiiran border, Amaria is a land of iron mines, coastal fog, and hybrid law. Ecktoria once claimed it; now it pays tribute to both Kahfagia and Oshiira to stay independent. Its people speak a creole of Kahfagian maritime slang and Oshiiran bureaucratic precision, and its courts rule by a blend of Admiralty tariff law and Vermilion Corps ledgerjustice.

What you notice first: The smell of rust and brine. The way every official carries two seals one for Kahfagia, one for Oshiira. The constant ticking of waterclocks that never agree on the hour.

The rule that kills newcomers: Never carry only one flag. Amarian vessels fly both the lantern and the grain sheaf. A single flag is a declaration of allegiance and an invitation to be sunk by the other side.

Quick Generators for Amaria (d6 each)

Spades Places (d6)

1. **Iron Quay** A pier built from salvaged warship timbers. The nails are iron from the inland mines; they rust red, staining the water like blood. '[INDUSTRY]'
2. **CoinHouse of Two Tallies** A countinghouse where every transaction is recorded twice once for the Kahfagian tariff, once for the Oshiiran grain tithe. The third tally is the smuggler's. '[TRADE]'
3. **Fog Lighthouse (Disputed)** A stone tower with two lamps: one green for Kahfagia, one white for Oshiira. Only one is lit at a time. The keeper changes them with the tide. '[AUTHORITY]'
4. **Smuggler's Rope-Walk** A hidden cove where boats land at low tide. The ropewalk is a series of knotted lines that lead to a cave full of untaxed cargo. '[STEALTH]'
5. **Mine Shaft of the Ninth Vein** An iron mine that goes deeper than the surveyors mapped. The miners whisper of a sealed door at the bottom Aeler work, they say. '[MYSTERY]'
6. **Dual Customs Post** A wooden shack with two windows: one for Kahfagian stamps, one for Oshiiran seals. The line snakes between them. Smugglers pay both clerks and skip the line. '[AUTHORITY]'

Hearts People (d6)

1. **TwoTally Clerk** Sits at a split desk, writing with two hands. Her left hand files Kahfagian tariffs; her right, Oshiiran grain receipts. Her third hand the one no one sees writes the real numbers. '[TRADE]'
2. **Iron Miner (Free)** A former indentured labourer who bought his freedom with a year's ore. His hands are stained red with rust. He knows the sealed door's location but will not speak of it. '[LABOR]'
3. **Smuggler Captain** Flies no flag. His ship's name changes with each port. He speaks four languages badly and navigates by the taste of salt on the wind. '[STEALTH]'
4. **Kahfagian Customs Agent** A oneeyed woman with a brass hook for a hand. She stamps cargo with a bellshaped seal. The seal rings when the declared value is a lie. '[AUTHORITY]'
5. **Oshiiran Grain Auditor** Thin, spectacled, carries a grain balance. He measures every sack against the Widow's standard. He has found nine thieves this year. The tenth was his own clerk. '[JUSTICE]'
6. **Fog Keeper (Lighthouse)** An old sailor who lost his sight to a Kahfagian mirror flash. He tends the lamps by touch. He knows which flag flies by the heat of the glass green is cool, white is warm. '[WEATHER]'

Clubs Complications (d6)

1. **Tariff DoubleCross** Both Kahfagia and Oshiira claim the same customs fee. Pay one, and the other impounds your cargo. Pay both, and you are bankrupt. Smuggle, and you are a patriot. '[WEIGHT]'

2. **Mine Collapse (Sealed Door)** A cavein opens a passage to the sealed Aeler door. The miners are afraid. Something is breathing on the other side. The party is asked to investigate or to seal it again. ‘[DISASTER]’
3. **Lighthouse Outage** Both lamps go dark. Ships founder on the reef. The keeper is found dead, one hand on each lamp. The cause of death: old age or old obligation. ‘[DEATH]’
4. **Census Dispute** Oshiira claims Amaria’s population for grain tithes; Kahfagia claims it for port taxes. The same people are counted twice or not at all. The party is asked to audit the tallies. The tallies are on fire. ‘[POLITICS]’
5. **Iron Embargo** A rival faction sinks an ore barge. Both powers blame each other. The price of iron spikes. The party’s cargo is now worth a fortune and a target. ‘[COMBAT]’
6. **The Ninth Vein Opens** The sealed door cracks. A cold wind blows from the deep. The miners flee. A voice whispers a name the name of the party member who carries the deepest weight. ‘[MYSTERY]’

Diamonds Rewards (d6)

1. **Dual Customs Stamp** One stamp, two seals. Passes both Kahfagian and Oshiiran checkpoints without inspection. Use once per journey. ‘[TRAVEL]’
2. **Iron Ingot (Ninth Vein)** A bar of ore from the sealed door’s chamber. It is warm to the touch. Aeler runes glow on its surface. Trade it to the True Masons for a favour. ‘[TRADE]’
3. **Fog Keeper’s Log** A journal of tide and lamp schedules. Decode it to predict when the disputed lighthouse will be unguarded. Gain +1 Position on smuggling attempts. ‘[WEATHER]’
4. **TwoTally Receipt** A document that proves you paid both tariffs. It is written in disappearing ink. The ink vanishes after one use but the paper remembers. ‘[JUSTICE]’
5. **Miner’s Compass** A brass needle that points to the sealed door. It also points to the nearest iron vein and to the nearest heart that beats with greed. ‘[TRAVEL]’
6. **Smuggler’s Flag (Neutral)** A plain grey banner. Fly it to pass between Kahfagian and Oshiiran patrols unmolested. The patrols will not salute. They will not shoot. They will pretend they did not see you. ‘[STEALTH]’

Chapter 2

Ecktoria

Marble & Fire.

My grandfather was a senator. He voted to burn the Ykrul tribute-pact, and then he voted to burn the inquiry into why the grain ships sank. He signed his name in wax and watched the city burn three times. He never raised his voice.

I am a Coin-House Factor. I seal deals with three ribbonswhite for "ask," red for "now," black for "never." I have never used the black ribbon. Not because I am kind, but because "never" is a debt I cannot collect.

Ecktoria is an Empire that never quite diedmore like a corpse propped up by gilded scaffolding and the stubborn refusal of its undertakers to admit the job's done. The Everflame burns in every basilica not as a symbol of divine truth, but as a literal lie detector: swear a false oath near it, and your tongue turns black. I have seen a merchant's tongue turn black mid-sentence. He finished his lie anyway. The buyers pretended not to notice. *That is Ecktoria.*

The statues watch. The fire judges. The marble remembers every name carved into its stepsand every name left out.

Do not refuse a toast in a coin-house. The ledgers are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined credit. You will not borrow again.

Marcus of the Red Ledger, Coin-House Factor, third generation

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Spiced flatbread dipped in olive oil and honeybut only if you can afford the honey. The poor eat millet porridge with a single dried fig. The fig is counted as part of the household's grain allowance.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count coins by touch. Every

Ecktorian child has a box of worn sesterces; by age five, they can tell a debased copper from pure silver by the weight alone.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their signature. Ecktorians judge by handwriting before face. A clerk with a steady hand is trustworthy. A noble with a flourish is hiding something. A merchant who signs with an X is not worth doing business with.

What is the most common crime? Tax evasionbut it is not a crime, it is a sport. Every household keeps two ledgers: the white one for the Censor, the red one for the family. The art is in keeping the red ledger from looking like a confession.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Censor's clerks are paid to find discrepancies. They are also paid to lose them. The price of a lost discrepancy is exactly 5% of the tax owed. This is not corruption. It is "administrative flexibility."

Where do people go when they die? The family crypt, beneath the basilica floor. The wealthy are burned, their ashes mixed with marble dust and pressed into the floor tiles. The poor are buried in unmarked graves outside the walls. The Everflame's light does not reach that far.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You petition the Censor to have the wrong stricken from the public record. The petition costs a tenth of your annual income. If accepted, the wrong is erasedlegally, it never happened. If rejected, the wrong is published, and you lose your civic standing.

What is the most important festival? The Triumph of the Flame (autumn equinox). The basilica's central flame is carried in procession through every district. To touch the flame is to be absolved of petty debts. To be burned by it is a sign that your debts are not petty.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Grand Magistrate's seal is a forgery. The original cracked in 783 AR. The current seal was carved by a prison engraver who was executed to keep the secret. The engraver's apprentice is still alive. They live in Silkstrand. They have the original sketches.

2.1 Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The flame remembers. The marble cracks. The law forgets but the statues watch.*

Grand Magistrate (Elite): “The law is written in marble and witnessed by the flame. Every judgment echoes in the stones but the stones have grown quiet. The patricians do not listen. They have forgotten what the flame tastes like. They seal their windows with silk and call it governance.”

Ferrymaster (Commoner): “I’ve seen the city burn three times. The marble remembers the heat. The flame remembers the lies. The rich have stopped looking at the flames. They only look at each other and at the cracks in their own mirrors. The fire isn’t burning anymore, friend. It’s *smiling*.”

Genre / Mood: Imperial decay, bureaucratic horror, memory as weight, Renaissance decadence a city walled off from its own rot, where the wealthy dance while the poor cough ash.

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles gutter beside melted icons. A factor with smoke-stained fingers offers a folded note. “The Lame King moves tonight. The Basilica burns with him. The Amber Palace hasn’t answered a summons in a month. Find out who lit the fire or the Vigil will audit your soul at dawn. And stay away from the Arena. The statues have been *whispering*.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Once the heart of the Utaran Empire, Ecktoria has worn its laurels into chains. Three centuries of sack, fire, and slow decline have not stripped its marble forums nor its gold-sealed coin-houses but each day, more of its weight slips into the hands of mercenaries and whispers. The Black Banners march on its purse, avenging old Ykrul wounds by proxy. Processions still crown its stairways, yet ash lines every step. The city burns not only with memory, but with a grief that refuses to name itself.

Yet the true sickness is not in the streets. It is in the **Amber Palace**, where the old patrician families have walled themselves away. They sit on laurels preserved from the empire, drinking wine that costs a village’s harvest, whispering deals with merchants who have never seen a loom. **Maelstraeus**, the demon of commerce, has threaded their accounts with invisible tolls; every contract they sign forgets a clause. **Livaea**, the demon of desire, has wrapped their hearts in silk; they marry for influence, divorce for scandal, and love only the reflection of themselves in gilded mirrors reflections that no longer blink. The common folk call them the *Unburdened* not because they carry no weight, but because they have forgotten what weight *feels* like.

The **Vigil** once the empire’s secret police, now a fractured ghost of an institution fights a silent war over the dream of restoration. One faction, the **Censer-Knights**, serves the Everflame and the Synod, hunting heresy and latent magic with brass censers and bells that ring at dawn. Another, the **Unburnt**, answers only to the old patrician houses, ensuring that no whisper of rebellion reaches the Amber Palace. A third, the **Red Vigil**, has sold itself to Maelstraeus, auditing not coin but *memory* they collect the names of those who have forgotten what they owe. They do not fight each other openly. They meet in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears. The statues are not decorative.

They are the city's *witnesses*.

Beyond the capital's walls, the province is a patchwork of struggling towns, abandoned fortresses, and grainlands whose harvests are disputed by rival tax-collectors. The Everflame Orthodoxy preaches unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The statues watch. The fire judges. And in the sewers, the Vigil's informers listen for the name of the next person to vanish not into death, but into the margins of a record no one will ever read.

What you notice first: The smell of old incense and fresh bread and beneath it, the faint sweetness of rot. The way crowds part for a procession and close again for a knife. The marble steps, worn smooth by centuries of petitioners. The way the wealthy never step on the cracks. The cracks are where the petitions of the poor are wedged. The cracks are where the Hollow reads.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a toast in a coin-house. The tallies are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined trust. You will not borrow again. But more than that: never accept a gift from a patrician without naming its price aloud. Maelstraeus and Livaea both listen, and a gift accepted in silence is a contract written in water it will drown you eventually.

Regional Mood: The Flame That Remembers And The Dancers Who Forgot

Here, the past does not fade it is polished into monuments. Every statue, every obelisk, every triumphal arch is a legal precedent carved in stone. But precedent is not justice. Precedent is *memory*, and memory is a weight that the city carries like a cracked keel. Ecktoria is not one city but three: the marble forums of the old patricians (where the Unburdened hold masques that last for weeks, their faces painted with ash from the Everflame), the soot-stained alleys of the mercenary camps (where Black Banner captains drink with Vigil informers), and the basilicas where the Everflame's priests balance piety against profit (and sometimes sell indulgences for the sin of being born poor). The Grand Magistrate presides over a skeleton empire, but the real power moves in coin-houses, grain rolls, and the whispered judgments of the Censor's Hall and in the *dreams* of patricians who no longer remember the scent of rain.

The **Vigil** does not patrol the streets. It *permeates* them. Every tavern has an informer; every bathhouse has a spy; every marriage is witnessed by someone who reports to a faction of the Vigil. The **Censer-Knights** hunt unlicensed magic; the **Unburnt** hunt sedition; the **Red Vigil** hunts *what was forgotten*. They are not allies. They are not enemies. They are three creditors fighting over the same soul and the soul is the city's.

The **patricians** the Old Blood no longer govern. They *perform* governance. A session of the Parlement might see two senators debate the price of grain while their slaves hold silver trays of honeyed figs. A decree might be passed that doubles the salt tax, then rescinded an hour later because a duchess sneezed. They are not cruel. They are *distracted*. Livaea has taught them to crave the next pleasure before they have finished the current one. Maelstraeus has taught them that every transaction is a game, and every game is winnable if you have enough coin but they have forgotten that the house always wins. The house is the Hollow.

The **Everflame** still burns in the basilicas, but its light has grown dim. The High Priest speaks of unity, but his sermons are interrupted by coughing from the pews not from illness, but from the ash that falls like snow. The common folk whisper that the flame no longer judges truth; it only *records* it, filing confessions in a vault that no one ever opens. The Vigil has a key. The patricians have a copy. The poor have nothing but their names, which the Censor's Hall writes in ink that

fades when you look away.

The Everflame Faith of Ash and Incense

The state religion of Ecktoria is a syncretic faith that venerates the Eternal Flame as the divine principle, but its power flows through three great Orders, each devoted to a different Patron. The Basilica of the Unquenched Flame is the heart of the city: a cavernous space of gold mosaics, weeping saints, and the perpetual smell of beeswax and myrrh. Mass is held at dawn and dusk, the congregation coughing through the ash that falls from the censers. The priests sell indulgences in the side chapels—a silver coin for the remission of a small sin, a gold coin for a large one, a horse for a murder. The choir sings in Utaran, a language most parishioners no longer understand, but the melody is beautiful enough to make them weep and to make the statues turn their heads.

- **Order of the Oath of Flame & Light (Orthodox)** The public face of the church. They lead processions, bless marriages, and anoint the dying. Their rites are those of vows, radiance, and protection. They are the ones who light the great candles at dawn. Many are sincere; most are tired. The tired ones are the ones the Vigil watches.
- **Order of the Inquisitor Prime (Prosecutorial)** The **Censer-Knights**. They hunt untutored magic, root out demonic cults, and enforce the purity of the flame. Their rites are those of judgment, purification, and burning censure. They carry brass censers that smoke with bitter herbs, and bells that ring once for a warning, thrice for a raid. They are feared, but also respected—for they are the only ones who still take the flame *seriously*. And the flame takes them seriously in return.
- **Order of the Oath of Mercy and Grace (Hospitalier)** The healers and confessors. They run hospices, tend to the sick, and hear the confessions of the dying. Their rites are those of healing, forgiveness, and the spiral of care. They are often at odds with the Inquisitor Prime—mercy can look like leniency. The common folk love them; the patricians ignore them. The Vigil watches both.

The Everflame is both beautiful and ugly. Its gold leaf covers the same marble where petitioners once scratched their names. Its hymns are sung by choirboys whose families sold them for a loaf of bread. Its relics—a nail from the True Cross, a tear of Saint Lucia—draw pilgrims from across the empire, but the priests charge admission, and the poor sleep on the steps. The flame itself is a wonder: a pillar of blue-white fire that never gutters, tended by the High Priest alone. It is said to show the truth to any who stare into it long enough—and to show the same truth to the Vigil, who watch from the shadows. The truth is always the same: *you have forgotten something*.

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Marble grandeur, ash-tipped ambition, the slow rot of imperial forms, and the cloying sweetness of a city drowning in its own nostalgia.
- **Key Conflict:** Legitimacy versus wealth; old families, new mercenaries, and the Everflame’s judgment—but beneath it all, the battle between Maelstraeus (greed) and Livaea (desire) over the souls of the powerful.
- **Notable Threats:** Bread riots, arena spills, ducal conflicts, inquisitorial visits, the Red List and the Vigil’s three factions, who may arrest you for unpaid weights, sedition, or simply being *remembered*.
- **Common Rewards:** Procession permits, coin-house credit, laurel deeds, a Golden Edict carved in precedent—and, if you are brave, a secret from the Vigil’s own files. The secret is always about

a statue.

Prominent NPCs of Ecktoria

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumored Quirk
Valerius	Grand Magistrate	Preserve the forms of law while the empire crumbles	His gavel is a sundial; it only strikes at noon. He has not struck it in a year.
Flavia	High Priest of the Ever-flame	Balance the factions and keep the flame lit	She has never raised her voice; the flame speaks for her. Lately, it speaks in the voices of the dead.
Cassia	Duchess-Regent of the Dolmis Gate	Protect her family's trading rights	She rules from behind a silk screen; a dagger-hole is cut at eye level. The screen was a gift from Livaea. The silk is warm.
Marcus	Coin-House Factor	Survive the next trust panic	He seals deals with three ribbons: white (ask), red (now), black (never). His black ribbon is fraying. He does not know who is fraying it.

Lucius	Lanista (arena master)	Own the next champion and the secrets of the hypogeum	His fighters’ brands are his signature; he never repeats a mark. One brand is a spiral the mark of the Red Vigil. The fighter does not know.
The Red Clerk	Censor’s Hall scribe	Control which names are remembered	His inkwell is a skull; the skull belonged to a name he erased. He has forgotten his own name. The skull remembers.
Censer-Knight Commander Vorenius	Prefect of the Order of the Inquisitor Prime	Hunt untutored magic before it wakes the Ninth	His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads one for each faction he has betrayed. He does not notice the third.
Lady Aelia	Patrician heiress, Livaea’s favorite	Outshine every rival before the next masque	She has not left the Amber Palace in seven years. She does not know the price of bread. She dreams of bread.

Names of Ecktoria

Inspired by late Latin and early Romance: strong vowels (ae, i, o), soft endings, and the weight of imperial bureaucracy. Surnames often denote a place of origin, a trade, or a notable ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valerius	Flavia	de Urbe	<i>the Iron</i>
Marcus	Cassia	Aquilinus	<i>the Coin-Wise</i>
Lucius	Aelia	Honoratus	<i>Flame-Touched</i>
Tiberius	Cornelia	Lateranus	<i>the Unburned</i>
Gaius	Livia	Silvanus	<i>Bread-Counter</i>
Decimus	Valeria	Portinari	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

The Three Ecktorias: Faction Spectrum

Ecktoria is not a single polity but a battlefield of three competing visions. Most citizens and factions fall somewhere between these poles, shifting allegiance as the grain price changes. Superimposed on them are the whispers of Maelstraeus and Livaea, who have no faction only those who owe.

- **Old Blood (Patrician Traditionalists)** – The ancient senatorial families who remember when Ecktoria ruled the world. They worship precedent, hoard marble, and see mercenaries as necessary filth. Their power is in law, lineage, and the silent networks of the Censor’s Hall. *Clocks: PATRICIAN PATIENCE [4], BLOOD PRICE [6]. Patron whispers:* Livaea they marry for influence, betray for pleasure, and mistake cruelty for wit. They mistake silence for consent.
- **Black Purse (Mercenary & Trade Leagues)** – The new power: condotta brokers, coin-house factors, and mercenary captains who have bought what birth could not give. They care about supply lines, not bloodlines. Their loyalty is to the next contract, and their god is the tally but the tally has no god. *Clocks: CONTRACT SPIRAL [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6]. Patron whispers:* Maelstraeus they measure profit in margins, margins in suffering, and suffering in silver. They do not measure the weight of marble.
- **The Everflame (Church & Inquisition)** – The priests, inquisitors, and relic-keepers who claim that the Eternal Flame is the only true sovereign. They offer legitimacy to whoever pays the tithe and withdraw it from whoever forgets. Their power is in pulpits, processions, and the fear of excommunication. *Clocks: HERESY INDEX [4], SANCTUARY VIOLATION [6]. Patron whispers:* Neither the Everflame remembers, but the Vigil has learned to filter its truths. The flame’s truth is ash; the Vigil’s truth is silence.

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul creditors** (who hold Ecktoria’s weight like a leash), the **Black Banners** (who hold its streets like a lease), and the **Vigil** (who hold its secrets like a knife and sometimes use it). A wise politician learns to balance all three and keeps a boat ready on the Dolmis.

The Vigil Three Faces of the Secret Police

The Vigil is not one order but three, each claiming the mantle of the old imperial secret police. They do not cooperate. They do not war. They *audit* each other. They also audit the dead.

- **The Censer-Knights (Orthodox, Everflame)** Hunters of untutored magic. They carry brass censers that smoke with bitter herbs and bells that ring once for a warning, thrice for a raid. They answer to the Synod and the High Priest, but their true loyalty is to the *precedent* the law that magic must be licensed, indexed, and taxed. A Censer-Knight raid is heralded by a single, low bell. They are the most feared and the most public. They are also the most forgetful. *Clocks: CANDLE-SMOKE SWEEP [4], HERETIC INDEX [6].*

- **The Unburnt (Patrician)** Bodyguards and spies of the Amber Palace. They wear red sashes and carry no visible weapons. Their job is to ensure that no whisper of rebellion, no bread riot, no unpaid toll ever reaches a patrician’s ear. They are experts at *redaction* not killing witnesses, but making them forget. They have forgotten their own names. *Clocks: PALACE SECRETS [4], REDACTED MEMORY [6]*.
- **The Red Vigil (Maelstraeus’s Own)** Collectors and enforcers. They serve no noble, no church, no magistrate only the record. They audit the wealthy for the wealthy, finding hidden obligations, unpaid tithes, and compound tolls that have grown teeth. A Red Vigil agent never demands coin. They demand *names*. They also demand silence the silence of the forgotten. *Clocks: TOLL DUE [4], ROLL OF NAMES [6]*.

The Vigil’s three commanders meet once a month in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears. No record is kept of these meetings. No one admits they happen. The common folk say that if you see a Vigil agent, it is already too late but they cannot agree on *which* Vigil. The statues know. The statues do not tell.

Spades Places (revised tone)

2. **Petition Steps** — Milk-stone worn smooth by a thousand hopeful knees. The petitions are written in ink and wax. The steps answer in silence, and the silence is a verdict: Your claim is under review. A clerk sweeps the steps at dawn. He never reads the petitions. He weighs them. The heaviest goes to the bottom of the pile. The pile is the city’s memory.
3. **Tally-Ford Ferryhouse** — Rope-drums thrum all day; the ferrymaster watches coin and banners. The rope-drums have a pattern. It spells the names of those who paid late and the names of those who forgot they owed. The ferrymaster has a brother in the Red Vigil. They do not speak.
4. **Everflame Cloister** — Candle markets and side-chapels. The flame has a voice. It is the voice of the last liar who tested it. Lately, it speaks in a whisper. The whisper is always the same: “*I remember. I remember. I remember.*” Those who listen too long forget their own names and start reciting the names of the city’s forgotten dead.
5. **Triumph Stairs** — Marble worn smooth by ambition. The stairs have a name: The Rise of the Forgotten. No one remembers why. The patricians still climb them at noon, their retainers counting the steps aloud. They never count to nine. The ninth step is a gap. The gap is where a senator fell or was pushed or simply forgot to step. His ghost is still climbing. He has been climbing for a century.
6. **Censor’s Hall** — Red-lacquered tablets record every name, every shame. The tablets are redacted in invisible ink. The truth is underneath. The Vigil has the reagent. The reagent is made from the tears of the last censor who told the truth. He is still crying.

Hearts People & Factions (revised tone)

2. **Torchbearer Child** — Ash-smudged hands, knowing every shortcut through the ruins. The ruins are not old. They are last year’s fashionable quarter, abandoned when the mortgage was reclassified. She has never been lost. The ruins speak to her in the language of eviction notices. She reads them aloud to the rats. The rats pay her in stolen bread.
3. **Decumanus-Master** — Surveyor who moves stones. His rod is a finger bone. The bone belonged to the last surveyor who argued. He does not rewrite the map. He rewrites the *memory* of the map. This street was always a cul-de-sac. You simply forgot. The Vigil pays

him in forgotten names.

4. **Censer-Knight Commander Vorenius** — His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads — one for each faction he has betrayed. He does not see the third head. The third head is his own, from a timeline where he kept his oath. It is weeping.

Clubs Complications/Threats (revised tone)

2. **Blocked Bridge** — A funeral procession for a pauper who died in debt. The law says the corpse cannot cross until the toll is paid. The family has no coin. The law does not accept stories. The corpse is beginning to smell, and the Hollow is beginning to notice a weight that cannot be buried. The Vigil is taking notes on who stops to help.
3. **Border Dispute** — A surveyor has moved a boundary stone three feet east. The new map shows your warehouse now stands on a public thoroughfare. The old map is in the archive. The archive wing collapsed last spring. The memory of the boundary now exists only in the cracked floor of the basilica, and the basilica is accepting sealed bids for reparative memory. The Vigil has already bid.

Diamonds Rewards/Leverage (revised tone)

2. **Procession Permit** — Move sacred flame through a crowded quarter; law walks with you. The permit is a torch. Carry it, and the city will part — or burn. The Vigil will follow. The flame will flicker when you lie. The permit is signed by a clerk who died three years ago. His ghost still signs.
3. **Golden Edict** — An exception carved in marble; precedent travels like law. The edict is a crack. The crack in the law is now an opening. The Vigil is already inside. They will leave a note. The note will say: *“We remember. Do you?”*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/favor/precedence) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **marble and fire** motifs — statues that turn their heads, flames that burn blue, law that remembers every name — and also echo the **Vigil’s presence**: a cough in the crowd, a seal on a document you did not stamp, a mirror that shows a different face. The different face is always older. It is always watching.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Imperial Ruins**: Every district bears halfcollapsed arcades, serving as markets, courts, or shelters for mercenary companies. The Vigil knows every hidden passage.
- **Competing Factions**: Dukes, guilds, and priests stage processions that collide at bridges and squares, each claiming legitimacy. The Vigil collects bets on the outcome.
- **Monuments as Weapons**: Statues, obelisks, and colonnades are not only symbols — they are barricades, rallying points, and high ground when the city riots. The Vigil has a map of which statues can be toppled.

- **Everflame Orthodoxy:** The basilicas preach unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The High Priest plays balance while cultivating his own following. The Vigil decodes every sermon.
- **Black Banner Contracts:** Foreign mercenaries fill the gaps left by a shrinking citizen levy, their loyalty secured only by steady coin. The Vigil audits their pay.
- **The Amber Palace Quarantine:** The patricians have not left the palace in a decade. No one is certain if they are prisoners or patrons. The Vigil maintains the perimeter and delivers the wine.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Saints & Cults):**
 - **St. Marcellus of the Gilded Scale (Mykkiel)** *The Justiciar*. His order enforces unwritten laws; reading a sealed precedent binds the reader to enforce it. His shrine is the Censor’s Hall. The Vigil keeps a copy of every precedent.
 - **St. Valeria of the Serpent (Isoka)** *The Shedding Saint*. Pilgrims who confess at her chapel forget one sin and one kindness. Her mosaic shows a snake eating its tail. The Vigil uses her chapel to erase memories.
 - **St. Lucia of the Undying Flame (Oath of Flame & Light)** *The Witness of Embers*. Any oath sworn over her shrine’s flame cannot be broken; the breaker sees their own face in every wave until they drown. The Vigil swears oaths there and never breaks them.
 - **The Reckoner (Maelstraeus)** *The Tally Keeper*. A mystery cult of coinhouse factors. They offer credit at the cost of a hidden toll that compounds in blood. The Red Vigil are their collectors.
 - **The Ember Prefect (Heretic Cult)** A schism that believes the flame should not be contained. They meet in the arena hypogeum, chanting the *Unspoken Ninth Citation*. The Grand Magistrate has outlawed them three times. The Vigil has infiltrated them twice.
 - **The Velvet Mask (Livaea)** A secret society of patricians who worship pleasure as the only truth. Their rites are said to last nine days. No one has ever left a rite unchanged. The Vigil watches their parties and reports to the Unburnt.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in the Shatterline Bazaar. They ask no payment but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the arena slaves, trying to untie her cord from a coinhouse weight. The Vigil has her file.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the grainprefects. Take it, and your store never runs dry but the coin will reappear in the mouth of a starving child. The Red Vigil uses it to mark those who owe.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ecktorian psions are called FlameReaders. They see the future in the Everflame’s flicker. The High Priest employs three and has never trusted a forecast that didn’t smell of smoke. The Vigil employs their apprentices.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Imperial Arena is a Class IV Poltergeist site the collective rage of every gladiator who died for the crowd. Saikou Ira would ring a bell eight times and leave a wreath of laurel. The Vigil rings the bell nine times. The Arena answers.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ecktorian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth hear a faint laughter from the marble

walls and their cases are never heard again. The Vigil cites the ninth often. The laughter does not bother them.

Ecktoria Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Flame:** Crumble a crust into the Everflame. Ignore the first *Bread Riots* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a coinhouse credit ribbon. Cancel *Frozen Purse* or take −1 die on your next trust roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Marble:** Whisper a dead debtor’s name into a statue’s ear. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their heirs this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Grand Magistrate. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Spit on the Seal:** Before signing any contract, spit on the wax seal. If it sizzles, the Vigil has a copy. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city guards or rival factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds or ceremonial processions**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **patrols or inquisitors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or ceremonial opportunity**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **City authorities or noble house** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction member or city official** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **guards, mercenaries, or zealots** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes **procession turns violent/boundary dispute erupts/patron turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **High Priest, Grand Magistrate, or Duchess-Regent** intervenes.

- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically **procession erupts/arena gate opens/monument collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice **flame speaks/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ecktoria (Marble & Fire):** Statues turn their heads, flames burn blue, ceremonial masks appear in windows.
- **Ecktoria (Procession):** Crowds chant your name, banners block your path, trumpets announce your arrival.
- **Ecktoria (Patronage):** Seals break in your hand, favors are revoked, noble houses compete for your allegiance.
- **Ecktoria (The Vigil):** A seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp. A cough from the crowd sounds like your name. Your reflection in a polished shield has a red sash.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Cross-Region Hooks (optional draws):**
 - *Aeler True Masons bid* to shore a failing aqueduct; accepting stabilizes *Aftershock* but grants them soft leverage in the ward. The Vigil audits the contract.
 - *Aelinnel Green-Market broker* offers “truthcredit” on court gossip; pay later in favors or names. The Vigil pays in silence.
 - *Black Banner retainer* parade demands back pay on the Triumph Stairs; crowd sympathy tilts your next parley. The Vigil arrests the ringleader.
- **Faction Entanglements During Travel (use en route or on city entry):**
 - If the party holds any *Condotta* Diamonds, begin with *Bread Riots* at +1 segment (mercenary grain trains rerouted).
 - Entering with an *Underway Pass* (Aeler) grants +1 Position on *Aqueduct Walk* scenes but ticks *Ducal Conflict* once (guild jealousy). The Vigil notes your pass.
 - Carrying *Green Market* tags downgrades one *Censor’s Hall* action but flags *Inquisitorial Visit* at the next temple. The Vigil compares tags.
- **Trade Good Consequences (pick 1 when a haul sells):**
 - *Arena Steel* → street duels spike → start *Arena Spill* at 1. The Vigil collects the weapons.
 - *Relic Fragments* → basilica prestige swings → tick *Church Purge* or grant *Basilica Audience*. The Vigil inspects the relic.
 - *Survey Rights* → boundary replat → downgrade one *Border Dispute* or upgrade a rival’s. The Vigil updates the map.
- **Diplomatic Favor (minor currency):**
 - Earn by resolving a public scene without bloodshed (Forum, Procession, CoinHouse).
 - Spend 1 to reduce DV of a permit/audience by 1, or to ignore *Blocked Bridge* for one crossing.
 - Holding 2+ makes you “interesting”: start a *Red List* [4] that advances on snubbed patrons. The Vigil adds your name.

- **Reputation Echoes (soft power):**

- *Crowd-Loved (Laurel-Deed)*: first time per session you face a mob, set Position one step safer. The Vigil watches how the mob loves you.
- *Coin-House Trusted (Credit)*: ignore the first *Frozen Purse*; next time, it returns at +1 severity. The Vigil audits your credit.
- *Clerically Vouched (Everflame)*: downgrade one *Inquisitorial Visit*; if abused, promote *Church Purge*. The Vigil has a copy of your voucher.

Monuments as Mechanics (opulence with teeth)

- **Processional Geometry**: When acting on the *Triumph Stairs*, choose: +1 Effect *or* –1 Heat; on a miss, *Rerouted Triumph* advances. The Vigil stands at the top of the stairs, watching.
- **Aqueduct Leverage**: Securing an aqueduct span grants a onescene *high ground* tag in any linked ward; if collateral hits, tick *Aftershock*. The Vigil knows where the aqueduct leaks.
- **Forum Acoustics**: Rally speeches at the *Grand Forum* grant an extra assist die if at least 20 witnesses; failure spawns *Bread Riots* at +1. The Vigil counts the witnesses.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Ecktoria flavor)

- Any 1 SB may become *Crowd Drift*: shift the scene’s terrain in favor of or against you (bridges clog, stairs clear).
- Any 2 SB may become *Seal Revoked*: void one paper (Permit/Chit/Indulgence); to avert, sacrifice *Diplomatic Favor*.
- On 3+ SB offer *Patron Bargain*: accept a visible mark (ribbon, laurel brand) to halve consequences; start a *Patron Weight* [6].

Hidden Orders & Ancient Conspiracies (d12 hooks)

1. **The Ash Senate** – a roll of “extinguished” patrician lines still voting by proxy through funerary guilds. The Vigil has the key.
2. **Surveyors of the Ninth Mile** – decumanusmasters who can *move* boundaries with ritual math; a lost rod sets precedent across the city. The Vigil owns the rod.
3. **Lantern Tetrarchy** – four basilica beadles who decide which miracles are counted; the fifth lamp was broken in a purge. The Vigil lit the purge.
4. **The Red Marble Compact** – coinhouse founders who tithe 1 in 100 coins to a secret indemnity fund used to flip coups. The Red Vigil administers the fund.
5. **Archivum Umbrae** – censor clerks maintaining a *shadow index* of names that must not stand trial (yet). The Vigil reads the index nightly.
6. **Peregrine Brotherhood** – ferrymasters trading in sealed confessions; blackmail that floats. The Vigil buys the confessions.
7. **The Laurel of Dust** – a gladiators’ mutual that chooses which champions live long enough to hold office. The Vigil chooses the champions.
8. **Aqueduct Collegium Obscura** – engineers who keep a second set of sluice keys; droughts become elections. The Vigil has the third set.
9. **Order of the Broken Obelisk** – surveycult that believes MileZero is *wrong* and can refund the city with one stone. The Vigil has the stone.

10. **The Funeral Republic** – undertakers running a parallel courier state through catacombs and wakes. The Vigil uses their couriers.
11. **The Ember Vault** – a sealed reliquary under the Arena; victors’ sweat was bottled for augury. The Vigil broke the seal.
12. **Triumphal Maskers** – procession costumers who encode heretical theses into robe pleats and torch patterns. The Vigil decodes the theses and sometimes agrees.

Cults & Mystery Rites (d10)

1. **Children of the Phoenix** (*rebirth by fire*): ashmarks grant +1 die vs. fear in crowds; mark Fatigue if you hesitate near open flame.
2. **Verdant Laurel** (*blood to marble, sap to coin*): once/session turn 1 Harm into 1 CoinHouse Credit; start a *Green Weight* [4].
3. **Mask of the Thirteenth** (*forbidden procession step*): walk through a riot unmolested; next parley with clergy begins one step worse.
4. **Brotherhood of the River Tongue** (*truth ferried at night*): ask the Dolmis one yes/no; a ferryman shows up later to collect a name.
5. **Candlemakers of Ever** (*flame remembers lies*): blue flame points to falsehood; the liar dreams of you for three nights (Exposure +1).
6. **Sable Standard** (*war saint cult*): your banner ignores morale checks once; start a *Blood-Tithe* [4] owed to the saint’s chapel.
7. **The Ninth Bell** (*hour that is not kept*): skip a queue or sentence; next edict you need arrives late (Delay SB free once).
8. **Guild of Red Accountants** (*sin as tally*): convert 2 SB into a *Magistrate’s Postponement*; add *Karmic Weight* [6].
9. **The Marble Eaters** (*mortification sect*): bite stone, gain +1 Effect resisting crowd crush; take Harm 1 (Stress) if you boast.
10. **Torch of Saint Vessa** (*saint of necessary arson*): sanctify a fire to purge a tag (Plague/Corruption); City Heat +2.

Religious Schisms & Trials

The Everflame Divide (choose a live schism)

1. **Orthodox Basilica vs. Ember Reformers**: Is miracle *counted* by law or *kindled* by need?
2. **Laurel Theologians vs. Street Saints**: Does glory flow *down* from triumphs or *up* from breadlines?
3. **Iconoclast Ward vs. Reliquary Keepers**: Is the flame purer without images?

Schism Mechanics (table-facing)

- **Heresy Index** [0–6]: ticks when players publicize a stance, defy clergy, or wield cult rites in view. At 3: inquisitorial audits become common; at 6: *Church Purge* (Q) autotriggers once/session until lowered.
- **Sanctuary / Anathema Tags**: locations acquire tags during arc scenes. *Sanctuary*: first harm in scene becomes Fatigue; *Anathema*: first social miss spawns “Proscribed Sigil.”
- **Trial by Fire (miniprocedure, 3 beats)**:

1. *Assembly*: set the forum/stair as arena; state thesis in one sentence (players or NPCs).
2. *Witness*: three proofs (relic, miracle, precedent). Each proof: test Social/Arcana/Resolve vs. crowd DV; on success, reduce Index by 1 or gain *Basilica Audience*.
3. *Judgment*: roll Crowd Mood (1d6): 1–2 mobs, 3–4 silent acceptance, 5–6 laurel toss (gain *Laurel-Deed*). If Index ≥ 4 , –1 to the roll.

Ecktoria – Marble and Fire

Starting Location: The CoinHouse floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons.

“In Ecktoria, even faith must balance its ledgers, and the gods audit in ash.”

In... the CoinHouse floor, a factor with smokesinged rolls offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. The Amber Palace has not answered a summons in a month. The Vigil is asking questions. I suggest you find the answers before they find you.”

Regional Motifs Coinoaths, basilica relics, marble acoustics, augury smoke, Vigil seals.

Whispers to Offer “Bid against the city,” “Pocket the relic shard,” “Name an innocent debtor,” “The Vigil’s informer sits in the corner.”

External Clocks Threat: *Procession of Ash* [6]; Community: *Credit Panic* [4]; Anchor: *Basilica Choir* [4]; Vigil: *Red List* [6].

Complications Smoke speaks truths; coins stick to skin; a reliquary runs hot; a seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp.

Anchors at Risk A choir novice; a patron account; a Vigil informer who owes you a favor.

Escalation Beat The Basilica tolls a note only one PC hears. The Vigil hears it too.

Relief Return the shard; pay a citytoll in blood or ; route the procession elsewhere; give the Vigil a name.

Boss Seeds (Cults & Conspiracies)

- **The Ember Prefect** (schismatic inquisitor): *Phase* [8] Citation → Censure → Autodafé → Purge. Lair: Everflame Cloister. Counters: relic provenance, crowdfavor, rival sermon. *Vigil twist*: The Prefect was once a Vigil informer. The Vigil knows where he hides.
- **The Surveyor-Primus** (geomantic usurper): *Phase* [6] Replat → Dispossession → Erase. Lair: MileZero. Counters: Aeler measurerods, witness line, broken rod. *Vigil twist*: The Primus has a Red Vigil agent as a protégé.
- **Phoenix of the Arena** (miracle or hoax?): *Phase* [10] Hype → Immolation → “Rebirth” → Riot. Lair: Imperial Arena. Counters: doused ash, Mask of the Thirteenth, Everflame test. *Vigil twist*: The Phoenix is a Vigil experiment. The Unburnt want to contain it. The Red Vigil wants to sell tickets.

- **The Velvet Mask** (Livaea’s cult): *Phase* [8] Invitation → Masque → Price of Pleasure. Lair: The Amber Palace. Counters: an unbroken oath, a mirror with no reflection, a name spoken without desire. *Vigil twist*: The Vigil’s Unburnt faction attends every masque. They are not there to stop it.

Diamonds: Forbidden Leverage (add to §??)

14. **Shadow Index Leaf** – remove one name from the Red List for a week; add *Countercoup* +1.
15. **Ember Writ** – sanction one cult rite as “orthodox” for a scene.
16. **Surveyor’s Ninth Rod** – redraw one ward line unnoticed (until dawn).
17. **Vigil Seal (Red)** – For one scene, the Red Vigil treats you as a contractor. The price will be collected later.

Cross-Contamination (fast ties)

- **Aeler True Masons**: backing an iconoclast audit grants shoring crews; bellcodes now gate temple entries. The Vigil has the bellcodes.
- **Aelinnel Thorn Courts**: hawthorn chaplains host “mirror sermons”; a basilica gains *Sanctuary* while a rival becomes *Anathema*. The Vigil watches both.
- **Black Banners**: warchaplain monetize indulgences; clearing *Payday* risks +1 *Heresy Index*. The Vigil takes a cut.

Patronage & Power

Ecktoria’s decline is not collapse, but transformation. Wealth bleeds into patronage webs: a senator’s indulgence, a censor’s indulgence, a noble’s purse. The city’s great houses keep mercenary captains on retainer, while priests sell ritual processions as public theater and private favor. And everywhere, the Vigil watches not to stop the rot, but to take notes.

Yet beneath the decay, two demons whisper. **Maelstraeus** teaches that every contract is a weapon, every obligation a leash. **Livaea** teaches that every desire is a chain, every pleasure a payment. The patricians who once ruled the world now rule only the Amber Palace, and the Amber Palace is a gilded cage. They do not see the bread riots. They do not hear the Vigil’s footsteps. They dance. They drink. They forget that the flame remembers everything.

For the GM: Patronage should function as both opportunity and trap. Any gift (a purse, permit, or charter) binds the receiver to service, but patrons can die, fall from favor, or suddenly proscribe what they once allowed. The Vigil offers a different kind of patronage: *protection* in exchange for *information*. A party that pays the Vigil in secrets may find doors opening and other doors closing behind them. To emphasize the decadence and dread:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, ribbons, laurel crowns, Vigil marks) that can be stolen, forged, or voided.
- Let rival patrons issue conflicting “safeconducts,” forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use processions, funerals, or trials as arenas for social contests, where patronage weights surface and shift allegiances.
- Introduce the **Vigil’s Faction Clock** [6] to track which Vigil faction (Censer-Knights, Unburnt, Red Vigil) has the most leverage over the party. When it fills, that faction makes a demand.

Patronage in Ecktoria is not mere background it is the engine of politics, coin, and survival. And beneath it all, Maelstraeus and Livaea are writing a contract. The city is the collateral. The poor are the interest. The patricians are the signature and they signed in blood long ago.

Chapter 3

Acasia

The Broken Marches.

We do not speak of the Curse. We speak around it, under it, through the gaps where words used to fit. The Curse is not a thing. It is the space where a thing used to be.

I am a charcoal-burner. My family has worked these woods for three generations. My grandfather could name every tree between the Pale Causeway and the Wolfstairs Pass. My father could read a deer's track in packed clay. I can tell you where the villages used to be. The map in my head has more empty spaces than marks.

Acasia was not always like this. Once, the granaries held grain through winter. Once, the roads carried more than ghosts and tax collectors. Then the trees started dying. Not all at once slowly, branch by branch, forest by forest. The Blackwood turned grey, then brittle, then silent. The farmers said it was a curse. The duke said it was blight. The merchants said it was the tariffs. The priests said it was the will of gods who had stopped listening.

Nobody said it was guilt. Nobody had to. Guilt is the smell of mildew on old parchment. Guilt is the way a village watches you pass without opening its gates. Guilt is the empty chair at the feast, the unmarked grave behind the chapel, the child who will not meet your eyes because their parents told them not to speak to strangers.

The truth the one we do not speak is that we could have saved the Blackwood. We saw the first trees wither. We saw the sap run black. We did nothing. We told ourselves it would pass. We told ourselves the duke would fix it. We told ourselves the forest was not our responsibility. And then the forest died, and the silence that followed was our answer.

The Curse of Acasia is not a spell. It is a memory. The land remembers what we did and what we failed to do. Every broken milestone on the old Imperial Road is a forgotten promise. Every abandoned vineyard is a harvest we chose not to plant. Every bridge that leads back to the same shore is the road we refused to take.

Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature. But more than that: the bridge knows when you are lying. Not to the other party. To yourself.

We are the Curse now. We carry it in our silence, in our empty fields, in the way we turn away when someone asks where the children went. Acasia is not a broken province. It is a province that broke itself, one small refusal at a time, until there was nothing left to break but the people who stayed.

And still we stay. Because leaving would mean admitting we were wrong. And that is the one thing guilt cannot bear.

Corvin, charcoal-burner of the Blackwood, who no longer names the trees because there are too few left to name

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Hardtack soaked in broth if you have broth. If not, hardtack and hope. The granaries have been empty for three winters. The merchants sell grain at famine prices. The duke says the roads are too dangerous for caravans. The farmers say the duke owns the caravans.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To name the dead. Every Acasian child has a list of ancestors they repeat at bedtime. The list gets shorter each generation. Not because children forget. Because the dead are forgetting themselves.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Whether they have a shadow. The Curse takes shadows first. A man without a shadow is not cursed—he is already gone. His body just hasn't stopped moving yet.

What is the most common crime? Bridge-toll evasion. The roads are unsafe, the ferries are unreliable, but the barons still demand payment for crossings no one can make. The crime is not in refusing to pay. The crime is in being caught trying.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Curse began with a promise broken on the Blackwood Bridge. A baron promised his daughter to a lord of the old forest. He married her to a lowland knight instead. The forest remembered. The forest is still waiting for the wedding.

Where do people go when they die? Into the Blackwood. Burial is forbidden—the ground rejects the dead. Bodies are carried to the tree-line and left. The wood takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking between the trunks. They do not look back.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You walk the Broken Milea stretch of road that collapsed into the river a decade ago. If you reach the far side, you are forgiven. If you fall, you were not sorry enough. No one has reached the far side in seven years.

What is the most important festival? The Counting of the Names (midwinter). Every village lists its dead aloud, from oldest to newest. If a name is forgotten, the ghost walks until someone remembers. The list grows longer each year. The memory grows shorter.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The duke's son is a ghoul. He was lost in the Blackwood as a child. They found him three days later, pale and smiling. He does not age. He does not eat. He only watches. The servants know. The servants do not speak.

3.1 Acasia — “Broken Marches”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The Empire conquered it first. The Empire left it last. Now neither remembers why.*

Margravine of the Broken March (Elite): “The tithe must be paid, not merely offered. A promise written in ash and sealed with iron will is worth more than a thousand gold coins scattered on the wind. The Empire is dead. Its weight is not.”

Hedge-Witch (Commoner): “Don’t cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you’ve got a silver tooth. The bridge’ll remember it, and next time you pass, it’ll want more than just your footfall. In Acasia, every road has a memory. The question is who pays the toll. The Empire forgot. That’s why it fell.”

Genre / Mood: Lowfantasy wasteland, mercenary realism, cursed borderlands.

Starting Location: The Pale Causeway’s last inn, walls sootblackened by coal and a century of gossip. A bounty poster flutters beside a halfempty hearth. The innkeeper is a oneeyed woman who pours small beer without asking. A stranger at the bar offers a sealed contract: retrieve a dowry chest from a Blackwood matriarch before the Margravine’s feast day. “The chest contains a claim, not coin,” the stranger whispers. “But a claim in Acasia is worth more than gold—it is a key to a bridge that does not loop. The Empire’s surveyors marked it. Then they died.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Acasia was the first province the Uтарan Empire swallowed when it turned its eyes east. The legions marched through the Pale Causeway, crushed the hillkings, and planted their eagles in the Blackwood. For centuries, Acasia was the empire’s eastern breadbasket and its first line of defence. Grain flowed west; coin flowed east. The roads were straight, the bridges paid, and the Curse was just a farmer’s whisper.

Then the empire rotted from within. When the last Uтарan emperor died and the provinces broke away, Acasia lingered for another hundred years a ghost province whose governors still stamped Uтарan seals, whose courts still cited Uтарan law, whose coins still bore the emperor’s face. No one came from the west to collect the taxes. No one sent legions to enforce the peace. The Acasians kept the forms, because they had never learned to keep anything else. They had no native king, no unifying faith, no common tongue beyond the legionary’s Latin. They were the empire’s children, and when the empire died, they became orphans.

For a century they clung to the ruins. Then the plagues came. Then the famines. Then the Curse a slow rot of roads that led nowhere, bridges that looped back on themselves, villages that woke to find their neighbours’ houses standing empty. The old imperial surveys became maps of places that no longer existed. The grain blights turned the storehouses to dust. The free companies, once hired to keep the peace, became the only law.

That was two hundred years ago.

Now Acasia is a wound that will not close. It sits between Ecktoria to the west and Vhasia to the east, claimed by both, ruled by neither. Petty kings raise their banners in burned keeps. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colours midmarch. The Margravine of the Broken March keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. The Lame King travels on a throne carried by debtors, making law by pointing. And the Curse the nameless thing that makes crossroads turn back on themselves is not a myth. It is the weight

of broken promises, and Acasia is drowning in them.

South, on the marshy islands of the Amaranthine coast, the city of Silkstrand squats on reclaimed silt, trading in silk, silver, and secrets. The Acasians call it “the Sink” a place where the Curse thins, but where law is measured in coin, not custom. Few Acasians go there. Fewer return unchanged.

What you notice first: The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved first in Utaran, then in a halfdozen failed scripts. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature. The Empire’s last governor signed a treaty on the PontduTithe. No one knows what it said. The bridge remembers.

Regional Mood: Famine, Ambition, and the Ghost of Empire

Here, the past is not a memory it is a geometry. The Utaran Empire left behind roads that lead to nowhere, laws that contradict each other, and a hunger that no harvest can fill. Acasia’s petty kings hold court in burned keeps, their crowns forged from iron nails pulled from famine coffins. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colors midmarch. And beneath it all, the Curse waits. It is not a monster. It is a wrong turn: the bridge that leads back to the same shore, the milestone that faces the wrong direction, the bell that tolls for no funeral. In Acasia, the land itself has become a broken contract, and the fine print is written in mildew.

The Curse is not ancient. It is a legacy. Some say it began with the last Imperial Survey, when the surveyors tried to map every bridge, every ford, every tolland in the measuring, broke something. Others say it was the plagues, when the dead were buried in unmarked pits and the priests forgot the proper rites. The hedgewitches say it was the empire’s own fault: they ruled Acasia for centuries but never taught the Acasians to rule themselves. When the empire left, the land had no king, no law, no memory. The Curse filled the gap.

Now the Margravine and the Lame King fight over the scraps, while free companies sell their swords to whichever claimant pays first. The hedgewitches tie red thread around bridges and leave offerings of salt at crossroads, hoping to keep the Curse from spreading. The villagers pray to saints the Empire forgot. And the roads the old imperial roads still march west toward a capital that no longer exists. The capital does not answer. But the roads keep marching.

The Curse of Acasia (Campaign Clock)

The Curse is a slow accumulation of broken promises and unpaid tolls. Track it with a visible clock:

Curse Awakening [10] Advances when:

- A contract is broken on a bridge (+1)
- A character speaks the ninth word in a negotiation (+1)
- The party ignores a road omen (GM spends 1 SB to tick +1)
- A free company flips allegiance midcontract (+2)

At 4 segments: Navigation rolls in Acasia gain +1 DV (roads shift). At 8 segments: The Curse Stirrs complication triggers once per session (roll on the table below). At 10 segments: The Curse manifests as a physical threat a bridge eats a village, a road swallows a patrol, or the ghost of the last emperor rides.

Curse Stirrs (d6) When the clock reaches 8, roll 1d6 for an immediate complication:

1. A milestone points the wrong way. Navigation DV +2 for the scene.
2. A bridge you crossed earlier now loops back to where you started. Lose 1 segment of progress.
3. A toll collector's ghost demands payment in a currency that no longer exists. Pay 1 Boon or mark 1 Fatigue.
4. A child with no shadow offers directions. If you follow, you arrive at your destination but you forget why you came.
5. The Margravine's seal cracks. One of your Diamonds (writ, charter, token) becomes a forgery until you rewitness it.
6. The Hollow's breath freezes the ford. Crossing requires a Desperate roll; on a Miss, you lose 1 Supply (drowned).

Prominent NPCs of Acasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Zara <i>"the Ledger"</i>	Margravine of the Broken March	Keep the province from fracturing completely	She has never lost a feud; her sword is also a counting rod. She claims descent from the last Utaran governor.
Oren <i>"Tin Crown"</i>	The Lame King	Be recognised as a true sovereign	His traveling throne is carried by debtors; he pays them in promises. His grandfather was a free company captain who declared himself king.

Ysabeau	Hedge-Witch of the Blackwood Charcoalers	Survive the Curse and keep her kin from the rope	She knows which bridges eat travellers, and her price is a story that ends badly. Her grandmother witnessed the last imperial survey.
The Bride	Dowry chest claimant (Blackwood matriarch’s heir)	Recover the chest before the Margravine’s feast day	She carries a dagger in her wedding veil. The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bridge was built by the Utaran legions.
Vladan	Free Company Captain (“The Rusted Banner”)	Find a permanent contract before winter	He has served three kings this year. He cannot remember their names. His company’s banner is an Utaran eagle, torn and stitched.
Sister Ash	Ex-Imperial surveyor	Finish the old map of Acasia	She visits villages that no longer exist. The map shows them anyway. She carries a sealed chest of the last governor’s papers.

Names of Acasia

Inspired by the martial duchies of a fallen southern empire: clipped Latin, warnames, and the hard consonants of mountain keeps. Many families still bear Utaranized surnames, though they have not spoken the language in generations.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Alboin	Theodelinda	da Ponte	<i>the Stiff</i>
Authari	Rosamund	del Ferro	<i>the Toll-Fist</i>
Liutprand	Gundiberga	di Rocca	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
Desiderius	Anspranda	Longobardus	<i>Blackwood</i>
Ratchis	Veleda	Saxo	<i>the Unremembered</i>
Aistulf	Gisela	Capoferro	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(**Pass/Ruin/TollTown**) Broken milestone on the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. Vineterrace hillside with an abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.

Spades — Places

2. Broken Milestone

[*RUIN*] [*OMEN*]

On the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight.

The stone has been chiseled seven times. The last mark is still wet. The first was cut by Utaran legionaries.

Mechanical hook: If you camp here, roll Spirit + Lore (DV 4). On success, you learn the true border line (+1 die on navigation for this leg). On failure, the milestone moves while you sleep start a **Lost Ways** [4] clock.

3. Vine-Terrace Hillside

[*RUIN*] [*HARVEST*]

Abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.

The ivy has grown around a skeleton. The skeleton still holds a wine cup. The vintage was the year the last governor left.

Mechanical hook: Foraging here gives 1 Supply, but the ivy is possessive. On a Miss, you are entangled (Body+Athletics DV 3 to break free) and tick **Curse Awakening +1**.

4. Toll-Bridge Town

[*TOLL*] [*BOUNDARY*]

Over a cold river; two tolls, no receipts.

The second toll is collected by a child. The child does not speak. The bridge was built by the legions. It remembers their footsteps.

Mechanical hook: Crossing costs 1 Boon or 1 Supply. If you refuse, the child writes your name in chalk. The bridge will demand double next time.

5. Wolfstairs Pass

[*MOUNTAIN*] [*AMBUSH*]

Switchbacks beneath a stonefall cliff.

The stones were placed by a landslide that knew your name. The pass was the empire’s eastern gate. No army has crossed it in a century.

Mechanical hook: Navigation DV +2. On a Partial, you are spotted by a free company scout start **Rival Hunt** [4].

6. Sootfall Abbey Ruins

[*RUIN*] [*DEATH*]

Bell tower intact; crypts breathing.

The breathing is a prayer. The monks are still down there. They have been praying for the empire’s soul for two hundred years.

Mechanical hook: A character who prays with the monks (Spirit+Lore DV 3) clears 1 Fatigue, but the monks ask for a story about a broken promise. Refusal ticks **Curse Awakening** +1.

7. Hill-Motte

[FORTIFICATION] [WAR]

Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops.

The caltrops are from a siege that ended last week. The bodies are still rotting. The siege was over a bridge toll. The bridge has not collected in fifty years.

Mechanical hook: The lord of the motte will hire the party as mercenaries (1 Supply). If they refuse, he accuses them of being spies start **Feud Spark** [4].

8. Border-Stone Ring

[BOUNDARY] [OMEN]

Carved with seven crowns; each points wrong.

The crowns belong to kings who never existed. The stones remember them anyway. The eighth crown was the empire’s. It is not carved. It is implied.

Mechanical hook: A character who touches the eighth (empty) crown must test Resolve (DV 4). On failure, they gain the Condition *Marked by the Curse* (GM may spend 1 SB to worsen Position in any negotiation).

9. Blackwood Charcoalers’ Hollow

[FOREST] [WITCHCRAFT]

Witchposts at every path.

The witchposts were made from the gibbets of tax collectors. The tax collectors still swing. They were collecting for the empire. They have not stopped.

Mechanical hook: A hedgewitch offers to read your fortune (1 Boon). On a success, she warns of the next Curse Stirrs trigger. On a failure, she demands a memory (erase a minor fact).

10. Salt-Road Ford

[RIVER] [DEATH]

Rains expose old bones in the chalk banks.

The bones are from three wars. They are not all human. The ford was the empire’s salt route. The salt is still in the water.

Mechanical hook: Crossing costs 1 Fatigue (cold). If you drink the water, test Endurance DV 3. On failure, you see the ghosts of the drowned for the next scene (1 die on all actions).

J Iron Mine Adits

[UNDERGROUND] [WHISPERS]

Held by a miners’ commune; the air is full of whispers.

The whispers are the mine’s memory. It remembers every collapse. The last collapse was the year the empire fell. The miners are still digging.

Mechanical hook: The commune will trade 1 Supply for a miner’s story. If the story is true, they also reveal a hidden exit treat the next travel clock as 2 segments shorter.

Q Margravine’s Hunting Lodge

[NOBLE] [SECRETS]

Tapestries of victories that never were.

The tapestries were woven by a blind weaver. The threads are from her own hair. The victories are Utaran. The weaver was Acasian.

Mechanical hook: A character who studies the tapestries (Wits+Lore DV 4) learns a noble’s secret (a String). On a failure, the blind weaver’s ghost asks for a favour start **Weaver’s Debt** [4].

K War-Camp City

[WAR] [REFUGE]

Tents around a burned keep; every banner claims the throne.

The keep was burned by its own lord. He did not want to share the heat. The lord was the last imperial governor. He died in the fire.

Mechanical hook: To enter the camp, you must swear a temporary oath to a claimant. Breaking it ticks **Curse Awakening +2**.

A The Pale Causeway

[ROAD] [CURSE]

The last high road that survives the spring thaws.

The causeway is made of bones. The bones are from the workers who built it. The workers were Acasian. The empire paid them in promises.

Mechanical hook: Crossing the Causeway at dusk forces a Resolve test (DV 4). On failure, you gain the Condition *Debtor to the Dead* (any spirit can demand one service from you). On a critical failure, the Curse Awakening clock ticks +2 immediately.

(Petty Crowns/Priests/Companies) Tithecollector's runner with a tallyrod and an empty stomach; roadside prior with three lay brothers guarding a relic.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. Tithe-Collector's Runner

[AUTHORITY] [HUNGER]

Tallyrod, empty stomach, and a list of names.

His tallyrod has notches from a dozen villages. The villages are now empty. He collects for the Margravine. She does not ask where the grain goes.

Debt they owe: He owes his soul to the Margravine's ledger. If you give him a name from the list, he will mark it paid but the ghost of that name will haunt you.

Price of aid: 1 Supply or a story about a tax collector who died hungry.

3. Roadside Prior

[FAITH] [RELIC]

Three lay brothers guarding a relic.

The relic is a finger bone. The prior claims it belonged to a saint who starved to death. The saint was an Utaran missionary. The Acasians ate his offerings.

Debt they owe: The prior's order swore to feed the poor. They have failed. He will help anyone who shares a meal.

Price of aid: A crust of bread and a prayer. If you refuse, the relic's ghost will follow you (1 die on all stealth rolls for one scene).

4. Hedge-Witch

[WITCHCRAFT] [KNOWLEDGE]

Knows which bridges eat travelers.

Her price is a story. The story must have a bad ending. She has heard all the good ones. The bridges listen when she speaks.

Debt they owe: She once cursed a tax collector. The curse still echoes. If you help her lift it, she will teach you a route that ignores the Curse once.

Price of aid: A story that ends with a death. If the story is true, she gives you a Salt Ward (Diamond). If false, the bridges will remember you.

5. Free Company Captain

[MERCENARY] [FATIGUE]

Pike and shot between contracts.

He has served three kings this year. He does not remember their names. His first contract was with a man who called himself emperor. The man is dead. The contract is not.

Debt they owe: He owes back pay to his company. If you pay 1 Supply, he will fight for you for one scene.

Price of aid: A contract signed in blood. If you break it, the Curse Awakening ticks +2.

6. **River Reeve** [LAW] [CORRUPTION]
 Rents every boat twice.
His paper is a single page folded into a boat. The other half is elsewhere. The other half is in the Margravine’s counting house. She does not know.
Debt they owe: He stole the halfpage from the Margravine. If you return it, he will waive all tolls for a season.
Price of aid: A bribe of 1 Boon or a secret about the river. He will also betray you for a better offer.
7. **Salt-Baron** [TRADE] [VIOLENCE]
 Hired blades; owns the ford and your timetable.
His salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned village. The village refused to pay the imperial salt tax. The empire is dead. The salt is not.
Debt they owe: He took a loan from the Margravine’s counting house. If you pay it (2 Supply), he will give you a Salt Charter (pass any ford free).
Price of aid: A wagon of grey salt. Using it in a bargain gives +1 die to intimidation, but the ghost of the burned village will haunt the transaction.
8. **Blackwood Matriarch** [NOBLE] [VENGEANCE]
 Tends the feud like a garden.
Her garden grows tombstones. She waters them with tears—her enemies’. Her grandmother was the last Acasian to hold an imperial title. The empire took it back. She has not forgotten.
Debt they owe: The empire stole her grandmother’s title. If you recover the original charter (in the Sealed Dowry Chest), she will name you her heir.
Price of aid: A lock of hair from a blood enemy. She will not say whose.
9. **Ex-Imperial Surveyor** [KNOWLEDGE] [LONELINESS]
 Has the last accurate map.
The map shows villages that no longer exist. The surveyor visits them anyway. She leaves offerings of bread and ink. The ghosts do not eat. They watch.
Debt they owe: She lost the map’s key a brass compass. Find it, and she will draw you a route that ignores the Curse for one journey.
Price of aid: A true name of a dead village. She will trade a secret for it.
10. **“King” of Three Villages** [CLAIMANT] [IRON]
 Ironnail crown, ironwill taxes.
His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse. The curse reversed back. He does not know.
Debt they owe: He borrowed the plowshare from a hedgewitch. The witch wants it back. Return it, and he will grant you a tax waiver.
Price of aid: A day’s labour in his fields. If you refuse, he accuses you of oathbreaking start a **Feud Spark** [4].
- J **Bride with No Dowry but a Claim** [CLAIM] [DESPERATION]
 Daggers in the wedding chest.
The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bride intends to collect. The bridge was built by the legions. The legions are gone. The bridge is not.
Debt they owe: Her dowry was the bridge’s toll. The Margravine seized it. If you help her collect, she will give you a **Bridge Token** (Diamond).
Price of aid: A dagger from her chest. Using it in a duel gives +1 die, but the bridge’s ghost will claim the loser.
- Q **Margravine of the Broken March** [AUTHORITY] [FEUD]

Half saint, half tax roll.

She has never lost a feud. Her tally stick is her sword. Her greatgreatgrandfather was the last imperial governor's clerk. He stole the seal. She still has it.

Debt they owe: She is losing her grip on the province. If you settle a feud for her, she will give you a **Blood-Peace Charter** (Diamond).

Price of aid: A signature on her tally stick. Signing binds you to her service until the feud is settled.

K The Lame King

[CLAIMANT] [FATIGUE]

Traveling throne; makes law by pointing.

His throne is a sedan chair carried by debtors. They owe him everything. He owes the Margravine a bridge toll. He has not paid. The bridge remembers.

Debt they owe: He cannot pay the toll. If you pay it for him (2 Supply), he will name you his heir for a day you may issue one royal decree.

Price of aid: A ride on his throne. The debtors will carry you, but you will owe them a favour in return.

A The Cursed Child of Silkstrand

[MYTH] [OMEN]

A rumor more than a person; her laughter ends sieges.

She is said to be twelve years old. She has been twelve for a century. She was born on the day the last imperial governor died. She does not age. She does not forget.

Debt they owe: She is the Curse's accountant. If you find her, she will tell you how many bridges you owe.

Price of aid: A name you have never spoken. She will write it in her ledger. The Curse will remember it forever.

(Feud/Levy/Weather/Curse) Peatfog; all horns sound like someone calling your name. Sudden levy—every traveler pressed for a day's service. Bridge feud; rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. Peat-Fog

[WEATHER] [FEAR]

All horns sound like someone calling your name.

The name is not yours. Answer it, and the fog will take you. The fog is the empire's last breath.

Mechanical hook: Navigation rolls are Desperate for the scene. On a Miss, a ghostly tax collector appears. It demands a story or a memory. Refusal ticks **Curse Awakening +1**.

3. Sudden Levy

[AUTHORITY] [TIME]

Every traveler is pressed for a day's service.

The levy master has a list. Your name is on it—in fresh ink. The list was copied from an imperial tax roll. The roll is two hundred years old.

Mechanical hook: Pay 1 Supply or serve. Serving forces a Resolve test (DV 4). On failure, you gain the Condition *Impressed* (1 die to all actions until you escape). Start a **Levy Escape** [4] clock.

4. Bridge Feud

[BOUNDARY] [VIOLENCE]

Rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach. The oath was sworn to the emperor. The emperor is dead. The chain does not care.

Mechanical hook: The chain will only lift if you swear an oath to one of the feuding parties. Swearing ticks **Curse Awakening +1** (oaths made on bridges always compound). Refusing forces a fight treat as a Cap 2 adversary.

5. **Grain Blight** [HARVEST] [FEAR]

Doubles the tithe; refusal means torches at night.

The blight has a face. It is the face of a tax collector who died hungry. The collector worked for the empire. The empire did not pay him.

Mechanical hook: You may pay double (2 Supply) or refuse. Refusing starts a **Village Hunt** [4] clock. When full, the villagers attack at night (Cap 3 mob).

6. **Scree Slide** [MOUNTAIN] [BLOCKED]

Seals the pass; the “safe” detour is owned by your enemy.

The enemy raised the toll yesterday. He was expecting you. The pass was the empire’s eastern gate. It still remembers the legions.

Mechanical hook: Pay 2 Supply to the enemy or find another way. Searching for another way forces a Wits+Survival roll (DV 5). On a failure, you lose 1 segment of progress and gain a **Black Mark** with the enemy.

7. **Wedding Turns Ambush** [SOCIAL] [TRAP]

You are caught between two bloodlines.

The bride’s veil is a shroud. The groom’s ring is a knife. The feud began when the empire divided the valley. The valley has not healed.

Mechanical hook: You must choose a side or flee. Choosing a side gives you an ally (Cap 2) but starts a **Feud Spiral** [6] clock with the other. Fleeing costs 1 Fatigue and ticks **Curse Awakening +1**.

8. **Witch’s Tithe Night** [WITCHCRAFT] [DEBT]

Lights move in the woods; owe nothing or else.

The lights have voices. They are arguing over who should collect. They are the ghosts of imperial tax collectors. They have not stopped working.

Mechanical hook: The ghosts demand a story. If you cannot tell one, they take 1 of your Boons (or 1 Supply). If you have nothing, they take a memory lose 1 XP (refundable by a quest).

9. **Pox Sign** [DISEASE] [ISOLATION]

On a village gate; your escorts desert you.

The pox is a rumor. The desertion is real. The pox came with the last imperial supply train. The supply train never arrived.

Mechanical hook: You must travel alone for the next leg (no assists). Start a **Disease Clock** [4]. When full, each PC gains 1 Fatigue.

10. **Condotta Breaks** [MERCENARY] [BETRAYAL]

The Free Company flips colors midmarch.

The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted to raise morale. He was hired by the Margravine. He was also hired by the Lame King. He is collecting both salaries.

Mechanical hook: The company now fights for your enemy. You may bribe them back (2 Supply) or fight them (Cap 3). Bribing ticks **Curse Awakening +1** (broken loyalty compounds).

J **Heretic Preacher** [FAITH] [RIOT]

Sparks a march; tollgates come down in splinters.

The preacher’s text is a tax receipt. He reads it like scripture. The receipt was issued by the

empire. It is still valid. No one knows to whom.

Mechanical hook: The preacher will grant you safe passage through the riot if you give him a relic (any Diamond). If you refuse, the mob attacks (Cap 2, and you are separated from allies).

Q Imperial Pretender

[CLAIMANT] [POLITICS]

Arrives; every petty lord changes tabards.

The pretender's seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is slightly crooked. The seal was stolen from the last governor's tomb. The governor's ghost is following him.

Mechanical hook: The pretender offers you a charter (Diamond) if you swear loyalty. Swearing ticks **Curse Awakening +2** (the ghost of the governor will remember). Refusing makes him a permanent enemy (start a **Pretender's Hunt** [6] clock).

K River Overruns the Levee

[WEATHER] [DESTRUCTION]

The pontoon goes; your rivals don't.

The river's name is "Debt." It remembers every unpaid crossing. The empire's engineers built the levees. They calculated the flood levels. They did not calculate the Curse.

Mechanical hook: You lose 1 Supply (washed away). If you have no Supply, you lose 1 Boon instead. The GM may also tick **Curse Awakening +1** (the river demands interest).

A The Curse Stirrs

[CURSE] [TRAP]

No matter the road, you return to the same crossroads.

The crossroads has a signpost. The arms are labeled "Regret," "Hunger," "The Same." The post was planted by the last imperial surveyor. She is still walking.

Mechanical hook: Roll on the **Curse Stirrs** table (see Regional Mood section). The party cannot leave until they pay a toll a story, a memory, or a name.

(**Papers/Claims/SafeConduct**) Tollexemption plaque for one bridge (once); monastery letter for bed and bread on a named road.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. Toll-Exemption Plaque

[TRAVEL] [ONCE]

For one bridge (once).

The plaque is a bronze leaf. Hold it up, and the tollkeeper will spit—but step aside. The leaf was minted by the empire. The empire's mines are closed. The metal is still good.

Curse cost: Using the plaque ticks **Curse Awakening +1** (the bridge will remember your face). If you use it on a bridge that has already taken a toll, the plaque crumbles and the bridge's ghost follows you for a day.

3. Monastery Letter

[HOSPITALITY] [ONCE]

For bed and bread on a named road.

The letter is sealed with a wax tear. The monks will honor it—or they will not. The abbot was an imperial clerk. He still follows the old forms.

Curse cost: The monks will ask you to pray for the dead. If you refuse, the letter burns and you gain a **Black Mark** with the monastery. If you pray, clear 1 Fatigue but tick **Curse Awakening +1** (the dead listen).

4. Wine-Right

[TRADE] [ONGOING]

On an abandoned terrace; locals will work for shares.

The wine is from a vine that grows over a mass grave. It tastes of iron. The grave holds the

last imperial garrison. They were paid in promises.

Curse cost: Drinking the wine gives +1 die to your next social roll, but the garrison’s ghosts will appear in your dreams. The GM gains 1 SB to use on a nightmare complication.

5. **Condotta Contract** [MERCENARY] [ONCE]

A signed pike contract (one battle on your terms).

The contract is written in blood. The blood is from the captain’s own finger. The contract was copied from an imperial legionary oath. The words have changed. The weight has not.

Curse cost: If the contract is broken, tick **Curse Awakening +2**. The captain’s ghost will demand a new contract signed in your own blood.

6. **Tithe-Remission Writ** [AUTHORITY] [ONCE]

For a village; they owe you a season’s labor.

The writ is stamped with a bell. The bell’s clapper is a finger bone. The bell was cast from melted imperial coinage. The coinage was debased. The bell rings true.

Curse cost: Using the writ forces the village to work for you, but the bell’s ghost will follow you. Every season, you must offer it a story or lose 1 Boon.

7. **Border-Stone Adjustment** [BOUNDARY] [ONCE]

Move a line two fields over.

The adjustment is a lie. The truth is that the line was always there. The line was surveyed by the empire’s best geometers. They are all dead. Their measurements are not.

Curse cost: The ghost of the surveyor will appear and demand you measure the new line with your own feet. Walk it exactly (8 steps) or lose 1 Fatigue and tick **Curse Awakening +1**.

8. **Pass-Key Charm** [TRAVEL] [ONGOING]

Recognized by Pale Causeway watchmen.

The charm is a knotted cord. Untie it to pass—or to stay. The cord was tied by an imperial courier. The courier’s route was swallowed by the Curse. The cord remembers the way.

Curse cost: The charm works for one season. After that, the courier’s ghost will visit you. He will ask for a message to deliver. If you refuse, the charm becomes a curse all roads lead back to the same crossing.

9. **Sealed Dowry Chest** [CLAIM] [MYSTERY]

Of claims, not coin; certain doors open.

The chest is locked with a riddle. The answer is a name you do not know. The name is the last imperial governor’s. He wrote it on the inside. He is the only one who has seen it.

Curse cost: Opening the chest ticks **Curse Awakening +3**. The governor’s ghost will appear and offer a bargain: the name in exchange for a service. Refusing means the chest locks forever.

10. **Mine-Share** [RESOURCE] [ALLIANCE]

In the commune; they fight like they mean it.

The share is a pickaxe. The commune will lend you a miner—or a grave. The mine was opened by the empire’s first surveyors. They found iron. They also found something else. They did not name it.

Curse cost: The miner will work for you, but the mine’s whispers will follow. Once per session, the GM may ask you to name something you found in the dark. If you lie, the miner dies.

J **Blood-Peace Charter** [SOCIAL] [TRUCE]

Suspend a feud long enough to move your wagons.

The charter is a white ribbon. Blood will not be spilled while it flies—but blood will remember. The ribbon was woven by a hedgewitch. She used thread from a tax collector’s uniform. The collector is dead. The thread is not.

Curse cost: The truce lasts one scene. After that, the feud returns with interest—both sides will demand a wergild from you. Pay 2 Supply or start a **Double Feud** [6].

Q Marriage Proxy [SOCIAL] [ALLIANCE]

From the Margravine; bind a hillking to your cause.

The proxy is a wedding veil. The veil was worn by a ghost. The ghost was the Margravine’s grandmother. She married an imperial legate. The legate never came home.

Curse cost: Using the proxy binds the hillking to you—but the ghost will appear at your own wedding (or any celebration). She will ask for a dance. Refusing costs 1 Boon and ticks

Curse Awakening +1.

K The Lame King’s Traveling Writ [AUTHORITY] [ONCE]

Troops must make way (for now).

The writ is a broken scepter. The Lame King’s seal is a footprint. The footprint was pressed into wax by his grandfather. The grandfather was a free company captain. He could not write. He used his boot.

Curse cost: The writ works only once. After that, the Lame King will send debtors to collect the scepter. If you refuse, start a **King’s Hunt** [6].

A Curse-Redemption Rite (Temporary) [RITUAL] [ONCE]

For one night, no crossroads can hold you.

The rite is a whisper. The whisper is a name you have never spoken. The name is the Curse’s. It does not want to be spoken. It does not want to be silent. It wants to be paid.

Curse cost: Using the rite clears all **Curse Awakening** segments for one night. The next morning, the Curse returns with double the segments. You cannot use the rite again in the same province.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/claims/safeconducts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo plague and curse motifs—crossroads that turn back on themselves, bells tolling for no funeral, banners blackened by mildew, the ghost of the empire in every milestone.
- Track the **Curse Awakening** [10] clock as a campaignwide pressure. Use the **Curse Stirrs** table when it reaches 8.

Additional Features

- **Feud as Currency:** Any insult, accident, or rumor can birth a feud; the GM may replace an SB result with a feudtoken tied to a petty lord or house. Feudtokens act as reusable complications: once per scene, the GM can spend a feudtoken to have a rival appear, a bridge close, or a village refuse aid.
- **Rot & Tithe:** Each market or harvest scene carries a risk of rot—add a pressure if food or coin are exchanged without a blessing or a seal. A failed roll may double the tithe or spoil

stored supplies.

- **The Curse Remembers:** When roads or negotiations stall, the GM may quietly repeat imagery—crossroads, whispers, mildew—to remind players that Acasia itself resists resolution. If the party ignores three such omens, the *Curse Stirrs* complication triggers automatically.
- **Empire’s Ghost:** Any ancient imperial structure (milestone, bridge, fortress) may still be haunted by the echo of its original purpose. A character who makes an offering (a coin, a salute, a whispered oath) may gain +1 die on a single roll within sight of that structure. The offering must be sincere. The empire does not accept bribes. It accepts memory.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in a burned abbey. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the charcoalers, trying to untie her cord from a Rothari death warrant. She says the empire’s last weight is still unpaid.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pale Causeway is a Class II Anchor site—the ghosts of workers who died building it still carry stones. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin in every crack. The workers do not spend the coins. They stack them. They are building something.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the tollcollectors. Take it, and your passage is always free—but the coin will taste of blood every time the Causeway floods. The coin was minted in the empire’s last year. The emperor’s face is worn smooth.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Acasian psions are called “FeudReaders.” They taste the weight of old grudges in the water. The Margravine employs two—and has never trusted a settlement they didn’t whisper. They say the Curse is not a thing. It is a conversation. The empire is still talking.
- **The Ninth:** In any Acasian scene, the ninth toll paid at a bridge is never the last. The wise pay eight and barter for the ninth. The ninth toll is collected by a child with no name. The child is the Curse’s accountant.

Acasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Milestone:** Crumble a crust at a broken milestone. Ignore the first *Peat-Fog* penalty.
- **Knot the Contract:** Tie a single knot in a writ’s ribbon. Cancel *Bridge Feud* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Blight:** Whisper a dead tax collector’s name into a grain sack. Gain +1 Effect when avoiding tithes this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Margravine.

Decline & Patronage

Patronage here is as brittle as candle wax. The Rothari Clan holds their marches by fear and iron law—patronage from them is real, but cruel, demanding service in blood or levy. Elsewhere, noble names are little more than titles printed on parchment and sold like promises. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days, while mercenary captains trade loyalty for coin, switching colors with each bell.

To seek a patron in Acasia is to choose which hunger you will feed: the Rothari’s iron teeth, a Free Company’s purse, or the hollow blessing of a saint who may never have lived. Yet

even false crowns cast shadows long enough to shelter those desperate enough to kneel. The empire is dead. Its weight is not. And the Curse is patient.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tithe-collectors or petty lords**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **Free Company patrols or village watchmen**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **feud-trackers or hedge-witches**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable road conditions**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **River reeve or Free Company captain** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or bridge closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival bloodline or toll-lord's enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **feudkin, Free Company deserters, or Margravine's guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/levy doubled/curse triggered**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Margravine, Lame King, or Cursed Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/bridge falls/curse loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Acasia (Feud & Tithe):** Toll collectors demand double, bloodlines take offense, wagons are seized as "payment."

- **Acasia (Rot & Famine):** Grain blights spread, wells run dry, abandoned villages hold only ghosts.
- **Acasia (Curse & Crossroads):** Roads loop back, milestones point the wrong way, the same bridge appears twice.
- **Acasia (Empire’s Ghost):** A phantom legionary marches past, an imperial seal glows on a broken stone, a tax collector’s ghost demands arrears.

Boss Archetypes in Acasia

- **The False King (Feud/Authority)** — A petty lord or pretender who crowns themselves on the ruins of empire. *Phases:* Levy Demanded → Feud Declared → Hasty Coronation. *Cracks:* a **Blood-Peace Charter** suspends his authority; a **Marriage Proxy** binds him to a rival.
- **The Witch of the Blackwoods (Witchcraft/Curse)** — A hedgewitch, matriarch, or revenant who manipulates feuds and curses. *Phases:* Tithe of Fear → Curse of the Crossroads → Hollow Wedding. *Cracks:* a **Curse-Redemption Rite** breaks her hold; a **Mine-Share** gives the commune courage to defy her.
- **The Tithe Collector (Greed/Extortion)** — A bureaucratpriest with writs, escorts, and the ability to summon feuds or famine with a single decree. *Phases:* Audit of Souls → Seizure of Grain → The Reckoning. *Cracks:* a **Toll-Exemption Plaque** voids his claim; a **Wine-Right** buys off his debtors.
- **The Rotting Child (Mystery/Curse)** — A folkloric horror tied to Acasia’s plague of false crossroads. *Phases:* Laughter in the Fog → The Bridge That Loops → The Feast of Ends. *Cracks:* a **Tithe-Remission Writ** fed to the fog; a **Monastery Letter** read aloud at the crossroads.
- **The Imperial Ghost (Undead/Precedent)** — The shade of the last imperial governor, still trying to collect the taxes. *Phases:* Audit of the Damned → Summon the Debtors → The Emperor’s Peace. *Cracks:* produce the original imperial charter (in the Sealed Dowry Chest), pay a wergild in the empire’s own debased coinage, or convince the ghost that the empire is truly dead.

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Dowry That Walked:** A Blackwood matriarch’s dowry chest has been stolen. The chest contains a claim to a bridge that never floods—and a curse that the Margravine wants broken. The chest was last seen in the hands of a free company captain who claims he is the heir to the empire.
- **The Lame King’s Feast:** The Lame King invites the party to a feast. The feast is a trial. The food is memory. The wine is lies. The king wants to know who killed the last imperial surveyor. The surveyor is sitting at the table.
- **The Curse of the Pale Causeway:** The Causeway is repeating. Every crossing brings the party back to the same inn. The innkeeper is missing a finger. She says she gave it to the bridge. The bridge wants more. The bridge remembers the empire’s last toll.

Chapter 4

Vhasia

The Fractured Sun.

Two crowns. One kingdom. A river so wide it might as well be a border and oh, how the crowns love pretending it's not.

I am a Road Warden. I have served under three different banners on this same stretch of road, and the only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls. The Northern Seigneurie and the Southern Parlement both claim the throne, both flood the river with paperwork to "prove" their right, and both are too busy arguing over seal wax colours to notice that the Fenwoods already burned Lence, and the Sun-court is a memory.

The Last Dauphin? A rumour. But rumours pay well when you're the one who started them and I started three: that he was swapped at birth with a goatherd's child, that he's secretly a Veiled Sister in disguise, and that he's been dead for ten years, his "reappearance" a puppet show run by the Seigneurie's spymaster.

Never carry a coin that bears only one sunburst. The realm has three mints, and the wrong metal on the wrong road is treason.

Road Warden Cerran, who has not slept in two days and is not sure which crown he serves

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Dark bread and watered wine the wine cuts the dust from the road. The nobility eat spiced eggs and fresh cheese, but they eat behind closed doors. To eat well in public is to invite envy. Envy is a dagger.

What does a child learn before they can walk? Which colours not to wear. Black and gold are the Northern Crown's colours. Red and silver are the Southern Parlement's. A child

who wears the wrong colour to the wrong village may not return home.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Which side of the road they walk on. The north side is the Crown's. The south side is the Parlement's. The middle is no man's land literally. Bandits, spies, and messengers use the middle. So do ghosts.

What is the most common crime? Raiding across the Belworth. The river is the border, the border is a suggestion, and the suggestion is enforced by armed men on both sides. The crime is not in raiding. The crime is in being caught on the wrong bank at dawn.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Sun-court was not burned. It was bankrupted. The Fenwoods did not sack Lencethey bought it. Every judge, every clerk, every guard captain had a price. The Fenwoods paid it. The Vhasians are still paying interest.

Where do people go when they die? To the crypts beneath the Sun-court if they can afford a plaque. The poor are buried in unmarked graves along the Belworth floodplain. The river floods every spring. The dead wash downstream, into the land of the other crown. Neither side claims them.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a chevauchée a raiding party that burns a village in your name. The apology is not in the burning. The apology is in the promise that the village will be rebuilt with your own hands. If you burn a village and do not rebuild, you have not apologized. You have started a feud.

What is the most important festival? The Sun-return (spring equinox). Both crowns claim the sun as their symbol. On this day, both hold processions. The processions are identical. The participants do not acknowledge each other. The sun does not care.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Queen-Mother has no claim to the regency. Her son is not the Dauphin. The real Dauphin died in childbirth. The Queen-Mother's daughter was stillborn. The child on the throne is a foundling, bought from a Tulkani caravan. The Tulkani know. The Tulkani are still waiting to be paid.

4.1 Vhasia — “The Fractured Sun”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The sun shattered at Lence. The pieces are still falling. Which shadow will catch you?*

Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (Elite): “The sun may be fractured, but our authority is absolute within our domains. Every coin minted here carries our blessing, and every law written bears our seal the rest is just politics. The rest is also ash. Ask the Fenwoods. They made the ash, and they left us to choke on it. But remember: the first crack came not from their swords, but from the marriage beds where Viterran queens bore Vhasian dukes and the sons who wondered whose blood truly ran in their veins.”

Road Warden (Commoner): “I’ve served under three banners on this same road. The only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls, oaths, the dead. The Fenwoods burned Lence ten years ago. Now every duke with a purse thinks he’s king. The QueenMother weaves, Valdais sharpens, and the Two Crowns count their silver. Me? I just want to get home before the snows bury the graves. And if you hear a cantor singing the *Planctus Armatus*, stop and listen. That’s the only honest history left especially the verse about the queen who married twice, bore sons to both kings, and left the realm wondering which throne was hers by right, and which by rumor.”

Genre / Mood: Courtly intrigue, chevauchée warfare, fractured legitimacy, the tragedy of chivalry a kingdom that cannot mourn because mourning would mean admitting the old world is dead.

Starting Location: The PontduTithe, its golden arches catching fire in the sunset as pilgrims chant from both banks. A Duchy Constable in splendid armour guards the toll gate. “The Chevauchee burns,” he says, gesturing to distant smoke. “Two Crowns march to meet it. Whose seal do you carry? Speak quickly the levy waits for no one. And keep your hand away from your sword. The bridge remembers the last blood spilled here. It remembers the Fenwood horses. It remembers the screams. If you hear a cantor’s voice on the wind, do not mistake it for a lullaby. It is a warning and it often sings of queens who wore two crowns, and sons who never knew which father’s blood they carried.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Vhasia is a realm of broken coronations and split loyalties, still bleeding from a wound a decade old. Once a proud province of the Utaran empire, the unified Sun Court shattered like its heraldic sunburst when the Fenwoods of Viterra and their allies sacked the capital of Lence and cast down the old Blood line. Duke Braedyn Fenwood uncle of Veralyn, now the Warrior Queen of Viterra led the assault, his ironshod cavalry grinding the Sun King’s army into the mud of the Ford of Ashes. They burned Lence until the mirrors melted and the very stones wept. They left the throne empty not destroyed, but open. And they left a wound that has not healed.

But the wound runs deeper than smoke and stone. Forty years ago, during the Province Wars, King Wymund of Viterra sought alliance with Vhasia through marriage taking Elianor Everblood (née Longblood) as his queen. She bore him two daughters and, rumor says, Valdais Longblood himself though Wymund died before the boy could claim Viterran succession. Elianor then married Wymund’s son, Baldwyn II (the “Good King”), becoming queen again

and mother to Wyllmot, Veralyn's father. The split between these marriages ignited the provincial wars that weakened both realms, culminating in Wyllmot's defeat of Valdais at Adriaa victory stained by the suspicion that he fought his own half-brother for a throne built on doubtful bloodlines.

When the Fenwoods came, Elianor was in her duchy of Ethor, having married into the Vhasian royal Bloods linea final attempt to stitch the realm back together that the sack of Lence tore apart utterly. Now, Elianor rules from Ethor, her alliances woven from the threads of three marriages and the quiet terror that none of her sons may be truly "hers" by the blood that matters. She is not mourning. She is waitingfor proof, for a sign, for the moment when the fractured sun might finally cast a single shadow.

The memory of the sack haunts every negotiation. The QueenMother, Elianor Everblood, lost her third husbandthe old Sun Kingand her cousins and sisters in the flames. Her second son, Wyllmot, King of Viterra and Duke of Aberiel, died fighting rebels in Viterra, leaving his crown to his daughter, Veralynwho is now the Warrior Queen, who was the Fenwoods' ward, and who was *there* when they burned Lence. Elianor rules from a riverside keep, weaving alliances and hiding a secreta Dauphin, perhaps her grandnephew, perhaps a changeling, who may be the key to restoring the Sun Court. Her eldest son, Valdais Longblood, Duke of Adria, claims the throne by blood and steel, but Elianor does not trust him. She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning. She is waiting.

The Fenwood sack was not just a military defeat; it was a betrayal of chivalry itself. The knights of Vhasia had sworn to protect the realm with the **Round of Five Virtues**: Courage, Courtesy, Mercy, Prowess, Truth. At Lence, the Fenwoods showed no mercy. The knights still argue about whether chivalry died there or whether it was already a corpse, dressed in armour. The Cantor Alain sings the *Planctus Armatus* each spring, and the congregation weeps for Sir Corin, who unbuckled his gorget to hear a thief's voice and was undone by the mercy he offered. Sir Corin died at Lence. He was trying to save a child. The child is now the Dauphin or so the QueenMother claimsand perhaps the living proof that Elianor's bloodline, however tangled, still holds the true sun.

What you notice first: The smell of old smoke and fresh ink. The way every noble's seal has a hairline cracklike the fault lines in old marriage alliances. The constant, nervous laughter of courtiers who remember whose head rolled last seasonand whose mother married which king. The way the knights touch their gorgets when someone speaks of mercy, remembering Sir Corin's unbuckling at Lenceand the queen who watched it all from Ethor, wondering if the mercy she'd been shown was ever real.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never carry a coin that bears only one sunburst. The realm has three mints, and the wrong metal on the wrong road is treason. Also, never speak the name "Fenwood" without naming Queen Veralyn first. The wound is still raw. The QueenMother's spies are everywhere and they have long memories. And never forget: the first treason was not in the field, but in the nursery, when a queen wondered if the son in her cradle was truly the king's.

Regional Mood: Crowns, Courts, and the Weight of Lence

Here, the past is a weapon and the future is a weight not of silver, but of memory. The Fenwoods came from Viterra with fire and iron, broke the Sun King's army at the Ford of Ashes, and burned Lence until the mirrors melted. Duke Braedyn Fenwood led them; his daughter Veralyn now the

Warrior Queen of Viterra was her father’s attendant and witness to the sack, a fact that complicates every border negotiation. The Vhasian nobility has not forgotten. They cannot forgive. But they cannot afford a war with Viterra, either.

So they fight each other instead.

Now every duke with a long purse and a short conscience backs a claimant. The QueenMother weaves alliances from her riverside keep, holding a Dauphin perhaps her grandnephew, perhaps a commoner with a convincing birthmark as a bargaining chip. The Two Crowns Valdais Longblood of Adria in the southwest, and a rival claimant backed by the southern parlements march their levies. Routiers sell their swords by the season, and the memory of Lence is ground into every negotiation. Vhasia is not a nation at war. It is a nation that forgot how to be at peace. And ten years later, the smoke from Lence still hasn’t cleared and neither has the doubt about whose blood truly flows in the veins of those who claim the throne.

The Province Wars (Forty Years Ago)

Before the Fenwood sack, there was the **Province Wars** a generation of lowintensity raiding between the cantons that left the old crown weakened and the knights bitter. The peace that ended the Province Wars was a treaty of exhaustion, not reconciliation. It was during those wars that the dynastic tangles began: King Wymund of Viterra married Elianor Everblood to seal the peace, only for her to later wed his son Baldwyn II after Wymund’s death a union that sparked the very conflicts it was meant to prevent. The veterans of the Province Wars are now the old men who watch the new claimants with weary eyes. They remember when mercy meant something. They also remember when it cost everything and they whisper that the first casualty of those wars was trust in the marriage beds of queens.

The Players of the Great Game

The succession crisis has four major factions, each with a claim, a secret, and a price each shadowed by the legacy of dual marriages and uncertain parentage.

- **QueenMother Elianor Everblood (née Longblood):** Widow of the last Sun King, mother of Valdais and the late Wyllmot. She rules the western canton of Ethon. Her price is a guarantee that her grandnephew (the Dauphin) will not be killed. Her secret: she is not sure if Valdais is truly her son by Wymund or if he is Baldwyn II’s bastard, conceived during the turbulent shift between husbands. She acts as if he is of the Blood, because certainty would destroy what remains of the Longblood line and because the Dauphin may be her only hope for a heir without doubt.
- **Duke Valdais Longblood of Adria:** The northern claimant. Nephew or halfbrother, depending on the rumour to the last Sun King. A tournament champion with a flawless record and a suspicious habit of opponents falling ill before jousts. His claim rests on blood and steel. His secret: his mother, Elianor, does not trust him and he suspects why. He was not at Lence. He wishes he had been so he could have died with honour instead of living with the question: “Whose son am I, truly?”
- **The Two Crowns (Rival Dukes of the South and West):** Backed by the southern parlements and the western march lords. Their claim rests on election and expediency. Their secret: they have been known to accept Viterran gold but never the Fenwood seal. They whisper that Veralyn is not her father’s daughter. They are wrong. They are also afraid that if the Viterran line is false, then the Vhasian claim via Elianor’s marriages is equally doubtful, and the realm has no true sun left to claim.

- **The Last Dauphin (The False/Real Heir):** A child of nine years, hidden in the QueenMother’s keep. His legitimacy is a matter of faith. His existence is the only thing keeping Valdais from marching on his mother’s castle. His secret: even Elianor does not know if he is truly her grandnephew but she has dreamed of Sir Corin, who died saving a child at Lence. The child in the dream has the Dauphin’s faceand perhaps, just perhaps, the unbroken line of Elianor’s blood, however it flowed.

The Cantor Alain and the Planctus Armatus

No figure embodies Vhasia’s tragedy more than **Alain, the Iron Bard**. A cantor who survived the sack of Lence as a boy rescued by Sir Corin himself Alain carries a cracked ring and a voice that carries the weight of the dead. Each dusk, he sings the *Planctus Armatus* (the Lament for the Armoured), a song that recounts Corin’s unbuckling and the mercy that killed him. The song has eight verses. The ninth is silence the space where the Hollow listens. The fourth verse, oft-whispered, speaks of “the queen who wore two crowns, and the son who knew not which father’s blood he carried.”

Mechanical Hook: Once per session, a character who hears Alain sing (or who recites a verse of the *Planctus Armatus*) may gain +1 die on a roll involving mercy or witness. On a failure, they mark 1 Fatigue the weight of remembering. If they recite the fourth verse specifically, they may instead gain +1 Effect on a roll involving inheritance or legitimacybut mark 1 Corruption, as the doubt it stirs is a poison to certainty.

Prominent NPCs of Vhasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Elianor Everblood	QueenMother of Ethor	Restore her grandnephew (real or false) to the throneand prove, at last, whose blood truly flows in Valdais’s veins. She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning she is planning, and waiting for the moment the doubt ends. Her shadow has begun to drift independentlysometimes toward Ethor, sometimes toward the memory of Wymund’s court, sometimes toward the empty space where Baldwyn II’s queen should stand.	

Valdais Longblood	Duke of Adria, claimant	Unite Vhasia under a strong northern crown and silence the whispers about his parentage once and for all. He has never lost a joust. His opponents have a habit of falling ill before the tilt. He does not poison them. His mother's spies do. He carries a shard of Wymund's coronation sword in his boot as a reminder that the first throne he ever knew may not have been his by right.	
The Red Marshal	Exiled commander of the Sun Court's army	Win back Lence or die trying	He lost the Battle of Ashes; he still sees it in his dreams and his nightmares. He was the last man to see the old king alive. The king's last words were a curse on the Fenwood name. He wonders, in the quiet hours, if the curse was meant for the Fenwoods or for the queens who married twice and left the realm questioning whose sons were truly theirs.

Seint Michel's Justiciar	Magistrate of the Order of the Gilded Scale	Enforce the chivalric code without mercy	He carries a scale with one pan empty; the empty pan is for lies. He has never been able to balance it. The empty pan holds the ghost of Sir Corinand sometimes, he swears, the whisper of Elianor's doubt as she watched the sack from Ethor.
Sister Oria	Custodian of the LanternRites House on the Belworth	Keep the rites of hospitality and witness	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to. The QueenMother's enemies who cross her threshold have a habit of forgetting why they came. Her scroll records every name and every death of those who fell at Lenceand the margins note the queens who watched from afar, wondering if the sons they bore were worth the cost.

The Cantor Alain	Iron Bard, bearer of the Cracked Ring	Sing the truth of Corin’s mercy before the armour closes againand sing the truth of the queens who bore sons to two kings, and the sons who never knew which father’s blood they carried. Feathers grow from his temples; his shadow moves a halfstep behind him. His songs are the only honest history left in Vhasia. He sings the names of the dead every dusk. The dead listenand sometimes, they answer with questions about parentage.	
The Dauphin (Child)	A child of nine, hidden in the QueenMother’s keep	Surviveand perhaps, one day, answer the question that has haunted Elianor since Valdaais was in swaddling clothes. He has never seen the sun. He knows three languages, the lineage of every noble house, and the taste of every poison. He does not know if he is a prince or a puppet. He dreams every night of a knight with an unbuckled gorgetand of a queen who wore two crowns, wondering which throne was truly hers.	

Names of Vhasia

Inspired by the fractured duchies: Francien, Norman, and Brittonic influences. Soft vowels, silent consonants, and surnames that recall a bridge, a ford, or a stained banner. Many names echo the Province Wars era, when marriage alliances were made and broken.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valdaais	Elianor	de la Marche	<i>the Iron</i>
Wymund	Baldwyn	l’Ever	<i>the Unwed</i>
Renaud	Isabeau	de Lence	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Corin	Oria	d’Ethor	<i>BellSworn</i>
Touénot	Mael	du Pont	<i>the Silver</i>
Alain	Giselle	de la Croix	<i>AshBanner</i>

Ghiro	Celandine	l'Argent	<i>the Unpaid</i>
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(**Château/Cathedral/Forest**) Wayside shrine with pilgrims tacking petitions to a scorched sun disc; vineterrace clos above a millstream with napping watchmen. The oldest vintners whisper that the "Crownbreaker" vintage was blessed by Elianor herself once as Viterran queen, once as Vhasian queen before the province wars turned the gift to ash.

Spades Places

2. **Wayside Shrine** Pilgrims tack petitions to a scorched sun disc; each parchment curls in different winds. *The petitions are never answered. The shrine is a mailbox for the dead especially those who fell at Lence. The dead do not write back. They wait and sometimes, they leave questions about which queen bore them.*
3. **VineTerrace** Clos above a millstream; watchmen nap, halberds traded for bottles. *The best vintage is called "Crownbreaker." It tastes like smoke and regret. The year of the sack was a particularly good harvest. The wine remembers and so do the old men who recall when Elianor wore two crowns, and the realm wondered which throne was hers.*
4. **Bastide Square** Neat as a checkerboard; merchants pay homage to different "hours" of the Sun. *The square has a gallows. It rotates to face whichever claimant lost the last duel. The wood is still green from the forest where the Fenwoods camped before Lence. The reeve who tends it swears he can still see Elianor in the distance, watching the ford where her sons' loyalties were first tested.*
5. **Royal Forest** Antler posts mark laws no king remembers; poachers still hang. *The forest's deer have grown bold. They wear crowns of shed antlers. Some say they are the ghosts of the old nobility or the knights who unbuckled their gorgets too late. The oldest stags remember when the province wars began not with a battle, but with a queen changing beds.*
6. **PontduTithe** Tollbridge flanked by chapels and crossbows; chains blessed by rival bishops. *The chains were forged from melted sunbursts. They ring in different keys. The Fenwood army crossed here. The bridge still groans when Viterrans approach. The groans are prayers and sometimes, they are questions: "Which son was truly yours, Elianor?"*
7. **Great Fair** Outside a chartered town; counting sheds ring like bells, rumours louder still. *The fair has a Court of Miracles where counterfeiters sell to informers. The best forgery is a sunburst coin that rings true until you test its weight. The weight of a lie is memory and the heaviest lies are those whispered in the nursery about parentage.*
8. **Salt Pans** Windpumps on an estuary; gulls own the law, smugglers own the night. *The salt is grey. It tastes of old tears and older weights. The smugglers carry more than salt they carry the QueenMother's letters. The letters smell of Lence and sometimes, they carry the ink of a queen who rewrote her will three times, trying to decide which son to name as heir.*
9. **SiegeChâteau** Hoardings patched, cistern low, banners cut into ragged suns. *The banner's ragged edges are from a Fenwood sword. The owner still limps. He lost his son at Lence. He fights for Valdaïs but he does not love him. He loves the ghost of his son and sometimes, he wonders if that son was ever truly his.*
10. **Cathedral Yard** Cranes creak, stones fly, scaffolds bristle with rival masons' marks. *The mason's marks are clan signs. A scratched out mark means a dead foreman. One mason's mark is a sunburst with a crack the mark of the QueenMother's architect. He was at Lence. He*

built the pyresand sometimes, he swears he heard Elianor whisper, “Which of these sons is truly mine?” as the flames rose.

- J **Parlement Hall** Hung with faded tapestries; sunbursts spliced and restitched by claimants. *The tapestries show battles that never happened and some that shouldn’t have. One tapestry shows the sack of Lence from the Fenwood perspective. The QueenMother has ordered it burned three times. It keeps reappearing. The thread is from the shrouds of the deadand the embroidery sometimes shows two crowns overlapping, or a queen’s hand hovering over two cradles.*
- Q **Queen’s Causeway** Milelong oath paved in quarried stone; halfsunken each spring. *The sunken half is a graveyard for vows. The stones are slippery with old lies. The QueenMother walks here at dawn. She speaks to the dead. The dead answer in the voice of the Dauphinand sometimes, they add, “Tell my mother which throne was hers.”*
- K **Sun Palace (Lence)** Shattered mirrors, brambled gardens; courtiers playing at kingship. *The mirrors were covered after the sack. No one wants to see what they show now a reflection of a kingdom that no longer exists. The courtiers pretend the king still lives. The servants know better. The mirrors know bestand sometimes, they reflect not a king, but the echo of a queen’s doubt as she watched from Ethor, wondering if the mercy she’d been shown was ever real.*
- A **King’s High Road** Milestones chipped of crowns; yet every army still marches it. *The road is paved with the bones of tax collectors. They are not missed. The Fenwood army marched here. Their footprints are still visible in the stone and in the memory of every orphanand in the quiet doubt of the nurses who wondered, as they swaddled the princes, if the blood in their veins was truly royal.*

(Lord/Court/Company) Road warden with dented badge and honest horn; vintnerguild syndic counting saints’ days as grace periods.

Hearts People & Factions

- 2. **Road Warden** Dented badge, honest horn; ignored by both crowns but knows the roads. *His horn is cracked. It still sounds but the note is always half a step flat. He was at Lence. He does not speak of it. The horn doesbut sometimes, in the quiet hours, he swears he hears a queen’s whisper from Ethor: “Which of these sons is truly mine?”*
- 3. **Vintner Syndic** Counts saints’ days as grace periods, vintages as treaties; wine as diplomacy. *He keeps a bottle of Crownbreaker in every cellar. He knows which vintage each duke prefers. He also knows which duke’s wine is poisoned. He does not ask. The poison is memoryand the memory of which queen bore which son.*
- 4. **AbbessChatelaine** Rules a fortressconvent with iron rule and sharper scripture. *She has never drawn a blade. The scaffold has, on her orders. She sheltered refugees after the sack. The QueenMother owes her a weight. The QueenMother does not forget weights or the smell of burning wool. She does not forget the weight of a queen’s doubt as she watched from afar.*
- 5. **Routier Captain** Scarred and mercenary; prefers ransoms to loyalty; coin as conscience. *He switches banners as often as his shirt. His loyalty is to the paychest and to his mother. He fought for the Fenwoods at Lence. He still has nightmares. He pays for them in silverand sometimes, he wonders if the silver was paid for a son who was never truly his.*
- 6. **Duchy Constable** Splendid armour, empty coffers, pride swollen as a banner; glory over gold. *His armour was his grandfather’s. It still has the dent from a Fenwood axe. He serves*

Valdais because Valdais pays but he served the old king first. He cannot forgive himself for surviving Lence. The dent weeps rustand sometimes, he swears he hears the echo of a queen's doubt as he stands watch, wondering if the loyalty he's given is to a son who was ever truly the king's.

7. **Cantor Alain** The Iron Bard, bearer of the Cracked Ring; his songs are the only honest history. *Feathers grow from his temples. His shadow moves a halfstep behind him. He sings the names of the dead every dusk. The dead listen. And sometimes, they sing back: "Which throne was yours, Elianor?"*
 8. **SaltFarmer** Gabelle lessee with cudgels, writs, and a riverchart no crown has; tax as tyranny. *His tally is written in salt. One drop of water and the obligations vanish along with the evidence. He is the QueenMother's man. He does not say so aloud. His salt tastes of ashand sometimes, he swears he can taste the doubt in it, sharp and bitter as the question no queen dares to ask aloud.*
 9. **Trouvère** A scandalous lay about the last Sun King brings knives to tavern doors. *He sings the truth. That is why he sleeps in a different inn every night. He knows who really ordered the burning of Lence. He will not say. He values his tongue. The truth is a currency he spends in silenceand sometimes, he spends it on the question that has haunted queens for generations.*
 10. **MarshalExile** The Sun Court's hammer; now wielded by whoever pays in silver. *He lost the Battle of Ashes. He still sees it in his dreams and his nightmares. He was the last man to see the old king alive. The king's last words were a curse on the Fenwood name. The curse is still unpaidand sometimes, he wonders if it was meant not for the Fenwoods, but for the queens who married twice and left the realm wondering whose sons were truly theirs.*
- J Heretic Perfect** Preaches peace while tucking hidden daggers into parchment margins. *His sermon is a code. The psalms tell you which bridge to cross and which to burn. He is the QueenMother's spy. He is also Valdais's spy. He is also his own spy. His sermons are the only honest prayers leftand sometimes, they pray for the day the doubt ends.*
- Q QueenMother** Riverside keep; weaves alliances as if they were dowries. *She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning. She is waiting. Her grandnephew real or false will sit on the Sun Court. She will not live to see it. She has made her peace with that. The peace tastes of Lenceand sometimes, it tastes of the doubt that has haunted her since the Province Wars began.*
- K Two Crowns** Rival dukes, each "crowned" in rival cathedrals, neither whole. *One wears a crown of iron. The other wears a crown of words. Both rust. Neither was at Lence. Neither speaks of it. They pay others to speak for them. And sometimes, they whisper that if the Viterran line is false, then the Vhasian claim via Elianor's marriages is equally doubtfuland the realm has no true sun left.*
- A Last Dauphin** A rumour with a birthmark; armies march for whispers alone. *He may be a baker's son. The armies don't care. They need a sun to follow. He has never seen the sun. He knows three languages, the lineage of every noble house, and the taste of every poison. He does not know if he is a prince or a puppet. He does not ask. He dreams every night of a knight with an unbuckled gorgetand of a queen who wore two crowns, wondering, as the child does, which throne was truly hers.*

(Chevauchée/Law/Church) Chevauchée burning loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. Interdict falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls.

Clubs Complications/Threats

2. **Chevauchée** Raiders burn loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. *The raiders wear no colours. Their horses answer to whistles and grudges. They were at Lence. They remember. The smoke smells of old wooland sometimes, it carries the echo of a queen’s whisper from Ethor: “Which of these sons is truly mine?”* ‘[WAR]’
3. **Interdict** Falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls, heretics prosper. *The bells were melted for shot three wars ago. The silence is old. The interdict was ordered by the CardinalRegent but no one knows which claimant he serves. The silence is a prayer for the dead of Lenceand sometimes, it is a prayer for the queens who watched from afar, wondering if the sons they bore were worth the cost.* ‘[FAITH]’
4. **Forest Law** Venison becomes treason; poachers hang from antler posts. *The antler posts are carved with the names of the hanged. They whisper at dusk. The names include survivors of Lence who could not find work. The whispers are the names of the dead they could not saveand sometimes, they add, “Tell me, Elianorwas this son truly yours?”* ‘[DEATH]’
5. **River Spate** Ferries chained, bridges drowned, pilgrims stranded midprayer. *The water is the colour of old gold. It washed away a mint last spring. The mint belonged to a claimant who could not pay his routiers. The routiers now raid for the other side. The water remembers the goldand sometimes, it remembers the doubt in the nursery about whose son was truly the heir.* ‘[WEATHER]’
6. **Coin Debasement** Three mints, three suns, no trust; soldiers demand silver alone. *The silver is from the same mine but the stamp is a prayer, not a promise. The QueenMother controls two mints. Valdaís controls one. The CardinalRegent holds the dies. The dies were made from melted Fenwood spurs. And sometimes, the QueenMother swears she can taste the doubt in the silversharp and bitter as the question no heir dares to ask aloud.* ‘[WEIGHT]’
7. **Parlement Divided** A siege laid on parchment before walls; war by paperwork. *The clerks duel with citations. The loser pays the winner’s ink bill. The winner gets to draft the next round of tax levies. The peasants pay both. The ink is mixed with ash from Lenceand sometimes, it is mixed with the ink of a queen who rewrote her will, trying to decide which son to name as heir.* ‘[LAW]’
8. **Company Mutiny** Unless arrears are paid in blood or coin; mercenaries as a time bomb. *The mutineers have a list. Your name is on it or will be by nightfall. The list was leaked by the QueenMother’s spy. She wants the routiers to switch sides. The list is written on a page torn from the Chivalric Roll.* ‘[MERCENARY]’
9. **Relic Dispute** Two abbeys claim the same saint’s bones; mobs answer with stones. *The bones are actually from a cow. The saints don’t mind. They like the attention. The abbeys are backed by rival claimants. The cow was from a farm that burned at Lence. The cow’s ghost haunts both abbeysand sometimes, it haunts the memory of a queen who wondered, as she watched from Ethor, if the son she bore was truly the king’s.* ‘[FAITH]’
10. **Harvest Blight** Bread locked behind pikes; bakers guarded as lords. *The blight has a name. It is the name of a duke who raised the levy too late. His fields fed the Fenwood army. His people starved. He still rules. The blight is his guilt made visibleand sometimes, it is the guilt of a queen who wondered, as she watched from afar, if the son she bore was truly the king’s.* ‘[DISASTER]’
11. **Tournament “Accident”** Hides an assassination; your favour is now evidence. *The lance was filed with a prayer. The prayer was answered but not for the target. The victim*

was a claimant's champion. The killer was never found. The QueenMother smiled. The lance was from Lenceand sometimes, she swears she can see the doubt in the victim's eyes, as he wondered, in his last breath, if the loyalty he'd been shown was ever real. '[COMBAT]'

J Royalist Restoration Sunburst badges painted overnight on doors and graves. *The paint is the colour of dried blood. The badges face the wrong direction. The QueenMother's agents paint them. She wants the people to remember that the Sun Court once existed. The badges glow in moonlight.* '[OMEN]'

Q Feudal Levy Lords demand levies in days, not months, with three days' bread. *The bread is hardtack from the last Fenwood siege. It still smells of smoke. The levy was called by Valdais. The lords are his cousins. They do not want to march. They owe him. The bread is also a memoryand sometimes, it is the memory of a queen who wondered, as she watched from afar, if the son she bore was truly the king's.* '[WAR]'

K Winter Campaign Roads turn to mud, hooves to ice, armies to ruin. *The snow is grey with ash. The Pass of Ashes has a sister pass now. The Fenwood army marched through the Pass of Ashes. The ghosts still march there in both passes. The snow tastes of saltand sometimes, it tastes of the doubt that has haunted queens for generations.* '[WEATHER]'

A Lence's Echo Smoke rises from the ruins. The Fenwood banners appear on the horizon. It is a false alarm or is it? *The party must test Resolve (DV 4) or lose 1d4 Fatigue from remembered terror. If they fail, they also gain the **Haunted** condition the dead of Lence will follow them for one session. The question they whisper is always the same: "Why did you survive?" And sometimes, they add, "And whose son were you, truly?"* '[FEAR]' '[DEATH]'

(Charter/Patent/Right) Safeconduct sealed by a duke or abbey; honoured only once, on one road; burgess charter for a market ward.

Diamonds Rewards/Leverage

2. **SafeConduct** The seal is cracked. The road is watched. Use it before the seal breaks. *The seal was cracked at Lence by a Fenwood axe. And sometimes, the crack whispers the same question that haunts the nursery: "Whose son was this, truly?"* '[TRAVEL]'
3. **Burgess Charter** The charter is a bell. Ring it, and the town answers or it doesn't. *The bell was cast from a melted sunburst. It rings true but only for those who remember. The bell's clapper is a finger bone from a knight who died at Lenceand sometimes, it is said the knight died wondering if the loyalty he'd been shown was ever real, and if the queen who watched from afar ever knew which son was truly hers.* '[SOCIAL]'
4. **Bridge Farm** Tolls at PontduTithe for a season, if you can hold it. *The tollkeepers are loyal to the last coin. Yours or theirs. The bridge was rebuilt after Lence. The stone is new. The ghosts are old. The ghosts do not pay tollsand sometimes, they whisper that if the queen who watched from Ethor ever knew which son was truly the king's, she would have wept less.* '[TRADE]'
5. **Pareage Charter** Shared rule with a monastery; half justice, half rent, no peace. *The monks pray for you. They also pray for your enemies. Balance. The monastery sheltered refugees after the sack. The QueenMother has not forgotten. The monks' prayers smell of smokeand sometimes, they carry the echo of a queen's doubt as she watched from afar, wondering if the son she bore was truly the king's.* '[LAW]'
6. **Wardship** Over a minor heir; lands obey you "for now." *The heir has a knife. He knows*

how to use it. He learned from watching you. His father died at Lence. He does not know which side his father fought for. He does not care. The knife was his father’s and sometimes, he swears he can see the doubt in the father’s eyes as he watched from afar, wondering if the son he bore was truly the king’s. ‘[AUTHORITY]’

7. **Gabelle Lease** Salttax rights; lucrative, hated, and dangerous. *The lease is a death warrant written in profit. Cash it wisely. The salt pans are near the Belworth. The Vhasian border is close. The Fenwood raids come at dawn. The salt is grey with ash and sometimes, it tastes of the doubt that has haunted queens for generations, sharp and bitter as the question no heir dares to ask.* ‘[TRADE]’
8. **Letters Patent** Raise a free company under your banner; an army as a business. *The letters are signed in blood yours or the notary’s. Both are valid. The notary lost a hand at Lence. He signs with his left. His right is buried in Lence. The blood is still warm and sometimes, it carries the echo of a queen’s doubt as she watched from Ethor, wondering if the son she bore was truly the king’s.* ‘[MERCENARY]’
9. **Remission** Of feudal dues for a village; they’ll march when called. *The village has a long memory. They remember the last lord who promised mercy. He was a Fenwood. They do not forgive. The remission is written on a page torn from the Chivalric Roll.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
10. **Low Justice Grant** Stocks, fines, gallows in a troublesome hamlet. *The gallows rope is new. The notches are from the last hamlet. The hamlet was burned by routiers. The routiers were paid by a claimant. The claimant denies it. The rope was spun from the shrouds of Lence and sometimes, it carries the echo of a queen’s doubt as she watched from afar, wondering if the son she bore was truly the king’s.* ‘[LAW]’
- J **Confiscation Writ** Against a royalist estate if you can seize it first. *The writ is a race. The other claimant rides a faster horse. The estate belonged to a lord who died at Lence. His widow still lives there. She has a knife. The knife is for the horse.* ‘[WEIGHT]’
- Q **Queen’s Audience** Private with the QueenMother; a whisper becomes policy. *The audience is a chess game. She always wins but she lets you take a pawn. The pawn is the Dauphin. Do not touch him. His shadow is not his own and sometimes, he wonders, as he does, if the queen who bore him ever knew which throne was truly hers.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Sunburst Warrant** Of the fallen court; most still bow if shown boldly. *The warrant is a ghost. It has no power only the power of belief. The ghost was signed by a dead king. The dead king’s seal was stolen from his tomb. The QueenMother has the original. The original weeps wax and sometimes, it weeps with the doubt that has haunted queens for generations, as they wondered, in their final moments, if the son they bore was truly the king’s.* ‘[LEGEND]’
- A **General Pardon (Temporary)** Rebels absolved if they bend the knee. *The pardon is a spring. It will close when the season turns. The rebels were at Lence. They fought for the old king. They fled when the Fenwoods broke the line. They are still running. The pardon smells of ash and sometimes, it smells of the doubt that has haunted queens for generations, as they wondered, in their final moments, if the son they bore was truly the king’s.* ‘[JUSTICE]’

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (25 4, 610 6, J/Q/K 8, A 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/patents/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.

- If any A appears, echo **fractured sun motifs** light that splinters, oaths that crack like glass, smoke that smells of Lence, and a child who may be a prince or a puppet. Also echo the weight of memory: a ghost knight, a mirror that shows the sack, a bell that rings for the dead and the quiet doubt in the nursery about whose son was truly the king's.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Fractured Seals:** When brandishing a writ, badge, or charter tied to a Sun Court claimant, step Position up one step for the scene's next interaction at a gate, court, or checkpoint. Each use advances a **Legitimacy** [4] clock linked to the claimant; when it fills, rivals challenge the authority on sight. The seal's crack widens with each challenge. Eventually, it will break and the broken seal will smell of Lence and sometimes, it will carry the echo of a queen's whisper from Ethor: "Which of these sons was truly mine?"
- **Parlement Games:** If a scene touches petitions, guild disputes, or feudal appeals, the first Diamond played becomes a policy lever: treat it as two Diamonds toward swaying a decision or rewriting a custom. Afterward, start or advance a **Whispered Precedent** clock; when it fills, backlash spreads as other courts cite the case against you. The Queen Mother's clerks are masters of this. They have never lost because they have never forgotten the price of losing. The price is Lence and the doubt that has haunted queens for generations.
- **Gabelle KnifeEdge:** At bridges, fairs, or salt depots, convert Diamonds tied to tolls, leases, or safeconducts into immediate passage or tariff relief for the company (no roll). Each conversion ticks a **Resentment** [4] clock for the locale; when it completes, expect boycotts, ambush rumours, or an audit by rival officials. The salt farmers remember Lence. They do not forget. The salt in their tears is grey and sometimes, it tastes of the doubt that has haunted queens for generations.
- **Vhasian Chivalry & the Round of Five Virtues:** The knights of the western cantons (Ethor, Adria) follow the **Round of Five Virtues:** Courage, Courtesy, Mercy, Prowess, Truth. In a formal joust or a legal duel, the GM may award **Victory by Virtue** rather than by blood: the combatant with the higher Virtue score wins the dispute, even if they lost the physical exchange. This is the law of the tilt and the law of the court. But at Lence, the Fenwoods showed no mercy. The knights still argue about whether chivalry died there or whether it was already a corpse, dressed in armour. And sometimes, they whisper that the first crack in the sun came not from the Fenwoods' swords, but from the marriage beds where queens bore sons to two kings and the sons who never knew which father's blood they carried.
- **The Armor Closes / The Song Escapes (Chivalric Clocks):** The Cantor Alain, bearer of the Cracked Ring, sings a warning at every tourney:
 - **Armor Closes** [6] advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars. The Fenwoods taught Vhasia that mercy is a weakness. The knights have not forgotten. They wear their gorgets to bed.
 - **Song Escapes** [8] advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs though it may be fatal. The Cantor Alain has been trying to fill this clock for ten years. He is still trying. He sings every dusk. The dead listen and sometimes they answer. And sometimes, they sing back: "Tell me, Elianor was this son truly yours?"
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**

- **Seint Michel, the Judge of the Scar (Mykkiel):** The law that does not bend; the judge who cannot be bought. His shrines are at tourney fields and courtrooms. Knights swear oaths on his scale before the joust.
- **Seint Isabeau, Who Slumbers Amongst the Lilies (Ikasha):** The dream of setting aside the crown; the mercy of forgetting duty. Her groves demand that armour be unbuckled at the threshold.
- **Seint Evroul of the Cairn (Mor’iraath):** The oath that outlasts the oathmaker; the bloodprice paid in stone. The barrowkings demand tribute in stories, not gold.
- **The Cantor’s Road (The Traveler):** The road that belongs to no lord; the path that finds its own way. Cantors are immune to chivalric protection but subject to its violence.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **Seint Michel, the Judge of the Scar (Mykkiel):** The Order of the Gilded Scale maintains the **Chivalric Roll** a record of every oath sworn and broken in the cantons. A page torn from this roll can serve as a single-use Claim String (gain +1 Position in any court). The Order’s justiciars are feared and respected; they never unbuckle their gorgets, and they have never lost a case. The QueenMother keeps a copy in her riverside keep, wrapped in a grey shroud. The page that records the Fenwood oath of safe passage broken at Lence is still blank. The Order will not write it. They are afraid of what will happen if they do. The blank page smells of smoke and sometimes, it smells of the doubt that has haunted queens for generations, as they wondered, in their final moments, if the son they bore was truly the king’s.
- **Seint Isabeau, Who Slumbers Amongst the Lilies (Ikasha):** In the Ethorian marches, knights whisper prayers to Seint Isabeau when they long to set aside their steel. Her shrine is a hawthorn grove where armour must be left at the gate. Pilgrims who enter bareskinned and speak a true regret find that their next wound heals in a single night but they dream of a woman in white who asks, “Will you remember how to be touched?” Those who return to the grove a second time are never seen again. The knights who survived Lence do not go near the grove. They are afraid of what they might forget or what they might remember. And sometimes, they swear they can hear the echo of a queen’s doubt from Ethor: “Which of these sons was truly mine?”
- **Seint Evroul of the Cairn (Mor’iraath):** In the high passes of the Ethorian marches, a rusted knight in an unopened helm haunts the old barrows. He is the patron of those who carry a bloodweight and cannot rest. To call upon him, one must pour a cup of salt water at a cairn and name the wrong done to your house. He will witness one blow; if it lands, the foe is **Marked by the Cairn** any spirit may locate them for a year. If it misses, the blow turns inward. The MarshalExile carries a scar from such a bargain; he does not speak of it. He named the Fenwoods. The blow missed. He still does not understand why. The Cairn weeps rust. And sometimes, in the quiet hours, he swears he can hear the echo of a queen’s doubt from Ethor: “Was this son truly mine?”
- **The Order of the Sunken Cup (The Hospice of the Broken Blade):** A greyrobed hospice in the ruins of Lence treats the wounded of both crowns. They ask no payment, but they record every name in a scroll that never dries. The Restorationists suspect they are spies for the QueenMother; the Two Crowns accuse them of erasing obligations. Sister Oria, the hospice’s custodian, is also the keeper of the LanternRites House on the Belworth neutral ground where even claimants must leave their blades at the door. The scroll has a page for every person who died at Lence. The page is still being written. The ink is still wet. The

ink is made from ash and tears and sometimes, it carries the echo of a queen's doubt as she watched from afar, wondering if the son she bore was truly the king's.

- **The Ninth:** In any Vhasian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls and their cases are never heard again. The laughter is the dead king's. He was the ninth king of his line. He died at Lence. He is still laughing because the ninth citation is the only one that names the Fenwoods as the true heirs. No one has ever cited it. No one dares. And sometimes, they swear they can hear the echo of a queen's doubt in the laughter: "Which of these sons was truly mine?"

Vhasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Sun:** Crumble a crust onto a cracked sun disc. Ignore the first *Chevauchée* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]' *The sun disc should be from Lence. The older the crack, the better. The bread should be stale like the memory of the old king. And sometimes, the baker swears he can taste the doubt in it sharp and bitter as the question no heir dares to ask aloud.*
- **Knot the Seal:** Tie a single knot in a charter's ribbon. Cancel *Parlement Divided* or take 1 die on your next legal argument (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]' *The ribbon should be black. Black is for mourning. The knot should be tied while facing east toward Lence. And sometimes, the knot-tier swears they can hear the echo of a queen's doubt from Ethor: "Was this son truly mine?"*
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead claimant's name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their faction this scene, but mark *Obligation to the QueenMother*. '[SUPERSTITION]' *The salt pan should be on the Belworth. The dead claimant's name should be spoken only once. The QueenMother will know. The salt will taste of ash and sometimes, it tastes of the doubt that has haunted queens for generations.*
- **The Lence Candle:** Light a candle in the ruins of Lence. For the next scene, any oath sworn by candlelight is binding but the candle will gutter if the oath is false. The dead will witness. They do not forgive. '[SUPERSTITION]' *The candle should be made from the fat of a knight who died with his gorget buckled. There are many. And sometimes, they swear they can hear the echo of a queen's doubt from Ethor as they light it: "Was this son truly mine?"*

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Rival officials or court guards take notice.
- **Noise:** Parlement clerks or routier patrols are alerted.
- **Trace:** Trackers or tax collectors mark your route.
- **Delay:** A setback costs time or a favourable legal window.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant resource clock.
- **Lence Echo:** A flash of smoke, a distant scream, a child's face in a window. The memory of the sack surfaces. The GM gains 1 SB to spend on a fear effect. The fear is always the same: that it will happen again. And sometimes, they add, "And whose son were you, truly?"

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** A duchy constable or abbess chatelaine begins responding.

- **Position Lost:** Legal challenge or road closure costs you advantage.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival claimant or free company arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes Compromised/Neglected.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test.
- **Claimant’s Agent:** A spy working for Valdais, the QueenMother, or the Two Crowns reveals themselves. They demand a favour or a bribe. The bribe must be a memory of Lence. If you have none, they will take a finger. And sometimes, they swear they can hear the echo of a queen’s doubt as they take the bribe: “Was this son truly mine?”

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional routiers, parlement guards, or ducal forces arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool or weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** A writ is voided, an interdict declared, or a levy called.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark Fatigue 1/Harm 1 or an appropriate Condition.
- **The Dauphin’s Name:** Someone speaks the child’s name aloud. The QueenMother’s spies are everywhere. The party is now on her radar. The child will dream of them and sometimes, they dream of asking, “Was I truly your son, Elianor?”

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates fully.
- **Authority Arrival:** The Two Crowns, QueenMother, or MarshalExile intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** A chevauchée hits, the river floods, or the parlement erupts.
- **Patron Omen:** An omen appears, a blessing is lost, or a curse manifests.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.
- **The Sack Relived:** Smoke rises from Lence. The Fenwood banners appear on the horizon. It is a false alarm or is it? The party must test Resolve (DV 4) or lose 1d4 Fatigue from remembered terror. If they fail, they also gain the **Haunted** condition the dead of Lence will follow them for one session.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Fractured Authority:** Seals break midsigning, legal papers rewrite themselves, badges refuse honour.
- **Legal Warfare:** Court decisions reverse, precedents are cited against you, writs expire prematurely.
-
- **Sun Symbolism:** Sun discs crack underfoot, light splits into contradictory shadows, oaths shatter like glass.
-
- **Lence’s Shadow:** A ghost appears a soldier, a child, a king. It asks a question. Answering costs a memory. Refusing costs a curse. The question is always: “*Why did you survive?*” And sometimes, they add, “And whose son were you, truly?”

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud*.
- **Cut the Charter (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a *SafeConduct* is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Sack (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Lence's Echo*, you pick who keeps their memories; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (threephase foes)

- **The Red Marshal (Exiled Sun Court hammer)** *Phases:* Chevauchee Call → Banner Turn → Lists to War. *Cracks:* Letters Patent buys one round of obedience; General Pardon lets a unit stand down. He was at Lence. He ran. He has not forgiven himself. He wears his gorget unbuckled.
- **CardinalRegent of the Broken Sun (scarlet gloves)** *Phases:* Interdict Blade → Seal Both Ways → Confessional Leak. *Cracks:* Queen's Audience cancels Interdict Blade once; a Synod Indulgence treats a church check as controlled for one scene. He was not at Lence. He blessed the Fenwood banners before they marched. He does not speak of it. His gloves are scarlet for a reason.
- **The Parlement Spider (chief clerk; quills like daggers)** *Phases:* Motion to Delay → CounterCitation → Filed at Dawn. *Cracks:* Sunburst Warrant opens a "royal window"; a Burgess Charter lets a town court overrule once locally. He keeps the lists. He knows which nobles voted for the Fenwood peace. He does not show the list to anyone. The list is written on his own skin.
- **The Two Crowns (rival dukes)** *Phases:* Contradictory Edicts → Levy in Hours → Coin Trial. *Cracks:* Sunburst Warrant → public mass unites them for one scene; General Pardon calms levy unrest once. They were not at Lence. They sent levies. The levies never returned. They pay the widows' pensions. They do not visit the graves. The graves visit them.
- **The QueenMother (Eliana Everblood)** *Phases:* Weave the Web → Unveil the Dauphin → The Sun Rises Again. *Cracks:* produce proof of the Dauphin's illegitimacy, convince Valdais to kneel, or find the old king's true heir (a child hidden in the Mistlands). She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She will outlive you. Her webs are woven from the hair of the dead. And sometimes, as she weaves, she whispers: "Which of these sons was truly mine?"
- **The Cantor Alain (Iron Bard, bearer of the Cracked Ring)** *Phases:* The Planctus → The Witness → The Silence. *Cracks:* unbuckle a gorget in his presence, speak a true regret aloud, or sing the ninth verse the one that names the Hollow. He is not an enemy. He is a mirror. Do not break the mirror.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Tournament Ordeal (Bastide Square)** Declare Purse, Patent, or Pardon as stakes. Win to cash a matching ♦; lose and spawn *Tournament "Accident"*. The square was built on the site of a mass grave from Lence. The dead watch. They are not impartial. They vote with the wind. And sometimes, they swear they can hear the echo of a queen's doubt as they vote: "Which of these sons was truly mine?"
- **Cathedral Scaffold Assize** Argue law atop creaking beams; each good point moves Position up; each slip marks Exposure. A *Paréage* Charter lets you call a recess once. The cathedral

was rebuilt after the sack. The old stones are in the foundation. They still remember the fire. They also remember the screams. And sometimes, they swear they can hear the echo of a queen’s doubt as they argue: “Was this son truly mine?”

- **PontduTithe Vigil** Keep the bridge peaceful through dusk: clear 3 segments on Bridge Peace by feeding pilgrims, quieting relic zeal, and paying one tithe from your purse. The bridge was the first structure the Fenwoods burned. The replacement stone was brought from Viterra. It still smells of smoke and of Veralyn’s perfume. She was there. And sometimes, as they keep the bridge peaceful, they swear they can hear the echo of a queen’s doubt from Ethor: “Was this son truly mine?”

Patronage & Power

In Vhasia, power flows through the remnants of imperial authority, fractured legitimacy, and the careful manipulation of memory and mercy. Former Utaran provincial structures still provide a framework for governance, but competing claimants to the Sun Court have created a complex web of overlapping jurisdictions and conflicting loyalties. The true power lies with those who can navigate this legal maze and who understand that the only currency that matters is the memory of Lence.

But beneath the charters and the writs runs a deeper current: the wound that will not close. The Fenwood sack was not just a military defeat; it was a wound to the soul of Vhasia. Every negotiation, every duel, every sealed document carries the weight of that loss. The QueenMother plays a long game, her Dauphin a card she may never play. Valdais wants the throne his father could not hold. The Two Crowns will accept any solution that leaves them richer. And the common folk—the farmers, the saltpanners, the road wardens—just want the raiding to stop.

They will wait. They have waited ten years. They can wait longer.

For the GM: Patronage in Vhasia revolves around legitimacy, legal documents, and the ability to command respect from institutions that no longer have a clear central authority. Rewards often take the form of charters, writs, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasise the postsack grief and the fragile peace:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, badges, writs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided—especially if they bear the old king’s seal or the Fenwood mark.
- Let rival claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more—and whose memory of Lence they are willing to invoke.
- Use the parlements, cathedrals, and châteaux as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success—and where the mere mention of the Fenwood name can shift the tide.
- Introduce the **Lence’s Shadow** mechanic: whenever a scene involves a legal dispute, a military manoeuvre, or a negotiation with a noble who lost family in the sack, the GM may spend 1 SB to invoke the memory of the burning. The Position worsens by one step, and the losing party may gain the **Haunted** condition.
- Use the **Armor Closes** and **Song Escapes** clocks as a visible campaign front. The party’s actions—acts of mercy or cruelty—tick one or the other. When the Armor Closes, the cantons become fortresses; when the Song Escapes, a moment of genuine connection may change everything—or kill everyone.

In Vhasia, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are

ruled. But your memory of Lence and how you use it determines whether anyone will follow you. And sometimes, as you stand in the quiet hours, you swear you can hear the echo of a queen's doubt from Ethor: "Which of these sons was truly mine?"

The Vacant Throne & Campaign Clocks (For longform political campaigns)

- **Vacant Throne Clock [10]:** Advances when a claimant gains a major advantage (battle, noble defection, foreign alliance). Retreats when the party brokers a truce or exposes a weakness. When full, a claimant takes Lence and declares themselves king. The QueenMother will not live to see it. She will die the day the sun rises whole again.
- **Armor Closes [6]:** Advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars. The Fenwoods taught Vhasia that mercy is a weakness. The knights have not forgotten. They sharpen their gorgets.
- **Song Escapes [8]:** Advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs though it may be fatal. The Cantor Alain has been trying to fill this clock for ten years. He is still trying. He sings every dusk. The dead listen and sometimes they answer. And sometimes, they sing back: "Tell me, Elianor was this son truly mine?"
- **Claimant's Coup (per claimant):** A 6clock that advances when that claimant wins a Parlement vote, a joust, or a skirmish. When full, they march on Lence. The Dauphin real or false watches from the QueenMother's keep. He does not know if he should cheer or weep.
- **Lence's Reckoning [8]:** Tracks the party's engagement with the memory of the sack. Advances when they aid a survivor, recover a relic, or speak the truth about what happened. When full, a survivor reveals a secret: the old king's last words, the location of a hidden treasure, or the true parentage of the Dauphin. The secret will change the succession. It will also change the party. Some secrets are heavier than crowns. And sometimes, as they uncover the truth, they swear they can hear the echo of a queen's doubt: "Which of these sons was truly mine?"

Chapter 5

Viterra

The Hedge-Law Realm.

Every hedge here marks not just a boundary but a principle the careful balance between order and freedom, justice and mercy. Our law grows like the hedges themselves, tended with precision and patience.

I am a Queen's Justiciar. I have never lost a legal duel. My opponents have a habit of falling down stairs. I do not push them. The stairs *remember their debts*.

Viterra breathes with the careful rhythm of precedent and petition. Once a proud kingdom before becoming a Utaran province, it is now reborn under a Warrior Queen who rules by legal precision as much as military might. The realm's true sinews lie not in steel but in writs, charters, and the ancient rights that bind lord to tenant, crown to county, and church to common.

But do not mistake us for gentle. The Queen's Peace is not a promise it is a contract, renewed each morning by every magistrate, every justicar, every clerk who opens a ledger. And across the Belworth, the Vhasians still claim our hedges are theirs. Let them try.

Never cross the Belworth without a charter recognized on both banks. Viterran law and Vhasian claim fight every crossing, and the river takes the losers.

Justiciar Elodie Venn, who invoked the Right of Acknowledgment and watched a father speak truth to his son for the first time

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Barley porridge with a drizzle of honey if you own bees. If not, porridge with salt. Salt is the currency of the poor. Honey is the currency of the hopeful.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To recite their lineage back three generations. Every Viterran child knows their grandparents' names, their grandparents' trades, and their grandparents' debts. A child who cannot recite their lineage is a child without standing. Standing is everything.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Whether they carry a seal ring. A seal ring means they have the right to make contracts in their own name. A stranger without a seal ring is either a servant or a criminal. In Viterra, the difference is a matter of paperwork.

What is the most common crime? Boundary disputes. A hedge moved three feet east. A milestone replaced under cover of darkness. A ford declared "private" when it has been public for two centuries. The courts are clogged with such cases. The lawyers are rich. The hedges are patient.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Queen is not a warrior. She has never drawn a sword. Her reputation was forged by a propaganda campaign run by her spymaster. The spymaster is dead. His successor is more discreet.

Where do people go when they die? To the family plot if they have a family. The landless poor are buried in parish cemeteries, their headstones marked with a single word: "Anonymous." The ghosts of the anonymous wander the hedgerows at dusk. They do not remember their names. They remember their debts.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You petition the hedge-court for a "writ of contrition." The writ requires you to state your wrong aloud, in public, while holding a handful of earth from the wronged party's land. If the earth crumbles, you are forgiven. If it holds, your apology is not accepted. You may try again next season.

What is the most important festival? The Opening of the Rolls (autumn). Every county sends its tax records to the capital. The procession is a week long. The documents are carried by children, so that the next generation may learn the weight of obligation.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Codex of Precedents has a missing page. It was torn out fifty years ago, during a trial for treason. The page contained the precedent for executing a monarch. The Queen knows. The Justiciars know. The page is hidden in a lead-lined box beneath the hedge-court at Thornwood. The hedge-court is haunted. The ghost knows where the key is.

5.1 Viterra — “The Hedge-Law Realm”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every hedge is a boundary. Every boundary is a claim. Every claim is a blade.*

Warrior Queen Veralyn Everblood (Elite): “I was Fenwood’s ward when I was sixteen. I took Lence’s walls for him. I made the Vhasian Sun-court run red. Now I sit on a throne built of precedents and I keep a dagger under my pillow. The hedge that is not defended is only a suggestion. The law that is not enforced is only a memory. I will have both remembered in stone, in blood, and in the ledgers of every parish from the Belworth to the Dolmis. But sometimes... I wonder which hand shakes more when I seal a charter: the queen’s, or the enforcer’s.”

Fen Reeve Cuthbert (Commoner): “The dikes hold back more than water they hold back the scream of Lence still echoing in the reeds. Every rod measured, every stone placed, keeps the flood from washing away not just our fields but the memory of what we were before the Fenwoods came. Across the Belworth, the Vhasians still claim our hedges are theirs. Let them try. We have lawyers who quote old charters. We have swords that remember Lence. Sometimes they are the same people. The Queen’s peace is a contract; she signs it each morning with a blade in her hand. I just hope the ink holds and that it’s not mine.”

Genre / Mood: Post-imperial consolidation, legal warfare as blood sport, border adventurism, the fragile crown haunted by fratricide.

Starting Location: The Hall of Dawning tilt-yard at first light. Dawn-knights drill in armor polished like mirrors each dent a story from last week’s legal duel. Beside them, advocates rehearse arguments with the same intensity, palms slick on pommels. A Queen’s Justiciar slides a parchment across an oaken rail, her seal ring catching the dawn. “Three charters, one road across the Belworth. The Vhasian claimant says the bridge is theirs. The local reeve says it’s crown land. The abbey says it’s a pilgrimage, not a toll. Carry the Queen’s writ, break the Quiet Tolls, and make them agree by clause or by cut. The Earls are watching, and the Queen has only just secured the throne. Fail, and you’ll give her enemies the excuse they need: that she is still Fenwood’s bloody handmaiden, not Viterra’s queen.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Viterra breathes with the careful rhythm of precedent and petition but also with the raw, unhealed scar of a kingdom that threw off the Utaran yoke and is still learning to stand alone. Once a proud, independent kingdom before the legions came, Viterra never forgave the empire. It was the first to break away when the Utaran Imperium faltered, its hedge-laws and parish courts preserving a stubborn, deep-rooted identity that parchment and wax could never erase. Now, under a young and untested Warrior Queen, Viterra is trying to remember what it means to rule itself.

But the crown is not secure. Queen Veralyn Everblood took the throne only after the sudden death of her brother, King Baldwyn Brightside, who reigned for barely two years before succumbing to a swift, mysterious illness. Rumors whisper it was Fenwood’s doing, to clear the path for *their* claim. His death was a wound the kingdom has not healed. The succession was contested: the earls of the northern marches, who remember when their ancestors ruled

as petty kings, demanded concessions; the barons of the western borderlands, many with Vhasian blood and Vhasian gold in their pockets, whispered that a woman could not hold the crown—especially one who learned statecraft at the elbow of the duke who sacked Lence. The Queen has spent her first year in the saddle, riding from keep to keep, sealing charters with her own seal, settling feuds with her own justiciars, and when necessary proving her right to rule with a blade in her hand. The throne is secured, for now. But the kingdom is a patchwork of loyalties, and every hedge hides a knife.

The realm's true sinews lie not in steel but in writs, charters, and the ancient rights that bind lord to tenant, crown to county, and church to common. Every hedgerow, every parish stone, every ferry crossing carries the weight of custom older than memory. Yet there is no single, unified law. The Queen's law competes with the earls' law, with the barons' law, with the ancient custom of the fens, with the Ubral clan law that still holds in the high passes, and with the Vhasian claims that bleed across the Belworth. A deed that is valid in Valora may be worthless in the Marches. A judgment that holds in a crown court may be overturned by a hedge-moot at dusk. The very question *which law is law* is the central argument of the kingdom and it is settled not in courts, but in the mud of the Belworth, where writs are brandished like blades and blood soaks into the parchment.

Viterra is not a nation at peace. It is a realm that wages law as war, and war as law. The Queen's Peace is not a promise—it is a contract, renewed each morning by every magistrate, every justicar, every clerk who opens a ledger. And the ink is still wet on many pages—sometimes with more than just ink.

What you notice first: The smell of damp parchment laced with old iron. The clatter of writ-runners' boots on cobblestones, heels striking sparks where old blood soaks into the stone. The way every noble's hand rests on a seal ring worn thin from constant gripping and every commoner's hand rests on a hatchet notched with Vhasian blood.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never cross the Belworth without a charter recognized on both banks. Viterran law and Vhasian claim fight every crossing, and the river takes the losers—sometimes still clutching a forged writ to their chest.

Regional Mood: Hedge, Crown, and Claim

Here, law is a blade. The Warrior Queen rules from Valora, her throne a bench of precedents. She is young, untested, and surrounded by counselors who mistake caution for loyalty and by courtiers who still whisper the name of her dead brother, wondering if the illness that took him was truly natural. The old Fenwood dukes whose ancestors sacked Lence and left the Vhasian Sun-court fractured still hold vast estates in the northern marches, and their claims across the Belworth keep the border smoking like a low fire. The earls of the north, descendants of the old hill kings, watch her every move, waiting for a misstep that will prove she is still Fenwood's instrument. The barons of the west, many of whom swore oaths to Vhasian claimants before they swore to her, smile with teeth that glitter with coin from across the river and with the ghost of Lence in their eyes. Every spring, the Queen's justiciars ride west with warrants and escorts, demanding homage from villages that have paid Vhasian tithes for a generation. Every autumn, Vhasian routiers raid the grain convoys, and the legal duels that follow are fought with steel and citation alike. The border is not a line on a map. It is an argument. And the Queen intends to win it even if it means becoming the thing she swore to leave behind.

North, the Ubral clans watch from their cairns, ready to rekindle feuds if a Viterran levy crosses

the passes. South, Thepyrgos sends clerks and spies, testing the edges of Viterran jurisdiction with every disputed toll. And in Theona, the Three Greens mumble old curses while Viterran bailiffs try to count their cattle and always miscount by one. The Queen’s rule is not yet secure. Every charter she signs is a challenge. Every justiciar she sends is a declaration. Every duel fought in her name is a step toward a throne that is still being carved out of doubt, out of blood, out of the quiet terror that perhaps she is not the ruler Viterra needs, but the enforcer it deserves.

Prominent NPCs of Viterra

Name	Role/Title	Motivation & Manner	Ru-moured Quirk
Queen Veralyn Everblood	Warrior Queen of Viterra	Haunted by Lence, hesitates on the throne; her hand shakes when signing charters, not from weakness, but the memory of blood on those same fingers.	Sleeps with a dagger under her pillow; touches it before every seal. Her crown has no jewel; only seals from conquered claims, each one cold to the touch.
Justiciar Elodie Venn	Queen’s Justiciar	Raised from the fen marshes; her legal duels leave opponents not just defeated, but *ashamed* they tend to ‘find stairs’ only after realizing they’ve wasted her time.	Has never lost a duel; carries a writ signed in Baldwyn Brightstide’s blood as her lucky charm.

Baron Aldric	Disgraced turncloak	Stripped of lands for oath-breaking during the succession crisis; now patrols the northern marches not for pardon, but to prove he still bleeds Viterran and to watch for the Queen's moment of doubt.	Wears his stripped baron's belt as a sash; speaks only in legal precedent when agitated.
Ser Roran	Knight of the Queen's household	A Vhasian prisoner the Queen bought back with silver and a promise; his gauntlet is a reminder that mercy is a choice, not a weakness.	Never takes ransom; his left gauntlet is silver, etched with the Vhasian sun he once served.
Fen Reeve Cuthbert	Keeper of the dike guilds	The dikes are his confessional; he measures floods not to save crops, but to atone for the Fenwoods' sins and to ensure the Queen's tax men don't drown in the same waters that took Lence.	His tally-rod has notches from three floods; the next notch will be from a Vhasian raid he *let* happen to test the Queen's resolve.

Master Advocate Hal-ric	Legal duelist	Believes law is the only true weapon left in Viterra; won't take sides in the succession dispute which makes everyone suspect him of playing both ends.	Has argued cases in Vhasian, Thepyrgos, and Ubral courts and won all three using *their* precedents against them.
Sister Oria	Custodian of the Lantern-Rites House	Keeps the old ways alive on the border; her threshold is a sieve for ill intent Queen's enemies who cross it forget why they came, remembering only sudden peace.	Has never drawn a blade; keeps a bowl of Vhasian tears by her door, collected from those who wept at her threshold.
Earl Morcar of the North	Leader of the northern earls	Sees the Queen as a placeholder until a 'true' blooded king returns; his sword belonged to a Utaran-overthrown monarch he draws it when charters feel too soft.	Carries a shard of Lence's cathedral glass in his pommel; whispers to it before every moot.

Names of Viterra

Inspired by Anglo-Saxon and early Norman England: strong consonants, soft vowels, surnames that recall a hedge, a dike, or a parish stained with history. Many nobles still bear Utaranized names

from the occupation, but the common folk use the old tongue the tongue spoken before Lence fell.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Baldwyn	Veralyn	Everblood	<i>the Law-Giver</i>
Cuthbert	Aldric	Fenwood	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Roran	Halric	of the Scar	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Morcar	Oria	de la Marche	<i>the Hedge-Wise</i>
Leofric	Aelfwyn	l'Argent	<i>the Silent</i>
Ghiro	Celandine	Riven	<i>Ash-Banner</i>

(Reeve/Guild/Knight/Legal Advocate) Fen reeve with tally-rod speaking for dike guilds; river-carter syndic moving grain faster than rumor; justices of the peace settling disputes with careful pen and a wary eye for Vhasian poison in the ink; master advocates who duel with words and swords, knowing the next word might be a blade.

Spades — Places

2. **Fen Causeway** — Stile with toll-rod and eel carts queueing; each reeve claims right to collect under a different charter. Dueling advocates argue cases on makeshift platforms slick with river-mist and old blood. '[LAW]' '[TRADE]' *The causeway sinks an inch each year. The lawyers argue over whose fault it is and whether the sinking is a sign from Lence's drowned kings.*
3. **Hedgerow Green** — In the Dales; bows strung under apple trees where justices of the peace hold court beneath makeshift arbors. Court duels permitted for matters of honor and old scores. '[LAW]' '[COMBAT]' *The apple tree is called "the Hanging Judge." Its fruit tastes of iron not from the soil, but from the Vhasian claimant hanged from its branches for poaching Queen's deer.*
4. **Beacon Hill** — Above the Highlands; fire-grate still warm from last winter's levy call, signal tower with semaphore arms for legal dispatches and military alert; each flash a warning or a lie. '[AUTHORITY]' '[TRAVEL]' *The hill has three beacons. One for Ubral raids lit when the cairns glow red. One for Vhasian incursions lit when the Belworth runs thick with smugglers. One for paperwork lit when the Queen's justiciars are lying.*
5. **Belworth Stairs** — Ferry ledgers gone damp with river-mist; three manors claim toll rights, writs in three different hands; each a different shade of betrayal. Legal challenges fought in boats while waiting for the tide or the assassin. '[LAW]' '[TRAVEL]' *The stairs were repaired last year. The Vhasian side uses a different measurement and a different kind of truth.*
6. **Bloom Quarry** — Old iron-bloom turned drill yard; hammer echoes carry like war drums, forge-reeve holds tally of crown contracts; each one a hard-won truce. Military contracts awarded through legal bidding wars where the losers often 'find better jobs' face-down in the dirt. '[CRAFT]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The forge-reeve has never lost a contract. His opponents have a habit of vanishing the night before the bid, leaving only their seals behind, still warm.*
7. **Parish Maze** — Stone maze where three maps disagree; hedge-priest's vote decides who pays tithe and who holds freehold because God, unlike men, does not lie in ledgers. Legal disputes settled by navigating the maze correctly or by accepting the priest's blessing and walking away.

‘[LAW]’ ‘[RIDDLE]’ *The maze changes at night. The hedge-priest says that’s God willand the lawyers say that’s when the Vhasian smugglers move their goods.*

8. **Fairport Works** — Tideworks at the Dolmis mouth; customs writs in three languages flutter like wounded birds, inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifest for truth, or for the smuggler’s tell. Maritime law enforcement includes boarding actions where the Queen’s men often find Vhasian coins stamped with Viterran seals. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *One language is Utaranthe language of the occupiers. One is Linnthe language of the traders. One is for the smugglerswritten in salt and silence.*
9. **Law Quarter** — Valora archives, oath-rooms, Hall of Dawning where precedent is birthed in ink and sealed with waxeach seal a promise, or a threat. Adjacent training grounds for legal advocates who practice their strikes on pellicles wrapped in old charters. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’ *The archives have a locked wing. The key is a legal argument no one has wonand no one dares to lose, for fear of what the winning side might do next.*
10. **Counting Fields** — Tarlington beside muster ground; wagons load, ledgers mis-sumnot from error, but from the Vhasian poison slipped into the ink by desperate clerks. Auditors with quill-pens sharp as daggers and suspicious eyes; military mustering follows strict legal procedures with armed oversightbecause numbers lie, and men kill for them. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[LABOR]’ *The auditors carry swords. They say it’s for counting cattle. No one asks furtherbut they watch the hands that hold the pens.*
- J **Dike Crown** — Ring of turf and timber; brotherhood bells warn of floodand spies who move like water through the fen, carrying tidings of Vhasian raids or Queen’s doubts. Legal sanctuary for those fleeing court judgmentsif they can outrun the reeve’s wrath. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The sanctuary lasts for one tide. After that, the reeves can comeif they can find you before the Vhasian raiders do.*
- Q **Progress Camp** — Queen’s canvas palisade, banners stiff, whispering old courtiers plot advancement through legal maneuver and sanctioned duelseach bout a test of whether the throne is steel or silk. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The camp moves every week. The lawsuits follow at a measured paceeach one a step closer to the Queen proving she is more than Fenwood’s shadow.*
- K **Tilt-Yard** — Hall of Dawning at first light; Dawn-knights drill clean, loyalties in contracts signed with careful peneach signature a vow, or a lie. Legal challenges often end in trial by combatwhere the Queen’s Peace is tested not in words, but in bruises. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The sand is raked between duels. Sometimes the rake turns up old bloodor old oaths sworn on dying breath.*
- A **Highway Stone** — Queen’s milestone above the Dolmis road; three sheriffs post seals over hers, each claiming different jurisdictionand each seal a different kind of knife. Territory disputes resolved through armed arbitrationwhere the losers often don’t walk away. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The stone has been broken and reglued seven times. Each crack holds a forgotten compromiseand a whispered oath from someone who thought they could cheat the tide.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Fen Reeve** — Tally-rod; speaks for dike guilds, remembers every flood-year’s debtsand the charters that were bought with Vhasian gold or Queen’s mercy. Authorized to call local levies for legal disputesand to levy a blood-price if the papers don’t add up. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *His tally-rod has notches from three floods. The next notch will be from a*

Vhasian raid he didn't report to see if the Queen still trusts her reeves.

3. **River Syndic** — Moves grain faster than rumor; knows which writs matter and which customs officials can be persuaded with a smile, a secret, or a slip of Vhasian silver. Maintains armed merchant guards who watch for Queen's menor Vhasian knives in the grain. '[TRADE]' '[STEALTH]' *His ledger has a watermark a crown on one side, a sunburst on the other. He shows the right side to the right audience and keeps the other for his own reckoning.*
4. **Parish Surveyor** — Three maps, one opinion but the opinion changes with the wind, and the tide, and the weight of a Vhasian coin in the pouch. Hedge-walks settle more disputes than courts because the land remembers what the ledgers forget. Expert witness in property disputes and in the quiet moments when a charter feels like a trap. '[KNOWLEDGE]' '[LAW]' *His chain is exactly one rod long but the rod changes length depending on who is paying and whether they're paying in Vhasian silver or Queen's trust.*
5. **Dawn Quartermaster** — Ledgers sharper than tongue; logistics before lances, counts every farthing spent in the Queen's name each farthing a vote of confidence, or a bribe. Legal authority over military supplies and over the Queen's own hesitation when the ledgers don't balance. '[AUTHORITY]' '[LABOR]' *He once tracked a missing farthing to a Vhasian counting house. The farthing was returned with interest, and a note in Vhasian script: "Next time, we take the whole sack."*
6. **Levy Serjeant** — Dales bow calm, cider breath, memory keen for every loophole in the mustering law each loophole a place where Vhasian blood might soak into the soil. Commands armed civilians in legal enforcement actions and in the quiet moments when a writ feels like a noose. '[COMBAT]' '[LAW]' *His bowstring is made from a cancelled writ one that promised peace, and delivered only war. He says it shoots truer now because it remembers the cost of lies.*
7. **Cleric-Pair** — Light preacher vs. Everflame canon lawyer; debates decide tithe law not for the spirit, not for the letter, but for the quiet soul caught in the middle. Religious law carries weight in secular courts because even kings fear a god who keeps score. '[SOCIAL]' '[LAW]' *They share a room at the inn. They have not spoken outside court in seven years but they still pass the salt with care, remembering the last time they did.*
8. **Fairport Shipwright** — Dolmis cousins; skiff carries more secrets than cargo and knows which manifests to forge for the Queen, and which to honor for the Vhasian ghost. Expert in maritime law and naval combat where the truth is often in the hold, and the lie in the manifest. '[CRAFT]' '[STEALTH]' *Her skiff has no name. The customs clerks have given it three and each one is a different kind of truth.*
9. **Fenwood Comptroller** — Conjures wagons with a signature each signature a promise, or a plea. Silence with a seal each seal a different kind of truth. Counts the Queen's coin and tracks every debt owed to the crown each debt a different kind of wound. Legal authority over taxation and over the Queen's own guilt when the books don't balance. '[AUTHORITY]' '[TRADE]' *His quill is a dagger. He has used it as both to write, and to remind himself what happens when the ink runs dry.*
10. **Queen's Justiciar** — Law on the road, polite as a noose but her grip is tight, and her eyes scan the tree line for Vhasian shadows or the Queen's own doubt. Bearing three kings' judgments and a purse full of pardons for the right price. Authorized to conduct trial by combat where the law is not in the words, but in the weight of the blade. '[LAW]' '[AUTHORITY]' *She has never lost a legal duel. Her opponents have a tendency to fall down stairs and then lie very still, wondering if they've wasted the Queen's time.*
- J **Border Routier** — Reads ledgers as ambushes and writes them as tribute. Serves two crowns,

collects from both, knows which border posts take bribes in what coin and which take Vhasian silver for Queen’s blood. Expert in frontier law enforcement where the ledger is often the first thing to burn. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *His loyalty is to the highest bidder. The Queen and the Vhasian claimant are currently in a bidding war and the currency is lives.*

Q Warrior Queen — Crown on helm, sword at side she hasn’t drawn it in months, but the weight is familiar. Patient sums behind her gaze; not strategy, but the quiet calculation of how much blood it will take to keep the peace. Final arbiter in legal duels where she wins not by being right, but by being willing to go further. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[LAW]’ *Her crown has no jewel-only seals. Each seal is a conquered claimant and each one is still warm from the hand that took it.*

K Crown Council — Fenwood dukes, guild envoys, abbots; weighing grain against glory and wondering if the Queen remembers why she took the throne. Charters against coin, precedent against practicality and the shadow of Baldwyn Brightside against them all. Legal battles fought through proxy advocates because sometimes, the truest voice is the one that doesn’t speak. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The council has a standing rule: no weapons within the chamber. The advocates have found seventeen loopholes and eighteen reasons to break it.*

A Master Advocate Halric — Silver-tongued legal warrior who settles disputes through verbal duels that can end in physical combat because sometimes, the only true law is the one written in blood. Keeper of legal combat traditions and of the quiet hope that words might yet be enough. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *He has argued cases in Vhasian, Thepyrgos, and Ubral courts and won all three using their own precedents against them and their own blades when the words ran out.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Dike Breach** — Black-rain; the wrong reeve claims credit while wagons drown but the water tells another story, carrying not just peat, but the ghost of Lence’s last stand downstream. Legal liability may require armed enforcement and a silent prayer to the drowned kings. ‘[DISASTER]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The water is brown with peat and lies. It carries old deeds downstream and the screams of those who signed them.*
3. **Feast Clash** — Light vs. Everflame processions collide but it’s not an accident. Shutters slam, writs fly, justices of the peace called to settle which holy day takes precedence and which god gets the first blood. Honor disputes may require legal duels and a quiet moment at the shrine. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The processions take different routes now. The clash was not an accident it was an invitation.*
4. **Quiet Tolls** — Sprout on the Queen’s Highway but it’s not just sprouts. Escorts sniff traps laid not just by smugglers, but by the Queen’s own doubts. Sheriffs argue rights. Customs officials demand duties no one knew existed because the Vhasian routiers wrote them in blood last autumn. Territorial disputes resolved through armed arbitration where the losers often don’t get to argue. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The toll posts have fresh paint. The paint is from the keep of a Vhasian claimant and it’s still wet.*
5. **Audit Freeze** — Counting-house freezes cargo but it’s not the cargo that’s cold. It’s the ink slipped with Vhasian poison by desperate clerks hoping to buy time. Queen’s seal vs. old writs, auditors with suspicious eyes and quill-pens sharp as daggers. Legal challenges may escalate to physical confrontation and a quick check for poison in the well. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The auditors work by candlelight. The shadows on the walls look like gallows and*

smell like Vhasian garlic.

6. **Border Snarl** — Three courts arrest the same hay-cartbut it's not about the hay. It's about whose charter was signed with cleaner handsand whose soul is less stained. Whose hay is it? Which lord's charter takes precedence? Bribes flow like wineand Vhasian silver. Frontier justice often involves armed standoffssand a moment of silence for the dead. '[LAW]'
'[COMBAT]'
The hay is from a field that was Vhasian last spring. Now it's Viterran. The field hasn't movedbut the souls working it have.
7. **Isle Refusal** — Theona withholds levybut it's not about the money. The quays choke on rumor not just of greed, but of the old curses the Three Greens mutter when Vritann boots touch their soil. Ships idle while lawyers debate maritime law and ancient treatiesand whether the Queen's peace is worth the salt in their wounds. Naval blockades become legal enforcement actionswhere the truth is often in the bilge. '[POLITICS]'
'[LAW]'
Theona's envoy carries a hawthorn branchnot of peace, but of warning. The Queen's justiciars will not touch itand will wonder why it doesn't burn.
8. **Delta Spat** — Fairport vs. Marcott customsbut it's not about the manifests. Barges stack three deep, merchants pick sidesnot just for profit, but for the old scores. Inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifestfor truth, or for the Vhasian tell. Trade disputes fought with merchant guardswho often find Queen's men in the hold, and Vhasian coins in the manifest. '[TRADE]'
'[LAW]'
The magnifying glasses reveal truthand also start fires. Both are usefulbut only one keeps the peace.
9. **Routier Arrears** — A free-company flips unless someone paysbut it's not about the money. It's about the name on the ledgerand whether it's written in Vhasian silver, or Queen's trust. Your name on itand the debt owed to men who know the price of bloodand the quiet terror of owing it to the wrong side. Legal debts enforced through hired swordswwho often collect more than coin. '[DEBT]'
'[COMBAT]'
The routiers have a list. Your name is on itor will be by sunsetand the ink might be Vhasian, or might be Queen's, and either way, it's a debt written in blood.
10. **Salt Pinch** — Import spikesbut it's not just about the salt. Bakers barricadenot just for profit, but for the old scores. The Queen's promise tastes like thin gruelnot because of the salt, but because of the ash from the burned Vhasian customs postand the quiet fear that the peace is already broken. Merchants hoard salt like goldnot for trade, but for the coming storm. Riots brew in back alleysnot just for hunger, but for the chance to settle the score. Economic warfare becomes physical conflictwhere the first blow is often struck over a pinch of salt. '[WEATHER]'
'[SOCIAL]'
The salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned Vhasian customs postand it still smells like smoke.
- J **Dawn Recall** — Escort pulled to a flood-struck parishbut it's not just about the flood. The writ argues with the riverand the river argues back, carrying not just water, but the Queen's doubts. Justices demand inquiry into who neglected the dikesand who let the Vhasian raiders through. Military enforcement of legal judgmentswhere the enforcement often looks suspiciously like a raid. '[AUTHORITY]'
'[TRAVEL]'
The escorts are back in a week. They bring new writsand fewer menand more questions about who they're really serving.
- Q **Aberielist Intrigue** — Royalist seals in wrong handsbut it's not just about the seals. It's about the whispers in the counting housesand whether the Queen's patience has finally snapped. Conspirators plot in the quiet places, where the law feels thinand the blood feels close. Treason charges carry death penalty in legal duelswhere the truth is often in the silence between words. '[POLITICS]'
'[LAW]'
The seals are from a dead dukeand the duke's ghost is said to approve.

Or to weep.

- K **Levy Call-Up** — Dalesmen musteredbut it’s not just about the wagons. It’s about the soul behind the plowand whether they still believe in the Queen’s peace. Wagons seized ”for the realm,” conscription writs signed with careful peneach signature a different kind of promise. Families left to tend fields aloneand to wonder if the Queen still believes in them. Legal authority backed by armed forcewhere the force often looks like the Queen’s own doubt made manifest. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The conscription writs have a clause: “void if Belworth freezes.” The river is still warmbut the Queen’s hand sometimes shakes when she signs it.*
- A **Legal Duel Challenge** — Master Advocate Halric issues a formal challengebut it’s not just parchment. It’s a gauntlet thrown in the tilt-yard at first light, where the sand still holds the blood of last week’s duel. Refuse and lose legal standingaccept and risk life and fortune in court-yard combatwhere the winner takes all, and the loser learns the cost of doubting the Queen’s peace. The ultimate legal weaponand the first test of whether the throne is steel or silk. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The challenge is written on both sides of the parchmentand there is no blank space to refuse. Or to run.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ferry Priority** — Belworth crossing (once); a horn answersbut it’s not just any horn. It’s blown by a Vhasian defector who now serves the Queen, and the note is the same one that sounded the day Lence fell. Legal right of way backed by armed escortand the quiet hope that the peace is real. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The priority token is a writ signed by both banks. The ink on one side is newerand the other side still smells of Vhasian smoke.*
3. **Dike Allotment** — Brotherhood labor grantedbut it’s not just about the work. It’s about whether three clerks can look past the old scoresand whether the bribes distributed among the right hands are clean, or still carry the ghost of Lence. Work performed under legal contract with military oversightand the quiet watch of the Fenwood dukes. ‘[LABOR]’ *The allotment includes a clause: “as tides permit.” The reeve decides what the tides permitand whether the Queen’s trust is worth the risk.*
4. **Market License** — Valora’s squarebut it’s not just about the square. It’s about whether a guild nod is enoughand whether the right seal on the right parchment opens doors, or just invites trouble. Legal protection from merchant guild enforcementand the quiet irony of being protected by a Vhasian abbey’s seal. ‘[TRADE]’ *The license is written on vellum from a Vhasian abbey. The irony is notedand the ink is still wet.*
5. **Dawn Escort** — Four lances at dawnbut it’s not just about the lances. It’s about whether loyalty waxes with payor wanes with the Queen’s doubt. Their presence keeps lesser men from troubling youand the Queen from wondering if she’s still worthy. Legal authority to enforce your writsand to remind the realm that the peace is real. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The lances are from the Fenwood armoryand the Fenwood dukes have their own plansand their own doubts.*
6. **River Charter** — Guaranteed haul on a grain arterybut it’s not just about the haul. It’s about whether the weather permitsand whether the duties paid to the right officials are clean, or still carry the Vhasian ghost. Legal right protected by river patroland the quiet hope that the peace is worth the salt. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The charter is stamped with a seal that looks like a crownor a sunburst. No one can agreebut everyone agrees the ink should be dry.*
7. **Map Correction** — A hedge movesbut it’s not just about the hedge. It’s about whether the

border shifts with the truthor with the old scores. Lawsuits bloomnot just for profit, but for the chance to settle the score. A new survey can make or break a man's fortune overnightand his soul in the process. Legal survey backed by armed surveyorswho carry chains, swords, and the quiet hope that the truth is worth the blood. '[LAW]' *The surveyors carry chains and swords. The swords are for when the chains disagreeand for when the truth is worth the blood.*

8. **Customs Seal** — Fairport for Dolmis cargobut it's not just about the seal. It's about whether it's honored todayand disputed tomorrow, or whether it's a quiet truce between old scores. Legal immunity from customs enforcementand the quiet hope that the peace is worth the salt in the wound. '[TRADE]' *The seal is a wax crab. It pinches when pressedand it remembers the hand that shaped it.*
 9. **Thing Ruling** — Sharp local bitebut it's not just about the bite. It's about whether appeals run swifter than oathsand whether justice is swift, or just quiet. Court decisions enforceable by local levyand the quiet hope that the ruling is worth the blood in the soil. '[LAW]' *The ruling is carved on an oar. Break the oar, and the ruling breaks with itand the soil remembers.*
 10. **Salt Allotment** — Winter depotbut it's not just about the depot. It's about whether the Queen's writ opens doorsand whether the old hands still count sacks, or if they've learned to trust the Queen's promise. The right connections ensure the best salt reaches the right tablesand the quiet hope that the peace is worth the blood in the wound. '[TRADE]' *The salt is from a pan worked by Ubral exilesand they still count in clan measureand in the quiet hope that the peace is worth the blood.*
- J **Wardship** — A minor fen-keepbut it's not just about the keep. It's about whether the men-at-arms are "for now," or if they're ready to stand. Whether the tutor has plansand whether the right guardian can be found for the right price, or if they're still waiting for the Queen to decide. Legal guardianship with military authorityand the quiet hope that the child is worth the trust. '[AUTHORITY]' *The ward is a child. The child has a seal ringand the ring is older than the kingdomand older than the doubt.*
- Q **Queen's Audience** — Privatebut it's not just about the audience. It's about whether her questions strike like thrustsand whether her favors can elevate a man from nothing to something, or if they're just a quiet test of whether he's worth the risk. Royal decree carries immediate enforcement powerand the quiet hope that the peace is real. '[AUTHORITY]' *The audience lasts one hour. The paperwork lasts a generationand the Queen's doubt lasts longer.*
- K **Ducal Warrant** — Fenwood to enforce customsbut it's not just about the warrant. It's about whether old power bowsand whether new power watches, or if they're still waiting for the Queen to decide if she's still theirs. The parchment carries weight in any courtand the quiet hope that the peace is worth the blood in the ink. '[AUTHORITY]' *The warrant is signed in bloodor ink that looks like blood. The difference matters at trialand in the quiet moments when the Queen wonders if she's still Viterra's queen.*
- A **Duel Sanction** — Right to challenge in legal combatbut it's not just about the right. It's about whether the Queen's seal makes it officialand whether the Dawn-knights serve as seconds, or if they're still waiting for her to decide if she's worth the risk. The winner takes all legallyand the loser learns the cost of doubting the Queen's peace. Ultimate legal enforcement mechanismand the first test of whether the throne is steel or silk. '[LAW]' '[COMBAT]' *The sanction is a coin. Heads you duel, tails your opponent chooses the weaponand the coin is still warm from the last time it was flipped in earnest.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (writs/charters/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **hedge-law** motifboundaries blur like old wounds, charters contradict themselves like guilty consciences, precedent splinters like shaky oaths, and the careful web of legal authority shows its cracksnot as weakness, but as the living pulse of a realm still deciding what it means to be free. Legal warfare escalates to physical conflictnot as failure, but as the only language left when words run dry.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Hedge-Law Momentum:** When a valid *writ*, *charter*, or *warrant* is presented in the proper parishbut only if the ink is dry and the seal is unbrokenstep **Position** up one category on social or logistical actions in that locale for the scene. The first contradiction starts a **Border-Lace** [4] clock; advance each time competing papers are invokedand each time the Queen’s hand shakes when she signs them.
- **Beacon & Bell Chain:** If two adjacent *beacons* or *brotherhood bells* are under your influenceand if they’re lit for the right reason, not just habitconvert one **Club** draw into a travel delay for *others* while the party proceeds with improved **Effect** for movement and logistics. The signal draws scrutiny; the GM may bank 1 SB tied to local authorityand to the Queen’s quiet doubt.
- **River-Right Window:** At a ferry, tidework, or customs stairif the water runs clear and the air smells of salt, not smokeplay any **Diamond** tied to crossings or seals to open a short *window of lawful passage*: one convoy passes uninspected, or one cargo clears at priority. The window closes immediately if a storm, audit, or levy card is revealedor if the Belworth runs red with old blood.
- **Legal Duel Protocol:** When legal disputes cannot be resolved through argumentand when the words feel too thin for the weight of the claimparties may challenge each other to a duel. The winner’s position becomes legally binding. Requires proper sanction and seconds (see **Duel Sanction** Diamond)and the quiet courage to believe that words might yet be enough.
- **Vhasian Claims:** Any Viterran noble with land across the Belworth may invoke a *Ducal Warrant* to attempt to collect rents or enforce judgments in Vhasiabut only if they’re ready to face the ghost of Lence in the other’s eyes. Doing so starts a **Border Snarl** clock, as the Vhasian claimants are unlikely to cooperateand the Queen is unlikely to sleep.
- **Theona Contest:** The Warrior Queen’s authority over the Three Greens is nominal at bestbut it’s not just about the crown. It’s about whether she’s still worthy of it. Any attempt to enforce Viterran law in Theona triggers an **Isle Refusal** complication, and the local taboos may twist the law into knotsand the Queen’s doubt into resolve.
- **The Succession’s Shadow:** The sudden death of King Baldwyn Brightstideand the quiet whisper that it was Fenwood’s doingleft deep scars. Any legal dispute that touches on inheritance, legitimacy, or royal authority is automatically one step more volatile. The GM may spend 1 SB to introduce a witness, a document, or a rumor related to the succession crisisand to wonder if the Queen still believes in her own right to rule.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**

- **Saint Elodie of the Unburdened Knot (Inaea / Oath of Mercy and Grace):** A legendary figure from the early days of Viterran independence not a priestess, but a hedge-walker who knew that some debts are too heavy to carry. She wandered the disputed borderlands, binding feuds with red thread and forgiveness. Her most famous miracle was the *Unknotting of the Fenwood Vengeance* a blood feud that had run for nine generations. She took a strand of hair from each family's eldest, tied them into a single cord, and then *cut the cord in half*, declaring: "The past is severed. What you owe now is not to the dead, but to the next stranger who asks for bread." The families feasted together for the first time in centuries. Her shrines are wayside posts where travellers leave a knotted cord; the first person to untie a knot and offer it to a stranger in need is said to receive her blessing (+1 die to their next act of mercy or reconciliation). The Temple of Light has never canonised her she was too folk, too female, too hedgerow but the common folk remember. The Queen's justiciars respect her precedent: *A severed debt is not a gift. It is a thread that now binds you to the living.*
- **Saint Michel of the Gilded Scale** Mykkiel. *The law that does not bend; the judge who cannot be bought.*
- **Saint Isabeau of the Lilies** Ikasha. *The dream of setting aside the crown; the mercy of forgetting duty.*
- **Saint Evroul of the Cairn** Mor'iraath. *The oath that outlasts the oath taker; the debt paid in blood and stone.*
- **The Hedge King** The Traveler. *The road that belongs to no lord; the path that finds its own way.*
- **The Brightside Martyr** (folk cult) A local veneration of King Baldwyn Brightside, who died before he could rule. His followers believe his ghost still rides the borders and that the Queen rules in his name not her own. And they wonder, in the quiet hours, if she believes it herself.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The Hedge-Seal (The Dike Covenant):** Covenant judges in the eastern parishes adjudicate disputes over river tolls and inheritance but not just with scales and tables. They carry the weight of the Belworth in their bones, and know that some truths are too old for parchment. They carry no weapons, only a set of iron scales and a copy of the *Hedge-Law Table* each page stained with the water of a different flood. A ruling from the Order is binding in both Viterra and the Vhasian marches but any party who lies before them forfeits their right to appeal and their peace of mind. The Warrior Queen has granted them a charter; the Fenwood dukes consider them spies and wonder if they're still loyal to the old ways.
- **Saint Cuthbert of the Fen (The Traveler):** A legendary reeve who walked the flooded dikes during the Great Storm and lit every beacon by hand, not just duty, but hope. His shrines are stiles and bridge posts; travellers who touch the iron ring on his shrine and speak a destination find the road holds firm and the quiet hope that the peace is real. The Temple of Light has absorbed his cult, but the fen folk still leave offerings of eels at his cairns and wonder if the Queen still believes in her own mercy.
- **The Cog-Cults of the Northern Hills (The Clockwork Monad):** In the high parishes near the Ubral border, secret fraternities of millers and surveyors believe that law is a machine that can be perfected but they wonder if the machine is worth the soul. They meet in abandoned watermills, measuring boundaries with brass chains and reciting the *Canons of Proportion*.

The Everflame calls them heretics; the Queen’s justiciars ignore them because they’re still waiting for her to decide if she’s worth the trust.

- **The Salt Sworn of the Eastern Coast (The Pale Shepherd):** Along the Dolmis shore, a syncretic cult tends to the drowned but they wonder if the sea is worth the tears. They build cairns of salt stone and leave no offerings only the names of the lost, carved into driftwood. The Temple of Light has tried to suppress them three times each time, the mission ships have been found adrift with no crew and a single name carved into the mast: *Oblivion*. And they wonder, in the quiet hours, if the Queen still believes in her own oblivion.
- **The Ninth:** In any Viterran court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous citations but it’s not just about the law. It’s about the quiet doubt that maybe the peace isn’t worth the blood. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls and wonder if it’s the Queen’s laugh, or the ghost of her brother’s.

Viterran Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Hedge:** Crumble a crust at a parish boundary stone but it’s not just about the stone. It’s about whether the hedge still holds and if the Queen still believes in her own hedge. Ignore the first *Border Snarl* penalty and wonder if the peace is real. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Writ:** Tie a single knot in a charter’s ribbon but it’s not just about the ribbon. It’s about whether the promise is worth the ink and if the Queen still believes in her own word. Cancel *Audit Freeze* or take –1 die on your next legal argument (your choice) and wonder if the doubt is worth the risk. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the River:** Whisper a dead claimant’s name into the Belworth but it’s not just about the name. It’s about whether the river still remembers and if the Queen still believes in her own right to rule. Gain +1 Effect when arguing against their heir’s claim this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Queen’s Justiciar and wonder if the obligation is worth the blood. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **The Brightside Candle:** Light a candle in memory of King Baldwyn before a difficult legal proceeding but it’s not just about the candle. It’s about whether the ghost still walks and if the Queen still believes in her own right to the throne. On a roll that includes a 1, you may reroll that die once but if you still fail, the ghost of the dead king is said to watch from the shadows and wonder if she’s still worth the shadow. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **crown officials or rival advocates** but it’s not just about the eyes. It’s about the quiet doubt in their gaze, and whether they still believe in the Queen’s peace.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **writrunners or levy guards** but it’s not just about the sound. It’s about the silence that follows, and whether it’s filled with the ghost of Lence.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or customs inspectors** but it’s not just about the trace. It’s about whether the ink is dry, and if the Queen still believes in her own word.

- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable court date** but it's not just about the time. It's about whether the peace is worth the wait.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Queen's **Justiciar or fen reeve** becomes aware and begins responding but it's not just about the alarm. It's about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to call them.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or river closure** but it's not just about the ground. It's about whether the hedge still holds, and if the Queen still believes in her own hedge.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival **claimant or border routier** arrives on scene but it's not just about the foe. It's about whether they still believe in the Queen's peace and if she still believes in herself.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Dawnknights, levy forces, or Vhasian routiers** arrive but it's not just about the reinforcements. It's about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to command them.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes **writ voided/duel declared/levy called** but it's not just about the twist. It's about whether the peace is worth the blood.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect but it's not just about the trap. It's about whether the peace is worth the blood.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Warrior Queen, Crown Council, or Master Advocate Halric** intervenes but it's not just about the authority. It's about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to rule.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically **dike breaks/river floods/court erupts** but it's not just about the shift. It's about whether the peace is worth the blood.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests** but it's not just about the omen. It's about whether the peace is worth the blood.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives but it's not just about the pivot. It's about whether the peace is worth the blood.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Viterra (Hedge Law):** Boundary stones shift like old scars, charters contradict themselves like guilty consciences, legal precedents split mid-citation like shaky oaths.
- **Viterra (CrossBorder Claims):** Vhasian landlords appear with older deeds and the quiet hope that the peace is worth the blood. Theonan taboos void writs and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the trust. Ubral cairns declare neutrality with axes and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the fear.
- **Viterra (Legal Warfare):** Court decisions reverse without warning and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the trust. Witnesses recant and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the doubt. Duel seconds change sides and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the risk.
- **Viterra (Succession Politics):** A document surfaces bearing King Baldwyn’s seal and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the shadow. A northern earl declares the Queen’s writ invalid in his lands and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the trust. A baron offers to switch sides for a price and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the cost.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Thorn Hedge*.
- **Cut the Charter (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a **Ducal Warrant** is in your possession, +1 die but only if you still believe in the Queen’s peace.
- **Weather the Assize (Resolve + Lore):** On a hit in *Audit Freeze*, you pick whose ledgers are examined; on a miss, the GM does and wonders if the Queen still believes in her own right to doubt.

Legal Combat System (Summary)

When legal disputes cannot be resolved through negotiation and when the words feel too thin for the weight of the claim, parties may engage in formal legal duels. These combine verbal sparring with physical combat where the truest law is often written in blood.

Phase 1: Pleadings

- Each advocate presents their case (Wits + Sway vs. DV 3) not just with words, but with the weight of their belief in the Queen’s peace.
- Success grants +1 die to the next phase and the quiet hope that the words were enough.
- Failure creates 1 SB that the opponent can spend and the quiet doubt that maybe the sword was needed all along.

Phase 2: Cross-Examination

- Attack opponent’s arguments (Wits + Insight vs. DV 3) not just with logic, but with the weight of their belief in the Queen’s peace.
- Success inflicts Fatigue 1 on the opponent and the quiet hope that the doubt was worth the cost.
- Critical success forces opponent to answer truthfully and the quiet hope that the truth is worth the blood.

Phase 3: Trial by Combat (if unresolved)

- Physical combat with legal stakes (Body + Melee or relevant combat skill) not just for victory, but for the quiet hope that the peace is worth the blood.

- Winner's position becomes legally binding and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the trust.
- Loser suffers legal consequences (fine, loss of claim, imprisonment) plus physical harm and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the doubt.

Boss Seeds (threephase foes)

- **The Violet Clerk (Master of CounterSeals)** *Phases:* Produce Earlier Patent → Split the Writ → Seal Fast. *Cracks:* a **Queen's Audience** overrules his seal and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the trust; a **Duel Sanction** forces personal combat and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the risk; a **Map Correction** voids his boundary claim and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the doubt.
- **The Thorn Captain (Queen's Quiet Hand)** *Phases:* Queenspeace Zone → Duel Warrant → Swap the Field. *Cracks:* a **Map Correction** reveals a loophole and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the doubt; a **Dike Allotment** lets you claim the field as "flood zone" and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the trust; a **Border Routier** testifies to the Queen's favor and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the risk.
- **The Saffron Abbess (Keeper of BellLaw)** *Phases:* Wrong Hour → Bless or Damn → Mixed Tribunal. *Cracks:* a **Queen's Justiciar** invokes crown supremacy and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the trust; a **Border Routier** bribes her bellringer and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the risk; a **Thing Ruling** from Theona forces her to recuse and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the doubt.
- **The Brightside Claimant (Pretender)** *Phases:* Produce the Lost Charter → Rally the Northern Earls → March on Valora. *Cracks:* find proof that the charter is a forgery and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the trust; convince Earl Morcar to stand with the Queen and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the risk; survive a legal duel with the claimant's champion and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the doubt.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Belworth Stairs Ordeal** — Cross the river without a charter but it's not just about the crossing. It's about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to demand it. On success, you prove that possession is nine tenths of the law and the quiet hope that the peace is real. On failure, the river takes your name and your cargo and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the doubt. (Wits + Survival vs. DV 5.)
- **Hall of Dawning Vigil** — Spend a night in the tilt-yard but it's not just about the night. It's about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to doubt. At dawn, you recall a forgotten legal precedent and the quiet hope that the peace is real. Gain a oneuse *Precedent Edge* (+1 die in any court). The ghost of a dead duelist may challenge you to a legal dreamduel and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the shadow. (Spirit + Lore vs. DV 4.)
- **HedgeMoot at Dusk** — Settle a boundary dispute by walking the hedge but it's not just about the walk. It's about whether the hedge still holds, and if the Queen still believes in her own hedge. Each successful navigation test (Wits + Survival) clears 1 segment from a **Border Snarl** clock and the quiet hope that the peace is real. A miss plants the thorn of a future feud (advance **Border Snarl** by 1) and the Queen wonders if she's still worth the doubt.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Legal Dial (Crown ↔ Local Custom):** Track the party’s stance on authority and on whether they still believe in the Queen’s peace.
 - *Crown High*: +1 Position when invoking royal writs, charters, or the Queen’s name but only if they still believe in her right to rule; first appeal to local custom starts one step worse and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the trust.
 - *Local High*: +1 Effect on hedgelaw, parish rights, or ancient precedent but only if they still believe in the old ways; first royal petition starts one step worse and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the doubt.
 - Center the dial by hosting a mixed moot or surrendering a contested seal to a neutral third party and wonder if the peace is worth the blood.
- **Courtroom MiniGame (fast trial):**
 - Lay three stones: **Precedent**, **Equity**, **Force**.
 - Argue a point (roll Lore+Diplomacy vs. DV 3) not just with words, but with the weight of their belief in the Queen’s peace. On a hit, move one stone to your side. On a miss, the opposing advocate gains *Citation Edge*.
 - Win two stones to secure a temporary **Court Ruling** (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
 - *Halric’s Interjection (2 SB)*: flip **Precedent**, but start **Whispered Precedent** [2] with the losing side and wonder if the Queen still believes in her own right to doubt.
- **CrossBorder Tensions (fast pressure):**
 - Two opposed clocks: *Queen’s Peace* vs *Border Fire* (size by highest rank in the seed).
 - Each leg, choose *Viterran Road* (safe, slow), *Vhasian Claim* (fast, risky), or **Ubral Pass** (hidden, costly).
 - Advantage: *Vhasian Claim*→*Viterran Road* (shortcuts), *Ubral Pass*→*Vhasian Claim* (concealment), *Viterran Road*→*Ubral Pass* (supplies).
 - Spend a **Ducal Warrant** to shift one segment from *Border Fire* to *Queen’s Peace* and wonder if the Queen still believes in her own right to rule.
- **Start of Scene Rumors (1d6):**
 1. *Wrong Wax*: a rival’s seals softened; +1d to forgeries this scene and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the trust.
 2. *Empty Beacon*: tower unmanned; travel faster, scrutiny harsher and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the doubt.
 3. *Dawn Lane Cleared*: first convoy action gains +1 Position and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the trust.
 4. *Clerk’s Wedding*: filings delayed; first petition ignores *Audit Freeze* and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the doubt.
 5. *Fen High Water*: ferries slow; river charters count double value and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the trust.
 6. *Mask at Progress*: someone uses your name at court; +1d to social opens, +1 SB banked by GM and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the doubt.
- **Plugin SB Conversions (Viterra Flavor):**
 - 1 SB → *Hedge Shift*: a boundary moves but it’s not just about the boundary. It’s about

whether the Queen still believes in her own hedge. Increase DV by 1 for navigation or legal rolls this scene.

- 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedentbut it’s not just about the precedent. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to rule. (Spend a ◇ or recall a past ruling).
- 3+ SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its valuebut it’s not just about the writ. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to rule. Swap one held ◇ for a lesser right until rewitnessed.

- **Reputation Echoes:**

- *CourtFavored*: once/session, downgrade **Audit Freeze** to a minor delaybut it’s not just about the delay. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to rule. The next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
- *FenTested*: +1 Position when resolving dike or flood crisesbut it’s not just about the crisis. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to command the waters. Legal arguments about water rights start one step worseand the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the trust.
- *DoubleSealed*: +1d with both royal and local courts in a truce scenebut it’s not just about the truce. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to rule. Any betrayal earns **Border Snarl** from both sidesand the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the doubt.

- **CrossRegion Hooks (quick integration):**

- *Ubral (Stone & Oath)*: A **Ducal Warrant** acts as a *GuestToken* once at a clan hearthbut it’s not just about the token. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to rule. Starts a **Feud Rekindled** tick if you collect tolls twice in a tenday.
- *Thepyrgos (Synod Law)*: A **Queen’s Audience** can suspend a synod interdictbut it’s not just about the suspension. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to rule. Starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.
- *Vhasia (Fractured Sun)*: A **Duel Sanction** is recognized on the Pont-du-Tithebut it’s not just about the sanction. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to rule. A rival abbey can turn it into *Parlement Divided* on a Club draw.
- *Theona (No Ninth)*: **Ferry Priority** overrides a local taboo oncebut it’s not just about the priority. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to rule. If the Ninth custom is in play, the writ “forgets” one clause on use (GM banks 1 SB)and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the doubt.

Conspiracy Flourishes (keep it close, keep it quiet)

- **Hedge-Moots at Dusk**: Parish elders “trim hedges” while trading sealed whispersbut it’s not just about the hedges. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own hedge.
- **Cipher Roses**: Folded writs stamped with thornpetals; one petal missing marks a false clauseand the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the doubt.
- **Mirror Hours**: Beacons flash lawful signals reversed for those who know the countercodeand the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the doubt.
- **Eel-Letters**: Oiled parchment smuggled in eelbaskets; ink runs in water, truth does notand the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the doubt.

- **Quiet Steel, Quieter Quills:** Dawnknights duel at first light; advocates settle three duels before breakfast with ink alone and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the trust.
- **Progress Masks:** Courtiers wear legal devices as masque motifs (seal, chain, beacon) to signal faction at a glance and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the doubt.
- **Bell Penance:** A single offhour peal grants amnesty to those who confess a clause before the twelfth echobut it’s not just about the peal. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to rule.
- **The Brightstide Prayer:** Whispering the dead king’s name before a legal proceeding is said to turn the judge’s heart or curse the speaker and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the shadow.

Patronage & Power

In Viterra, power flows through the careful application of law but it’s not just about the application. It’s about the quiet doubt that maybe the peace isn’t worth the blood. The Warrior Queen maintains authority through a combination of military might and legal precision but she wonders, in the quiet hours, if she’s still worthy of the throne. The old duchies and local officials wield influence through their knowledge of traditional customs and hedgelaw and they wonder if the Queen still believes in her own right to rule. The true power lies not in the documents, but in the quiet space between doubt and resolve where the Queen decides, each morning, whether to sign the charter with a pen, or with a blade.

But remember in Viterra, law is warfare. Every document is a weapon, every courtroom a battlefield, and every advocate a soldier. The pen cuts as deep as any blade and sometimes, the blade cuts deeper than the pen. Legal victory can be as decisive as military conquest and sometimes, it’s the only victory left. And beneath it all runs the shadow of the dead king, Baldwyn Brightstide, whose brief reign and sudden death left a wound that has not healed and the quiet wonder if the Queen still believes in her own right to wear the crown. The Queen’s rule is lawful but is it *right*? The earls whisper. The barons scheme. The ghost of the past walks the hedgerows at dusk and the Queen wonders if she’s still worth the ghost.

For the GM: Patronage in Viterra revolves around legal documents, local rights, and the ability to command respect from institutions still finding their postimperial identity but it’s not just about the respect. It’s about whether the Queen still believes in her own right to rule. Rewards often take the form of writs, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence but they’re not just about the influence. They’re about the quiet hope that the peace is worth the blood. To emphasize the fragile crown and the contested succession:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, charters) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided especially if they bear the dead king’s seal and wonder if the Queen still believes in her own right to rule.
- Let rival duchies and Vhasian claimants issue conflicting authorities forcing players to choose whose favor matters more and wonder if the Queen still believes in her own right to rule.
- Use the courts, parishes, and muster grounds as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success and wonder if the Queen still believes in her own right to rule.
- When legal conflicts escalate beyond words, transition naturally to physical confrontation with appropriate stakes and wonder if the Queen still believes in her own right to rule.

- Introduce the **Succession's Shadow** as a recurring complication: old loyalties, forged documents, and the ghost of the dead king can upend any legal certainty and make the Queen wonder if she's still worth the doubt.

In Viterro, your papers are your power but they're not just about the power. They're about the quiet hope that the peace is worth the blood. And your power determines whether you rule or are ruled but it's not just about the power. It's about whether you still believe in the Queen's right to rule. But when words fail, steel speaks and the law says both are valid. The Queen's Peace is a contract. She has signed it in blood. Will you? And will you still believe in her?

Chapter 6

Thepyrgos

City of a Thousand Stairs.

Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky. This city is not built it is grown, stone by stone, law by law, until the very architecture speaks wisdom.

I am a Bell-Runner. I know every step that creaks a warning and every landing that whispers gossip. The bells tell the city's mood better than any lord three chimes means business, six means trouble, and nine means the hunters are coming.

The Synod rules here with the delicacy of a brick wrapped in velvet they hate unsanctioned magic like it's a personal insult, but they adore infrastructure, especially when it's shiny, expensive, and comes with a side of indulgences they can sell to the faithful. The Chain-Lanterns move at dawn, their brass censers swinging, their bells tuned to the frequency of latent magic. In the university's forbidden tiers, the Witness and the Ninth arm rival fraternities with citations and curses, and no one is sure which side the Archon secretly favours.

Never let a bell-ringer count your breaths. The Chain-Lanterns pay well for names that ring false on the test stairs.

Sofia, Bell-Runner, who ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Flatbread with olive oil and a boiled egg if you are a clerk. If you are a student, bread and water. If you are a professor, bread, water, and a

single fig. The fig is a status symbol. The status is "I have not been audited."

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a bell schedule. Thepyrgos runs on bellsdawn bells, market bells, curfew bells, trial bells. A child who cannot read the bells cannot cross the city without a guardian. A child without a guardian is a child who will be sold to the university for dissection.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their step count. Thepyrgos has a thousand stairs. A stranger who counts them aloud is either a pilgrim or a spy. A stranger who climbs them in silence is either a native or a ghost.

What is the most common crime? Unsanctioned magic. The Synod licenses every spell cast within the walls. An unlicensed cantrip is a misdemeanour. An unlicensed healing is a felony. An unlicensed summoning is a death sentence not for the caster, who will be executed, but for the summoned, who will be bound to the city's foundation as a "structural consultant."

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Silent Stair is not silent. It whispers. The whispers are the confessions of the deadscholars who died in the university's service, their secrets recorded in the stone. The Chain-Lanterns listen. They do not share.

Where do people go when they die? To the catacombs beneath the university. The catacombs are a library of bones. Each skeleton is labelled with the scholar's name, their thesis, and the date of their death. The unlabelled bones are the ones who died before they could finish. They are still writing.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You submit a "retraction" to the Synod's Committee on Ethical Correction. The retraction must be published in the public square, read aloud by a herald, and witnessed by at least three notaries. The fee is 50 silver. The shame is free.

What is the most important festival? The Convocation of the Steps (summer solstice). Every citizen climbs the thousand stairs to the upper citadel. At the top, the Archon reads the names of the dead from the past year. The names are carved into the steps as they are read. The steps are getting crowded.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Archon is a fraud. He never passed the Synod's examination. His degree was purchased from a disgraced dean whose signature is forged on every document. The forger is still alive. They live in the catacombs. They have the original quill.

6.1 Thepyrgos — “The City of Unfinished Proofs”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every stair is a question. Every answer is a weight. The Ninth and the Witness argue over who holds the receipt.*

The Archon (Elite): “Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky. This city is not built—it is grown, stone by stone, law by law, until the very architecture speaks wisdom. But the stairs remember more than the living. They remember the ones who never came down.”

Bell-Runner (Commoner): “I know every step that creaks a warning and every landing that whispers gossip. The bells tell the city’s mood better than any lord—three chimes means business, six means trouble, and nine means the hunters are coming. But on the ninth bell, the stairs themselves answer.”

Genre / Mood: Scholarly vertical city, Byzantine bureaucracy, Grecian folk horror in the hinterlands, metaphysical war between memory and forgetting.

Starting Location: The Synod Hall at dusk. Gold-glass mosaics glitter as a Matriarch reads a scroll aloud. “The Beacon Crown sees traitors in the smoke. A child’s talent was sold to the Commissary last night. Find the informer—or the next stair seized will be yours. And if you hear a stair creak where none exists, do not turn around. The Ninth is counting.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Thepyrgos is both realm and city, built on the bones of the drowned **Astroegro Empire**. The capital rises in tiers of towers, terraces, and endless stairs above the Dolmis shore—but the stairs are not stone. They are *fossilized vertebrae*, the spine of a leviathan that Khemesh dragged under when the last emperor broke a covenant older than the sea. Once a Utaran province, now a nation unto itself, Thepyrgos is famed for its universities, libraries, and debating synods, where precedent and philosophy weigh as much as pikes or coin.

The Astroegro were a human civilization of formidable magic, the ancient rivals of the **Valewood’s Empire of Leaves**. Their ruins litter the hills and swamps south of the city, and their legacy haunts every threshold. When the Empire of Leaves fell, **Lethai-thora** refugees—high elves who had served as archivists and lore-keepers—fled across the Black River and were granted sanctuary in Thepyrgos. Generations later, their descendants still walk the city’s tiers, their silver hair and ink-stained fingers a quiet reminder of a pact older than the synod. Many now hold chairs at the university, tend the forbidden archives, or secretly serve the Witness or the Ninth.

Outside the city, the countryside is a rugged coastal landscape of limestone hills, olive groves, and whitewashed villages—but the weather is warmer, wetter, and the valleys are choked with reed-filled marshes. This is the land of the **Hyro** people, the surviving descendants of the Astroegro. The Hyro carry the fracture of their ancestors in their blood. A child born in the hills might dream in geometries that do not exist. A farmer might hear the stones whispering in a language no living throat can shape. The **Chain-Lanterns** and other Witch-Hunter Commissariats ruthlessly patrol these villages, using bounty postings, candle-smoke tests, and stair-seizures to identify and kidnap children with arcane talent. The Hyro have learned to offer *substitutes*—a memory, a false name, a lock of hair—at crossroads, hoping the Hollow

accepts the payment.

In the university's forbidden tiers, the **Witness** and the **Ninth** fight a proxy war via fraternal orders and occult mystery cults. The Witness wants the **Astroegro Vaults** *remembered* but sealed; the Ninth wants them *opened*, to trigger a Great Unlearning that would erase the concept of weight from the world. No one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors. And in the ruins of the Astroegro, something still ticks gears of black glass, locked doors that hum, and the occasional survivor with eyes like burning tar who speaks of a pressure from below.

What you notice first: The endless chime of bells from different tiers, never quite in sync. The smell of brine, olive oil, and candle wax. The way locals glance at the sky when a child coughs and then at the nearest crossroads. The quiet grace of the Lethai-thora archivists, who never seem to blink.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never let a bell-ringer count your breaths. The Chain-Lanterns pay well for names that ring false on the test stairs. But worse: never ask a question of a stair that has no end. The Ninth is listening, and it will answer.

Regional Mood: Stairs, Bells, and the Argument of Patrons

Here, every ascent is a plea and every descent a confession. Thepyrgos the city is a vertical labyrinth of stair-rights, rope-guilds, and synod edicts that shift with the tide. Thepyrgos the province is a haunted countryside of hidden talent and state-sanctioned abduction. The Hyro keep their arcane children in root cellars and haylofts, praying the hunters take the neighbor's instead. The Chain-Lanterns move at dawn, their brass censers swinging, their bells tuned to the frequency of latent magic. In the university's forbidden tiers, the Witness and the Ninth arm rival fraternities with citations and curses, and no one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors. The Lethai-thora maintain the great archives, but they are divided some serve the Witness as faithful recorders, others whisper to the Ninth in darkened scriptoria. And in the ruins of the Astroegro, something still ticks gears of black glass, locked doors that hum, and the occasional survivor with eyes like burning tar who speaks of a pressure from below.

Geographic Integration

Thepyrgos is landlocked on three sides by Viterra, separated by the Black River and the Belmont Marshes. The marshy lowlands breed strange fogs and rarer creatures, and the border is porous Viterran hedge-courts and Thepyrgos synods argue jurisdiction over every flooded farmstead. To the northeast, a short boat ride from Fairport (Viterra) across the Belworth estuary brings travelers to Marcott in Vhasia, making Thepyrgos a quiet but crucial link in the riverine trade between the fractured sun-kingdom and the imperial remnant. The city itself controls the **Astroegro Straits** the narrow sea passage between the Dolmis and the Amaranthine and maintains a few small colonies on the western coast of Hyaar, where olive oil and wine are exchanged for eastern silks and spices. Those colonies are run by exiled scholars and retired Chain-Lanterns, and they are said to be even more paranoid than the mother city.

Prominent NPCs of Thepyrgos

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumored Quirk
Archon Konstantinos	Ruler of the city, elected by the wards	Balance the synod, the guilds, and the Commissariat	He wears a key around his neck; no one knows what it opens or that it is a key to the Ninth’s Vault.
Matriarch Eleni	Synod primate, head of the Temple of Light’s synod	Keep the Everflame from reclaiming the province	She speaks once a session; when she does, the bells listen. She has never spoken the ninth word.
Commissary Kyrillos	Chain-Lantern commander	Purge all untutored magic from the province	His lantern shows not only latent talent but also the bearer’s greatest fear. He refuses to look into it himself.
Sofia	Bell-Runner (commoner exemplar)	Outrun the hunters and protect the hidden gifted	She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun; her hair is a thicket. One knot is white a hunter she could not outrun.
Nomophylax Zoe	Law-scholar, master of citations	Reform the synod from within	She has never lost a case; her opponents have a habit of vanishing into the Unfinished Stair.

The Lighthouse-Patriarch	Reclusive seer of the Beacon Crown	Steer the city through the coming storm	He has no eyes only mirrors where his eyes should be. In the mirrors you see the faces of those who owe the Ninth.
Keeper Lian (Lethai-thora)	High Archivist of the Library of Keys	Preserve the Astroegro records and keep the Ninth's cult from the deepest vaults	She has not spoken aloud in twenty years. She writes on water. The water never freezes.

Names of Thepyrgos

Inspired by the southern peninsulas and the Aegean coast: clear vowels, soft endings, and surnames that recall a stair, a tower, or a village. Lethai-thora names are longer, more flowing, often ending in -iel, -ael, -ir.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Konstantinos	Eleni	Skalas	<i>the Stair-Wise</i>
Dimitris	Zoe	Platanos	<i>the Unseen</i>
Kyrillos	Sofia	Raptis	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Nikolas	Anastasia	Laskaris	<i>the Accursed</i>
Leonidas	Irini	Makris	<i>Ash-Finger</i>
Stephanos	Fotini	Koutroulis	<i>the Silent</i>
Aerendil	Lian	Thoraen	<i>Archivist</i>

(Tower/Stair/Sea-wall) Pilgrim's Stair zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; Tower Quarter with family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges.

Spades Places

- Pilgrim's Stair** — Zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; ascent as devotion. '[TRAVEL]' '[RITUAL]' *Every hundredth step has a bell. Pilgrims ring once for mercy, twice for memory. The ninth bell has no clapper.*
- Tower Quarter** — Family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges; vertical neighborhoods. '[SOCIAL]' *The lowest rung of each ladder is painted red a toll for the rope-guild. The rope-guild's scroll is written in disappearing ink.*

4. **Chain-Barbican** — Harbor gate; capstans ready to raise the boom at horn’s call. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The capstan pins are carved from the thighbones of executed smugglers. The bones still warm in your hand.*
5. **Blue Cistern** — Under the forum; cool echo, strict tally; water as law. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’ *The water tastes of copper and old prayers. Drink deep, and you may forget a promise but the water will remember your face.*
6. **Ropeyard Terrace** — Cranes walk cargo up slope by treadwheel; muscle and machinery. ‘[LABOR]’ *The treadwheel operators sing in eights. The ninth beat is always silent that is when the Stair moves.*
7. **Storm-Wall Arcades** — Wind shrieks through arched galleries; defense as architecture. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The wind carries voices from the last siege. Some say they’re warnings. Others say they’re the Ninth rehearsing.*
8. **Beacon Crown** — Ring of watchtowers signaling along the Dolmis; eyes of the city. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The beacons burn juniper and saltpeter. Black smoke means fire; white smoke means hunters. Green smoke means the Stair is hungry.*
9. **Library of Keys** — Archive vaults; shelves locked by rung and rite; knowledge as power. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[SECRET]’ *The keys are graded by the weight of what they lock. The ninth key opens nothing and everything. It is kept in a box that has no lid.*
10. **Siege Court** — Test ramp and scarred stones; war never far from peace. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The ramp’s stones are stained with lamp oil and regret. Practice charges end in the cistern or the Unfinished Stair.*
- J **Ladder Monastery** — Perched on a needle of rock; monks climb toward truth. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The monks never speak. They write commandments in chalk on the rungs. The ninth rung has no chalk only a smear of ash.*
- Q **Synod Hall** — Gold-glass mosaics; judgment audible at a whisper’s distance. ‘[LAW]’ *The acoustics are enchanted. A lie told here echoes twice once in the liar’s voice, once in truth’s. The Ninth’s lies echo only once.*
- K **Archon’s Citadel** — Acropolis peak; mirror tiles glare like noon’s justice. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The mirrors were a gift from Kahfagia. They show not the sea, but the faces of those who carry obligations and sometimes a stair that was not there before.*
- A **The Unfinished Stair** — A hidden flight that appears only to those who have asked a question the Synod cannot answer. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The stairs have no end. Each step is a different year. At the top, the Ninth and the Witness are playing knucklebones with forgotten names.*

(Archon/Synod/Guild) Bell-runner child whose feet know every stair by heart; Master of Ropes with palms like oak, voice like a whistle.

Hearts People & Factions

2. **Bell-Runner** — Child whose feet know every stair by heart; speed as currency. ‘[STEALTH]’ *She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun; her hair is a thicket. One knot is white a hunter she could not outrun.*
3. **Master of Ropes** — Palms like oak, voice like a whistle; guild head of lifters. ‘[LABOR]’ *He lost two fingers to a frayed line. He keeps them in a jar as a warning. The jar is on the ninth shelf.*

4. **Icon-Smith** — Portable shrine, temper about pigment; faith in detail. ‘[CRAFT]’ *His pigments are ground from stolen icons. He calls it recycling the divine. The Ninth calls it preparation.*
 5. **Wall Strategos** — Drills levies on the test ramp; defense as daily ritual. ‘[COMBAT]’ *She lost a son to a Linn raid. She trains orphans now and keeps a list. The list has nine names.*
 6. **Chain-Keeper** — Harbor boom; hates “surprises” at dusk; order as obsession. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *His bell never rings the same note twice. He says the tide changes its mind. The Ninth changes its tone.*
 7. **Oath-Examiner** — Weighs words like iron; notary of truth and consequence. ‘[LAW]’ *She carries a scale with one pan empty. The empty pan is for lies. When the Ninth speaks, both pans tip.*
 8. **Archive Sister (Lethai-thora)** — Key to the “forbidden rung”; keeper of dangerous knowledge. ‘[SECRET]’ *Her left eye is milk-white a price for reading a cursed shelf. The shelf was a stair in a past life.*
 9. **Salt-Fish Syndic** — Warehouse queen of the quays; profit in preservation. ‘[TRADE]’ *Her salt is cut with ground bone meal. The fish stay fresh and quiet. The bones were from a stair.*
 10. **Nomophylax** — Law-scholar whose citations close mouths; precedent as weapon. ‘[LAW]’ *He has never lost a case. His opponents have a habit of vanishing. The Unfinished Stair has a new step.*
- J **Palikar Captain** — Tower guards; ladder-quick and letter-shy; strength in motion. ‘[COMBAT]’ *His shield is painted with a ladder each rung a battle he survived. The ninth rung is blank.*
- Q **Matriarch of the Ladder** — Synod primate; calm as stone, wisdom in height. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *She speaks once a session. When she does, the bells listen. She has never spoken the ninth word.*
- K **The Archon** — Elected, entrenched, counting bells; ruler of the ascent. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *He wears a key around his neck. No one knows what it opens. The key is a stair.*
- A **Lighthouse-Patriarch** — Reclusive seer; said to steer beacons in storms. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *He has no eyes only mirrors where his eyes should be. In the mirrors you see the Unfinished Stair.*

(Edict/Quake/Chain) Tremor with hairline cracks racing down a stair; crowds freeze; iconoclast riot in the Tower Quarter.

Clubs Complications/Threats

2. **Tremor** — Hairline cracks race down a stair; crowds freeze, dust speaks. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The dust spells names. Yours appears if you’ve broken a stair-right or if the Ninth is curious.*
3. **Iconoclast Riot** — In the Tower Quarter; pigments and teeth fly through the air. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The riot started over a missing icon’s eye. The eye was a hunter’s informer. The icon was a stair.*
4. **Chain Jam** — At the barbican; capstan pins shear at the worst moment. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The pins were filed by a saboteur. The chain will hold or not. The Ninth is taking bets.*
5. **Black Northerly** — Pins cranes; cargo hangs between tiers, prayers below. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The wind smells of iron and ice. Someone is using weather magic. The Witness disapproves.*

6. **Cistern Taint** — Sour water; inspectors padlock spouts, thirst rises. ‘[WEIGHT]’ *The taint is sweet too sweet. Someone poisoned the cistern to flush out a talent. The talent is a stair.*
7. **Synod Summons** — A chant or badge is suddenly proscribed; law shifts like wind. ‘[LAW]’ *The summons is written on a bell-clapper. Read it, and you are a witness. The Ninth writes the margin.*
8. **Rope Guild Interdict** — No lifts until a grievance is heard; the city stops climbing. ‘[LABOR]’ *The guild’s grievance is a single name. The name is yours. The name is also a stair.*
9. **Siege Drill Panic** — Practice horns mistaken for real; chaos in the ranks. ‘[FEAR]’ *The horns were blown by a child who didn’t know the difference. Or did they? The child is a step.*
10. **Smuggler’s Ladder** — Discovered; the whole stair sealed, routes rerouted. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’ *The ladder was built by a Hyro family. Now they are all “guests” of the Commissariat. Their house is a stair.*
- J **Ropeyard Fire** — Sparks leap uphill faster than boots; smoke chokes the ascent. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The fire was set to cover a kidnapping. The victim’s name is on the bounty board. The board is a stair.*
- Q **Exarch’s Claim** — “Thepyrgos under my protection”; arrests follow the papers. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Exarch is a puppet of the Chain-Lanterns. His seal is a bell without a clapper. The Ninth has the clapper.*
- K **General Watch** — All towers manned; levies seize carts “for the walls.” ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The levies are looking for one thing: children who flinch at candle-smoke. The children are stairs.*
- A **The Unfinished Stair Awakens** — A hidden flight appears in the middle of a crowded tier. The Ninth’s attention falls. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ ‘[BOSS]’ *The stairs have no end. The Witness is writing. The Ninth is counting. You are already on the third step.*

(Key/Rite/Paper) Stair token passes a barricaded stair without delay; harbor pass lowers the boom for your vessel on command.

Diamonds Rewards/Leverage

2. **Stair Token** — Pass a barricaded stair without delay (once); height as right. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a bronze step. It fits into a missing rung. The missing rung is a secret.*
3. **Harbor Pass** — Boom lowers for your vessel on command; sea as ally. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The pass is a note written on a fish scale. The gate-keeper will not ask why. The fish was a witness.*
4. **Cistern Draw-Right** — A named ward during scarcity; water as favor. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The right is a clay cup. Break it to claim your share. The cup was a stair.*
5. **Crane Allotment** — One guaranteed lift on the Ropeyard Terrace; height as service. ‘[LABOR]’ *The allotment is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each use. The ninth knot is a lie.*
6. **Icon License** — Display a disputed image without penalty; faith as leverage. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The license is stamped with the Archon’s ring. The ring is warm the Archon is watching. The ring is a stair.*
7. **Archive Hour** — Library of Keys; one shelf opened to you; knowledge as power. ‘[SECRET]’ *The shelf is sealed with a riddle. Solve it, or the key will break. The riddle is about the ninth step.*

8. **Bellmark** — Lawful right to ring a tower bell (summons the watch); sound as law. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The bellmark is a brand on your palm. Show it, and the watch bleeds for you once. The blood is a witness.*
9. **Watchlight Code** — Today’s beacon and mirror signals; navigation as paper. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The code is written in lemon juice. Heat it to read, then hide it again. The heat is a confession.*
10. **Synod Indulgence** — One proscribed chant or rite permitted (for you). ‘[MAGIC]’ *The indulgence is a bell-note held in a jar. Break the jar to release it. The bell-note is a name.*
- J **Pronoia Grant** — Temporary farm/tax of a terrace hamlet; land as income. ‘[TRADE]’ *The grant is a wooden token. Present it to the village elder if she is still alive. The elder is a stair.*
- Q **Synod Audience** — Private with the Matriarch and clerks; wisdom as policy. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The audience is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written. The fog is a witness.*
- K **Archon’s Writ** — Palikars escort you between towers; authority as escort. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt, and the guards will know your voice. The rope was a stair.*
- A **Golden Key** — Open or seal any city gate once; access as power. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist. It will work once. The fist is the Ninth’s.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock ($25 \rightarrow 4$, $610 \rightarrow 6$, $J/Q/K \rightarrow 8$, $A \rightarrow 10$).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (keys/rites/papers) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **height and sound** motifs — bells that carry, wind that remembers, stairs that echo with purpose.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Bell-Law:** Bells are law made sound. Once per session, a Bellmark or tower bell summons the watch, a levy, or a decree. False rings stain a reputation; the Synod may inquire. The ninth ring is never false — it is always the Ninth.
- **Stair-Rights:** Every stair is owned, owed, or leased. A token bypasses barricades and tolls; climbing the wrong stair without leave sparks a riot or a duel. The Unfinished Stair has no owner — only a bearer of its weight.
- **The Unfinished Stair Clock [6]:** Tracks the party’s entanglement with the hidden architecture of Thepyrgos. Tick it when you use a hidden stair, ask a question the Synod cannot answer, or speak a true name of an Astroegro ruin. At 6 segments, the party discovers a *new* hidden stair — one that leads to an Astroegro Vault — but they are also *marked*. The Witness’s attention falls on them. Their reflections in mirrors begin to lag by a heartbeat. The Chain-Lanterns receive a vision of their faces. Reduce the clock by feeding a memory to the Ninth’s Coterie (lose a fact, a skill point, or a Bond) or by recording a truth in the Synod’s archives (gain Obligation to the Witness).
- **The Offering at the Crossroads (Hedge Gift):** Once per session, a Hyro character (or someone who has learned their customs) may leave a *substitute* at a crossroads — a written name, a lock of hair, a childhood memory. For the next scene, they are *invisible to the*

Chain-Lanterns (cannot be tracked or identified by candle-smoke). The substitute becomes a *Weight Token* that the GM may cash in later (the Hollow accepted it; the Hollow will ask for more).

- **The Candle-Smoke Test (GM Tool):** When the Chain-Lanterns test a village, the GM rolls 1d6. On a 1-2, they find a gifted child (the party must intervene or witness a tragedy). On a 3-4, they find a substitute (a false name, a hidden memory) and leave. On a 5-6, the village has already paid in silence no raid occurs. The party can influence the roll by offering their own substitute (use a Boon to shift the result by 1).
- **The Astroegro Singing (Player Tool):** A Hyro character can hum a fragment of an old empire song. The song has no words only pressure. When hummed at a ruin, it may open a hidden door. When hummed at a Chain-Lantern, it may cause their lantern to flicker. Each use advances the *Unfinished Stair* clock by 1 (the past is waking).
- **Lethai-thora Archivists:** The high elf refugees have integrated into the city’s scholarly elite. They are the keepers of the deepest archives and the most secret keys. A character with Lethai-thora heritage (or who earns their trust) may gain access to the *Archivists’ Mark* a brass key that opens one restricted door in the Library of Keys per session. However, the Archivists are not monolithic; some serve the Witness, others the Ninth. Choosing a side may alienate the other faction.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Unwritten Citation** The Witness. *A precedent that exists only in the margin.*
 - **The Bell-Founder** Mykkiel. *The law that rings true, even when it hurts.*
 - **The Abyssal Pressure** Khemesh. *The weight beneath the city; the weight that the deep remembers.*
 - **The Silent Stair** The Ninth. *The step that is never counted, the threshold that opens only once.*

The Astroegro Vaults

Beneath the city, nine vaults. The Synod knows of three and has sealed them with Witness-branded wax. The Ninth’s Coterie has found a fourth. The other five are still buried, waiting for the right key a true name, a specific death, a memory that has never been spoken.

Each vault contains:

- A weapon (a bell that rings the target’s true name, a lens that shows the death of anyone you name, a stone that erases a page from the world’s record).
- A guardian (a spirit of an Astroegro archivist, bound to defend the vault with its last calculation).
- A cost (to open the vault, you must sacrifice something the empire valued a memory of salt water, a dream of drowning, a confession of hubris).

The Ninth’s Goal: Open all nine vaults simultaneously. The resulting “unlearning” would erase the concept of *weight* from the world. No one would owe anything to anyone. The Hollow would starve. The Witness would have nothing to record. The Ninth would become the only law: *forgetting*.

The Witness’s Goal: Keep the vaults sealed, but *remember* them perfectly. Every weapon, every secret, every crime of the Astroegro must be recorded in the Synod’s archives not to use, but to witness. The Witness does not want to prevent the Ninth’s plan; it wants to be *the one who writes down what happened*.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Astroegro Remnant (Khemesh):** Deep beneath the Beacon Crown, a sealed chamber contains a working Astroegro orrery. Its gears are carved from abyssal glass, and it still ticks. Those who listen too long hear a voice whispering the true names of drowned emperors. The Chain-Lanterns have posted a perpetual guard; they say the orrery is a beacon for something that should not surface.
- **Saint Methodia of the Silent Stair (The Witness):** A legendary archivist who climbed the Ninth Stair of the Library of Keys and never came down. Her ghost is said to appear to those who speak a truth the Synod has buried, offering a single citation that can overturn any edict. The price is a secret of equal weight, and the ghost never forgets.
- **The Cog-Cults of the Clockwork Monad:** Underground fraternities of gear-smiths and logicians who believe the Astroegro Empire fell because its geometry was imperfect. They meet in the basements of the Ropeyard Terrace, trying to reconstruct the lost orrery. The Chain-Lanterns tolerate them because their calculations sometimes predict talent blooms. Heretics from the Everflame call them clock-worshippers; the Cog-Cults call themselves the True Iterators.
- **The Daughters of the Cord (The Bitter Root):** A hospice in the lower tiers is run by gray-robed women who ask no payment, but they take names. They are tolerated because they treat the poor for free, but the Commissariat suspects they also hide gifted children. A renegade Sister hides among the bell-runners, trying to unbind her Hollowed from the Chain-Lanterns' record.
- **The Savage Heart (Red Maw):** In the highland villages west of the city, a bear cult has arisen. They believe the only way to escape the Commissariat's hunts is to become the hunter. They wear cured skins and speak in growls, and they have begun hunting Chain-Lantern patrols. The Archon has declared them outlaws, but the villagers leave offerings of raw meat at their shrines.
- **Zakov's Astroegro Foundation:** The pirate city of Zakov is built on top of a sunken Astroegro port. Smugglers occasionally pull up black glass artifacts from the deep channels, which find their way to Thepyrgos' black market. The Ninth's Coterie pays handsomely for such relics; the Witness's archivists try to buy them first.
- **The Ninth:** In any Thepyrgos scene, the ninth bell rung in an hour opens a threshold. The wise stop at eight and cover their ears. Those who ring the ninth are said to see a pale figure standing on the Beacon Crown's mirror tiles waiting to collect a name.

Thepyrgos Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stair:** Toss a crust onto a rung before climbing. Ignore the first *Tremor* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Rope:** Tie a single knot in a crane line. Cancel *Rope Guild Interdict* or take 1 die on your next lift (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Smoke:** Whisper a hunter's name into the Beacon Crown's fire. Gain +1 Effect when evading the Chain-Lanterns this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Synod. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Offer the Substitute:** Leave a written false name at a crossroads. The next Candle-Smoke Test against you automatically fails but the Hollow gains a *Weight Token* on you. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tower guards or guild masters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bell-runners or civic patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or archive keepers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable ascent**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Wall Strategos or guild head** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **quake damage or stair closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction or civic enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **palikars, guild enforcers, or synod guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes **bell rings falsely/stair collapses/law changes**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Archon, Matriarch, or Lighthouse-Patriarch** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically **quake hits/bells ring/bridge collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Thepyrgos (Height & Law):** Stairs shift position, bells ring with the wrong tone, legal papers rewrite themselves.
- **Thepyrgos (Synod Power):** Edicts change mid-speech, citations appear in the air, wisdom comes unbidden.
- **Thepyrgos (Vertical City):** Ropes fray without warning, cranes swing cargo unexpectedly, tower windows show wrong views.
- **Thepyrgos (The Unfinished Stair):** A hidden stair appears behind the party. The Ninth is counting. The Witness is writing. The stairs have no end.

The Magic Colleges (University Extensions)

- **College of Ladders & Lines** geomancy, architecture, constraint; stairs as sigils, capstans as circles.
- **College of Bells & Beacons** acoustics, omen-fire, signal calculus; law made audible, augury made measurable.
- **College of Waters & Weights** alchemy, cistern rites, dyes; solutions, precipitates, and lawful flow.
- **College of Names & Oaths** nomikon theurgy; citations that bind, clauses that compel.
- **College of Mirrors & Haze** illusion, scrutiny; seeing, being seen, un-being seen.
- **College of Quiet** ethics of death, memory rites; permitted remembrances anything more is heresy.

The Witch-Hunter Province (Commissariat Extensions)

Thepyrgos-the-Province funds Witch-Hunter Commissariats ministries with bounties posted per ward. Notices hang on stair-landings; bells announce *hunts lawful and hunts less so*. The Chain-Lantern order is the most feared, but others compete for quotas.

Hunter Hearts (faces of the persecution)

- **Commissary-Exarch** Writes in triplicate; quotas in private.
- **Bounty-Reader** Weighs children like coin; “verification” by bell.
- **Pardoner-Chaplain** Sells absolution to informers; keeps a careful record.
- **Stair-Runner Informant** Knows which doors open to the right knock.
- **Chain-Lantern Captain** Commands the most feared order; his lantern reveals truth through flesh.

Hunter Clubs (pressures and sweeps)

- **Bounty Posting** New price on “untutored talent”; crowds turn into nets.
- **Candle-Smoke Test** Lines at the Blue Cistern; smoke curls toward the Gifted.
- **Commissary Sweep** Ladders chained; a whole tier searched under horn.
- **Quieted Child** An “accident” near the Exam Stair; evidence goes missing.
- **Chain-Lantern Raid** Dawn assault on a hamlet; children taken before the rooster crows.

Hunter Diamonds (leverage and reprieve)

- **Witness Pardon** Informer absolved and paid; cancels one legal fallout *once*.
- **Archon’s Clemency** Suspends a bounty clock for one named; bell-marked and public.
- **Hidden Stair Token** Through a maintenance run unseen; good for one group escape.

Detection & Denial (Fast Procedures)

Scry & Deny (evading the tests)

1. **Mask the Trace:** dye, salt, bell-oil; pick *one* (each grants +1 die to one approach).
2. **Pick the Test:** *Smoke, Sound, Mirror*. State how you spoof it (alchemical veil, bell overtones, angle games).

3. **On a hit:** cancel a **Candle-Smoke Test** or **Proctors’ Gate** tag for this scene. **Consequence:** start *Bell Weight* [2] or *Rector’s Notice* [2].

Bounty Economy (quick table, GM picks or 1d6)

1. *Whisperer* (faint talent): 1 purse; informers abundant.
2. *Spark-Hand* (cantrip): 2 purses; “rehabilitation” promised.
3. *Mirror-Bent* (glamour): 3 purses; seized at once.
4. *Bell-Singer* (acoustic): 4 purses; Synod claims jurisdiction.
5. *Oath-Breaker* (binding): 5 purses; Exarch insists on custody.
6. *Quiet-Worker* (death-ethic): 6 purses; College of Quiet petitions for trial.

Scenario Starters (Plug-and-Play)

The Bright Child on the Exam Stair *Hook:* A Bell-Runner begs you to get a latent child to campus before the dawn sweep. *Complications:* **Candle-Smoke Test**, **Commissary Sweep**, a jealous **Street Thaum**. *Relief:* Trade a *Latency Seal* for testimony; or ring a lawful *Bellmark* to create a corridor accept *Censure Murmurs* [2].

The Black Ledger of Bounties *Hook:* The College of Quiet wants proof that a Commissary inflates prices to fill quotas. *Complications:* **Synod Summons**, **Smuggler’s Ladder**, **Chain Jam**. *Relief:* Publish via a *Nomikon* colloquy (gain *Synod Indulgence*); or sell it to the Archon (gain *Archon’s Clemency* but start *Faculty Feud* [4]).

The Golden Key and the Silent Stair *Hook:* A dying Archivist gives you a Golden Key. “It opens the stair the hunters fear.” *Truth:* The stair leads to the Beacon Crown’s secret basement a prison for children who passed the smoke test. *Relief:* Free the children and expose the Commissariat (gain *Archon’s Clemency* for the whole party, but start *Exarch’s Claim* at full); or seal the stair forever (gain *Golden Key* to use elsewhere, but the children are lost to memory).

The Ninth Vault *Hook:* A fragment of an Astroegro weapon has been unearthed in a hill village. The Ninth’s Coterie and the Synod both want it. The village elder offers it to the party if they can offer a substitute that satisfies the Hollow. *Truth:* The weapon is a bell that rings the true name of anyone you name. Its guardian is the ghost of the Astroegro archivist who sealed it. The ghost will not speak to anyone who has not climbed the Unfinished Stair. *Relief:* Climb the stair, speak the archivist’s true name, and take the bell but the stair adds a segment to the Unfinished Stair Clock. Or destroy the bell with a memory of the Astroegro’s fall (lose a cherished memory permanently). Or give the bell to the Synod (gain a Synod Indulgence) or to the Ninth’s Coterie (gain a Weight Token from the Ninth).

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Stair (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a stair token is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Quake (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *Tremor*, you pick who keeps their footing; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Bell & Inquisition)

- **The Bell-Exarch (Nine Bans)** *Phases:* Candle-Smoke Sweep → Orchestrated Silence → Synod Coup. *Cracks:* ring a forgotten bell, expose a false bounty, survive a night in the Beacon Crown.
- **The Astroegro Engine (Pressure from Below)** *Phases:* Gears Turn → Whispers Become Names → Seiche. *Cracks:* abyssal glass shard, survivor testimony, the Lighthouse-Patriarch's mirror turning clear.
- **The Ninth's Advocate (Living Stair)** *Phases:* Count → Omit → Forget. *Cracks:* speak a true name that the Ninth does not know, offer a memory the Witness has not recorded, climb the Unfinished Stair and refuse to answer the Ninth's question.

Patronage & Power

In Thepyrgos, power flows through elevation, education, and the precise application of law but also through the hidden architecture of the Unfinished Stair. The Archon maintains authority through a complex web of guilds, synods, and civic institutions, but the real power lies with whoever can climb the stairs that should not exist. Social mobility is literally upward mobility, with stair-rights, bellmarks, and archive access serving as both currency and status symbols. But the highest status belongs to those who have seen the top of the Unfinished Stair and remembered how to return.

The Lethai-thora, as the city's most respected archivists, hold a special kind of power: they know which shelves are watched, which keys are false, and which doors lead to the Ninth's vaults. Some whisper that the Archon is secretly a Lethai-thora puppet; others say the real ruler is the ghost of an Astroegro emperor, still counting stairs in the deep.

For the GM: Patronage in Thepyrgos revolves around access to towers, to knowledge, to the right to climb, and to the hidden stairs. Rewards often take the form of keys, passes, or legal exemptions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the metaphysical war:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, keys, papers) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guilds and the two Patrons (Witness and Ninth) issue conflicting rights, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the synods, towers, and staircases as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success but where the Ninth's silence and the Witness's memory can tip the scales.
- Introduce the Unfinished Stair clock as a campaign tension; every time the party uses a hidden stair, they advance the clock and bring the Ninth's attention closer.

In Thepyrgos, your ascent is your standing, and your standing determines whether you rise or fall or whether you are simply *forgotten*.

Part II

The Northern Reaches

“The mountain counts your breaths. The frost writes your name in ice. In the north, the dead do not wait they walk, and they remember every promise you made to keep warm.” Dusana of the Raven Road

Chapter 7

Aeler

Crowns & Under-Vaults.

The mountain remembers every word carved in its stone, every seal pressed into its walls. To govern here is not to command, but to harmonize with the ancient songs that still echo in the deep places.

I am an Under-Mason. I can hear stone shift a room away. When the rock starts singing a different tune, you best listen. Three knocks in the morning means all's well, but three knocks at night means something's coming through the walls that wasn't meant to walk.

My homeland. The place where we don't trust the surface, but we do trust the weight of a well-placed keystone and oh, how the surface loves to test that trust. Our breath-bonds aren't just currency they're the hardest thing in the peaks, forged in the sighs of miners who knew too much. We sell them to Vilikari jarls who pay in furs stained with brother's blood, to Ykrul khagans who weigh the value in warhorses and broken oaths. Once, we sold one to the Veiled Sisters. They paid in secrets which is another way of saying they paid in future leverage.

Never count your breaths aloud in a mine. The mountain listens, and if it hears you reach the ninth, it will take one a breath, a memory, a shadow. My grandfather reached nine once. He lived another thirty years, but he never cast a shadow again.

Thromm Stone-Tongue, Under-Mason, who has never counted to nine

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Stone-bread and cave cheese the bread is baked on heated stone slabs, the cheese is aged in sealed galleries where the temperature never varies. The cheese has been aging for three generations. It is an heirloom. It is also barely edible.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count their breaths. Aeler children wear breath-counters small brass bells on leather cords. Eight breaths, ring the bell. Nine breaths, run. A child who cannot count is a child who will not survive the winter.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their bell. Every Aeler carries a bell tuned to their breath. A stranger's bell will ring at a different pitch the mountain's lungs are calibrated to local frequencies. A mismatched bell is a warning. A silent bell is a threat.

What is the most common crime? Air theft. In the deep vaults, ventilation is shared. A sealed door, a blocked vent, a diverted shaft these are thefts of breath, punishable by breath-debt. The guilty party must donate their own air ration to the victim. The donation is measured in days. The days are counted by bells.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The True Masons are not neutral. They are the Vault-Queen's eyes. Every "independent" repair, every "neutral" inspection, every "routine" audit the True Masons are watching. They do not report to the Queen. They are the Queen. They have always been the Queen.

Where do people go when they die? To the Deep Vault the oldest galleries, where the air is thin and the stone is cold. The dead are not buried. They are sealed in niches carved into the walls, their names chiselled above their heads. The niches are reused every century. The names are never erased. The dead share walls with strangers. The strangers are patient.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a keystone a load-bearing stone from your own holding. The stone is installed in the wronged party's wall. If it holds, you are forgiven. If it cracks, the debt stands. If it crumbles, your holding collapses. Apology is architecture. Architecture is law.

What is the most important festival? The Ringing of the Underways (deep winter). Every bell in every hold is rung at the same hour eight times, no more. The sound travels through the stone, a heartbeat that reminds the mountain that the living are still here. The dead listen. The dead do not ring back.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Vault-Queen is a construct. She was assembled in 723 AR, after the real queen died in a cave-in. Her heart is a keystone. Her breath is a bellows. Her voice is a recording. The True Masons maintain her. They have the schematics. The schematics are missing three pages. The missing pages describe how to turn her off.

7.1 Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”

Elite (Vault-Queen of a crownland)

“The mountain remembers every word carved in its stone, every seal pressed into its walls. To govern here is not to command, but to harmonize with the ancient songs that still echo in the deep places. But the deep places also sing other songs songs that forget the living.”

Commoner (Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away)

“When the stone starts singing a different tune, you best listen. Three knocks in the morning means all’s well, but three knocks at night means something’s coming through the walls that wasn’t meant to walk. My grandfather called it the pressure that thinks. He walked into the deep one day and never came back. The mountain answered his knock. It always does.”

Crowns & Under-Vaults

The Aeler Kingdoms hold the mountains by breath, bell, and bargain. Dozens of sovereign holds some sealed for centuries, others trading openly with lowland markets share only the deep roots of stone and the supremacy of the High King Beneath the Peaks. Their halls run like arteries, their cities open in thunderous caverns where bridges leap between ribs of stone and cisterns shine like night skies turned inward. *Survival* is the first law: air is counted, water is bartered, light is rationed by wick and prayer. *Tradition* is the second: seals are kept, measures remain true, and the dead keep their offices as carefully as the living. Between the two, a people learn to argue quietly and build loudly.

Collectives (clans, guild-kin, lamp-companies) own what the mountain allows; individuals are custodians by oath. Trade runs under and over the range through underways and passforts, stitching protectorates and lowland markets to vaultmouth gates. When tunnels whisper or the air tastes wrong, the Aeler move as one animal; when the Kingsmoot calls, crowns and abbesses argue in bellcode and sealed writs until the stone itself seems to lean in.

But beneath the order, beneath the breath-counters and the record-stones, something older stirs. The Aeler do not speak of it directly. They call it *the pressure that thinks* a presence that lives in the deepest galleries, in the spaces between sealed holds, in the darkness where bells have not rung for centuries. It does not attack. It *invites*. Miners who wander too deep return with no memory of why they went. Others do not return at all. The pressure does not hate. It is patient. And it is always, always listening.

The Pressure That Thinks The Deep Drake

Deep beneath the oldest mountains, beyond the Ninth Seal and past the last lamplighter’s mile, there is a presence. The Aeler do not name it a dragon or a wyrm; they have no word for what it is. They call it *the pressure that thinks* a weight in the stone that feels like curiosity, a whisper in the dark that sounds like your own name spoken with concern. It has no lair that any living Aeler has seen, but the rumor persists: a vast chamber of black glass and fossilized bone, where the heat of the earth meets the cold of the void. In that chamber lies the Deep Drake an ancient wyrm of psychic hunger that feeds not on flesh but on *attention*. It draws the living toward it not through force, but through a gentle, irresistible lure: a halfremembered tune, a forgotten oath, a face you thought you had left behind. You walk toward it because you believe you have business there. You have no business there.

The Deep Drake does not kill. It *collects*. Its victims become part of its hoard – not corpses, but still, silent figures that sit in the dark, their eyes open, their mouths moving silently as they repeat the last promise they ever made. The Aeler have learned to live with the pressure. They seal off tunnels that grow too warm. They never answer a knock that comes in three. They count their breaths not out of habit, but out of a deep, unspoken fear that the ninth breath might be the one the pressure answers.

Hooks for the GM:

- A sealed hold has not answered the Kingsmoot in nine years. The pressure is whispering through the stone. The party is sent to investigate – or to seal the hold permanently.
- A miner returns from the deep with no memory of the past week, but their shadow now moves independently. The pressure is using them as a messenger.
- The Deep Drake does not attack. It *negotiates*. It offers forgotten secrets, lost treasures, or safe passage through its territory – in exchange for a single memory of sunlight. The party must decide what to trade.

The Fractured Crowns: Aeler Faction Spectrum

Aeler society is not monolithic. Beneath the High King’s nominal authority, each crownland follows its own star. Attitudes toward the surface range from open partnership to militant isolation, and even the most reclusive holds maintain **Edgewalker** contacts to monitor the world above.

- **Traditionalist / “The Old Ways”** – These holds idealize the ancient mountainempire: closed gates, iron tariffs, and the certain knowledge that surfacedwellers cannot be trusted. They resemble the dwarves of fireside tales: stubborn, insular, and quick to reach for an axe when a human mentions “progress.” Their kings speak of the days when no foreigner stepped past the vaultmouth. They also speak of the pressure in whispers, and they seal any tunnel that shows signs of warmth. *Clocks: FOREIGNER SUSPICION [4], HOLD SEALED [6]*.
- **Cooperative / “Open Hand”** – These holds trade freely with Aelaerem, Kahfagia, and even the Vilikari. They staff the undermarkets, send engineers to repair bridges in Viterra, and treat the surface as a resource to be managed, not a threat to be shunned. They prefer soft power: standardized measures, certified weights, and bellcode protocols that make others *want* to trade on Aeler terms. They are also the most likely to send expeditions into the deep, seeking lost holds – and the most likely to lose miners to the pressure. *Clocks: TRADE ROUTE PROSPERITY [6], CULTURAL FRICTION [4]*.
- **Isolationist / “Silent Stone”** – Deep holds that have not answered a Kingsmoot call in living memory. Their gates are lost, their peoples rumored to have turned inward, worshiping forgotten depths – or to have become part of the pressure’s hoard. They neither help nor harm the surface – but when a White Flood or a gas flare occurs, their silence becomes a hazard of its own. The Deep Drake is said to lair somewhere beneath the Silent Stone holds. *Clocks: SILENT HOLD AWAKENS [8], ANCIENT GRUDGE [6]*.

Most Aeler characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same hold might shift its stance over a season, depending on grain prices, a new VaultQueen, or a disaster that forces its hand.

The Breath Count – Habit, Not Function

Among the Aeler, counting breaths is not merely a safety measure – it is a cultural reflex, as automatic as a human’s heartbeat. Aeler children learn to count in eights before they learn to speak. They tap

their fingers, their bells, their spoons in rhythms of eight. They never, ever count to nine aloud. The ninth breath is not a number; it is a *gap* the space where the pressure listens. Aeler who forget to count in eights are considered unreliable, possibly touched by the deep. Those who deliberately count to nine are shunned; they are thought to have invited the pressure to notice them.

Mechanical note: Breathcounting is not a skill roll or a resource to track. It is a narrative and cultural tic. The GM may use a characters failure to observe the count as a trigger for a complication (e.g., the mountain shifts, a bell rings falsely, a character feels watched). Conversely, an Aeler who scrupulously counts their breaths in eights may gain a small boon (e.g., +1 die to resist fear in confined spaces) as the mountains attention slides past them.

Prominent NPCs of Aeler

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumored Quirk
Valthor Aezelbron	High King Beneath the Peaks	Preserve the ancient concord and balance the crownlands	He has not spoken above a whisper in seven years. The court reads his will by bellcode.
Grunhelda Thrainsdottir	Vault-Queen of Irondeep	Expand trade routes while keeping the Old Ways satisfied	She keeps a pet geode that hums when a contract is fair and goes silent when the pressure is near.
Maeva Kaelen	Legate of the Under-Seal	Negotiate passage rights and standard measures with lowland realms	Her sealrod is carved from a fossilized root. She has never lost a tariff dispute.
Thromm StoneTongue	Under-Mason (Commoner exemplar)	Hear the mountains warnings and keep the tunnels safe	He can identify a false weight by tapping it once with his hammer. He has never counted to nine.

Orthen WhiteRib-bon	Tunnel Courier	Deliver sealed writs across hostile jurisdictions	He has run the Spine Underway in darkness without a lamp. Twice. He says the dark has a voice, but it only asks questions.
Lumenor Saela	Keeper of the Under-Altars	Maintain the breathrites and the old flame	She speaks only in bell tones during services. Her mundane voice is never heard.

Names of Aeler

Aeler names blend flowing vowels and soft diphthongs (ae, ei, ou, ui) with harsh consonants (k, th, z, r, g). Surnames are carved from mountain-roots: a hold, a forge, a seam, or a trade.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Thrain	Grunhelda	Aezenbron	<i>the Iron</i>
Kaelen	Maeva	Thrainkhar	<i>Breath-Steady</i>
Orthen	Saela	Valdurg	<i>Seal-Keeper</i>
Rurik	Aeldis	Kaelthane	<i>Bell-Tongue</i>
Bromm	Helka	Zarkul	<i>the Under-Mason</i>
Zelgur	Thorunn	Dornvael	<i>White-Ribbon</i>

Spades — Places (vaultmouths, descents, underways, crown seats)

- (Security/Gatekeeping) Vaultmouth Gate in a hillslope: bronze lungs for breath-tests, tally-niches for lamps.
- (Tradition/Oaths) Crown-Crypt Porch where oaths are sworn to sleeping kings.
- (Commerce/Underground) Under-Market: lantern alleys between cistern pillars; damp coin, dry wit.
- (Labor/Danger) Smoke-Shaft Stair spiraling up to a soot hatch; handprints black as seals.
- (Mystery/Whispers) Gloam Cistern—black water, lead scales, whispers carry too far.
- (Maintenance/Travel) Lamplighter's Mile on the Under-Road; niches sting with spent wicks.
- (Precision/Authority) Measure Vault: standard rods and weights chained under glass and oath.
- (Sacred/Knowledge) Reliquary Arcade: bell-chimes answer drafts; saints keep their own tallies.
- (Military/Strategic) Twin-Throne Gate—surface fortress straddling a chasm bridge.

- J (Knowledge/Secrecy) Deep Archive Stacks behind grillwork; scriptoria cells breathe ink and dust.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Queen’s Descent: private stair from palace to royal vault-house.
- K (Politics/Power) Kingsmoot Cavern—crownstones in a ring around a bottomless dark.
- A (Infrastructure/Majesty) The Spine Underway, a great tunnel linking crownlands beneath the peaks.

Hearts — People & Factions (crowns, keepers, guilds, legates)

2. (Apprenticeship/Dedication) Lamplighter apprentice with a jingling key-ring and soot in the lungs.
 3. (Craft/Knowledge) Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away.
 4. (Authority/Duty) Vault Warden with breath-tally and seal-rods; patient as granite.
 5. (Protection/Faith) Censer-Knight of the Dawn – fights miasma and men with equal zeal.
 6. (Sacred/Craft) Key-Sister (monastic locksmith) who names wards like prayers.
 7. (Commerce/Authority) Under-Market assessor whose stamp can starve or save a stall.
 8. (Engineering/Expertise) Engineer of Underways (geometer) with rod, hammer, and the right maps.
 9. (Tradition/Law) Oath-Keeper of the Crown Crypt – memory like iron, smile like law.
 10. (Diplomacy/Authority) Legate of the Under-Seal, royal commissioner between kingdoms.
- J (Communication/Loyalty) White-Ribbon tunnel courier; runs blind, rings true.
- Q (Royalty/Authority) Vault-Queen of a crownland, sovereign above and below.
- K (Supreme Authority/Tradition) High King Beneath the Peaks, first among crowns by ancient concord.
- A (Spiritual Power/Resolution) Lumenor of the Under-Altars, one sentence opens doors and closes debates.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (air, water, stone, rite, jurisdiction)

2. (Danger/Disorientation) Bad air pocket—candles gutter blue; lungs complain, schedules fail.
 3. (Disruption/Flood) Drip-flood from a burst cistern reroutes corridors without asking.
 4. (Accident/Destruction) Gas flare kisses a lamp; eyebrows and evidence vanish.
 5. (Error/Security) Seal misread—the wrong door opens, the right one will not.
 6. (Quarantine/Delay) Under-mold quarantine shuts the market just as your crate arrives.
 7. (Danger/Warning) Settling crack—dust snow warns the roof wants down.
 8. (Accusation/Suspicion) Stolen key turns up in your kit; accusations ring like bells.
 9. (Conflict/Jurisdiction) Bell-code conflict—two authorities claim the same chime.
 10. (Political Conflict/Violence) Vault-right feud: crown guards face basilica wardens on a stair.
- J (Disaster/Trapped) Cave-in behind—proof, friends, and retreat on the far side.
- Q (Religious Conflict/Inquisition) Heresy inquest in the under-chapel; arrests in whispers.
- K (Authority/Restriction) General Under-Seal—all vault traffic halted by royal decree.
- A (Natural Disaster/Destruction) White Flood—mountain thaw becomes a river through your route.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (keys, passes, breath, priority, precedent)

2. (Utility/Time) Lamp-priority tally—skip one lamplighter queue.
3. (Safety/Access) Breath-measure allotment—lawful time in a sealed chamber (once).
4. (Security/Authority) Key-Writ—operate a named lock one time, witnessed.
5. (Travel/Security) Underway Pass—escorted travel between two vaultmouths.
6. (Commerce/Rights) Stall-Right in the under-market for a season.
7. (Engineering/Safety) Engineer Shoring—a crew stabilizes your chosen corridor on your timetable.
8. (Commerce/Trust) Assay Mark—your coin/metal accepted sight unseen below.
9. (Protection/Law) Crypt Asylum—temporary sanctuary under crown law.
10. (Authority/Access) Vault Inventory License—remove a named cache under witness.
- J (Military/Authority) Under-Guard Commission—command a vault detachment for a day.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Private Descent with the Vault-Queen or High King’s chancellor.
- K (Supreme Authority/Access) High King’s Sealed Writ—doors open, mouths close across crownlands.
- A (Exception/Power) The Under-Seal Clause—temporary exception to any lock, levy, or rite below.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5→4, 6–10→6, J/Q/K→8, A→10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (keys/passes/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo stone & breath motifs keys click, bells answer, and the mountain listens (and remembers). Also, the pressure that thinks may manifest as a whisper, a warmth, or a knock in the dark.

Additional Features

- **Count the Air:** When a scene establishes scarce air, a character who actively paces their breathing (counted steps, measured rests) may shift *Position* one step safer on their next physical action in a confined space. This is habit, not a resource; Aeler characters may do this reflexively.
- **Bell-Code Courtesy:** If the party adopts local bell etiquette (asking a warden which chime applies and heeding it), gain +1 assist die on negotiations or passage requests within a vault or under-market. Ignoring the bells invites the mountain’s attention.
- **Measure is Mercy:** Presenting a certified measure (rod, weight, sealed tally) calms a dispute: cancel the first SB generated by commerce or jurisdictional friction in the scene. A false measure, however, may draw the pressure’s curiosity.
- **The Ninth Breath (Cultural Tic):** An Aeler character never counts to nine aloud. If forced to do so (or if they deliberately break the taboo), they must test Resolve (DV 3) or gain the *Marked by the Pressure* condition (the next environmental hazard automatically triggers a

complication). This is not a mechanical resource; it is a narrative and cultural constraint.

Stone & Sovereignty

In the deep places, survival depends on precision and tradition. The Aeler understand that stone does not forgive error — a misread seal can mean death, a miscalculated air measure can doom an expedition, and a broken bell-code can spark jurisdictional war. But beneath the law, beneath the tallies, there is the pressure. It does not hate. It does not judge. It simply *thinks*. And when it thinks of you, you will feel a warmth in the stone, a whisper in the dark, a knock that comes in threes. The wise pretend not to notice. The foolish walk toward it.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **vault wardens or lamplighter companies**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **under-guards or echo bats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or assessors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable air**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Breath warden or vault warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **air shift or seal change**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival crown’s guard or gas wraith** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **crown guards, true masons, or lamp companies** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **seal misread/cave-in/flare ignites**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.
- **Pressure Whispers:** A character hears their name spoken from a crack in the stone. They must test Resolve (DV 3) or be compelled to move toward the sound.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Vault-Queen, High King’s Legate, or Lumenor** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **gas floods/water breaks/floor collapses**.

- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.
- **The Deep Drake's Attention:** The pressure that thinks focuses on a character. They gain a *Marked by the Deep* condition. The GM gains 2 SB to spend on environmental or psychic complications in future scenes.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aeler (Stone & Breath):** Keys click in the wrong locks, bells answer without being rung, mountain air grows thin without warning.
- **Aeler (Authority & Tradition):** A seal is misread, bell-codes conflict between jurisdictions, a vault warden demands proper credentials.
- **Aeler (Underground Hazards):** Bad air pockets form, settling cracks warn of collapse, gas flares ignite unexpectedly.
- **Aeler (The Pressure That Thinks):** A distant knock in threes, a warmth from a cold wall, a whisper that sounds like a dead relative, a shadow that moves independently.

Aeler — UnderVault Tensions

Starting Location: An Underway junction lit by guttering brass lanterns, its stone walls scored with tallymarks from a dozen forgotten crowns.

“Among the Aeler, stone remembers the weight of oaths, and every echo calls a reckoning. But some echoes call from the deep, where the pressure thinks. Do not answer.”

In... An Underway junction, a Geometer halts the party with a tally-rod. “The Spine shifts,” he says, stone-dust in his beard. “Choose a crown or be buried by one. And if you hear a knock in threes, pretend you did not. The pressure is listening tonight.”

Regional Motifs Load-bearing oaths, fault-prayers, crown-rights, catacomb guilds.

Whispers to Offer “Cut a supporting tie,” “Sign for another’s weight,” “Take a shortcut through the sealed tunnel,” “Answer the knock it might be a friend.”

External Clocks Threat: “The Spine Slips”; Fracture: “Maps Reorder”; Community: “Surface Panic”; Deep: “The Pressure Wakes [8]”.

Complications Load-lights dim; echoes reply in politics; crown agents arrive early; a miner goes missing in the deep.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s workshop; a shared refuge tunnel; a relative who works in the deep galleries.

Escalation Beat The tally-rod points to the most guilty PC. Then a knock sounds from the darkness three times.

Relief Shore a vault with sacrifice (1 anchor), or complete a truce between crowns; Spirit + Resolve (5) to hold a cave-in long enough to evacuate. Or offer a memory to the pressure it will accept, but it will remember.

Faction Entanglements

- **Edgewalkers (Prospectors):** If you accept their escort or intel, start a 4-segment *Opportunity* clock you can cash for +1 Effect on one venture. If you refuse a posted hazard, they post *your* route as “open” (first stealth or smuggling roll this leg suffers –1 die). Edgewalkers are the most likely to have heard the pressure’s whisper and survived.
- **True Masons (Infrastructure Orders):** Pledge tools or labor to earn a *Mason’s Stamp* (treat as papers to traverse construction zones). Cross a marked barrier without their leave and gain the *Tampered Work* tag—first structural mishap SB against you is free. True Masons are the ones who seal the tunnels that grow warm.
- **Lamplighter Companies:** Donate wick, oil, or time on the Mile to bank a *Lamp Credit*; spend to ignore darkness penalties once on the Under-Road. Skip a service bell and all under-market buys that scene cost +1 clock tick (queues & suspicion). Lamplighters are the first to notice when a light goes out for no reason.
- **Under-Market Assessors:** Submit to measure/weigh and reduce Commerce DV by 1 this scene. Try to pass unassayed goods—on a Miss, lose the load *or* accept a *Caveat Stamp* that poisons your price two markets downstream. Assessors have a sixth sense for false weights; they claim the pressure tells them.
- **Breath Wardens:** Register bodies & flames before sealed work; compliance cancels the first air-hazard SB. Skipping registry adds a *Thin Air* tick to the leg (applies –1 die to the first exertion test in confinement). Breath Wardens are the ones who count every exhalation. They never speak of what they hear in the silence between breaths.

Cross-Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Agrarian Reliance (Human Breadbelts):** Grain, timber, tallow, and fleece convoys from Acasia/Vhasia/Viterra sustain vault populations. Famine or levy spikes uprange impose night rationing: Under-Road checks +1 DV and food trades add +1 SB pressure until relief.
- **Standards Diplomacy:** Aeler *Measure Vault* rods adopted abroad grant +1 die to settle disputes in foreign markets; rejecting Aeler standards increases toll and inspection frequency (first border scene gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB).
- **True Mason Missions Abroad:** Accept a Mason cadre to “stabilize” bridges, ports, or sluices: reduce Travel DV by 1 on that route for the arc, but the route now respects Aeler closure bells (authorities can halt traffic with one writ).
- **Edgewalker Concessions:** Prospect notes traded to frontier lords exchange for wayleaves and salvage rights; cash once for an *Under-Seal Clause (local)* or accept a rival claimant clock that will mature if you delay.
- **Kahfagian Interface (Sea Monopoly):** Aeler export hard-goods via Kahfagian factors; storm seasons or privateer scares add a *Harbor Quarantine* tick to any surface leg feeding those ports (customs DV +1).
- **Aelerem/Aelinnel Fallout:** When *Valewood Weather* is signaled, Aeler works creak; all bell-codes in mixed settlements (Aelerem/Aelinnel) are one step easier to misread (first bell-etiquette scene: add a free “Error/Security” SB unless you consult a local).

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Airworks & Wick (Oil, Char, Filters):** Donate to a vault—bank a *Breath Favor* to cancel the next bad-air complication. Hoard in a shortage and your lot is flagged; all purchases beneath that crown suffer –1 die until you settle a fine or tithe.
- **Stonework & Ironwork (Beams, Keys, Rods):** Selling to foreign keeps spreads Aeler codes: once per arc, treat a foreign gate as if it used Aeler warding (gain +1 die with Key-Sisters/warders there). Counterfeit measure rods trigger a cross-border inquest clock.
- **Foodflows (Grain, Fleece, Tallow):** Move relief trains to clear one *Rationing* tag for a settlement (DV –1 for social checks there). Divert a relief train and gain an *Audit* clock that follows you three markets hence.
- **Cistern-Right & Water Engineering:** Fund a sluice or cistern abroad to gain *Water Priority* (skip one queue during drought). Neglect maintenance and the keeper may invoke *Aeler Liability*—pay or lose access to the route for a season.

Patron Networks (Below and Beyond)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Consecrated door-nails from True Mason kits act as single-use *stay* writs (negate one forced entry this scene).
- **The Traveler:** Spine milestones double as wayshrines; leave a brass chit to reroll one failed travel test on that segment this arc.
- **Inquisitor Prime:** Breath-pure censers sanction “clean rooms”; once per delve, dispel one ambient miasma or ward-rot effect at cost of +1 Obligation to local abbey-knights.
- **Maelstraeus:** Under-Market stalls tithe to the Great Ledger; cash a *Market Dominance* tick to flip one price band in your favor for a scene, then mark a 4-segment *Karmic Weight* with assessors.

Survival-Horror Procedures (Use Often)

- **Headcount & Flamecount:** At scene start in confinement, ask “Who breathes, what burns?” If headcount+flamecount exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start a 4-segment *Stale Air* clock.
- **Two Bells to Safety:** Any time the fiction stalls underground, ring two nearby bells (authority vs. sanctum). PCs must pick one to heed; ignoring both increases the next hazard’s Cap by +1 (stone holds grudges).
- **Measure or Mistrust:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB this scene; failing to present one imposes –1 die on haggling or passage until appeased.
- **The Knock in Threes:** If a character hears three knocks from the darkness, they must test Resolve (DV 3) or be compelled to walk toward the sound. The knock may be the pressure or it may be a lost miner. The difference is not always clear.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Breath Favor (minor resource):** Earned by donating wick/oil or assisting air wardens. Spend to downgrade one underground hazard outcome or to bypass a lamplighter queue.
- **Stamps & Seals:**

- *Mason-Marked*: Doors to worksites open; smugglers avoid you (harder to buy contraband, easier to cross safely).
- *Edge-Trusted*: Prospectors share fresh maps—first detour per leg is free; officials eye you as opportunists (first civic audience DV +1).
- *Assessor-Clean*: Under-markets honor your assay; rivals spread rumors—add a trailing *Audit* clock if you score a windfall.

Boss Archetypes in Aeler

Systemic / Economic / Conspiracy

- **Under-Market Syndic (Cartel/Measure Fraud)**: Price-fixes breath, wick, and water; wields corrupt assay marks to starve rivals. *Win by exposing forged measures or seizing the Assay Chain.*
- **True Mason Provost (Infrastructure Coup)**: Locks cities behind “safety closures,” weaponizes detours and permits. *Win by forcing a public bell-code audit or breaking the Permit Clock.*
- **Edgewalker Concessionaire (Route Monopolist)**: Controls salvage and short-cuts, posts hazards to strangle traffic. *Win by proving route tampering or opening a sanctioned bypass.*
- **Bell-Code Inquisitor (Silent Coup)**: Rewrites chimes to shift jurisdiction; arrests arrive as echoes. *Win by restoring canonical bell charts or capturing the Chime Key.*

Survival Horror (Environment as Boss)

- **White Flood (Water/Pressure)**: Thaw-swollen river through the halls; phases at *trickle* → *surge* → *roar*. *Win by sluicework, sacrificial breach, or riding the flood.*
- **Bad Air (Miasma/Invisible)**: Candles gutter blue; thoughts slow; corridors choose the slowest. *Win by air discipline, filter rites, or opening a lung-shaft.*
- **Hungry Stone (Creep/Collapse)**: Settling cracks hunt noise and heat; shudders on every miss. *Win by shoring, silence, and rerouting stress through old ribs.*
- **Lamp Famine (Darkness/Isolation)**: Wicks fail in sequence; last lights lure you deeper. *Win by restoring the Lamplighter’s Mile or kindling a saint-wick.*

Undead / Fallen Kingdom / Eldritch / Demonic

- **Crown-Lich of the Crypt (Undead Sovereign)**: Keeps ancient offices; binds petitioners with oaths to the dead. *Win by repealing a mortmain writ or severing the Oath-Chain.*
- **Echo-King in the Deep (Eldritch Memory)**: A throne of voices; answers every argument you will ever make. *Win by changing the Measure (new precedent) or striking the Silent Note.*
- **Seal-Devil (Demonic Contract)**: Lives in locks and signatures; eats exceptions. *Win by offering a flawless counter-seal or starving it of loopholes.*
- **The Hollow Architect (Fallen Works)**: A ghost-guilder rebuilding the empire wrong on purpose. *Win by unkeying the master plan or collapsing the false load paths.*
- **The Deep Drake (The Pressure That Thinks)**: Not a boss to be fought, but a presence to be negotiated with or escaped. *Phases: Whisper* → *Knock* → *Invitation* → *Collection*. *Cracks: offer a memory of sunlight, speak a true regret, or allow a willing sacrifice to walk into the deep in your place.*

Boss Mechanics Notes

- **Air & Light Tracks:** In confined scenes, track *Headcount*, *Flamecount*. If *Headcount* + *Flamecount* exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start **Stale Air** [4]. Each tick imposes –1 die to exertion until vented.
- **Jurisdiction Clocks:** Many bosses run a **Bell-Code Conflict** [4] or **Seal Dispute** [6]. On fill, the boss gains *Authority Surge*: increase their social DV by +1 and seize initiative once.
- **Lair Actions (choose 2–3):**
 - *Collapse Probe*: Mark “Settling Crack”; nearest noisy PC tests PROWESS or risk *Pin/Separate*.
 - *Breath Tax*: Reduce *Flamecount* by 1; next exertion in zone costs Fatigue 1 on a miss.
 - *Blackout/Glare*: Snuff or flare lamps; impose Disorient (–1 die) until a *Lamplighter Action* restores balance.
 - *Bell Override*: Swap which faction’s law applies; social actions vs. boss gain +1 DV this round.
 - *White Flood Surge*: Advance environment clock; force MOVE/WRECK or be *Separated*.
 - *Pressure’s Knock (Deep Drake only)*: A character hears three knocks. They must test Resolve (DV 4) or be compelled to move one range band toward the sound.
- **Phase Triggers:** Environment bosses phase when *Air* hits 2/4, *Water* hits 3/6, or *Light* hits 0; Conspiracy bosses phase when *Audit* or *Permit* clocks fill.
- **Truth & Measure:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB each phase; forging one gives the boss 1 SB and a free *Expose Fraud* reaction.
- **Crowd Pressure:** In under-markets, add **Panic Crowd** [4]; each tick adds +1 DV to precise actions (shoot, pick, ritual) unless calmed with bell-code or coin.
- **Fear Hooks (optional):** *Bad Air* inflicts FEAR vs. suffocation; *Echo-King* inflicts FEAR vs. isolation; *Seal-Devil* inflicts FEAR vs. helplessness; *Pressure’s Knock* inflicts FEAR vs. the unknown. On Fail: mark *Shaken*; on Critical Fail: drop a resource (*lamp, key, breath*).

Chapter 8

The Mistlands

Bells, Salt, and Breath.

The bells here do more than mark time they weave the very fabric of reality, keeping the mist at bay and the dead in their proper places. Each chime is a thread in the pattern that holds the world together.

I am a Bell-Warden. I refuse to write down the ninth note. It lives only in my memory and that memory is fading.

The Mistlands are a protectorate of the Aeler in name only. The fog here doesn't just hide the land; it hides the law, and oh, how the wraiths love that ambiguity. The bell-lines aren't just defence they're the only thing keeping the wraiths from dragging whole villages into the mist. The Aeler built them. The Aeler charge for them. The Aeler will leave when the money runs out. And when that happens, the fog will remember every single soul they abandoned.

Never answer a voice that calls your name from the fog. The mist collects names, and once it has yours, the ferryman will always know where to find you. I've seen men answer. I've watched them walk into the white, still talking, still smiling, until their voices came back from a direction they hadn't gone.

Warden Kael, who has seen the ninth bell rung once and will not speak of it

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish and sour bread the fish is smoked over peat fires, the bread is leavened with fog-damp yeast. The yeast is caught in cloth traps hung from the bell-towers. The traps are emptied at dawn. The yeast is not alive. It is not dead either.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To ring a bell. Every Mistlands child is given a small bronze bell at birth. By age three, they can ring the eight notes of the ward-chime in their sleep. The ninth note is never taught. The ninth note is discovered.

Discovery is fatal.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their salt-pouch. Every Mistlander carries a leather pouch of consecrated salt. A stranger without a pouch is either a fool or a wraith. A stranger whose pouch is empty is a fool who is about to become a wraith.

What is the most common crime? Ward-salt theft. The Aeler control the salt pans, and the salt is the only thing that keeps the dead from rising. A stolen pouch can buy a week's protection. The price is a year's debt to the Aeler. The debt is collected in labour. The labour is collecting salt. The salt is stolen. The cycle is perpetual.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Bell-Wardens are not chosen they are volunteered. A village that loses a warden must send a replacement to the Aeler training holds. The holds are in the mountains. The mountains are cold. The trainees do not always return. The ones who do return do not speak of what they learned. Their bells ring at a different pitch.

Where do people go when they die? To the fog. Bodies are not buried in the Mistland the ground rejects them. Corpses are carried to the edge of the bell-line and left for the mist. The mist takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking the lanes. They do not speak. They do not need to. Their presence is a question.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You ring the Bell of Atonement a cracked bronze bell that hangs in every village square. The bell rings once for each wrong confessed. If the bell rings true, you are forgiven. If it cracks further, you are not. If it shatters, you are banished to the fog. The banished never return. Their voices still answer from the white.

What is the most important festival? The Rehangings of the Lines (autumn). Every bell-line is taken down, cleaned, and rehung. The work takes three days. The villages are silent for three nights. The dead listen. The dead wait. The dead do not ring.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Legate of the Mists is a wraith. She died in 803 AR, during a bell-line failure. The Aeler rebuilt her from fog and memory. She does not know she is dead. She attends council meetings. She signs documents. Her signature fades after sunset. The documents are refiled every morning.

8.1 Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The mist counts your breaths. The bells remember your name.*

Legate of Mists (Elite): “The bells here do more than mark time—they weave the very fabric of reality, keeping the mist at bay and the dead in their proper places. Each chime is a thread in the pattern that holds the world together. The Aeler gave us bells. The fog taught us to ring them.”

Salt-Monk (Commoner): “Salt don’t just preserve the fish—it holds back the things that shouldn’t walk. Every grain blessed is a prayer, and every prayer keeps the mist from remembering your name. The Aeler tax our salt. We pay in silence.”

Genre / Mood: Folk horror, coastal gothic, supernatural debtcollection.

Starting Location: A BellLine levee veiled in fog, where bellropes sway though no wind stirs, and each ring tastes like a heartbeat. A Ferryman demands a name as toll. When the party hesitates, a BellWarden steps forward. “The Ninth Bell rings tonight. Will you answer—or flee? The Aeler won’t save you. The fog doesn’t care. Only the bells keep the line.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Mistlands lie north of the Aelerian mountains, where the Aberderrin Sea laps against reedfens and drowned shores. To the west, the Direwood breathes; to the east, the salt tides of the Aberderrin. It is a Protectorate of the Aeler, but their iron passes only hold the southern roads—the land itself belongs to fog and bells. Every levee hums with wardnotes, every ferry takes salt as tithe, and every shadow is measured against the Direwood’s endless breath. The people here live by the weight of salt, the echo of bells, and the hope that their names will not be spoken by the mists.

The Aeler Protectorate maintains order with ledgers, patrols, and breathbonds, but the real law is older: salt lines drawn at dusk, iron nails hammered into threshold posts, and the unspoken knowledge that the ninth bell must never ring. The Mistlands do not forgive forgetfulness. The mist has a long memory, and it shares its grudges freely.

What you notice first: The constant, distant chime of bells—never quite in sync. The taste of salt on your lips even inland. The way everyone holds their breath when crossing a bridge. The silence when a bell fails to ring.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a voice that calls your name from the fog. The mist collects names, and once it has yours, the ferryman will always know where to find you.

Regional Mood: Bells and Breath

Here, breath is currency and silence a sin. Every exhalation is counted by the wardbells, and every stolen inhalation feeds something that should not be. The Aeler Protectorate maintains order with ledgers and patrols, but the real law is older: salt lines drawn at dusk, iron nails hammered into threshold posts, and the unspoken knowledge that the ninth bell must never ring. The Mistlands do not forgive forgetfulness. The mist has a long memory, and it shares its grudges freely.

The tension between the Aeler governor (Legate Halvar) and the local bellwardens is constant. The Aeler want standardized bellcodes, efficient salt taxes, and compliant villages. The wardens want the old ways: counting in eights, never the ninth, and the right to refuse a name to the fog. Payden's Port, the only true city, is a battleground of ledgers and lanterns. Grain ships leave each autumn, carrying the Protectorate's tithe east and returning with iron, engineers, and the occasional missionary who rarely stay.

Prominent NPCs of the Mistlands

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Legate Halvar	Aeler governor of the Protectorate	Keep the belllines intact and the grain flowing east	She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.
Mother Anja	SaltMonk of the White Pans	Preserve the old wards against the Direwood	Her tongue is white with salt; she speaks only in blessings or silence.
Warden Kael	BellWarden of the High Line	Protect his village from the mist and the Aeler taxmen	He refuses to write down the ninth note; it lives only in his fading memory.
Sister Darya	Healer of the Grey Hospice of the Unnamed (Temple of Light)	Tend the fogsick and the drowned	Her grey robes never stain, and she asks no payment only a name for her tally.
Notary Voss	Covenant judge (Mykkiel)	Impose Aeler law on local customs	He carries a waterclock to measure the shifting of legal moods. The mist ignores it.

The Ferryman	Oathferryman of the Ghost Slip	Collect fares in salt and whispered names	His left hand is always gloved; underneath, the names are carved into his palm.
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Names of the Mistlands

Inspired by the coastal fens and the Aeler protectorate: clipped, breathy, with soft vowels and hard endings. Surnames often denote a marsh, a craft, or a ward.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Halvar	Anja	Foss	<i>the BellSworn</i>
Kael	Darya	Mork	<i>FogBorn</i>
Voss	Pia	Saltvedt	<i>the Unnamed</i>
Torben	Lise	Kyst	<i>BreathThief</i>
Stian	Ragna	Dyrep	<i>WardKeeper</i>
Vidar	Signe	Tangen	<i>AshFinger</i>

(Fen/Levee/Bellline) Reedfen causey with chalked wardrunes on every milestone; BellLine levee with iron posts and eight bells per span.

Spades — Places

2. **Reed-Fen Causey** — Chalked wardrunes on every milestone; safe path through the mist. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Step only on the chalked stones. The mud between has no bottom.*
3. **Bell-Line Levee** — Iron posts, eight bells per span; one bracket empty, one note forbidden. ‘[WARD]’ *The empty bracket is for the bell that never rings. The rope is still there.*
4. **Ghost-Ferry Slip** — Rope crosses black water; fares paid in salt and whispered names. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The ferryman never blinks. Some say he traded his eyelids for the right to collect.*
5. **Pall Watch-Tower** — Piles above mire; mirrors face west to the Direwood’s breath. ‘[WARD]’ *The mirrors are silvered on both sides. The wardens watch their own reflections as much as the trees.*
6. **Mist-Chapel** — Stilted planks; votive lanterns gutter under damp rafters. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The icon has no face. Worshippers say it lost its features to the fog, one by one.*
7. **Dead-Cut Canal** — Old imperial ditch; patrolled by eel boats and law. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The eels have eyes like men. Fishermen throw back any that blink.*
8. **Drowned Copse** — Roottangles clutch tide like old hands; bones in the bark. ‘[DEATH]’ *The trees were planted on a mass grave. They grew twisted, hungry.*
9. **Fogmill Ridge** — Wind vanes vanish into cloud; gears hiss like prayers to fog. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The miller grinds salt, not grain. His customers pay in breath, not coin.*

10. **Salt-Pan Terraces** — Patched with peat; wardsalt dries under nets, watched by monks. ‘[RESOURCE]’ *The monks chant without ceasing. If they stop, the salt spoils and so does the warding.*
- J **Fort-Stair** — Stacked timber and stone; flags swallowed by mist, guards by routine. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The flags are changed daily. The ones that vanish are never spoken of again.*
- Q **Witchlight Bridge** — Over black runnel; ninth plank “counted” but unseen. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ *The missing plank is there you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t step at all.*
- K **High-Mist Pass** — Through Aelerians; cairns ringed in iron nails, bells in the stones. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Each cairn holds a bell that rang once at the death of a warden. They ring again when mist takes another.*
- A **Weeping Gate** — Western palisade facing Direwood; bells wired to bones of trees. ‘[WARD]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The gate weeps sap that smells of iron and old grief. Wardens collect it in silver cups.*

(**Warden/Ferryman/Aeler**) Bellwarden whose ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts; oathferryman collecting fares in salt and names.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Reed-Cutter** — Peatblack hands, precise opinion on fog; knows every safe path. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *She cuts reeds in a pattern one snip, two snips, then a pause for the ninth.*
3. **Salt-Monk** — Blesses pans, keeps wardmeasure honest; salt as both shield and vow. ‘[RITUAL]’ *His tongue is white with salt. He speaks only in blessings or silence.*
4. **Bell-Warden** — Ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts at bay. ‘[WARD]’ *She refuses to write down the ninth note. It lives only in her memory and that memory is fading.*
5. **Oath-Ferryman** — Fares in salt and names; remembers both, collects both. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *His left hand is always gloved. Underneath, the names are carved into his palm.*
6. **Lantern Acolyte** — Trims wicks and arguments; light as law in the mist. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *He carries a bell on his belt. It rings once for each lie he hears.*
7. **Mist-Pilot** — Linn refugee; ghosts ships through reedlace if paid in breath. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *She never speaks above a whisper. Her voice is currency, and she spends it carefully.*
8. **Protectorate Clerk** — Aeler oilskin ledgers, narrow smile; law in triplicate. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *His stamp is a bell. He presses it twice once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
9. **Shroud-Diver** — Harvests tokens from drowned fields before dawn’s false light. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *He wears a bell around his ankle. If it rings, he’s stayed too long.*
10. **Direwood Refugee** — Cold breath, colder stories; knows what the trees whisper. ‘[FEAR]’ *She carved out her own tongue. The trees still speak through her in a voice not her own.*
- J **Fog-Knight** — Cavalry rides levee crowns by bellcode; mist as their steed. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *Their horses have no shadows. Some say they traded them for fogsight.*
- Q **Legate of Mists** — Aeler governor; equal parts mercy and decree, bells at their command. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.*
- K **Lord Warden** — Local strong hand sworn to Legate’s seal; law walks the fens. ‘[AUTHOR-

ITY]‘ *He lost an eye to a wight. He wears a bell in the socket.*

- A **Mist-Seer** — Bargains breath for answers; candles shorten when she speaks. ‘[MAGIC]‘
‘[FEAR]‘ *She has no shadow. The mist took it as a down payment.*

(Undead/Weather/Law) Groundmist lifts off fen and eats tracks by the yard; witchlights try to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets you.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Lifts from fen; eats tracks by the yard, names by the breath. ‘[WEATHER]‘
‘[DEATH]‘ *Your footfalls vanish behind you. The mist is following, not rising.*
 3. **Witchlight Count** — Trying to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets your path.
‘[MAGIC]‘ ‘[FEAR]‘ *The lights flicker in a pattern two short, two long. They’re signaling someone.*
 4. **Ward-Salt Short** — Pans go green; bells ring, nothing answers from the other side. ‘[RE-
SOURCE]‘ ‘[WARD]‘ *The salt is grey, not white. Someone cut it with grave dust.*
 5. **Wrong Bell** — Cracked note opens a door the Legate can’t close; mist takes the gap.
‘[MAGIC]‘ *The bell’s clapper is a finger bone. The original owner wants it back.*
 6. **Linn Raid** — Slips reedmaze; hearths douse, horns travel on the fog. ‘[COMBAT]‘ *The
raiders wear bells on their belts stolen from the last village.*
 7. **Direwood Moan** — At dusk; Weeping Gate ropes go taut by themselves. ‘[DEATH]‘ ‘[FEAR]‘
The moan has words. You don’t want to understand them.
 8. **Valewood Wind** — Crosses Aberderrin; voices sweet, landmarks false. ‘[WEATHER]‘
‘[MAGIC]‘ *The wind smells of honey and rot. Do not follow it.*
 9. **Bell-Line Failure** — Levee breaks silence; wraith steps across like it owns the road. ‘[WARD]‘
‘[DEATH]‘ *The wraith carries a lantern. The light is blue the colour of drowned breath.*
 10. **Marsh-Quake** — Sod heaves, dyke slumps; proofs and bodies sink together. ‘[DISASTER]‘
The ground exhales. Your name rises from it like smoke.
- J **Protectorate Interdiction** — All ferries sealed “until review”; routes dry up. ‘[AUTHOR-
ITY]‘ ‘[TRAVEL]‘ *The seals are stamped with a bell. The wax is mixed with bone ash.*
- Q **Rite-Purge** — Inspectors call local customs heresy; tempers at a boil. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘
‘[SOCIAL]‘ *The inspectors carry blank ledgers. They fill them with names of the accused.*
- K **General Alarm** — Pall horns sound; every lantern becomes law, every shadow suspect.
‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[FEAR]‘ *The horns are made from the tusks of a sea beast. The beast’s ghost is angry.*
- A **Tide-Mist** — Rolls from Aberderrin; spirits ride the white and won’t be named. ‘[WEATHER]‘
‘[DEATH]‘ *The spirits have no faces only the faces of the drowned.*

(Pass/Seal/Token) Wardsalt allotment draws safe circle once; ferry token crosses named black runnel regardless of curfew.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ward-Salt** — Pure measure draws safe circle once; mist parts, briefly. ‘[WARD]’ *The salt is warm. It knows it will be used.*
3. **Ferry Token** — Cross named black runnel regardless of curfew or tide. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a knuckle bone. The ferryman accepts it without comment.*
4. **Bell-Key** — Unlock and set one bell on the Line to your note; change the song. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The key is a tuning fork. Strike it once to claim your note.*
5. **Lantern Writ** — Lawful travel at night along levee crown with escort. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is written on dried bladder. It crinkles when you lie.*
6. **Exorcist’s Seal** — Stamped clause downgrades “haunt” to “nuisance.” ‘[MAGIC]’ *The seal is a bell without a clapper. It’s silent, like the wraiths it binds.*
7. **Codeleaf** — Today’s mirror and horn sequences; fog cannot hide what you know. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The leaf is soaked in brine. Read it before it dries.*
8. **Protectorate Mark** — Priority rations and rope from FortStair stores. ‘[RESOURCE]’ *The mark is a brand. It smokes when you show it.*
9. **Wraith-Indemnity** — Legal immunity for actions taken under apparition threat. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The indemnity is signed in salt water. It will dissolve if you misuse it.*
10. **Bone-Field License** — Salvage rights at drowned hamlet (with witnesses). ‘[RESOURCE]’ *The license is a map drawn on a shroud. Follow the stitch marks.*
- J **Refuge-Right** — Move a named household through Gate unchallenged; breath as passport. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The right is a bellrope. Tie it to your belt. Nonna will ask.*
- Q **Legate’s Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; bells ring your decree. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Legate’s ear is a silver bell. Speak into it once.*
- K **Warden’s Commission** — Raise levee guards; local doors open, purses too. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the fens answer.*
- A **Pall Indulgence** — Temporary exception to ward law, spoken and sealed by bell. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The indulgence is a single bellnote, held in a jar. Break the jar to release it.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (25 4, 610 6, J/Q/K 8, A 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/seals/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **breath and boundary** bells answering across water, salt that won’t dry, voices returning late.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Breath-Toll:** Many claim the mist remembers every breath. Travelers hold breath crossing bridges, fearing the mist will count them wrong. Mechanically, when you cross a threshold without a wardsalt or bell, roll Spirit + Resolve (DV 3). On a failure, the mist learns your name gain the **MARKED** condition (the next spirit encounter starts at Desperate Position).

- **Salt as Promise:** A handful of salt is more than warding—it is a vow. Spill it on plank or stone to swear safety. Once per session, a character may spend a handful of wardsalt to create a **Salt Oath** [4] clock. While the clock has segments, the oath-taker gains +1 die to resist fear or possession. If the oath is broken, the clock fills and the breaker takes Harm 1 (spiritual backlash).
- **The Ninth Bell:** Legends say a ninth bell once rang on the Line. The note is not in any ringbook; no warden speaks of it. Some nights, though, it rings—and gates open where none should be. When the GM spends 3+ SB in a scene, they may declare that the Ninth Bell rings. All characters must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or lose 1 Fatigue (the sound steals breath).
- **Payden’s Port:** The only true city in the Mistlands, huddled on the western coast of the Aberderrin. Its wharves are built from salvaged longship timber, and its law is split between the Aeler Legate’s seal and the old bellwardens’ traditions. Grain ships leave from its harbour each autumn, carrying the Protectorate’s tithe east—and returning with iron, engineers, and the occasional missionary. The port’s inn, the *Drowned Rat*, has a bell that rings once for every sailor lost at sea. It rings often.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Bell-Keeper** The Sealed Gate. *A bell that never rings, yet holds the threshold closed.*
 - **The Salted One** Oath of Mercy and Grace. *A prayer that preserves body and soul, but demands a name in return.*
 - **The Mist-Father** Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the fog; the hunger that waits in still air.*
 - **The Lantern Bearer** The Traveler. *The light that guides lost ships—and lost souls.*

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **Saint Kael of the Iron Bell (The Sealed Gate):** The bellwardens venerate a legendary warden who hammered a ninth bell into the Weeping Gate to seal a Direwood breach. The bell cracked, but the breach closed. His chisel is kept at Payden’s Port; it is said to quench the mist for an hour if struck against an iron post. The Aeler Protectorate has tried to confiscate it twice; both attempts ended with the confiscators lost in fog.
- **Saint Anja of the White Pans (Oath of Mercy and Grace):** A saltmonk who died blessing the pans during a tidemist. Her body never decayed, and her chapel now serves as a hospice for fogsick sailors. The Temple of Light sends offerings of fresh water each spring; the Everflame considers her a heretic. Pilgrims who pray at her shrine may ask one question of a drowned ancestor—but the answer is always a single word, and that word is a tithe.
- **The Grey Hospice of the Unnamed:** Sister Darya runs a hospice near Payden’s Port. She asks no payment, but she records every patient’s name in a tally that never dries. The Aeler clerks suspect she is erasing records, not healing wounds. She has been investigated three times; each time, the investigator vanished into the fog and returned with no memory of why they came.
- **The Bellringer’s Covenant (The Keeper of the Silent Seal):** Notary Voss is the Protectorate’s appointed judge, charged with imposing Aeler law on local customs. He carries a waterclock to measure the shifting of legal moods, but the mist ignores it. His rulings are always delivered in triplicate, and the bellwardens obey them—slowly. Those who lie before him find that their next passage through the GhostFerry Slip is denied; the ferryman refuses

to name them.

- **The Ninth:** In any Mistlands scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the mist's attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count. Those who speak ninth are said to see a pale figure standing at the foot of the bed that night waiting to collect a breath.
- **The Black Barrow Keep (Aelinnel Ruin):** Looming over Payden's Port, this ancient workshop of bellautomata and wardforges is sealed by the Protectorate but smugglers and treasurehunters still enter. Locals whisper that the lowest catacombs connect to the Ways Between. The Aeler have tried to collapse the upper levels three times; each time, the rubble was found cleared by morning, with no tracks in the fog.

Mistlands Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Fog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a bridge. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Hold the Ninth Breath:** Cross a threshold while holding your breath. Cancel *Witchlight Count* or take 1 die on your next action (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect against undead for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Legate. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fog-knights**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **spirits or patrol boats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Protectorate forces or local warden becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift or bell failure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A wraith, raiding party, or inspector arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fog-knights, spirits, or Aeler forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes **bell-line fails/ward broken/mist claims name**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Legate, Lord Warden, or Mist-Seer** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically **mist thickens/bells ring/forest breathes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Mistlands (Bells & Breath):** Bells ring without cause, breath forms visible words, mirrors reflect wrong faces.
- **Mistlands (Salt & Warding):** Salt refuses to dry, ward-runes bleed colour, protection tokens crack.
- **Mistlands (Direwood Threat):** Trees whisper your name, roots shift position, forest breath grows stronger.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Silence the Bell (Presence + Stealth):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a wardsalt pouch is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Tide (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Tide-Mist*, you pick who keeps their bearings; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Bell & Breath)

- **The Ninth Bell Ringer (Direwood herald)** *Phases:* Lost Names → Broken Lines → Open Gate. *Cracks:* restore a ringbook; trade a breath; rehang a forbidden bell with copper nails.
- **Queen of Counting Lights (fae arbiter)** *Phases:* Courteous Tithes → Geas-Market → Tally of Leaves. *Cracks:* return stolen waymarks; speak said and meant; gild the iron.
- **Reed-Wolf Captain (Linn raider)** *Phases:* Smoke Signals → Night Oars → Thing Verdict. *Cracks:* name a feudtoken; win a skaldduel; force harbourtruce under bell and banner.

Patronage & Power

In the Mistlands, power flows through ritual, warding, and the careful balance between the living and the dead. The Aeler Protectorate maintains nominal control through military presence and legal frameworks, but true authority lies with those who understand the bells, the salt, and the breath of the land itself. Local wardens, saltmonks, and bellkeepers hold sway over daily life, while the Legate of the Mists mediates between imperial law and ancient custom.

For the GM: Patronage in the Mistlands revolves around protection from mist, from spirits, from the encroaching forest. Rewards often take the form of tokens, seals, or safe passage

that can be leveraged into greater security. To emphasise the folkhorror feel:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (salt, bells, lanterns) that can be challenged, depleted, or voided by the mist itself.
- Let rival factions (Protectorate vs. bellwardens vs. Direwood refugees) issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more.
- Use the levees, ferries, and watchtowers as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of the old ways (counting breaths, naming spirits, offering salt) determines success.

In the Mistlands, your safety is your standing, and your standing depends on who remembers your name.

Black Barrow Keep The Ruin Above Payden's Port

Looming over the eastern edge of Payden's Port, Black Barrow Keep is a jagged wound in the skyline. Its basalt walls weep salt, and its broken towers lean into the fog like old men listening for a bell that never rings. The Aelinnel built it in a forgotten agenot as a fortress, but as a *workshop*. Here, they forged bellautomata, copper sentinels, and the first wardlines that still keep the Direwood at bay. When the Mistlands became a Protectorate, the Aelinnel sealed the deep forges and retreated. The locals say the keep is haunted. The truth is worse: it is not haunted it is *occupied*.

Below the keep, the catacombs stretch down through nine known levels. Each level was sealed by a different generation of wrights: Aeler engineers, Aelinnel bellsmiths, Linn shipwrights, and older crafts whose names are scrubbed from the records. The lowest level is said to contain a working that has been ticking since before the Hollow learned to count.

Accessing the Keep: The main gate is chained with a bellock that requires a copper key and the correct sequence of rings (eight, never nine). Side entrances include a collapsed ropeway from the salt pans, a flooded stair from the GhostFerry Slip, and a smugglers' tunnel that exits near the Grey Hospice. The Protectorate has officially sealed the keep, but wardens look the other way for a share of salvage or a story about what moves in the deep.

Generator Black Barrow Keep: Rooms & Encounters

d12	Area / Encounter
1	The Hanging BellGarden. A collapsed floor reveals a chamber where bells grow from the ceiling like stalactites. Each bell has a clapper shaped like a finger bone. <i>Effect: A bell that rings once for each secret spoken beneath it. The ringing can be heard throughout the keep.</i>
2	The Copper Forge. Still warm, though the fire went out centuries ago. A halfcompleted automaton sits on the anvil. Its brass skull is hinged open; inside, a nest of salteels writhes. <i>Effect: The forge can be reactivated with a bellkey, producing a single wardsalt token per scene.</i>

3	The Oubliette of the Unnamed. A pit lined with counting marks eight scratches, a gap, eight scratches. At the bottom, a wrights skeleton still holds a hammer. The hammer rings when you touch it. <i>Effect: The hammer can drive a copper nail into any surface, sealing a threshold for one scene.</i>
4	The Echo Scriptorium. Shelves of slate tablets, each inscribed with a single number. The numbers are not in sequence. A ghost wright sits at a desk, writing the same number over and over. <i>Effect: The ghost will answer one question about the keeps history, but will then ask for a number you have never written.</i>
5	The Drowned Armoury. Sealed by a slow leak from the salt pans. Weapons float in brine. One of them a bellhilted sword hums when you near it. <i>Effect: The sword counts your heartbeats. If you draw it in combat, you gain+1 die, but the sword will demand a name at the end of the scene.</i>
6	The Weeping Cistern. A stone basin filled with black water. The water rises when you speak. A voice from below asks, What is the ninth number? <i>Effect: Answer with silence, and the water recedes, revealing a sealed door. Answer incorrectly, and the cistern floods the room.</i>
7	The Cogwheel Choir. A chamber of interlocking copper gears, each tooth stamped with a rune. When the wind blows through the broken wall, the gears turn and the runes sing a cracked hymn. <i>Effect: A character who learns the tune may reroll one failed navigation test while in the Mistlands (once).</i>
8	The SaltLiches Studio. A wright who refused to die. Its flesh is replaced by saltcured leather and copper wire. It still tries to finish a bell that has no clapper. <i>Effect: The saltliche is not hostile, but will trade a bellkey for a memory of fresh water.</i>
9	The Unstable Lift. A chainhoist that descends into darkness. The chains are warm. The lift stops at every eighth floor, never the ninth. <i>Effect: Riding the lift skips two levels of the catacombs, but ticks the FOG ATTENTION clock by1.</i>
10	The Bone Gallery. A corridor lined with the remains of wrights from every generation. Each skeleton wears a different style of bellmakers apron. The newest apron is still damp. <i>Effect: A PC may spend a scene searching; on a Wits+Lore roll (DV4), they find a key, a token, or a warning.</i>
11	The Ticking Heart. A sealed chamber behind a copper door. Something inside ticks at a steady rhythm. The rhythm changes when you lie. <i>Effect: The door requires a blood offering and a true confession to open. Inside is a working that can reset one broken bellline but it will ask for a year of your life.</i>

- | | |
|----|---|
| 12 | <p>The Ninth Gate. A door that appears only when the keeps bells have rung eight times in sequence. Beyond it, a spiral stair descends into absolute silence. No echo returns. <i>Effect: This leads to the lowest catacomb, where the first wrights original bellline generator still turns. Activating it would drive the Direwood back a mile but the noise would wake the Ninth Bell Ringer.</i></p> |
|----|---|

To use: Roll once for the room, then optionally roll again for a resident, hazard, or treasure from the appropriate tables in §8.1, §8.1, or §8.1. For the deeper catacombs, increase the DV of all spiritrelated rolls by1 and add a STALE AIR clock[4] at the start of each scene.

Factions in the Keep

- **The BellWrights Ghosts:** Ancient Aelinnel spirits who still maintain the lower forges. They ignore the living unless the forges are disturbed. Offerings of copper nails or a correctly rung bell will buy safe passage.
- **The Protectorate Salvage Team:** Aeler engineers and a squad of fogknights, ostensibly surveying the keep for hazards. They will confiscate any working bell they find and arrest anyone without a Protectorate writ. Their captain has a brass hand that is also a tuning fork.
- **The Hollows Anticipators:** A cult that believes the keep was built to contain the Hollows attention. They leave offerings of salt and silence. They are not dangerous but they will follow you, writing down every bell you ring and every name you speak.

Catacombs Depth Clock For expeditions that descend below the first sublevel, track a **Depth Clock** [6]. Each time the party descends a stair, uses the unstable lift, or passes a sealed door, tick the clock. At 3 segments: all navigation rolls gain +1 DV (the walls shift). At 6 segments: the party reaches a sealed level that requires a bellkey, a blood offering, or a true name to open. The deepest level (Depth 6 or more) connects to the Ways Between a mistake may drop the party into the Hollows own threshold.

Chapter 9

Ykrul

Wolf Standards, Winter Camps.

The steppe remembers every oath sworn beneath its endless sky, and the wolf-standards carry the honour of clans that have outlasted empires. To lead here is to keep the old ways sharp as winter steel.

I am a Herd-Scout. I can read a trail by the way the grass bends and a lie by the way a rider sits. The Ykrul don't measure wealth in silver; we measure it in hoofbeats, in the snort of a warhorse at dawn, in the weight of a promise kept through winter.

We do not build monuments. We build relationships, each one a stone in an invisible cairn that stretches from the Dolmis to the Aberderrin. A camp is a weave of favours owed and honour satisfied. A feud is a slow equation: blood in, blood out, with interest compounded by winter.

The Khagan's Court doesn't rule from a throne; it rules from a saddle. Our "laws" are the Thirty-Six Sayings of the Road, and the thirty-seventh is the one you learn alone, on a night when the stars blink out and the wolf does not howl.

Never ride between two wolves at dusk. The space between them is a blind angle, a route with no exit, a debt with no payment. The wolves know this. They choose the gap deliberately.

Sogata, Herd-Scout, who has never been lost but has been found many times

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Fermented mare's milk and dried meat. The milk is drunk warm from the skin, the meat is sliced thin and dried on saddle-pommels. The meat carries the taste of horse sweat. The milk carries the taste of the steppe. Both are acquired. Both are necessary.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To sit a horse. Ykrul children are placed on a horse before they can stand. The horse is old, patient, and knows the child's weight. A child who falls is a child who learns to hold tighter. A child who cannot ride is a child who cannot eat.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their braids. Ykrul warriors braid their hair with clan colours: red for the Wolf Clan, black for the Iron Horse, grey for the Salt Steppe. A stranger whose braids are cut has been shamed. A stranger whose braids are dyed black has killed a clan-mate. A stranger with no braids has no clan. A stranger with no clan is prey.

What is the most common crime? Horse theft. A stolen horse is a stolen relative. The price is blood: the thief's or the owner's. The courts are the council fires. The evidence is the horse's memory. Horses remember faces. Horses remember smells. Horses do not lie.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Khagan is not chosen by blood. He is chosen by the horse. Every five years, the clan chiefs lead their best stallions to the sacred ring. The horse that steps forward first chooses the next Khagan. The horse has not stepped forward in twenty years. The council chooses by silence. The silence is growing loud.

Where do people go when they die? To the sky. Ykrul dead are placed on open platforms, wrapped in felt, and left for the wind and the birds. The bones are collected after a year and ground into powder. The powder is mixed with clay and fired into beads. The beads are worn by the dead's descendants. The beads are warm. The warmth is memory.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a hostage: a string of braided cord that ties your wrist to the wronged party's. The cord is cut when the apology is accepted. If the cord is cut before the apology is finished, you are not forgiven. If the cord is never cut, you are bound. The binding is lifelong. The binding is called "friend."

What is the most important festival? The First Grass (spring equinox). The herds are released onto the new pasture. The riders race to the horizon and back. The winner names the summer camps. The loser tends the sick animals. The sick animals are always the loser's. The loser always wins next year.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Sky-Speaker is a fraud. She cannot call storms. She cannot read omens. She cannot speak to the dead. She is a horse-witch who learned to read the clouds. The clouds are reliable. The Khagan does not know. The Khagan does not want to know.

9.1 Ykrul — “Wolf Standards, Winter Camps”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The steppe remembers every oath. The wolf counts your breaths.*

Genre / Mood: Nomadic epic, honourbound geometry, windwhispered law.

Starting Location: A winter camp on the steppe edge, banners snapping in frostbright wind as the Khagan’s fires burn in the east. A Khatun of the Ring offers a clay cup of salted tea. “The Khagan’s kin ride from the salt pan. The old sayings say the straight road is a lie. You came by the bent path the wolf knows you. Speak your errand before the wind changes.”

Khatun of the Ring (Elite): “The steppe remembers every oath sworn beneath its endless sky, and the wolfstandards carry the honour of clans that have outlasted empires. To lead here is to keep the old ways sharp as winter steel.”

Herd-Scout (Commoner): “The horses know the weather before it comes, and the wolves know the thoughts in a man’s heart. Best speak true and ride steady the steppe doesn’t forgive lies or clumsy hands on the reins. An old saying: the straight road is a lie. The wise follow the bent twig.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Ykrul ride the endless Violet Steppe, where the horizon drinks the sky and law lives in saddlebags. Their sacred patterns are called *Kon’reh* not a written code but a living way of reading routes, obligations, and exits. Every crossing has its price, every ford its weight, every feud an angle measured in horse-lengths and heartbeats. Hosts gather by the thousand, then scatter at a word; one night you share their fires, the next they test your bonds. Their banners are wolves’ teeth, their treaties braided cords, their memory longer than the rivers that cut the grass. The old folk still recite the ThirtySix Sayings of the Road, but the wisest know the thirtyseventh is the one you learn alone, on a night when the stars blink out and the wolf does not howl.

What you notice first: The smell of horse sweat and woodsmoke. The way every rider counts hoofbeats under their breath. The silence when a stranger approaches the fire.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ride between two wolves at dusk. The space between them is a blind angle a route with no exit, a weight with no payment.

Regional Mood: The Geometry of the Steppe

Here, the horizon is not a line it is a question. The Ykrul measure distance in oaths, not miles. A camp is a weave of favours owed and honour satisfied. A feud is a slow equation: blood in, blood out, with interest compounded by winter. The Khagan rules not by force alone but by keeping the old patterns the unwritten rules that govern every crossing, every treaty, every duel. Break the pattern, and the steppe itself may turn against you. Keep it, and even enemies will share their salt. The Ykrul build no monuments. They build relationships, each one a stone in an invisible cairn that stretches from the Dolmis to the Aberderrin.

Prominent NPCs of the Ykrul

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Khatun Bortai	Keeper of the Ring	Keep the clans from tearing each other apart	Her hostage strings are braided from the hair of oathbreakers.
Noyan Temur	Bannerlord of the Red Reeds	Win a winter pasture without bloodshed	He has never lost a negotiation. He has never needed to speak.
Sogata	HerdScout (commoner exemplar)	Read the weather before the storm	He can read a trail by the way the grass bends and a lie by the way a rider sits.
Elder Saruul	BoneSinger	Keep the names of the dead	She sings the names of the departed each dawn; the dead sing back.
The Dust Prince	Raider who rides the wind's lee	Amass enough salt to buy a clan	He offers escort braids for secrets, never seen from the front.
StormSinger Urum	SkySpeaker	Sell weather on credit	His bills come due during the Wolf Moon.

Names of the Ykrul

Inspired by the open steppe and the deep east: guttural stops, flowing vowels, and suffixes that mark lineage or deed.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Bortai	Temur	Sogata	<i>the Grey</i>
Urum	Saruul	Khorch	<i>RedString</i>
Khasar	Altan	Noyan	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Mongke	Checheg	Borjigin	<i>StormBorn</i>
Edil	Borte	Uriankhai	<i>AshProw</i>
Toghrul	Orghana	Qasar	<i>the Silent</i>

(**Steppe Road/Winter Ring/Ford**) Wolf Road milepost of stacked stones with wind whining through eyeholes; winter camp ring with felt tents in horseshoe facing wind.

Spades — Places

2. **Wolf Milepost** — Stacked stones; wind whines through eyeholes. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Each stone is a treaty. Remove one, and the wind names you oathbreaker.*
3. **Remount Station** — Low corral with stamped snow and tetherposts. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The tetherposts are carved with the names of dead horses. The living ones remember.*
4. **Birch Windbreak** — Above blackearth tracks; old offerings in the bark. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The offerings are strips of wool. Each strip is a prayer for safe crossing.*
5. **Salt Pan** — Crusted white; hoofprints like stars across the void. ‘[WEIGHT]’ *The pan has a name: “The Khagan’s Mirror.” Look into it, and you see what you owe.*
6. **Reed Ford** — River braids; poles mark yesterday’s safe line. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The poles shift in the night. The river’s path changes with the moon.*
7. **Trading Palisade** — Waypost with wolfskull pennons snapping. ‘[TRADE]’ *The skulls face outward. They watch for liars and bad weights.*
8. **Winter Camp** — Felt tents in a horseshoe facing the wind. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The open end is for guests. The closed end is for the ancestors.*
9. **Kurgan Field** — Low barrows; horsebones bead the grass like prayer beads. ‘[DEATH]’ *The bones were placed by a bonesinger. Each bead is a name.*
10. **Watch Kopje** — Lonely tor with signal firescar; the eye of the steppe. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The firescar is from a signal that saved a host. The smoke still smells of hope.*
- J **Pontoon Crossing** — Laced hides creak; the current speaks fast and hungry. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The hides are from horses that died crossing. Their ghosts still pull.*
- Q **Council Hollow** — Standards planted; the ground tamped like a wardrum. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The standards have ears. Speak a treason here, and every clan will know by dawn.*
- K **Khagan’s Station** — Broad ger on a timber platform; guards in silence. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The guards never blink. They are paid in salt and secrets.*
- A **Sky Steppe** — Open, wind like a voice; tracks keep pace beside you. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The tracks are not yours. They belong to the ancestors who ride with you.*

(**Host/Envoy/Rider**) Herdscout with three ponies and six opinions; campmother who chooses where fires live.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Herd-Scout** — Three ponies and six opinions; the horizon as a map. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *He can read a trail by the way the grass bends. He can read a lie by the way a rider sits.*
3. **Camp-Mother** — Chooses where fires live; hospitality is law. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.*
4. **Banner Youth** — Minding the wolves’ tooth standard; pride as duty. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The standard is older than his grandmother’s grandmother. He will die before it falls.*
5. **Salt-Broker** — Weighs promises like grain; trade as precision. ‘[TRADE]’ *Her scales are honest—except when they aren’t. The difference is a prayer.*

6. **Remount Keeper** — Stringmaster with a book of brands; horses as currency. '[TRAVEL]' *His book is written in hoofprints. He can read a horse's soul.*
7. **Bone-Singer** — Knows the kurgans' proper names; death as memory. '[DEATH]' *She sings the names of the dead each dawn. The dead sing back.*
8. **Road-Judge** — Tümen scribe with seals and a patient ear. '[LAW]' *His seals are from three empires. He uses whichever one is still valid.*
9. **Noyan Envoy** — Silver paiza, iron smile; diplomacy as a blade. '[SOCIAL]' *His paiza was a gift from a Khagan who is now dead. He does not mention that.*
10. **Host Captain** — The tentwall is a map; strategy in every fold. '[COMBAT]' *He can see a battle in the way smoke rises. He is usually right.*
- J **Falcon Courier** — Leather gauntlets, answers sooner than asked. '[TRAVEL]' *The falcon is a sleeper agent. It belongs to a different clan. The courier doesn't know.*
- Q **Khatun of Ring** — Keeper of camplaw and hostage strings. '[LAW]' *Her strings are braided from the hair of hostages. She knows each strand's owner.*
- K **Khagan's Kin** — A nephew or niece sent to bind a foedus with a look. '[SOCIAL]' *They have never lost a negotiation. They have never needed to speak.*
- A **Sky-Speaker** — Shaman of storms; shortcuts owe them a price. '[MAGIC]' *They can call lightning—or call it off. The price is always a story.*

(Law/Weather/Feud) White squall with dry snow, lost horizons; rasputitsa turning the road to porridge; a feud spark from a name spoken wrong.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **White Squall** — Dry snow, lost horizons; navigation by instinct alone. '[WEATHER]' *The snow tastes of iron. Someone is bleeding nearby.*
3. **Rasputitsa** — The road becomes porridge; wheels are lies on the earth. '[WEATHER]' *The mud has a smell—old blood and older lies.*
4. **Remount Sickness** — A cough in the string; swaps get awkward, trust thinner. '[DEATH]' *The cough is a curse. The horses know who cast it.*
5. **Salt Shortage** — Meat spoils; tempers thin like winter air. '[WEIGHT]' *The salt was cut with grave dust. Someone wanted the winter to be hard.*
6. **Hostage Call** — Protocol invoked; someone must sit in the tent. '[SOCIAL]' *The tent has no floor. The hostage can see the earth beneath—and the bones.*
7. **Feud Spark** — A name spoken wrong reopens an old cut; blood remembers. '[WEIGHT]' *The name was spelled correctly. The insult was in the pause before it.*
8. **Grassfire** — Runs with the wind faster than horses; escape as a prayer. '[DISASTER]' *The fire has a face. It is the face of a Khagan who burned a village.*
9. **Foedus Recall** — Treaty terms reread; your papers disagree. '[LAW]' *The treaty was written on both sides. The other side used a different ink.*
10. **River Break** — Ice goes; ferries don't; crossing becomes a gamble. '[TRAVEL]' *The ice is still thick in the middle. The edges are lying.*
- J **Raid Shadow** — Another banner follows at a patient distance. '[COMBAT]' *They are not attacking. They are waiting for you to make a mistake.*

- Q **Kurultai Call** — Camps converge; travel becomes politics. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The kurultai has a list of grievances. Your name is near the top.*
- K **Wolf Muster** — A levy raised; every road a checkpoint, every rider a judge. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The muster horn is a wolf’s skull. It sounds like a scream.*
- A **Sky Omen** — Three suns, or none; routes rewrite themselves. ‘[OMEN]’ *The omen is a wedge of cranes flying north in winter. The sky is wrong.*

(Pass/Remount/Truce) Camp token for one night’s lawful fire and fodder; salt allotment from a named store without quarrel.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Camp Token** — One night’s lawful fire and fodder; hospitality as a right. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The token is a horsehair braid. Burn it to claim your fire.*
 3. **Salt Allotment** — Draw from a named store without quarrel. ‘[TRADE]’ *The allotment is a saltcake. Break it in half to share.*
 4. **Ford-Right** — Cross a named braid at lawful depth. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The right is a pole. Plant it in the river, and the ford will hold—once.*
 5. **Remount Chit** — Swap two tired mounts for fresh. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The chit is a horse’s tooth. The remount keeper will not smile when you present it.*
 6. **Escort Braid** — Two riders see you through a bad stretch. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The braid is woven from the riders’ own hair. They will die before they cut it.*
 7. **Safe-Hostage** — Place or take tokenkin for a truce. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The hostage is a child. The child is patient.*
 8. **Paiza Tablet** — Priority on the Wolf Road and at posts. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The tablet is bronze. It is warm when your reputation is good.*
 9. **Foedus Seal** — A treaty clause that trumps petty order. ‘[LAW]’ *The seal is a wolf’s head. Press it into wax, and the steppe listens.*
 10. **Market-Green** — Trade under a banner; weapons sheathed. ‘[TRADE]’ *The banner is a green field. No blood may be spilled beneath it.*
- J **Standard Guard** — Travel under wolftooth; raiders defer. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The standard is a wolf’s tooth on a pole. Raiders will bow—or die.*
- Q **Ring Audience** — The Khatun hears you alone; precedent sticks. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The audience is held at midnight. The fire is the only witness.*
- K **Khagan’s Writ** — Doors open, mouths close across the steppe. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is a sheet of hammered silver. It bends, but it does not break.*
- A **Sky’s Exception** — Once, the weather ignores you (storm, whiteout, dust). ‘[WEATHER]’ *The exception is a single breath. Use it well.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (25 → 4, 610 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/remounts/truces) that change position rather than call for a roll.

- If any A appears, echo **steppe and sky** motifs wind that speaks, horses that remember, treaties that bind across generations.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Hostage Strings.** Every oath is secured with a **hostage string**—a token kin, retainer, or sworn ally left in the other camp. If the deal is broken, the hostage’s fate becomes the story’s next beat. (Mechanically: create a 4segment *Hostage* clock; on breach, the clock becomes a countdown to vengeance.)
- **Steppe Law.** Travelers are bound by **steppe law**: hospitality lasts three nights, insults last three generations. The Keeper may demand 1 SB when either law is broken.
- **Sky Omens.** When the sky shows strange signs—mocksuns, green fire, thunder without storm—the steppe itself speaks. Once per scene, players may treat an omen as a *Diamond*, shifting Position without a roll. The GM may bank 1 SB for future weather complications.
- **Bowl and Board.** Ykrul elders settle disputes not by shouting but by drawing two circles in the dirt: the **Bowl** for fairness, then the **Board** for routes and concessions. A successful *Wits + Lore* (or a relevant skill) roll creates a *Seasonal Concession String* at a ford, harbor, or pass. On a miss, the **Market Moot** [4] clock advances as factions argue.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Hoof** The Traveler. *The path that never ends, the remount that never tires.*
 - **The Wolf’s Tooth** The Witness. *Every oath is counted. Every broken promise is a scar.*
 - **The Salt Throat** Maelstraeus. *The weight that salts your tongue; the interest that blinds your horses.*
 - **The Sky Father** Kuva. *The wind that carries names; the storm that erases them.*

The ThirtySeven Sayings of the Road (Excerpts)

The Ykrul teach strategy not in manuals but in proverbseach a line of play. A few of the most quoted:

Let the river freeze before you cross. — Do not rush. Let the opponent make the first move; your opening will be built on their impatience.

Borrow a corridor to trap a king. — When the enemy carves a path toward you, let it deepen. Then seal the mouth behind them.

Loot a burning house. — Strike only when the enemy is committed elsewhere.

Hide your dagger behind a smile. — Threaten one flank; strike the other.

The reed bends, the oak breaks. — Yield to overwhelming force, but do not break; preserve your core.

A distant banner casts no shadow. — A threat far away is no threat at all; control the centre.

The guest who outstays his welcome steals the host’s peace. — Allow no force, however small, to remain within your lines uncontrolled.

Count exits, not victims. — Before you move, count the ways your foe can flee. If the number is greater than zero, you have not yet won.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice near the salt pans. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the herders, trying to untie her cord from a Ykrul bloodweight.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The kurgans are Class II Anchor sites—the spirits of old Khagans bound by unfinished wergild. Saikou Ira would carry a bag of salt in each hand here.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the saltbrokers. Take it, and your store never runs dry—but the coin will reappear in the salt pan at every new moon.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ykrul psions are called “WeatherReaders.” They taste the future in the wind. Roadjudges employ two—and have never trusted a verdict they didn’t hear from the sky.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ykrul camp, the ninth cup poured at a feast is for the ancestors. The wise pour eight and leave the ninth as a pause.

Ykrul Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Salt to the Wind:** Toss a pinch into the air before a long ride. Ignore the first *White Squall* penalty.
- **Knot the String:** Tie a single knot in a hostage cord. Cancel *Feud Spark* or take 1 die on your next oath (your choice).
- **Name to the Kurgan:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into a horse’s ear. Gain +1 Effect when raiding their clan this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the BoneSinger.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Unwanted attention from **roadjudges** or **border riders**.
- **Noise:** Sounds alert a **nearby camp** or **raiding party**.
- **Trace:** Hoofprints or broken grass mark your route for **feudkin**.
- **Delay:** A horse throws a shoe, a rope breaks lose time.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on **fodder** or **water** clock.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** A **watch kopje** signals; riders are coming.
- **Position Lost:** **Rasputitsa** or **white squall** hides the trail.
- **Foe Appears:** A **raid shadow** or **hostage taker** arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A saddle snaps, a bowstring frays.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A river breaks, a ford becomes impassable.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** A **wolf muster** or **kurultai** war party arrives.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A horse goes lame, a paiza cracks.
- **Major Twist:** A **grassfire** cuts off retreat, or a **feud spark** escalates.

- **Rail Tick:** Advance a campaign clock (e.g. **Hostage Crisis**).
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Exhausted** or **Marked by Feud**.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A **hidden kurgan** collapses, a **pontoon** sinks.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Khatun of the Ring**, **Khagan's Kin**, or **Sky-Speaker** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** A **sky omen** rewrites the terrain; paths appear or vanish.
- **Patron Omen:** A wolf watches, a horse speaks, the wind carries a name.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The feud is not what it seemed; the hostage was a willing sacrifice.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Steppe Law:** Hospitality fails, insults echo, treaties shift midparley.
- **Horse Culture:** Mounts refuse to move, remount posts are empty, riding rolls suffer 1 die.
- **Sky Omens:** Weather changes instantly, stars point the wrong way, a raven shadows the party.

Extensions (Plugin)

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Ride):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud*.
- **Cut the Herd (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a *remount chit* is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *White Squall*, you pick who keeps their bearings; on a miss, the GM does.

Terrain Stock (d20)

Roll or choose a striking detail to dress a hex of the Violet Steppe.

1. Wolf milepost with fresh red thread; someone retied the law.
2. Reed ford poles lying on bank; current whispers a different depth.
3. Fallen standard tooth used as a chopping block; grooves still warm.
4. Circle of pony skulls facing east; one blinks when the wind shifts.
5. Snow trench with cudgel steps; no prints leave it.
6. Copper salt-scale hung from a birch; pans balance only under oath.
7. Hoof-bells threaded on hair; ringing calls riders or storms.
8. Abandoned paiza shard wedged in a milestone; edges bite skin.
9. Kurgan capstone chalked with a name misspelled; feud waiting.
10. Flint knapper's tarp half-buried; a perfect arrowhead points north.
11. Blue-fletched signal arrow stuck in frost; message in the vane.
12. Camp-sweep marks: three rings last night was a council.
13. Wheel rut frozen like glass; a face looks up from inside.
14. Salt-brined jerky hanging from a tripod; untouched by birds.

15. River ice singing in thirds; ferryman’s pole wedged under.
16. Pony hobble-rope knotted in hostage-string pattern.
17. Cold forge dug into loess; tools wrapped in wolfskin.
18. Child’s braid-bead dropped in snow; still warm to the tongue.
19. Thorn-tether scratched with clan brands; two over-scratched.
20. Bone flute lodged in a cairn; playing it summons a road-judge.

Lair Seeds (OnePage Rides)

1. **Ger of Echoes** Empty felt walls repeat anything uttered in the Khagan’s voice once per night.
2. **Salt-Pit Shrine** Rope winch to brine caverns; offerings are tears and horsehair.
3. **Remount Vault** Subterranean stables under reed mats; mounts won’t leave without a tale.
4. **Kite-Maker’s Bluff** Bone kites pinned on racks; their shadows scout for raiders.
5. **Storm-Rider’s Stone** Pillar that hums to hooves; racing round it sets weather wagers.
6. **Frozen Court** Ice dais in a dry riverbed; law held here counts triple until thaw.
7. **Banner Grave** Flags planted like trees; each knows the battle it died in.
8. **String-Mother’s Yard** Web of hostage cords; cutting one opens a secret but starts a feud.
9. **Fire-Under-Snow** Warm vent where foals winter; spirits ask for salt-song.
10. **Quiet Palisade** Trading post where voices fail; deals done in gesture and cut meat.
11. **Ashen Trident** Three lightning-split birches; tie a braid to choose a road’s luck.
12. **Grey Ger** Moves at night; inside, a camp-mother tests your hospitality the other way around.

Steppe Bestiary (Palette)

- **Steppe Manticores** Lionine torsos, porcupine tails of bone quills. *Signs:* quills in fence-posts; ponies refuse to drink. *Hook:* play a raid-song backward; they circle to listen.
- **Dust Hulks** Wind-packed silhouettes that rise from dunes. *Signs:* dunes “breathe”; grit sifts upward. *Hook:* spill water on their shadow; they settle for a watch.
- **Bone Kites** Carrion birds with rune-etched pinions. *Signs:* spiral flights over kurgans. *Hook:* offer a name-stake (twig with hair) to barter silence.
- **Frost Wargs** Blue-pelt wolves that steam cold. *Signs:* rime on tracks; breath that crackles. *Hook:* warm milk poured on ice buys one unchallenged crossing.
- **Reed Stalkers** Long-necked marsh hunters, gait like stilts. *Signs:* polepocks where no ferryman walks. *Hook:* carry reeds in your mouth; they read it as truce.
- **Salt Screammers** Pale eels in dry pans; voices like flutes. *Signs:* fissures crusted with salt frost. *Hook:* scatter ash; they coil to sing and forget to bite.

Relic & Find (d10)

When you uncover a kurgan cache or a lost hoard, roll or pick:

1. Wolf-tooth standard tip; planted, it demands silence for parley.
2. Bronze paiza half; merchants honour it as full once then talk.
3. Salt-needle that points to the nearest brine store.

4. Frost-bitten stirrup; mount that wears it ignores ice once.
5. Braid-bead of hostage glass; melts when a string is cut nearby.
6. River-depth rod carved with safe counts for three fords.
7. Iron hoof-bell that rings for liars at council.
8. Bone-lot cup; roll it to name which feud clause applies.
9. Wind-wrung scarf; pass it round to share breath in a white squall.
10. Wolf-road tablet scrap; reads as a *Foedus Seal* to one clerk.

Complication Twists (d8)

When a travel complication arises, roll or choose a twist that deepens the story.

1. *White Squall* reveals a remount vault's smoke hole; entering angers reed stalkers.
2. *Rasputitsa* exposes kurgan stones; riding around them starts a name-claim.
3. *Feud Spark* was staged by a salt-broker; paying in *Salt Allotment* unmasks them.
4. *Hostage Call* is for a *Safe-Hostage* you already carry by another name.
5. *Grassfire* runs uphill toward a council hollow; smoke votes before riders do.
6. *Foedus Recall* cites a river you crossed yesterday now it flows the other way.
7. *Raid Shadow* is your own tracks, mirrored by sky omens; choose which you admit.
8. *Kurultai Call* stacks councils; words spoken in one bind you in the other.

Boss Seeds (ThreePhase Foes)

- **The String-Mother (Nine Hostages)** *Phases:* Knot → Tighten → Sever. *Cracks:* return a hostage string, win a Bowl and Board arbitration, cut the right knot.
- **The Dust Prince (Rider of the Red Wind)** *Phases:* Raid Shadow → Salt Tithe → Kurultai Coup. *Cracks:* spill a salt allotment in his path, unmask his face before the council, outride him through a white squall.

Patronage & Power

In Ykrul society, power flows through the careful management of hospitality, the binding of oaths with hostages, and the ability to navigate the complex web of tribal relationships. The Khagan maintains authority through the loyalty of noyans and the respect of khatuns, while local leaders wield influence through their control of resources like salt, remounts, and safe passage. The true power lies with those who understand the ancient customs and can maintain the delicate balance between hospitality and honour.

For the GM: Patronage in Ykrul society revolves around hospitality, hostage exchanges, and the ability to command respect from hosts and courts. Rewards often take the form of tokens, treaties, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the old ways:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, braids, standards) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Use the *Bowl and Board* procedure for disputes—first fairness (Bowl), then routes and concessions (Board), then a seasonal right.

- Let rival hosts issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more.

In Ykrul society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you ride as guest or ghost.

Ykrul of the Eastern Steppe The Iron Grass Clans

The wind is colder here, and so are the hearts. We do not forget an insult because we cannot afford to. The grass is thinner, the wolves are bolder, and the sky speaks only in threats. The western Ykrul trade in stories. We trade in teeth.

Eastern Khatun (Elite): “The westerners count their weights in silk and verses. We count ours in frost and iron. A broken oath here is not a story for the skald it is a hole in the winter larder. We do not forgive because we cannot. The Hollow rides with us every night. We have no room for mercy.”

The Eastern Ykrul share blood with their Violet Steppe cousins, but generations on the harsher eastern ranges where the Kuvani horse clans also roam have carved them into a different shape. They are more isolationist, more pragmatic, and their honour code has less room for poetry. They live among the Kuvani but do not intermarry; they trade when the snows allow, raid when the grass is thin, and speak a dialect that grinds like stones in a riverbed. Outsiders call them the *Iron Grass Clans*. They call themselves *Those Who Remember Winter*.

Eastern Variations (Use with Ykrul Core)

When generating an Eastern Ykrul camp, clan, or encounter, roll on the tables below instead of (or in addition to) the standard Ykrul generators. Use dice rather than cards.

Eastern Clan Trait (d6) Roll to determine a clans defining characteristic.

1. **Frost-Bitten:** The clan survives on the edge of the permafrost. +1 die to Survival in cold weather, but 1 die to all social rolls with lowlanders (they stink of frozen horse).
2. **Kuvani-Kin:** This clan has traded with the Kuvani for generations. They speak the Kuvani tongue and may call on one Kuvani remount station per journey. Rivals whisper they have forgotten the old ways.
3. **Wolf-Pacted:** The clan has a standing truce with a local wolf pack. Wolves do not attack their herds. In exchange, the clan leaves every ninth calf unbranded for the wolves. The pack sometimes fights beside them in battle (Cap 2, appears once per arc).
4. **Salt-Misers:** This clan controls a small, bitter salt pan. They trade salt for iron with the Kuvani. They are wealthy but paranoid; any visitor is assumed to be a spy. +1 die to detect deception, but starting Position in parley is Desperate.
5. **Curse-Bearers:** A broken oath from three generations ago still hangs over the clan. Their horses are prone to sickness, and their children are born with grey eyes. They seek a way to lift the curse and will do almost anything to find it.
6. **Road-Breakers:** This clan claims the right to open or close the high passes east. They carry a brass key (actually a bronze paiza) that Kuvani caravans recognise. They are isolationist, proud, and quick to draw steel over matters of passage.

Eastern Steppe Hazards (d6) When travelling through Eastern Ykrul territory, roll for a hazard (or replace a standard Clubs draw).

1. **Frost-Rime Grass:** The grass is coated in a crystalline frost that cuts horse legs. Travel speed halved for one leg. On a failed Survival roll, one mount goes lame (mark 1 Fatigue or lose 1 Supply).
2. **Wolf Howl at Dusk:** A pack shadows the party for a day and a night. They will not attack unless the party is weak or separated. If a character sleeps alone, roll Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or be found by wolves at midnight.
3. **Ice Lens Mirage:** The flat steppe plays tricks. Navigation rolls suffer 1 die for the leg. On a miss, the party wanders into a kurgan field the dead are restless. Start a **Spirit Attention** [4] clock.
4. **Salt Pan Crack:** A dried salt pan has a hidden fissure. A horse or wagon breaks through. Lose 1 Supply (salt pork ruined) and mark 1 Fatigue for the party as they pull the animal free.
5. **Kuvani Border Markers:** The party has crossed into a Kuvani grazing ground without permission. Kuvani riders appear (Cap 2, nonhostile unless provoked). They demand a story or a small offering of salt. Refusal starts a **Border Dispute** [4] clock.
6. **Silent Sky:** No birds, no wind, no insect sounds. The Hollow is near. For the next scene, any roll that shows a 1 also summons a **Oath-Keeper** it will appear at the end of the scene to ask one question. Answer poorly, and it takes a memory.

Eastern Ykrul Encounter (d8) When meeting an Eastern Ykrul camp or patrol, roll for their initial disposition and a twist.

1. **Hungry Hosts:** The camp is low on supplies. They will trade at ruinous prices. But they will also remember a fair deal. If you overpay (give 1 extra Supply), gain a **String** (Eastern Ykrul favour).
2. **Grieving Clan:** A child died last night. The camp is in mourning. They will not trade or talk. If you offer a story about a lost loved one, they will share a meal. The story must be true.
3. **Feud-Watch:** The clan is on alert for raiders from a rival banner. They mistake the party for scouts. The first social roll is at Desperate Position. A successful Deception or Bribe (cost 1 Boon or 1 Supply) clears the misunderstanding.
4. **Salt-Brokers Caravan:** A small caravan of salt traders, heavily armed. They are willing to trade salt for news of the west. They ask pointed questions about the Violet Steppe they are planning a raid.
5. **Kurgan Pilgrims:** A group of bonesingers and their guards are travelling to a sacred kurgan. They will allow the party to accompany them if the party helps perform a ritual: each member must whisper a forgotten name into a horse skull. Afterwards, the party gains +1 die to resist fear for one day, but the Hollow knows one of your names.
6. **Storm-Singers Challenge:** A skyspeaker challenges the party to a weathercalling contest. Roll Spirit+Lore vs. DV 4. On a success, the storm-singer is impressed and grants a **Skys Exception** (ignore one weather hazard). On a failure, the party is drenched and loses 1 Fatigue.
7. **Hollow-Touched Camp:** The camp is silent. Everyone is sitting still, staring at a single point. A Oath-Keeper has passed through. If the party can speak the name of the broken oath, the camp will wake. Otherwise, they must leave an offering of salt and retreat.

8. **Iron Grass Market:** A rare gathering of three clans at a neutral ford. The market lasts only one day. Goods for sale: remounts (cost 1 Supply each), salt (1 Supply per 2 portions), iron arrowheads (1 Boon for 1 die bonus on next ranged attack), and one cursed paiza (half price, but the previous owners ghost follows).

Eastern Ykrul Customs (d6) When interacting with an Eastern Ykrul camp, roll for a local custom that may affect social rolls.

1. **No Left Hand:** Offering anything with the left hand is an insult. All social rolls using Presence+Sway suffer 1 die unless you explicitly use your right hand.
2. **Fire First, Talk Later:** Guests must warm their hands at the central fire before speaking. If you refuse, the host will be offended the first request you make is automatically refused.
3. **The Empty Saddle:** One saddle in the camp is always empty. It belongs to a rider who died last winter. If you sit in it, you must tell a story about a death you witnessed. If the story is true, the ghost may give you a warning (GM reveals one future hazard). If false, the ghost haunts you for a day (you gain the **Haunted** condition).
4. **No Naming the Dead:** Eastern Ykrul do not speak the names of the deceased for one year after death. If you accidentally name a dead person, the clan demands a blood-price: 1 Supply or a lock of your hair.
5. **Salt Before Meat:** A meal is not blessed until the host throws a pinch of salt into the fire. If you eat before the salt, you are considered an oathbreaker. The meal will not nourish you (you do not recover Fatigue from that rest).
6. **The Ninth Breath:** When drinking fermented mares milk, you must pause after the eighth sip. If you take a ninth, you must immediately name an enemy. The clan will consider that enemy as their own for one season. The enemy may not appreciate this.

Eastern Ykrul Superstitions (burn for +1 die once) Add these to the standard Ykrul superstitions when in the eastern steppe.

- **Iron to the Frost:** Press a cold iron nail into the ground before a white squall. Ignore the first *Frost-Rime Grass* penalty.
- **Braid the Tail:** Tie a single knot in a horses tail hair. Cancel *Wolf Howl at Dusk* or take 1 die on your next survival roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Hollow:** Whisper a dead enemys name into a salt pan at midnight. Gain +1 Effect when evading Oath-Keepers this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Eastern Khatun.

Eastern Ykrul Boss Seed (d6) When the party faces a major antagonist from the Eastern Ykrul, roll for a unique foe.

1. **The Frost-Khagan (Undying):** A chieftain who froze to death but did not stop riding. *Phases:* Blizzards Call → Frozen Host → The Long Night. *Cracks:* burn a horse tooth in a fire, speak his true name (carved on his saddle), or offer a living rider to take his place.
2. **The Salt-Throat (Cursed Broker):** A salt merchant who sold his clans future for wealth. *Phases:* Weigh the Debt → Salt Tithe → The Scales Close. *Cracks:* pay a wergild in untainted salt, expose his false paiza, or cut his hostage string with a silver knife.
3. **The Hollows Rider (Oath-Keeper in Flesh):** A warrior who made a pact with the Hollow to survive a winter famine. *Phases:* Count the Breath → Ride the White → Claim the Ninth.

Cracks: feed him a memory of warmth, show him a red thread tied in eight knots, or outride him to the horizon the Hollow cannot cross moving water.

4. **The Iron Grandmother (Bone-Singer Revenant)**: An ancient bone-singer who refused to die. *Phases*: Song of Names → Kurgan Rising → The Dead Vote. *Cracks*: sing a true name she does not know, return a stolen kurgan stone, or answer her riddle: What weight is never paid?
5. **The Wolf-Banner (Pack-Leader)**: A clan chief who has fused with a wolf spirit. *Phases*: Stalk → Circle → Feast. *Cracks*: break his banner, offer a raw heart to his pack, or survive a night without fire.
6. **The Sky-Weeping Child (Curse Bearer)**: A child born during a white squall, marked by the Hollow. *Phases*: Winter Dreams → Frost-Fever → The Ninth Day. *Cracks*: warm her hands with your own breath, speak her true name (her mother is still alive she will tell you), or find the horse that was born at the same moment it carries the other half of the curse.

Eastern Steppe Names (d8 each) For quick NPC generation, roll or choose:

Male first names (d8): 1. Bortei, 2. Temurjin, 3. Khorchi, 4. Edil, 5. Sogata, 6. Toghrul, 7. Ogedei, 8. Chagatai.

Female first names (d8): 1. Orghana, 2. Borte, 3. Altan, 4. Saruul, 5. Checheg, 6. Nergui, 7. Tolui, 8. Hulan.

Clan epithets (d8): 1. Iron-Heart, 2. Frost-Mane, 3. Salt-Tongue, 4. Wolf-Brood, 5. Hollow-Sight, 6. Curse-Bearer, 7. Red-Hoof, 8. Silent-Banner.

Eastern Ykrul at a Glance

Core Traits: Isolationist, pragmatic, harsher honour code, live among Kuvani but do not intermarry. **Key Resources**: Salt, iron, remounts, wolf truces, kurgan spirits. **Common Conflicts**: Feuds over salt pans, disputes with Kuvani over grazing, Hollow incursions in winter, curselifting quests. **Tone**: Bleaker than western Ykrul. Fewer stories, more teeth. Hospitality is still sacred but the guest is expected to earn it. **Ritual Objects**: Frost-bitten stirrups, bronze paizas, horsetooth chits, saltcakes, wolf skull standards.

Chapter 10

Vilikari

Laurels & Longhouses.

We are the bridge between empire and wilderness, the marriage of law and custom. Our strength lies not in choosing one path but in walking both with equal surety.

I am a Hearth-Mother. I have never lost a quarrel. My voice is soft, my memory longer than the Foedus Stone.

The Vilikari straddle the border like a drunkard on a fencehalf empire, half steppe, all headache. Their foedus treaties aren't just agreements—they're a tragicomic mess, half carved in marble by emperors who forgot to pay the sculptors, half braided in string by chieftains who forgot which knot meant "peace." And yet, somehow, the treaties hold. Not because of the marble. Not because of the string. Because both sides are too exhausted to start the argument over again.

Never invoke only one law. The mallus (oak-ring) and the basilica (marble bench) must both be honoured. Choose one, and the other will find you usually at midnight, usually with a writ, usually with a sword.

Hearth-Mother Vesna, who has fed three kings and forgotten none of their debts

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Oatmeal with dried berries—the berries are harvested from the border scrub, where the empire's orchards meet the steppe's wild brambles. The berries taste of both. The oatmeal tastes of neither. The oatmeal is filler. The berries are the point.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To speak both languages—Imperial

Utaran and the steppe cant. A child who speaks only one is a child who will never cross the border. A child who crosses the border is a child who will come back with stories. A child with stories is a child who will be listened to. Listening is power.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Which side of the road they ride on. The empire's roads are measured from the centre. The steppe's paths are measured from the edge. A stranger who rides in the centre is an imperial. A stranger who rides at the edge is a nomad. A stranger who rides in the ditch is a spy. The ditch is not a road. The ditch is a message.

What is the most common crime? Treaty-splittingselling the same rights to both sides. A Vilikari factor will promise river access to an imperial merchant and grazing rights to a Ykrul clan, then collect from both and disappear before the paperwork collides. The crime is not in the selling. The crime is in getting caught before you cross the border.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Foedus Stone is a copy. The original was stolen in 712 AR by a Vilikari trader who owed debts on both sides. She melted it down and sold the marble dust as "treaty-strengthening powder." The powder was mostly chalk. The treaties are still holding. The traders are still selling.

Where do people go when they die? To the border. The Vilikari bury their dead at the edgeclose enough to the empire for the priests to pray, close enough to the steppe for the shamans to chant. The dead are planted face-up, so they can see both skies. The skies are different colours. The dead do not complain.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You invoke the mallusthe oak-ring court. The wronged party sits inside the ring. The wrongdoer circles it three times, speaking their apology. On the third circuit, the elders judge. If the apology is accepted, the wrongdoer is admitted into the ring. If it is rejected, the ring closes. The wrongdoer is outside. Outside is the lawless land. The lawless land is where the wolves are.

What is the most important festival? The Renewal of the Foedus (summer solstice). The stone is washed with milk and honey. The milk is from a Ykrul mare. The honey is from an imperial apiary. The mixture is drunk by the elders. The elders speak the treaty aloud. The treaty is long. The elders are old. The ceremony takes all day.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Foedus Stone has a crack. The crack was caused by a hammer in 799 AR, during a dispute over horse tariffs. The stone was repaired with clay and prayer. The clay is drying. The prayer is fading. The crack is spreading. When the stone splits, the treaty splits with it. No one knows what happens then. No one wants to find out.

10.1 Vilikari — “Laurels & Longhouses”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Two laws, one people. The oak remembers; the marble writes. The stone is cracking.*

Federate King (Elite): “We are the bridge between empire and wilderness, the marriage of law and custom. Our strength lies not in choosing one path but in walking both with equal surety. But the bridge is rotting, and no one sends hostages anymore. The stone cracks, and the cracks have no witnesses.”

Hearth-Mother (Commoner): “The old ways and new laws both have their place at our table. Serve the right mead to the right guest, honor the proper customs, and you’ll find we’re better hosts than most kings. The trouble is, the guests are forgetting why they came. The stone is forgetting their names.”

Genre / Mood: Early Holy Roman Empire on the steppe legal dualism, hybrid identity, frontier pragmatism, forgotten treaties.

Starting Location: A longhouse quarter tucked into an old forum. Laurel garlands hang from broken columns. Smoke from a dozen hearths curls under cracked marble arches. A HearthMother offers a cup of small beer and a piece of oatcake. “The Foedus Stone cracks,” she says. “The steppe listens. Which law will you speak when the Ykrul envoy arrives oak or marble? The stone has a new crack. No one knows which promise it represents. Speak carefully. The stone is listening too.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Vilikari are not caught between empire and steppe they are *forgotten*. The Foedus Stone, the ancient treaty that guaranteed their autonomy, is *cracking*. Every season, another shard falls. The Ecktorian clerks have stopped renewing the oath; the Ykrul no longer send hostages. The Vilikari are becoming *invisible* to both sides. Their law still holds, but the witnesses are dying. The Elder of Elders speaks once a year, but fewer and fewer listen.

Their halls are longhouses raised over ruined forums; their laws carved on both oak and marble; their loyalties braided like the braids of their warmaidens’ hair. Unlike the Ykrul, who read the geometry of the steppe, the Vilikari read the geometry of *jurisdiction*. They are the bulk of the nonelite population in Ecktoria the legionaries’ descendants who never went home. A Vilikari blacksmith in Ecktoria might swear by the marble bench; his cousin two valleys over in Acasia still ties knots for the oak. This is not contradiction. It is survival. But survival requires witnesses. And the witnesses are fading.

What you notice first: The smell of woodsmoke and old parchment. The way everyone speaks two languages at once switching midsentence. The longhouse roofs that use broken imperial tiles as shingles. The silence where there used to be oaths.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never invoke only one law. The *mallus* (oakring) and the *basilica* (marble bench) must both be honored. Choose one, and the other will find you. But now, neither may answer. The stone has forgotten which law applies so it applies neither.

Regional Mood: Laurels and Longhouses

Here, the past is not a ruin it is a *creditor*. The old Utaran forums still echo with the footsteps of legionaries, but now those columns hold longhouse roofs. The Vilikari do not choose between

empire and tribe; they marry them, awkwardly, imperfectly, and with frequent arguments. Their kings wear both a laurel wreath and a wolftail cloak. Their courts meet twice: once under the oak for bloodprice, once on the marble bench for statute. No verdict is final until both have spoken.

But the witnesses are dying. The Foedus Stone has a crack for every forgotten promise. The newest crack has no date. It appeared last winter. No one knows which promise it represents.

On the coast, Vilikari fishing villages double as smugglers' coves, running fugitives, forbidden goods, and whispered messages. Their boats are fast, their pilots know every reef and patrol route, and their loyalty is to the cargo's survival. They are the last people in the Amaranthine who still remember the old treaty's third clause. They are not sure why it matters. They keep it anyway.

Prominent NPCs of the Vilikari

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Federate King Aldric	RexDux of the Vilikari	Keep the twolaw balance and the Foedus Stone intact	He has three thrones oak, marble, and saddle. He uses whichever is not being argued over. Lately, all three are dusty.
HearthMother Vesna	Keeper of guestright (commoner exemplar)	Protect her village from raiders and tax men alike	She has never lost a quarrel; her voice is soft, her memory longer than the Foedus Stone. But the stone is shrinking.
ShieldBrother Rurik	Comitatus oathbearer	Enforce the mallus code in the marches	His braids are his record; each knot is an oath kept or broken. He has started tying knots in his sleep, hoping the stone will remember.

March Theodora	Notary	Utarantrained legalist	Draft treaties that neither side can break	She writes in three scripts; her left hand writes Latin, her right writes runes. Her third hand writes in ink that no one can read not even her.
Smuggler Drago	Captain	Vilikari fisherman and trafficker	Run contraband and refugees past the Kahfagian patrols	He knows every reef and every lantern shift; the harbormasters cannot catch him. He says the Foedus Stone’s cracks are good for business no one checks the old treaties anymore.
Elder of Elders		Thingcouncil speaker	Preserve the old customs against imperial erosion	He speaks once a year; the rest of the time he listens and re- members. But his memory is cracking like the stone.

Names of the Vilikari

Vilikari names blend Utaran (Latin) roots with steppe influences: hard consonants, fluid vowels, and surnames that recall a ford, a bridge, or a longhouse.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Aldric	Vesna	de la Marche	<i>the Two-Law</i>
Rurik	Theodora	Longwood	<i>the Fox</i>
Drago	Gisela	Kalderash	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
Oswin	Mira	Oakenshield	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Vidar	Svanhild	Tregard	<i>Ash-Prow</i>

Kael	Ragna	Foedus	<i>the Grey</i>
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(**March Town/VillaFort/Old Road**) Longhouse Quarter tucked into old forum with hearthsmoke under broken eaves; Milefort XVII with earth bank and faded eagle.

Spades Places

2. **Longhouse Quarter** — Tucked into old forum; hearthsmoke under broken eaves. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The forum’s marble floor is worn smooth by dancing feet, not sandals. The ghosts of tax collectors weep in the corners.*
3. **Milefort XVII** — Earth bank, stone gate; faded eagle over fresh knotwork. ‘[MILITARY]’ *The eagle’s stone wings were reglued after a lightning strike. It still leans left toward the steppe.*
4. **Stone Ford** — Plankpalings and a customs table at kneeheight; border as bureaucracy. ‘[TRADE]’ *The ford changes hands every season. The customs table never moves. The wood is stained with ink and blood.*
5. **Villa Granary** — Barracks with a tile roof; spear racks where olives once slept. ‘[MILITARY]’ *The olive press still works. The pressers are now armorers. The oil is for lamps, not cooking.*
6. **Twin Court** — Mallus ring beneath an oak, basilica bench across the lane. ‘[LAW]’ *The oak and the bench are the same distance from the well. The well is neutral ground. The well has a chain.*
7. **Blackwood Road** — Milestones recarved in runes and Latin both. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The runes say “safe passage.” The Latin says “toll payable twice.” The third line is scratched out.*
8. **Staple Market** — Frontier where Ykrul horses meet Vilikari iron. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The horsetraders and smiths speak a pidgin of gestures and grudges. The scales are honest mostly.*
9. **Burial Field** — Shipridge mounds beside tiled mausolea, both garlanded. ‘[DEATH]’ *The mausolea have fresh offerings. The ancestors are not picky. The shipmounds whisper at dawn.*
10. **Repaired Bridge** — An arch of stone, a Vilikari trestle stitched on; past and present joined. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The trestle creaks in Vilikari, the stone groans in Utaran. They argue at midnight. The tollkeeper listens.*
- J **Hill Amphitheater** — A lord’s hall raised in an old arena’s curve; power in architecture. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The lord’s throne is a gladiator’s chair. He does not know who last sat in it. The sand beneath is still dark.*
- Q **New Raivon** — March capital; gridstreets colliding with wandering lanes. ‘[URBAN]’ *The grid was laid by a surveyor who never came back. The lanes are older. They move at night.*
- K **Dux’s Palace** — Purple awnings, wolfhides, law tablets on the wall. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The tablets list every treaty broken. The wolfhides are from the treatybreakers. They still growl.*
- A **Foedus Stone** — At a crossroads; every treaty carved, every hand weighed. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *The stone has grown. Each new treaty adds a finger of granite. The oldest fingers are worn smooth. The newest crack has no date.*

(**Federate/Mixed Court/Diaspora**) HearthMother with guestcup and wergild chest key; ShieldBrother with oaths braided into hair.

Hearts People & Factions

2. **Hearth-Mother** — Guestcup and wergild chest key; hospitality as power. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *She has never lost a quarrel. Her voice is soft, her memory longer than the Foedus Stone. She remembers obligations that are not yet owed and the stone is forgetting.*
3. **Shield-Brother** — Comitatus oaths braided into hair; loyalty as bond. ‘[MILITARY]’ ‘[OATH]’ *His braids are his record. Each knot is an oath kept or broken. He has started tying knots in his sleep, hoping the stone will remember.*
4. **March Notary** — Utarantrained; writes three scripts without blinking. ‘[LAW]’ *His left hand writes Latin, his right writes runes. He signs with his foot. The document is always binding until the stone forgets.*
5. **Horse-Reeve** — Rations pasture between plows and warbands. ‘[TRADE]’ *He measures grass in fistfuls. The Ykrul respect his arithmetic. The Ecktorians pretend not to notice. He is saving fistfuls to patch the stone.*
6. **Ykrul Envoy** — Riding under safeconduct; speaks obligations in proverbs. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *He never carries a weapon. His tongue is sharp enough. His hostage string has nine knots. He is running out of space and the stone is running out of memory.*
7. **Old Legionary** — Drillmaster for Vilikari levies; Utar in muscle memory. ‘[MILITARY]’ *He still marks time in paces. The recruits call him “Grandfather Eagle.” The eagle on his shield is chipped. He says the stone’s cracks are just more places to put his thumb.*
8. **Ecktorial Factor** — Vilikari blood, Ecktorial coin; flows where the market points. ‘[TRADE]’ *His coat has two collars one for each loyalty. He wears whichever is warmer. His tally has three columns. The third column is labelled “crack width.”*
9. **Kahfagian Pilot** — Lanternlaw chit and clan tattoo; sealaw on land. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *He navigates by stars and tariffs. Both change with the season. He has never been lost only delayed. The stone’s cracks are good for smuggling.*
10. **Marcher-Lord** — Ironnail crown, Vilikari law in pocket; a frontier king. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse. His hands are still calloused. He does not sit on his throne. He spends his days pressing his ear to the stone.*
- J **War-Maiden** — Oathbraid names the dead and the owed; vengeance as memory. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[OATH]’ *Her braid is longer than her sword. Both have drawn blood. She never cuts the braid. The dead would forget her. The stone is forgetting everyone else.*
- Q **Queen of Marches** — Consortregent; smiles like precedent. ‘[POLITICS]’ *She married the Federate King for peace. She kept the kingdom for herself. Her seal is a broken arrow. She keeps a piece of the stone in her pocket it gets smaller every year.*
- K **Federate King** — RexDux sworn to forms, sung by his own. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *He has three thrones oak, marble, and saddle. He uses whichever is not being argued over. His crown is a laurel and a wolf’s tooth. He has stopped arguing. He just listens to the stone.*
- A **Elder of Elders** — Thingcouncil speaker; a nod can unmake a clan. ‘[LAW]’ *He speaks once a year. The rest of the time he listens and remembers. But his memory is cracking like the stone. He has started writing things on his own skin.*

(Two Laws/Two Fronts/Old Grudges) Annona late grain stipend misses the comitatus; tempers quicken; jurisdiction tangle of mallus vs. basilica writ.

Clubs Complications/Threats

2. **Annona Late** — Grain stipend misses the comitatus; tempers quicken like flint. '[SUPPLY]' '[SOCIAL]' *The granary is full. The keys are in the wrong vault. Someone is waiting for the price to rise. The soldiers are not. The stone does not care.*
3. **Law Tangle** — Mallus verdict vs. basilica writ whose seal bites? '[LAW]' *The oak judge and the marble judge are cousins. They send each other holiday cards. The case has been open for three generations. The stone has forgotten who started it.*
4. **Raid Rumor** — A Ykrul boyar; levies panic the plowlands. '[COMBAT]' '[FEAR]' *The boyar is a ghost or a tax collector. The farmers don't wait to find out. They burn the fields themselves. The stone's cracks are good cover for ghosts.*
5. **Bridge Levy** — Doubled for roadworks; caravans balk, fists rise. '[TRADE]' '[COMBAT]' *The roadworks are a ditch. The ditch fills every spring. The bridge keeper has a new sword. He sharpens it on the stone.*
6. **Succession Feud** — Wolfbrother claim vs. purplecharter heir. '[POLITICS]' '[DEATH]' *The wolfbrother has a better sword. The purplecharter has a better notary. The notary's ink is mixed with blood. The stone's crack drinks it.*
7. **Foedus Recall** — A prefecture resettlement is "requested"; homes bristle. '[LAW]' '[SOCIAL]' *The prefecture's map is forty years old. It shows a village that drowned. The villagers are still there. The stone remembers their names barely.*
8. **Coin Talk** — Debasement; pay demanded in salt, hides, or hostages. '[TRADE]' '[WEIGHT]' *The salt is from a disputed pan. The hides are from cattle that were never born. The hostages are children. The stone's cracks are full of their names.*
9. **Grave Offense** — A burial field disturbed; omens ride with the news. '[DEATH]' '[OMEN]' *The ancestors are angry. They have a list. Your name may be on it. The list is carved on a ship's prow. The stone's new crack is shaped like a finger pointing.*
10. **Port Clash** — Lanternlaw vs. streetlaw; confiscations bloom. '[LAW]' '[TRADE]' *The lanterns were moved last night. The old safe channel is now a reef. The harbor master is not answering questions. He is listening to the stone.*
- J **Warband Flip** — Colors change midpay; hostage protocol snaps shut. '[MILITARY]' '[BETRAYAL]' *The hostages are eating well. Their captors are not. The captain's new banner is stitched with his old captain's hair. The stone's crack has grown wider.*
- Q **Restoration Preacher** — Stirs crowds against the "barbarian king in purple." '[SOCIAL]' '[FEAR]' *The preacher's license was signed by a dead abbot. The seal is still warm. The crowd does not know. The stone does not care.*
- K **General Levy** — The march is closed; markets freeze into spears. '[MILITARY]' '[SUPPLY]' *The levy notice is posted in three languages. None of them are local. The tax collector has a bow. The stone has stopped listening.*
- A **Spring Melt** — Eats the Wolf Road; proofs, plans, and armies bog. '[WEATHER]' '[TRAVEL]' *The road is a memory. The ruts fill with water and older things. The bridge keeper is fishing for boots. The stone's crack is now a chasm.*

(Charter/Right/Escort) Foedus Renewal Seal for settlement and stipends; Mallus BenchRight to hold court under the oak.

Diamonds Rewards/Leverage

2. **Foedus Seal** — Settlement and stipends confirmed for a season. ‘[LAW]’ *The seal is a bronze wolf’s head. It warms when the treaty holds and cools when it doesn’t. The wolf’s eyes are garnets. One eye is cracked.*
3. **Mallus Right** — Hold court under the oak and be obeyed. ‘[LAW]’ *The oak is older than the kingdom. Its roots have seen more verdicts than the throne. The acorns are bitter. The oak’s leaves are falling early.*
4. **Stipend Arrears** — Paid in salt and grain; portable, persuasive. ‘[SUPPLY]’ *The salt is grey. The grain is from last harvest. Both are worth more than coin. The soldiers will accept. The stone will not.*
5. **Utaran Patent** — Citizenshipstyle privilege; doors open, bows deepen. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The patent is a worn scrap of vellum. It has been folded and refolded for a century. The seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is fading.*
6. **Stall-Right** — Customs favor on a frontier market line. ‘[TRADE]’ *The stall is a painted plank. Plant it, and the tax man will pretend not to see you. He will remember the favour. The stone will not.*
7. **Hostage Treaty** — Exchange fosters; grudges trade for leverage. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The hostages are children. Their parents are patient. The treaty has nine clauses. The ninth is unspoken. The stone has forgotten the first eight.*
8. **Remount Allotment** — Fresh horses from royal paddocks, no questions. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The horses are from the king’s own herd. They know the roads better than you. They also know the king’s secrets. They refuse to cross the stone’s shadow.*
9. **Wergild Table** — Recognized by both codes; vengeance priced and paid. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’ *The table is a slate slab. The prices are carved deep and often recarved. The newest price is a year of rain. The rain is washing away the carvings.*
10. **Bridge Farm** — Imperial for a season; funds and friends accrue. ‘[TRADE]’ *The bridge toll is a copper a head. The bridge keeper is your new best friend. He also keeps a list of your enemies. He scratches the list on the stone.*
- J **Purple Warrant** — Wear the stripe; officials defer on sight. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The stripe is a sash. It was a curtain in a past life. The present life is yours. Do not lose it. The stone’s crack has swallowed one like it.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Private; a whisper becomes policy. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The audience is held in a garden. The flowers are listening. The gardener is a spy. The gardener is also the queen. She keeps a piece of the stone under her tongue.*
- K **Dux Commission** — Command a mixed unit with pay authority. ‘[MILITARY]’ *The commission is a baton. It doubles as a mace in a pinch. It also doubles as a receipt. The receipt is overdue. The stone has a receipt for the stone.*
- A **Great Law Day** — Proclaim a new concord; one temporary exception to old law. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[LEGEND]’ *The proclamation is made at noon. By sunset, everyone will have an opinion. By dawn, the Foedus Stone will have a new finger or a new crack.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).

- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/rights/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **law and bond** motifs oaths that bind, stones that witness, treaties that remember every hand but also **cracks and forgetting**. The stone's newest crack widens; the Hollow listens.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Witness Fading Clock [8]:** Tracks the erosion of Vilikari legal authority. **Ticks** when:
 - The party defies a Vilikari judgment or brings a dispute to an outside court (+1)
 - The GM spends 2 SB to represent a forgotten oath (+1)
 - A foreign envoy (Ykrul, Ecktorian, etc.) publicly ignores a Vilikari ruling (+1)

At 4 segments: Any Vilikari NPC the party interacts with suffers 1 die to social rolls (they doubt their own authority). The stone's cracks are visible to all. **At 8 segments:** The Foedus Stone cracks completely. The Vilikari are no longer recognized as a neutral party. The Ykrul and Ecktorians begin fighting over their land. The party can reset the clock only by **renewing the treaty** finding a witness older than the stone itself (a Lethai-al elder, a Trow, a ghost of the original signatory) and having them speak the oath aloud.
- **TwoLaw Balance:** Whenever a *jurisdictional conflict* arises (mallus vs. basilica, oak vs. marble), players may step Position up by citing the Foedus Stone or an older precedent but every use adds a tick to a **TwoLaw** [4] clock. When it fills, one side demands exclusive authority. The other side sharpens its knives. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 4+, this clock ticks twice as fast.
- **Frontier Diplomacy:** If a *Heart* card involves a foreign envoy, a federate, or a mixedblood courtier, treat the first **Diamond** played in the scene as doubled leverage. Once per session, a deal struck reverberates advance or start a **Border Tension** front. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 6+, the deal also ticks the clock by 1 (the stone forgets another clause).
- **March Markets:** At any *Staple Market, Ford, or Bridge*, Diamonds tied to rights or escorts may be cashed as currency in lieu of coin, one for one. Doing so creates a **Stone Weight** that the GM may call in later through factions or raiders. The weight is never written. It is remembered until the stone forgets.
- **The Vilikari Diaspora (Ecktoria & Acasia):** Vilikari characters in Ecktoria gain +1 die on Streetwise checks (they know the back alleys and the bribes), but 1 die on social rolls with Old Blood patricians (who see them as upstarts). In Acasia, they gain +1 die on Survival checks (their ancestors were farmers here) but 1 die on social rolls with the Cursetouched (who remember imperial tax collectors). A Vilikari character may start with one "family tally" a minor asset that tracks a single unpaid favour across generations. If the Witness Fading Clock ever fills, the tally turns to ash.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The TwoFaced King** Mykkiel. *Justice that wears a laurel and a wolf's tail.*
 - **The Hearth Judge** The Witness. *The flame that watches both sides of the bargain.*
 - **The Oak Father** Grimmer. *The root that holds the law; the branch that signs the treaty.*
 - **The Coin Saint** Maelstraesus. *Interest on a handshake; the stone that never sleeps.*

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The Smugglers’ Covenant (The Sealed Gate):** Vilikari pilots who run the Kahfagian coast swear by a secret oath to the *Unlatched Lock* a threshold that never fully closes. They leave a copper nail at every hidden cove. A captain who breaks the covenant finds that their boat will not cross the tide line; the sea simply refuses to carry them. The Kahfagian Admiralty has tried to bribe the covenant’s keeper; he accepted the coin and sank the next morning in calm water. The stone’s newest crack appeared that same night.
- **Saint Theodora of the Dual Writ (The Witness):** A march notary who uncovered a Fenwood spy in the Federate King’s court. She forced the spy to sign a confession under both oak and marble, then burned the oak copy and kept the marble one. The spy vanished, but his signature appears on every broken treaty in Vilikari history. Her quill is kept in the Dux’s Palace; it writes in lemon juice, and the truth it records cannot be erased by fire or water. The stone’s cracks drink the juice.
- **The Host of the Two Ledgers (The Longhouse Healers):** A hospice near the Foedus Stone is run by greyrobed healers who ask no payment. They treat wounded raiders from both sides of the steppe, and the Ykrul and Ecktorian captains have agreed to a truce around its doors. The Federate King tolerates them because they also hold the rite of the *Unbuckled Oath* a ceremony where a knight may renounce a blooddebt without losing honour, by placing their sword on the stone and speaking a single true regret. The stone remembers these regrets. It has many.
- **The Ostrihari Cousins (The Savage Heart):** The eastern Vilikari, called Ostrihari by lowlanders, are no more savage than any frontier people. Their reputation comes from the bear cults of the upper Wolf Road, where initiates wear cured skins and speak in growls. The Ostrihari do not raid Vilikari villages; they trade furs for iron and send their young to serve as mercenaries in the Black Banners. A Vilikari proverb says: “The Ostrihari sharpen their teeth on stone, not on kin.” The stone does not mind. It has no teeth left.
- **The Ninth:** In any Vilikari scene, the ninth witness called to a mallus court is always a ghost. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court. Those who call a ninth witness find that the ghost speaks the truth but the truth is always the worst possible version, and the living witnesses remember it as their own. The stone’s cracks are full of these truths.

Vilikari Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stone:** Crumble a crust at the base of the Foedus Stone. Ignore the first *Law Tangle* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Braid:** Tie a single knot in a horse’s tail. Cancel *Annona Late* or take 1 die on your next supply roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Oak:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the hollow of the mallus oak. Gain +1 Effect when collecting wergild from their kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Elder of Elders. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Press the Crack (new):** Touch the newest crack in the Foedus Stone and speak a promise you intend to break. Gain +1 die on your next deception roll, but the stone will remember your name. The Hollow will too. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **march officials or tribal elders**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **levy guards or market patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or treaty keepers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable legal window**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.
- **Crack Whispers (Vilikari only):** A character hears the stone whispering a forgotten promise. They must test Resolve (DV 3) or mark 1 Fatigue.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised: Horse-Reeve or March Notary** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or border closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction or warband** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.
- **Witness Fading:** Advance the **Witness Fading Clock** by 1 segment (the stone forgets something).

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **shield-brothers, levy forces, or foreign troops** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **treaty voided/levy called/border dispute erupts**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.
- **Stone Speaks:** The Foedus Stone whispers a forgotten clause that invalidates a character's legal protection for the scene.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Federate King, Queen of Marches, or Elder of Elders** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **raid hits/levy called/treaty breaks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.
- **Crack Splits:** The Foedus Stone's newest crack widens. One of the party's active Diamonds is lost (crumbles to dust).

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Vilikari (Two Laws):** Legal documents contradict each other, courts issue conflicting rulings, oaths bind to different authorities. The stone's cracks eat ink.

- **Vilikari (Frontier Diplomacy):** Treaties expire without warning, foreign envoys demand additional concessions, mixedblood courtiers shift allegiances. The stone forgets who signed what.
- **Vilikari (Border Tensions):** Frontier posts close without notice, markets shift locations, safeconducts are revoked midjourney. The stone’s shadow grows longer.

Boss Seeds (threephase foes)

- **The March Notary (quills like daggers)** — *Phases:* Citation Tangle → Seal Swap → Precedent Trap. *Cracks:* produce a **Foedus Seal** to quiet him; a **Queen’s Audience** overrules his filing. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 6+, he gains +1 die in all phases (the stone supports him).
- **Ykrul Storm-Rider (wolfcloak, bone whistle)** — *Phases:* Raid Cry → Herd Stampede → Blood Price. *Cracks:* a **Wergild Table** settles the feud without combat; a **Hostage Treaty** buys a season’s peace. He fights harder if the stone is cracked (he smells weakness).
- **The Prefect’s Auditor (Ecktorial ink on his fingers)** — *Phases:* Tally Seizure → Tax Levy → Fort Closure. *Cracks:* an **Utaran Patent** grants immunity; a **Mallus Right** transfers jurisdiction to the oak. He carries a piece of the stone in his pocket; if the party takes it, the Witness Fading Clock resets by 2.
- **The Stone’s Ghost (Foedus Avatar)** — *Phases:* Whisper of Forgotten Clauses → Crack Widens → The Hollow Steps Through. *Cracks:* speak the original treaty aloud (requires a Lethai-al witness), repair the stone with a memory of a kept promise, or sacrifice a personal oath to feed the stone instead of the Hollow.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **TwoLaw Dial (Oak ↔ Marble):** Track which legal tradition holds sway.
 - *Oak High:* +1 Position when invoking mallus, bloodprice, or tribal custom; first basilica petition starts one step worse.
 - *Marble High:* +1 Effect when citing charters, patents, or Utaran precedent; first mallus oath starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by offering a wergild recognized by both sides or hosting a joint moot. If the Witness Fading Clock is at 4+, centering requires a sacrifice (a memory, a name, a drop of blood on the stone).
- **TreatyFeast Procedure (fast diplomacy):**
 1. **Set the Table:** Name 2–3 *terms* (what both sides want) and 1 *taboo* (offlimits).
 2. **First Cup (Position):** Roll a social test; success grants +1 die to bargain, failure grants the host 1 SB.
 3. **Bread & Salt (Offer):** Put *one* leverage on the table (Diamond or oathpromise). Host matches with an obligation (escort, market access, or hostage).
 4. **Smoke (Complication):** The GM reveals a pressure tied to *Old Grudges* or *Two Laws*. Resolve it or accept a *Rider Clause*.
 5. **Knot the Braid:** On success, create a **FeastBond** [3] clock that protects both parties from betrayal in that matter while it has segments; on breach, the breaker immediately takes 1–2 SB and the clock flips to **BloodOwed** [3].

6. **Stone Witness:** If the FeastBond is sworn at the Foedus Stone, it also reduces the Witness Fading Clock by 1. The stone remembers one more promise.
- **Frontier Market (quick trading):**
 - At any *Staple Market* or *Stone Ford*, players may convert a held $\diamond$ into a *Market Edge* (+1 die to all buy/sell rolls for the scene).
 - Each conversion ticks a **Market Knives** [4] clock for that locale. When it fills, a rival factor challenges your right to trade face a duel, a bribe demand, or a confiscation.
 - If the Witness Fading Clock is at 6+, the rival factor is a ghost a forgotten signatory of the Foedus Stone. The duel is a legal dream-duel.
 - **StartofScene Omens (1d6):**
 1. *Laurel Wilt:* first legal action gains +1d; first boast draws **Law Tangle**.
 2. *Smoke on the Steppe:* **Raid Rumor** advances once; shortcuts open.
 3. *Twin Bells:* both courts are in session; pick a side or start **Law Tangle**.
 4. *Queen's Dove:* a message arrives; +1d on the next **Queen's Audience**.
 5. *Grey Salt:* **Stipend Arrears** counts double value today; smugglers' ears open.
 6. *Old Eagle:* an Utaran relic surfaces; **Utaran Patent** use is free this scene.
 7. *Crack Light (special when Witness Fading Clock 4):* The stone glows. The next legal argument made at the stone is automatically binding for both sides.
 - **Plugin SB Conversions (Vilikari Flavor):**
 - 1 SB $\rightarrow$ *Seal Crack:* a writ loses half its value until rewitnessed.
 - 2 SB $\rightarrow$ *Citation War:* increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a $\diamond$ or recall a past ruling).
 - 3+ SB $\rightarrow$ *Crown Fracture:* a treaty splits; halve a consequence by accepting a rival's seal on your paper (start **TwoLaw** clock).
 - 2 SB (Vilikari only) $\rightarrow$ *Stone Whisper:* The Foedus Stone reveals a forgotten clause. The GM must answer one yes/no question about a treaty or oath in the region.
 - **Reputation Echoes:**
 - *CourtFavored:* once/session, downgrade **Law Tangle** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
 - *RaidTested:* +1 Position when evading Ykrul or Black Banners; supply lines run 1 segment longer.
 - *Neutral Broker:* +1d with both oak and marble in a treaty scene; any betrayal earns **BloodOwed** [2] from both sides.
 - *StoneMarked (gained by renewing the treaty):* The Foedus Stone remembers your name. Once per session, you may reroll a failed social roll involving a Vilikari or a treaty. The stone will ask for a memory in return.
 - **CrossRegion Hooks (quick integration):**
 - *Kahfagia (LanternLaw):* A **Foedus Seal** may stand in for a *SafeConduct* along a beacons lane once. Doing so starts **Port Clash** [2] in the next harbor touched.
 - *Ecktoria (Imperial Remnants):* An **Utaran Patent** counts as either *Archive Hour* (scholars open doors) or *Icon License* (display symbols) in Ecktorial sites choose once per session.

- *Aelerian Mountains (Pass & Toll)*: A **Pass-Ring** (from the Aeler expansion) grants priority at dwarf switchbacks; cashing it to bypass inspection spawns **Stone Notice** [3].
- *Direwood (Breath & Bells)*: Spending **Stipend Arrears** for levee labor converts one Direwood **Clubs** draw into a *Ward-Salt* Diamond for a scene, then begins **Names Disputed** [3] with bellwardens.
- *Acasia (Curse Tithe)*: A **Wergild Table** accepted by a Cursetouched village also clears one *Feud Spark* clock, but the Hollow gains +1 Attention.
- *Lethai-ar Silk Bridges*: A **Hostage Treaty** can be witnessed by a Lethai-ar silkwarden, making it binding across the Crimson Valley. The price is a strand of the treaty-bearer’s hair.

Patronage & Power

In Vilikari society, power flows through the careful balance of multiple legal traditions, the management of frontier diplomacy, and the maintenance of complex oaths and treaties. The Federate King maintains authority through a combination of imperial forms and traditional customs, while local leaders wield influence through their knowledge of both Utaran law and tribal custom. The true power lies with those who can navigate this complex legal and diplomatic landscape while maintaining the loyalty of their people and the respect of their neighbors.

But the stone is cracking. The witnesses are dying. The Vilikari are becoming *invisible*.

For the GM: Patronage in Vilikari society revolves around legal documents, diplomatic relationships, and the ability to command respect from institutions that operate under multiple legal systems. Rewards often take the form of treaties, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the hybrid identity and the fading authority:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, treaties) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided and that may crumble if the stone forgets.
- Let rival legal systems issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more. Neither may remember them tomorrow.
- Use the courts, markets, and frontier posts as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success and where the stone’s whispers can tip the balance.
- Remember that Vilikari characters are at home in Ecktoria’s countinghouses and Acasia’s hedgerow courts alike but they are never fully trusted in either. That suspicion is their best tool. When the stone cracks fully, that suspicion becomes exile.

In Vilikari society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you rule or are ruled. But a bond is only as strong as the stone that witnesses it. And the stone is forgetting.

Chapter 11

Black Banners

Condotta & Crowns.

A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it. In this game, we sell steel by the season and vendettas by the year.

I am a Veteran Sergeant. I've seen three captains rise and fall in the time it takes to grow a beard, but the mud stays the same and the pay comes when it pleases.

Mercenary companies sell steel to the highest bidder and oh, how they love a good spreadsheet. The Banner-Captains don't just want payment; they want proof they're getting their money's worth, which is why they pay in safe-conducts that are good until the next battle... and utterly worthless after, once the smoke clears and the ledgers need balancing.

The camp sings when payday comes. The camp falls silent when the ledger is written in blood. I've heard both. I prefer the singing. At least the singing means you're still alive.

Never break a Bell Dawn. Three bells at sunrise means bury the dead, trade prisoners, fix the wells, no ambushes. Violating it is how legends end badly and how captains end hanging.

Old Sorka, Veteran Sergeant, who counts scars like coins and spends them on whiskey and mercy

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Hardtack and camp stewthe stew is whatever was caught, killed, or traded for before dawn. The cook is called "The Alchemist." No one knows their real name. No one asks.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count coin. Camp children are taught to tally pay shares before they can read. A child who miscounts is a child who will go hungry. A child who goes hungry is a child who learns to count faster.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their colours. Every Black Banner company has its own bannerlantern, thorn, bell, fishbone, broken scale. A stranger whose colours are faded has been running. A stranger whose colours are too bright has never fought. A stranger with no colours has no company. A stranger with no company is a deserter. A deserter is a liability. A liability is a corpse.

What is the most common crime? Desertionbut desertion is not a crime, it is a negotiation. A soldier who wants to leave will sell their gear to the quartermaster, sell their secrets to the enemy, and sell their silence to the captain. The price is negotiable. The price is always "one more season."

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Black Colonel is not a person. The Colonel is a title held by a wax seal. The seal is kept in a lead-lined box. The box is carried by a mute lieutenant. The lieutenant signs documents with the Colonel's thumb-print. The thumb-print is a forgery. The forger is the lieutenant. The lieutenant has no thumbs.

Where do people go when they die? To the pyre. Camp dead are burned in a bonfire of broken spears and banner poles. The ashes are scattered by the quartermaster. The quartermaster charges a fee. The fee is deducted from the dead's final pay. The final pay is never enough.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You stand a watch. The wronged party chooses the hourmidnight, dawn, the dead of winter. You stand alone. If you survive, you are forgiven. If you do not, the debt is paid. The camp does not mourn. The camp does not forget.

What is the most important festival? Paydaybut payday is not a day, it is a negotiation. The captain promises payment on the first of the month. The quartermaster promises payment when the supply train arrives. The soldiers promise loyalty until the payment comes. The payment never comes. The loyalty never ends.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Banner-Captain's contract is written in disappearing ink. The ink was supplied by a Sidhi forger who was paid in promises. The promises were not kept. The forger is now a camp follower. The forger knows where the contract is hidden. The forger is waiting for the right offer.

11.1 Black Banners — Condotta & Crowns

Quick Reference

Tagline: *A contract is only as good as the next payday.*

Banner-Captain (Elite): “A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it. In this game, we sell steel by the season and vendettas by the year.”

Veteran Sergeant (Commoner): “I’ve seen three captains rise and fall in the time it takes to grow a beard, but the mud stays the same and the pay comes when it pleases. Best keep your own counsel and your blade sharp. The camp sings? You live. They stop singing? Even the best charter bleeds.”

Genre / Mood: Mercenary realism, winter warfare, logistics-driven violence.

System Type: Portable overlay — apply to any region (Acasia, Violet Steppe, Ecktorian borderlands). Not a fixed geography.

Condotta & Crowns

Ecktorian treasuries bankroll a perpetual border-war they claim to be *containing*. In truth, the gold keeps the fire burning. The Black Banners are mercenary leagues — ex-Utaran legionaries, second-sons, debt-dodgers, and exiles — who sell steel to the highest bidder, today’s ally becoming tomorrow’s quarry. Between them move the Ykrul steppe-clans (swift, pragmatic, oath-canny) and the Vilikari hill tribes (crafty, patient, and proud). Ecktorian ministers call it “pressure management.” The companies call it a season.

What you notice first: The smell of wet wool and old blood. The way every tent has a pay roster pinned to its flap. The silence when the chest is opened — and the murmur when it’s light.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never break a Bell Dawn. Three bells at sunrise means bury the dead, trade prisoners, fix the wells, no ambushes. Violating it is how legends end badly — and how captains end hanging.

The Theater of Banners

Here, war is a marketplace. The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling league of freelance violence, bound by camp law, pay customs, and the shared knowledge that tomorrow’s enemy might be today’s employer. The real battles are fought in counting-tents over clauses and riders; the clash outside is just the audit. Loyalty is a share that fluctuates with the market, and a captain’s true skill lies in reading the political winds that blow across contested borders. Between the rigid honour codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground where survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one — always at dawn, with a witness, and with surety paid.

Quickstart (Two-Minute Setup)

1. **Condotta Crossroads:** Put two conflicting charters on the table. Ask: *Who do you disappoint first?*

2. **Company Sheet:** Name, Colors, Captain. Add clocks: **Payday** [4], **Supplies** [4], **Cohesion** [6].
3. **Pressure Clocks:** Pick two external threats (e.g., *Skirmish Spiral* [6], *Camp Fever* [6]).
4. **Allegiances in Flux:** At each scene start, roll 1d6 and apply the twist (see table).
5. **Honor vs. Pragmatism Dial:** Slide based on choices; affects Position and logistics.

The Four-Suit Generator

Draw until you have all four suits. Highest rank sets the main Clock (25 → 4, 610 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10). Any Ace echoes winter & loyalty motifs: hunger, omen, promotion-by-attribution.

Spades — Places (Camps, Battlefields, Fortresses)

Rank	Name	Description & Mechanical Hook
2	Burned Village	Field hospital; flies, tinctures, fever-prayers. ‘[DEATH]’ <i>Start a Camp Fever [4] clock. Each failed Medicine roll ticks it.</i>
3	Frozen Ford	Last month’s dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[WEATHER]’ <i>Crossing costs +1 Fatigue. The dead whisper a name — the next Desertion check is at 1 die.</i>
4	Latrine Row	Mud, shame, whispered mutiny; a sergeant who hears too well. ‘[SOCIAL]’ <i>Any failed social roll here ticks Cohesion +1 (soldiers lose faith).</i>
5	Crater Pasture	Alchemical barrage aftermath; glass flowers sprout like guilt. ‘[MAGIC]’ <i>Scavenging here gives a Glass Shard (1 use: +1 die to intimidate), but ticks Supplies +1 (poisoned ground).</i>
6	Supply Road	Twelve broken wagons; oxen nose the wreckage for salt. ‘[TRAVEL]’ <i>First scavenge roll of the scene is Controlled; on a Miss, tick Supplies +1.</i>
7	Half-Raised Siege Tower	Abandoned camp; every rung creaks with grudges. ‘[COMBAT]’ <i>Climbing costs 2 Fatigue; on a Partial, the tower leans — next attack from it is Desperate.</i>
8	Salt-Cured Cache	Behind the surgeon’s tent; wrong kind of maggots move. ‘[DEATH]’ <i>Opening it gives 1 Supplies but starts a Disease [4] clock (the maggots carry rot).</i>
9	Command Tent	Maps show borders diplomacy erased. ‘[SOCIAL]’ <i>A player who studies the map for a scene may ask one question about enemy intentions; on a Miss, the map is a decoy — start False Orders [4].</i>
10	Watch-Tower	Stacked from skulls and slate; crows know the countersign. ‘[WAR]’ <i>The crows will warn of ambush once, but only if fed a memory (erase a minor fact).</i>
J	Ancient March-Keep	Held by a skeleton garrison of veterans; they remember when banners were gold. ‘[DEATH]’ <i>They will fight for you if you swear an oath to restore their banner — start Oath Share [6].</i>

Q	The Bone Fields	Ykrul elders parley among cairns; reckon oaths with the dead. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[OATH]’ <i>The dead vote on any dispute. Roll Spirit+Lore (DV 4). On success, they side with you (gain +1 Position on next parley). On failure, they demand a blood-price.</i>
K	Marcher’s Fortress	Three walls, two sieges’ scars, one gate that opens inward only. ‘[COMBAT]’ <i>The gate opens inward so the dead can leave. Living who enter without permission take Harm 1 (spiritual backlash).</i>
A	The Singing Wastes	Fallen weapons hum with voices of their last wielders. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEATH]’ <i>Each weapon can answer one question about its owner’s death. After three questions, the Wastes awaken — start Wrath of the Fallen [8].</i>

Hearts — People & Factions

Rank	Name	Description & Mechanical Hook
2	Young Cadet	Father’s sword, mother’s share, hunger to prove himself. ‘[SOCIAL]’ <i>If you mentor him (a downtime scene), he becomes a Cap 1 follower. If you ignore him, he joins a rival company — tick Rival Agenda +1.</i>
3	Veteran Sergeant	Counts scars like coins — spends them on whiskey and mercy. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ <i>She will fight for you, but at end of scene demands a story about a broken oath. If you cannot provide one, she takes 1 of your Boons as “interest.”</i>
4	Ecktorian Banner-Captain	Griffon standard, roster of noble grudges, smile like winter. ‘[LAW]’ <i>He offers a Letter of Marque (once: ignore one legal complication). Accepting starts his Favor Share [4] — he will call in a favour during a critical moment.</i>
5	Condotta Broker	Changes colours when wind turns, always lands on his feet. ‘[SOCIAL]’ <i>He will flip a contract for you — but the price is a Black Mark (reputation stain).</i>
6	Ykrul Clan Emis-sary	Speaks in riddled proverbs; pays in copper from a cursed mine. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[OATH]’ <i>He offers a Safe-Conduct Token (one free passage through Ykrul land). Accepting marks Obligation [2] — the curse follows.</i>
7	Vilikari War-Chief’s Second Son	Honour burns brighter than his father’s patience. ‘[SOCIAL]’ <i>He will join your next battle as a Cap 2 ally, but if he takes Harm, start a Blood Feud [6] with his clan.</i>
8	Surgeon of the Red Tally	Treats friend and foe; her record balances in blood. ‘[SHARE]’ <i>She can heal 1 Harm — but the patient’s name is added to her roll. Once per arc, she calls in the share: a dangerous mission.</i>
9	Quartermaster	Knows where every coin went and every man will fall. ‘[SHARE]’ <i>His bribe book is thicker than his roster. Spend 1 Boon to cancel one Supplies tick — but he now has a String on you.</i>

10	Tribune's Aide-de-Camp	Sealed orders contradict the general's intent. '[SOCIAL]' <i>He will leak the real orders for a Favor Share [4] — but the leak may be a trap.</i>
J	The Black Colonel	Legendary commander not seen in months, yet his banner rides. '[LEGEND]' <i>The banner rides alone. If you follow it, you find a cache (gain 1 Diamond of your choice). Following it three times summons his ghost.</i>
Q	Ykrul Clan-Mother	Weaves war-braids from hair of oath-breakers. '[OATH]' <i>She can witness any oath; breaking it gives her power over you (she may demand a service).</i>
K	Vilikari High Chief	Trades mercenaries like game pieces; never tips the board. '[SOCIAL]' <i>He offers a Trading Charter (buy/sell anything in any camp). Using it ticks Cohesion +1 (soldiers suspect you of corruption).</i>
A	The Bannerless One	Commands loyalty without rank or flag. '[LEGEND]' <i>She appears when Payday is at 3/4. She clears 1 Payday segment — but you owe a Price of Mercy [4]. When it fills, she asks for a prisoner you'd rather keep.</i>

Clubs — Complications/Threats

Rank	Name	Description & Mechanical Hook
2	Payday Delayed	Supplies die before coin arrives. '[SHARE]' <i>Tick Payday +1. On fill, a squad deserts — lose 1 Supplies and gain a Black Mark.</i>
3	False Orders	Your target is now your ally — on paper. '[SOCIAL]' <i>The first command this scene is misinterpreted unless countered with a Diamond (cipher, cantor, witness).</i>
4	Blizzard Pins	Two rival companies, one cloister; vows and knives both come out. '[WEATHER]' '[COMBAT]' <i>Tick Cohesion +1. The abbot will sell safe passage to the highest bidder — start an Auction [4] clock.</i>
5	Ykrul Counter-Offer	Better terms than Ecktoria; your contract becomes a liability. '[SOCIAL]' '[SHARE]' <i>You may accept (gain +1 Effect, mark Obligation [2]) or refuse (tick Payday +1).</i>
6	Condotta Flip	Unit switches colours mid-battle; your “relief” hits your flank. '[COMBAT]' <i>On a Miss, the unit attacks you. On a Partial, they demand double pay — tick Payday +1.</i>
7	Camp Fever	Blooms in the surgeon's tent; the counting-house for the dead. '[DEATH]' <i>Start Camp Fever [4]. Each failed Endurance test ticks it. At 4, a key NPC dies.</i>
8	Vilikari Raid	Cuts your supply road; winter moves the schedule. '[COMBAT]' '[TRAVEL]' <i>Tick Supplies +1. The raiders left a recipe — cooking it gives 1 Supplies but starts a Rival Hunt [4] (they want the recipe back).</i>

9	Honour Code Collision	Ecktorian ideals vs. mercenary pragmatism; the camp splits by doctrine. ‘[SOCIAL]’ Choose Honour (tick Supplies +1 , logistics suffer) or Pragmatism (gain +1 Effect now, but start Parley Divided [4]).
10	Tribune Captured	The aide must choose: the rescue or the war. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[SHARE]’ <i>Rescue him: lose 1 Supplies. Abandon him: gain Black Mark but tick Payday 1 (his captors pay you off).</i>
J	Black Colonel’s Banner	Appears on the wrong field; confusion is a weapon. ‘[COMBAT]’ <i>Roll 1d6. On 13, the enemy believes you have reinforcements (+1 Position). On 46, your own side hesitates (1 die on first attack).</i>
Q	Blood-Feast	Clan-Mother calls it; all contracts suspended until dawn’s judgment. ‘[OATH]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ <i>The feast is a trial. Each PC must confess a broken oath or take Harm 1 (the clan judges).</i>
K	High Chief’s Game	Plays companies against each other; “winner” takes obligations, not spoils. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[SHARE]’ <i>The “winner” inherits a Obligation Clock [6] from the loser. Refusing the game starts a Vendetta [4].</i>
A	The Singing Wastes Awaken	Every fallen blade rises to seek its last hand. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEATH]’ <i>The blades attack everyone for 1 round. Afterward, any PC may claim a Cursed Blade (+1 die, but the blade whispers secrets — the GM gains 1 SB per scene).</i>

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

Each Diamond is a physical object with a cost and expiration.

Rank	Name	Description & Mechanical Hook
2	Emergency Requisition	Strip a fallen company; their ghosts watch. ‘[SHARE]’ <i>Gain 1 Use of any mundane gear. After use, the quartermaster’s ghost haunts you for 1d4 scenes (1 die on stealth).</i>
3	Dual Contract	Serve two masters whose goals cannot both be met. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[SHARE]’ <i>Gain +2 dice on one negotiation, but start a Double Charter [6] — when it fills, both masters demand payment.</i>
4	Honour Dispensation	Your acts are justified regardless of code (for now). ‘[SOCIAL]’ <i>Once, ignore a Black Mark consequence. The dispensation is a bell — ring it, and the tribunal looks away. The bell then cracks.</i>
5	Condotta Rider’s Pass	Cross any camp perimeter unchallenged. ‘[STEALTH]’ <i>The pass is a feather from a messenger who arrived too late. Use it once; then the feather burns.</i>
6	Ykrul Safe-Conduct Token	Pass a named clan’s lands unmolested (until the moon changes). ‘[TRAVEL]’ <i>The token is a horse’s tooth. The horse was a gift from a dead Khagan. The tooth turns to dust after one use.</i>

7	Vilikari War-Mark	Their scouts guide you through hostile hills — and remember the favour. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[SHARE]’ <i>Gain +1 Effect on one navigation roll. The favour will be called at dawn: they will demand a ridge or a bridge.</i>
8	Surgeon’s Debt-Note	Medical care when no coin remains; the interest is names. ‘[SHARE]’ <i>Heal 1 Harm now. The note is a name — the surgeon will collect it later (GM gains a String on you).</i>
9	Tribune’s Cipher Ring	Decode orders that do not exist yet. ‘[SOCIAL]’ <i>Once, treat a False Orders complication as Clean Success. The ring is warm — it cools after use.</i>
10	Banner-Captain’s Seal	Commandeer resources from junior companies (and their resentment). ‘[AUTHORITY]’ <i>Gain +1 Supplies now, but start a Jealousy [4] clock (junior officers scheme against you).</i>
J	Field Promotion Warrant	Assume command of a shattered unit, inherit its clocks. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[SHARE]’ <i>You gain a Cap 2 follower (the unit’s sergeant), but inherit their Payday [2/4] and Black Mark [1].</i>
Q	Clan-Mother’s War-Braids	Her chosen fight beside you this battle, then judge you after. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ <i>Gain a Cap 3 ally for one battle. Afterward, she judges your conduct — on a Miss, she takes a war-braid from you (lose 1 Boon).</i>
K	High Chief’s Trading Charter	Buy or sell <i>anything</i> in any camp, no questions asked aloud. ‘[TRADE]’ <i>Once per arc, treat a market roll as Clean Success. The questions are asked in silence — the answers are paid in silence (GM gains 1 SB).</i>
A	The Bannerless Word	Loyalty that outruns rank, law, and coin. ‘[LEGEND]’ <i>Once, when all other resources are exhausted, whisper this word to rally a shattered company. They fight for one scene without tracking Payday or Cohesion. Afterward, the word is forgotten — you cannot use it again.</i>

Company Mechanics (Visible Tracks)

Every mercenary company (PC-led or NPC) tracks three clocks:

- **Payday** [4] Missed pay, bad terms, seized chests. On fill: a squad deserts (lose 1 **Supplies**) or a veteran sells secrets (GM gains 2 SB).
- **Supplies** [4] Weather, marches, sabotage. While Supplies ≥ 3 , all risky maneuvers start **Position 1** unless you bring a Diamond (scavenge, requisition).
- **Cohesion** [6] Losses, betrayals, officer feuds. When Cohesion hits 12, the GM may convert the first 1 SB each scene into **Desertion, Brawl, or Refusal**.

Recovery: A successful **Payline Drill** scene clears 1 Payday. A **Quartermaster Audit** clears 1 Supplies. A **Rally & Reform** roll (Presence+Command, DV 3) clears 1 Cohesion.

Camp Event Mini-Generator (d8)

When the company makes camp or when tensions run high, roll on this table for a camp event that affects morale, cohesion, or supplies.

d8	Event
1	Deserter's Tale. A soldier tries to flee with a payroll satchel. If caught, the company demands a public flogging. Intervening costs 1 Boon but earns a loyalty share (+1 Cohesion). If ignored, tick Payday +1 (the gold is gone) and Cohesion 1 (trust erodes).
2	Surgeon's Lottery. The camp surgeon runs a lottery for medical priority. Those who pay 1 Boon jump the queue. Those who refuse may lose a wounded ally to infection (lose 1 Supplies or a follower). The surgeon's ledger grows longer.
3	Muster of the Fallen. A ghostly formation marches through camp at midnight. Veterans take it as an omen. Each PC must test Resolve (DV 3) or gain the Haunted condition (1 die on initiative for one day). On a success, they gain +1 die on the next morale check.
4	Brawl Over Bread. A fight erupts over the last rations. The quartermaster demands the party intervene. Choose: <i>Break it up</i> (costs 1 Fatigue, no change), <i>Take sides</i> (gain a small faction's favour but tick Cohesion 1), or <i>Let it burn</i> (lose 1 Supplies to spoilage).
5	Pardoner's Visit. A travelling pardoner offers absolutions for past sins. Pay 1 Boon to clear one Black Mark (the pardoner writes your name in his book). Refuse, and the pardoner's curse gives 1 Position on the next social roll against clergy.
6	Desertion Ring. An informant reveals a plot to desert en masse. The party can pay arrears (clear 1 Payday), execute the ringleaders (gain a Black Mark but tick Cohesion +1), or ignore it (tick Payday +2 as half the camp vanishes overnight).
7	Camp-Fever Peak. The surgeon's tent overflows. Mark 1 Fatigue for each PC. A successful Medicine test (DV 4) reduces the effect by half. On a critical failure, a key NPC (the quartermaster or a sergeant) dies.
8	The Bannerless One Visits. The mysterious figure appears at the edge of the firelight. She offers to clear 2 Payday segments in exchange for a Price of Mercy [4] clock. The clock advances each time the party shows mercy to an enemy. When full, she asks for a prisoner or a promise.

Allegiances in Flux (Scene Start, 1d6)

At the start of every scene involving mercenaries, roll 1d6:

1. **Condotta Flip** Rival charter offers better terms. Accept: gain **Black Mark** [1] with old patron. Refuse: tick **Payday +1**.
2. **Ykrul Counter-offer** Accept an exit-rich but costly route: gain +1 Effect now, mark **Obligation** [2]. Refuse: tick **Payday +1**.
3. **Vilikari Shortcut** +1 Effect on this maneuver via night roads; GM gains 1 SB (hostile terrain later).
4. **Ecktorian "Correction"** March under "imperial guidance": +1 Position this scene or take a **Black Mark** for defiance.

5. **False Orders** First command this scene suffers misinterpretation unless countered with a **Diamond** (cipher, cantor, witness).
6. **Bannerless One** A myth-wrapped figure clears 1 Payday but starts **Price of Mercy** [2]. When it fills, she asks for a prisoner you'd rather keep.

Honor vs. Pragmatism Dial

Place a two-step dial. Starting position: balanced (0).

- **Honour** (left): +1 Position in parley/oathbound actions; logistics burn faster (tick **Supplies** on a Partial where you'd normally be safe).
- **Pragmatism** (right): +1 Effect in ambush/sabotage; social rolls start one step worse Position when oaths/witnesses matter.

Centering Actions: Pay arrears on-screen, return prisoners with witness, fulfill a broken writ at cost. Move the dial one step toward center.

GM Tools

Field Procedures

- **Colours & Countersigns:** Declaring correct countersigns cancels the first **False Orders** SB each night; wrong signs worsen Position on first contact.
- **Payline Drill:** If a scene depicts orderly pay, clear 1 **Payday**. If pay is “creative,” clear it but mark **Black Mark** future officers begin one step colder in parley.
- **Scavenge Doctrine:** After battles, gain 1 temporary Gear tag or advance **Supplies** by 1; on a 12 on 1d6, spawn “Honour vs. Pragmatism” conflict immediately.

Boss Archetypes (Condensed)

- **Banner-Captain (Fixer General)** Break chain-of-command clock [6] by flipping lieutenants, forging orders, or seizing the paychest.
- **Condotta Broker (Colour-Flipper)** Expose a dual contract or force public arbitration under neutral bells to collapse their leverage track.
- **Quartermaster-Provost (Logistics Tyrant)** Complete the *Three Cuts* (road, ration, rumor) any two stalls them; all three topple their supply engine.
- **Ykrul Raid-Mother (Oath-Weaver)** Honour horse-rites to gain truce windows; break one braid in parley to end a phase.
- **Vilikari Hill-Fox (Ambush Architect)** Clear *Three High Stones* (overwatch, supply cache, signal cairn) to force even ground.
- **The Singing Wastes (Weapon-Host)** Complete the *Silencing Acts*: oil the choir (funeral honours), bury the standards, ring the wind-break bell each lowers its Tier for one exchange.

Cross-Regional Use

- **Vhasia:** A *Condotta Rider's Pass* substitutes for a *Safe-Conduct* on the Pont-du-Tithe once; after use, start a *Parlement Divided* tick.
- **Viterra:** A *Ykrul Safe-Conduct Token* may be notarised as *Ferry Priority*; the notary's fee is a story.

- **Ubral:** A *Clan-Mother's War-Braid* counts as a *Guest-Token* in hill-forts; the clans will ask whose side you took.
- **Mistlands:** A *Banner-Captain's Seal* can be presented to a Bell-Warden as proof of lawful passage; the Warden tests it with a bell. If it rings false, the mist takes a day.
- **Valewood:** A *Field Promotion Warrant* can be offered to a Green Knight as proof of worth; the Knight may challenge you to a trial of paths instead of blades.

Patronage & Power

In the Black Banners, power flows through contracts, paychests, and the weight of a reputation. A Banner-Captain's authority rests on the number of companies he commands; a Condotta Broker's on the thickness of his roster. There is no loyalty, only the shared understanding that a broken contract costs more than a broken blade.

For the GM: Power in the Black Banners is measured in payday clocks, broker's favours, and the length of a duel record. Patronage often takes the form of dual contracts, emergency requisitions, or the Bannerless Word each tied to a specific company, broker, or share. To emphasise the mercenary realism:

- Use **Payday & Supplies Clocks** as visible pressure. Let players negotiate, raid, or pledge future services to clear ticks.
- Enforce **Allegiances in Flux** every scene, loyalties may shift. The Keeper's SB pool grows when the party betrays a contract.
- Let **Honour vs. Pragmatism** be a dial the party can slide through their actions. Centre it by a costly act of mercy or a profitable betrayal.
- Track **Black Marks** as a persistent reputation score. Three Black Marks and no condotta broker will write a clean charter for you.

In the Black Banners, the camp sings when payday comes and falls silent when the pay chest is empty.

Final GM Mantra (Black Banners Edition)

The camp sings when payday comes and falls silent when the chest is empty. Set **DV low**. Use **Allegiances in Flux** every scene. Let **Payday, Supplies, and Cohesion** be visible. Spend **SB** as false orders, cut supply lines, or camp fever. And remember: in the Black Banners, a broken contract costs more than a broken blade.

Chapter 12

The Linns

Skerries & Storm-Oaths.

The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds. To rule these shores is to dance between their moods and never miss a step.

I am a Net-Wife. I tie a knot for every storm I've survived. My belt has thirty.

North of the Aberderrin Sea, the Linns don't just raid and trade they do it with the fervour of the converted, swearing oaths to storm and sea that aren't just words they're leverage with a supernatural clause. They pay in stories, not silver, because to them, a tale well-told is worth more than a chest of gold... especially when it's true.

The jarls measure their wealth in ships. The skalds measure their wealth in verses. The dead measure their wealth in how many living remember their names. I measure mine in knots. Each knot is a promise I kept to the sea. The sea remembers. The sea does not forgive forgetting.

Never name a drowned person aloud while underway. The sea collects names, and if it hears you speaking one it doesn't recognize, it may reach up to correct the ledger.

Astrid, Net-Wife, who has never lost a sailor to the mist but has lost three to bad stories

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Seal blubber and flatbreadthe blubber is chewy, the bread is dense, and both are stored in the same barrel. The barrel is shared with the crew. The crew shares everything. The crew is family. Family is obligation.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To tie a knot. Linn children are given a length of rope at birth. By age five, they can tie the eight sea-knots: clew, clove, figure-eight, reef, sheet, stopper, timber, and the ninththe one that slips when pulled. The ninth knot is for emergencies. The ninth knot is for funerals. The ninth knot is for when the sea asks for a life.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their breath. Linn sailors chew kelp to sweeten their breaththe kelp is harvested from sacred beds, blessed by the Volva. A stranger whose breath smells of salt has been at sea. A stranger whose breath smells of nothing has not. A stranger whose breath smells of copper has spoken a false oath. The sea knows. The sea will answer.

What is the most common crime? Oath-breakingbut oath-breaking is not a crime, it is a storm. The oath-breaker's ship will founder. The oath-breaker's nets will tear. The oath-breaker's children will be born with webbed fingers. The punishment is not imposed by the jarl. The punishment is imposed by the sea. The sea is patient. The sea does not forget.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Sea-Queen is not a queen. She is a figureheadliterally. Her body is carved from the keel of a ship that sank in 612 AR. Her voice is a recording. Her throne is a navigation table. The jarls pretend. The jarls have always pretended. The pretending keeps the peace.

Where do people go when they die? To the waves. Linn dead are placed in boats and set adrift, weighted with stones. The stones are carved with the dead's name. If the boat sinks before it reaches the horizon, the dead is accepted. If it reaches the horizon, the dead is rejected. If it returns to shore, the dead is cursed. The cursed wash up on beaches. The beaches are littered with their bones.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a storm-oath. You stand on a cliff during a gale and swear your apology to the wind. If the wind carries your words, you are forgiven. If the wind throws you into the sea, you are not. The sea does not give second chances.

What is the most important festival? The Launching of the Longships (spring thaw). The ships are dragged from their winter shelters and blessed with blood and mead. The blood is from a sacrificed goat. The mead is from the jarl's own stores. The ships are named after ancestors. The ancestors are listening. The ancestors approve.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Volva of the Mist is a fraud. She cannot see the future. She reads the weatherthe pressure, the wind, the taste of salt on the air. The sailors know. The sailors do not care. A weather-reader is more useful than a seer. The Volva knows this. The Volva uses this. The Volva is never wrong.

12.1 Linn — “The Frost Ledger”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The sea writes in salt. The frost binds in iron. The skald remembers in verse.*

High Jarl (Elite): “The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds. But the frost the frost is the tally. It preserves what the tide would wash away. A promise sworn in winter is owed until the ice melts. And the ice never truly melts.”

Net-Wife (Commoner): “The water speaks to those who know how to listen the way it moves tells you if the fish are running, if the weather’s turning, or if something’s coming that wasn’t invited to the feast. My grandmother taught me to read the frost on the oar-blades. That’s how I know who will live through the winter and who will feed the seals.”

Genre / Mood: Norse coastal saga, oath-driven honour, horror of the unwitnessed death, the tyranny of seasons, the weight of wyrd.

Starting Location: A longship house lined with stormcharms and whalebone runes, salt wind clawing at the doors. A NetWife binds a stormtoken into a PC’s palm. “The WhaleRoad sings,” she says. “But the Mistlands whistle back. Bring us three keellengths of ironwood from the Valewood edge, or the tide will take our boats in the spring. The frost tally says you owe us for the shelter you took last winter. Pay, or the ice will remember.”

Theme & Atmosphere

North of the Aberderrin Sea, where fjords split the coast and skerries break the tide, dwell the Linn. They are traders and raiders in equal breath, their longships crowding the whaleroad and river mouths. They descend the Ylolka like an axeblade and cut into southern shores, or slip through the Thin Strip where the Valewood dares not touch salt. Yet even these stormoath people dread the Mistlands and the Valewood, whose fog and trees have no need of ships or harbors to claim their due.

The Linn measure their lives in seasons, not years. There is a season for raiding (summer, when the seas are open), a season for planting (spring, when the frost breaks), a season for governance (autumn, when the ships are beached and the Thing meets), and a season for survival (winter, when the frost tally is written). In winter, the fjords freeze, the longships are dragged into sheds, and the people gather around the longhall fires to settle weights, tell sagas, and wait for the sun to return. The frost tally is not a book it is a set of carved tally-sticks, each notch a promise kept or broken, each knot a story still unfolding. When a Linn says a debt is “written in frost,” they mean it is unchangeable until the ice melts. And the ice, in the high north, never truly melts.

The gods of the Linn are not distant. **Adar**, the AllFather, walks the ridges in a grey cloak, his one eye watching for those who break oaths. He is a manifestation of the Oath of Flame and Light, but the Linn know him as the god of wisdom, death, and binding promises. **Rorg**, the Storm Father, rides the clouds, his hammer cracking the sky. He is the patron of raiders and sailors, a Thorlike figure who laughs in the teeth of the gale. His cult is loud, proud, and dangerous a Rorg devotee will swear a stormoath by drinking seawater and shouting at the lightning. The Temple of Light calls him a demon. The Linn call him captain.

What you notice first: The smell of tar and salt fish. The creak of oars from unseen boats. The way everyone jarl to thrall touches a knotted cord before speaking of the sea. The tallysticks hanging from every belt, each notch a weight carried.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name a drowned person aloud while underway. The sea collects names, and if it hears you speaking one it doesn't recognize, it may reach up to correct the tally. Also, never refuse a cup of winter mead it is a test of your honour and your weight.

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

(A commoner's view, overheard at a winter hearth)

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish and sour bread the fish is smoked over peat fires, the bread is leavened with fogdamp yeast. The yeast is caught in cloth traps hung from the belltowers. The traps are emptied at dawn. The yeast is not alive. It is not dead either.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To ring a bell. Every Mistlands child is given a small bronze bell at birth. By age three, they can ring the eight notes of the wardchime in their sleep. The ninth note is never taught. The ninth note is discovered. Discovery is fatal.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their saltpouch. Every Mistlander carries a leather pouch of consecrated salt. A stranger without a pouch is either a fool or a wraith. A stranger whose pouch is empty is a fool who is about to become a wraith.

What is the most common crime? Wardsalt theft. The Aeler control the salt pans, and the salt is the only thing that keeps the dead from rising. A stolen pouch can buy a week's protection. The price is a year's weight to the Aeler. The weight is collected in labour. The labour is collecting salt. The salt is stolen. The cycle is perpetual.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The BellWardens are not chosen they are volunteered. A village that loses a warden must send a replacement to the Aeler training holds. The holds are in the mountains. The mountains are cold. The trainees do not always return. The ones who do return do not speak of what they learned. Their bells ring at a different pitch.

Where do people go when they die? To the fog. Bodies are not buried in the Mistlands the ground rejects them. Corpses are carried to the edge of the bellline and left for the mist. The mist takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking the lanes. They do not speak. They do not need to. Their presence is a question.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You ring the Bell of Atenment a cracked bronze bell that hangs in every village square. The bell rings once for each wrong confessed. If the bell rings true, you are forgiven. If it cracks further, you are not. If it shatters, you are banished to the fog. The banished never return. Their voices still answer from the white.

What is the most important festival? The Rehanging of the Lines (autumn). Every bellline is taken down, cleaned, and rehung. The work takes three days. The villages are silent for three nights. The dead listen. The dead wait. The dead do not ring.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Legate of the Mists is a wraith. She died in 803 AR, during a bellline failure. The Aeler rebuilt her from fog and memory. She does not know she is dead. She attends council meetings. She signs documents. Her signature fades after sunset. The documents are refiled every morning.

Wyrd and the Tvíhögg The Double-Cut Fate

The Linn do not believe in a single, woven fate. They believe in **wyrd** a web of actions and consequences that can be *cut*, not rewoven. A skilled volva (seeress) or a desperate warrior may invoke the **tvíhögg** (“double-cut”), severing one thread of fate to redirect another.

Mechanically, once per session, a character who has sworn a stormoath or carries a frost notch may declare a **tvíhögg** before rolling. They choose one:

- **Cut the Weight:** Treat a failed roll as a success, but the GM gains 1 SB and the character marks a **Frost Notch** (as if they had accepted a gift the weight follows them).
- **Cut the Witness:** Reroll any roll involving the sea, storms, or oaths, but the character’s name is added to the frost ledger in a hidden place. The GM may call on this weight once in the future (a complication, a recalled debt, a spirit asking for a name).

The tvíhögg cannot be undone. The Linn say: *“A cut thread does not grow back. You simply learn to carry the shorter end.”*

Regional Mood: Skerry Stormcall, Frost Tally

Power here is spoken, not written. A jarl’s authority rests on the weight of his oathchest and the sharpness of his skald’s tongue. Longships are not vessels; they are promises carved in timber. Every voyage is a gamble against tide, reef, and the attention of things that sleep beneath the waves. The Linn do not fear death they fear dying without a witness, swallowed by fog where no verse will remember their name.

But beneath the sealore runs the frost tally. Each Linn keeps a tallystick, notched for every weight they carry and every weight owed to them. When the winter gales ground the longships, the Thing convenes to settle the tally. A jarl whose stick is too deeply notched may find his hall burned; a thrall who has collected enough notches may buy his freedom. The frost tally is the true law of the Linn not the spoken word, but the carved one.

Prominent NPCs of Linn

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Jarl Skjold	High Jarl of the Southern Fjords	Unite the scattered strands under one oath	His beard is braided with silver from every ship he has taken. His tallystick has notches from three wars.

Volva Hervor	Mistseer and oathreader	Read the tides of fate before they turn	She speaks once a year; the rest of the time she listens to the fog. She reads the frost tally by touch her fingers are scarred from counting.
Astrid	NetWife (commoner exemplar)	Keep her village safe from the Hollow and the deep	She ties a knot for every storm she's survived. Her belt has thirty. She is the keeper of the village tallysticks.
Brother Halvard	Missionary of the Temple of Light	Convert the Linn to the Lens of the White Flame	He carries a waterclock to measure the hours of prayer, but the skerries have no hours. His tallystick is blank the Linn do not trust him.
Gunnhild	SeaQueen's Hand	Enforce the queen's will without drawing a blade	She never draws her sword. The threat is enough. She carries a tallystick notched with the names of every jarl who tried to cheat the queen.

The Draugr Jarl	Unfinished business (rumoured)	A dead jarl whose oath was never fulfilled	Said to rise from the ThingHolm when the ninth bell tolls. His tallystick is frozen the notches are filled with ice.
Einar Frost-Tongue	Skald of the Frost Tally	Keep the memory of weights alive through verse	He has never lost a verse duel. His tongue is forked he can praise and curse in the same breath. His tallystick is longer than his arm.

Names of Linn

Inspired by the northern fjords: short, hard consonants, compound words that evoke the sea and the storm. Surnames are often patronymic (son, dottir) or taken from a notable deed.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Skjold	Astrid	Einarsson	<i>the OathKeeper</i>
Bjorn	Gunnhild	Hervorsdottir	<i>TideReader</i>
Ragnar	Sigrid	Ketilsson	<i>BellSworn</i>
Halvard	Yrsa	Ormsson	<i>the Unfinished</i>
Torsten	Runa	Sturladottir	<i>WhaleBone</i>
Vidar	Helga	Haakonsson	<i>AshProw</i>
Einar		FrostTongue	<i>the Tally</i>

(Fjord/Skerry/Hall) Kelpskerry gut: a narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock; tideshed of longship houses with tar smoke and gulls for sentries.

Spades Places

2. **Kelp-Skerry Gut** — Narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock. *Kelp strands like dead men’s hair; row silently or the reef listens.* ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[STEALTH]’
3. **Tide-Shed** — Longship houses; tar smoke and gulls for sentries. *Each shed holds a keel’s ghost; old crews sleep under the floor planks.* ‘[REPUTATION]’

4. **Wave-Gate Reef** — Just off a raiding beach; only locals know the cut. *One wrong turn and the wave breaks over you twice.* ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[DEATH]’
5. **Runestone Causey** — Across tidal flat; names half lost to barnacle. *Touch the stone with your left hand. If it’s warm, the ancestors approve.* ‘[LEGEND]’
6. **Herring-Stairs** — Drying racks above cliff path; knives flicker like fish. *Workers sing a counting song eight verses, never nine.* ‘[LABOR]’
7. **Winter Hall** — Turf walls, smokeeye roof, benches crowded with shields. *The fire never goes out. Feed it a story each night or it goes hungry.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
8. **Mistlands Maze** — Reedchannels braid and vanish; navigation by instinct. *The reeds whisper names you’ve forgotten. Do not answer.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
9. **Boomed Harbor** — Iron rings in whalebone posts; controlled access. *The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
10. **Aberderrin Headland** — Current rips past wreck timbers in the kelp. *On foggy nights, the drowned signal with lanterns. Never follow.* ‘[DEATH]’
- J **Dolmis Waystation** — Low isle with fresh water and old weights. *The well is lined with copper. A single dropped coin returns as a blessing.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
- Q **Thing-Holm** — Flat islet ringed with stones for speaking and swearing. *The stones have ears; oaths spoken here echo for three tides. The frost tally is kept here, frozen in a block of ice that never melts.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- K **High Jarl’s Seat** — Above fjord, beacon tower glaring out to sea. *The beacon oil is mixed with whale fat. It burns green when a storm is close, blue when the frost tally is called.* ‘[WEATHER]’
- A **Whale-Road Horizon** — Open water where storms are born and names are made. *Here, the sky meets the sea. Here, the dead meet the living.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(**Jarl/OarCrew/Keeper**) Netwife who reads the sea like a tally and the sky like a mood; steersman whose tillerhand never shakes.

Hearts People & Factions

2. **Net-Wife** — Reads sea like tally, sky like mood; weatherwitch in all but name. *She ties a knot for every storm she’s survived. Her belt has thirty. She is the keeper of the village tallysticks.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
3. **Steersman** — Tillerhand never shakes, even when keel does. *His left ear is scarred he listened too long to a siren’s promise. His tallystick is notched for every life he’s lost.* ‘[REPUTATION]’
4. **Shipwright** — Pitch on palms, schedule in teeth; knows every plank’s story. *He names each timber after a dead relative. The keel is his grandmother. The tallystick for the ship is carved into the mast.* ‘[CRAFT]’
5. **Oar-Master** — Sets beat that decides if home is today or never. *He drums on a hollowed skull. The rhythm is a prayer to Rorg. The tallystick for the oarcrew is his own arm notches in the bone.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
6. **Mist-Pilot** — Ghosts boats through marsh lanes; reedrunner with secret paths. *He never blinks in fog. Some say he traded his blink for safe passage. His tallystick is knotted, not notched the knots are spells.* ‘[STEALTH]’

7. **Skald** — Verses buy silence, start fights, end them; law in rhyme. *Her tongue is forked she can praise and curse in the same breath. She is the only one who can rewrite the frost tally by composing a new verse that changes the meaning of a notch.* ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’
8. **Shield-Band** — Cousins fine with coin, better with cattle. *They sharpen their swords on runestones. The sparks tell fortunes. Their tallystick is shared each notch is a blood weight owed to the band.* ‘[COMBAT]’
9. **Foster-Son** — Southern coast birth; speaks both laws and subtext. *He wears two brooches one iron, one bone. Neither is his true allegiance. He carries two tallysticks one for the Linn, one for the lowlands.* ‘[POLITICS]’
10. **Thing-Speaker** — Makes war into lawsuit, lawsuit into lunch. *He carries a waterclock that runs on meltwater. When it runs out, so does your patience. He interprets the frost tally for those who cannot read ice.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- J **Sea-Queen’s Hand** — Envoy with sealbag and swordbelt; queen’s will made manifest. *He never draws his blade. The threat is enough. His tallystick is branded with the queen’s mark a seal that cannot be forged.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- Q **Sea-Queen** — Crown of hammered silver, eyes for weather and law. *She lost an eye to a storm or to a spy. She won’t say which. She is the only one who can order the frost tally opened.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **High Jarl** — First among raids, last to boast; paramount over strands. *His beard is braided with silver from every ship he’s taken. His tallystick is a whale’s rib too long for anyone else to carry.* ‘[REPUTATION]’
- A **Volva of Mist** — Oathreader whose nod stills surf; seer of tides and truth. *She speaks once a year. The rest of the time, she listens to the fog. She reads the frost tally by touch her fingers are scarred from counting.* ‘[LEGEND]’

(Weather/Reef/Feud) Black squall drops from clear band; oars or prayers pick one; fogfall makes friend and reef trade places.

Clubs Complications/Threats

2. **Black Squall** — Drops from clear band; oars or prayers pick one. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The wind screams a name. Listen carefully it might be yours. Rorg is testing your courage.*
3. **Fogfall** — Sound travels, sight does not; friend and reef trade places. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you. The drowned are rowing.*
4. **Boom Lift** — Harbor chain rises; schedules drown in harbor mouth. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The chain’s links are inscribed with names of those who carry weight. Each one rattles differently. Your name is on one.*
5. **Levy Clash** — Viterra’s wardens arrive with polite spears. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *They carry a writ stamped with the queen’s seal. The seal is still wet. The frost tally says the queen is owed three ships.*
6. **Keel-Rot Rumor** — Crews beach midvoyage; trust in timber fails. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The rot smells sweet too sweet. Someone poisoned the tar. The tallystick for the ship is missing.*
7. **Feud Token** — Raid becomes wedding... or funeral; oathweight called due. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *A bronze ring arrives on an arrow. The meaning is clear. The frost tally shows the notch.*

8. **Oath Matured** — Verse sworn last winter comes due today. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The skald clears her throat. The room goes cold. The ice in the ThingHolm cracks.*
9. **Mistlands Miscount** — Channels “move,” cargo vanishes without witnesses. ‘[DEATH]’ *The fog lifts to reveal a different shore. Your charts are now lies. The tallystick for the cargo is blank someone erased it.*
10. **Aberderrin Race** — Contrary currents split flotilla; half late, half lost. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The water churns like a dying man. Something beneath is feeding. The frost tally has a new notch.*
- J **Southron Fire-Pots** — Nightrun turns to daylight; surprise ashore. ‘[COMBAT]’ *Pots shatter on the deck. The fire burns blue alchemical. Rorg laughs. The tallystick for the raid is now firescarred.*
- Q **Thing Injunction** — No sailing till grievance heard (hours? days?). ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The ThingSpeaker smiles. He has all the time in the world. The frost tally is frozen no one can leave until it thaws.*
- K **General Muster** — Horns on every headland; all bays become spears. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The war fleet assembles. Your ship is the smallest. Adar is watching. He counts the notches.*
- A **Ground-Sea** — Long, blind swell rolls under; steering lies. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The swell has a rhythm two short, one long. A signal from below. The drowned are voting.*

(**Right/Token/Escort**) Harboreen mark dock without levy in named strand; oarshare claims two benches on fast longship.

Diamonds Rewards/Leverage

2. **Harbor-Mark** — Dock without levy in named strand (once). ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The mark is a notch cut in a bone. Match it to the harbor post. The notch must be cut by the harbor master’s own knife.*
3. **Oar-Share** — Claim two benches on a fast longship for a season. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The oars are carved with your name. Row well, or they’ll be recarved. The tallystick for the oarshare is the oar itself.*
4. **Pilot’s Token** — Mistrunner guides through reedmaze safely. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a dried eel skin. Keep it dry. The pilot’s tallystick is knotted in the same pattern.*
5. **Wharf-Right** — Dolmis waystation loading priority; first ashore. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The harbormaster frowns but steps aside. Your name is now on a list. The list is the frost tally’s marginalia.*
6. **Salvage Claim** — Flotsam on reef stretch becomes “inventory.” ‘[TRADE]’ *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim. The tallystick for the salvage is the tide line.*
7. **Thing Ruling** — Verdict in your favor that travels with you. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The verdict is carved on a whalerib. Carry it as a shield. The frost tally will not be opened for the same dispute twice.*
8. **Raid-Truce** — Immunity in named bay for one market day. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *A white banner on your mast. No one will attack openly. The tallystick for the truce is the banner rope. Cut it, and the truce ends.*
9. **Foster-Bond** — Guestkin by jarl’s house; hospitality guaranteed. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *You share a*

cup with the jarl. The cup is silver. The promise is iron. The frost tally has a new notch for both of you.

10. **Herring Allotment** — Priority barrels when the run hits; silver in season. ‘[TRADE]’ *The barrels are sealed with your mark. Break one to test quality. The tallystick for the allotment is the barrel hoop.*
- J **Escort Writ** — Eight shields and wolfbanner from cape to cape. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The shields are painted with a wolf’s head. They die before you do. Their tallystick is their swords notched for every oath kept.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Whisper exits as policy; sealaw bends. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Queen’s hand writes your words on vellum. The ink is her blood. The frost tally will record the audience but not the words.*
- K **High Jarl’s Pennon** — Levies open booms and mouths when it flies. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The pennon is torn from a captured ship. Fly it proudly or else. The tallystick for the pennon is the ship’s mast.*
- A **Storm-Oath Clause** — Temporary exception to any sealaw, sealed. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The clause is whispered, never written. The sea hears and obeys once. Rorg will remember. The frost tally will not record it the ice cannot hold a whisper.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (25 → 4, 610 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (rights/tokens/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **seaomens** horns on wind, white horses on swell, verse unfinished until landfall, the frost tally cracking.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Frost Tally (Weight Clock):** Every Linn community keeps a tallystick or a frozen block of ice carved with notches representing promises and weights. A character who accepts a favour, shelter, or gift from a Linn must accept a **Frost Notch** a 4segment weight clock. When the clock fills, the community may demand a service (a raid, a story, a season of labour). A character who refuses to accept a Frost Notch is considered an oathbreaker and suffers 1 die on all social rolls with Linn for the remainder of the journey. The Frost Notch can be cleared by performing a seasonappropriate task (planting in spring, raiding in summer, governing in autumn, surviving in winter).
- **Storm-Oaths:** A Linn may swear an oath by touching salt water. Breaking a stormoath inflicts 1 Fatigue (the sea’s disappointment) and gives the GM a free SB to represent the sea’s attention. Keeping an oath until its completion grants +1 die on the next roll involving the sea or sailing. Oaths sworn during a storm (under Rorg’s eye) are doubly binding breaking them inflicts 1 Harm.
- **The Season’s Turn:** The GM may declare that the current season affects certain actions. In **Spring** (planting), foraging and healing rolls gain +1 die. In **Summer** (raiding), combat and sailing rolls gain +1 die. In **Autumn** (governance), social and legal rolls gain +1 die. In **Winter** (survival), all survival rolls are Desperate, but clearing a Frost Notch is easier (the

community is too cold to argue). The season changes when the GM spends 3 SB, or after a major story beat.

- **Saga Reputation (Community Track):** Every Linn settlement has a Saga Track [6] that reflects the community's oral memory. The party can increase it by performing deeds worthy of verse (rescuing a ship, slaying a sea monster, keeping a difficult oath). At 3 segments, locals offer hospitality without question. At 6, the party gains a permanent epithet and may call on one favour from any Linn jarl.
- **Mist-Dread:** Linn characters suffer 1 die on navigation rolls when entering the Mistlands or Valewood, but gain +1 die on rolls to avoid supernatural fear (they have learned to dread the right things).
- **Skald's Burden:** A PC who publicly composes a verse about an event may choose to increase or decrease the Saga Track by 1 (as they shape memory). On a failed Performance roll (DV 3), the verse backfires and the track moves the opposite direction.
- **The Wyrd Track (Optional):** Each PC may maintain a personal Wyrd Track [6]. The GM ticks it when the character invokes a *tvíhögg*, breaks a small taboo, or is named in a skald's verse. At 3 ticks, the character feels the weight of unseen attention the first time each session they roll a 1, the GM may convert it into a complication of their choice. At 6 ticks, the character is **fated**: once, they may treat a failed roll as a success, but the GM gains 3 SB and the character's name is added to a hidden frost tally somewhere in the Linn lands. The Wyrd Track resets only after a major sacrifice or a pilgrimage to a *volva's* cairn.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **Adar the All-Father** Oath of Flame and Light. *The oneeyed god of wisdom, death, and binding oaths. He watches from the ridges. His tallystick is the frost tally itself.*
 - **The Storm Father** Rorg. *The god of thunder, raiding, and the wild sea. His devotees swear stormoaths by drinking seawater. He laughs at lightning.*
 - **The Salted Anchor** The Sealed Gate. *The harbour that never closes, the oath that never rusts.*
 - **The Wave Mother** Raéyn. *The tide that carries and the storm that answers.*
 - **The Drowned Chorus** Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel, the weight the sea collects.*
 - **The Unwritten Verse** The Witness. *The memory that survives the drowning.*

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The Draugr Jarl (Unfinished Business):** The ThingHolm is haunted by a jarl who died before his oath was fulfilled. He rises when a stormoath is broken, demanding a bloodprice paid in stories. The Temple of Light has sent three missionaries to lay him to rest; all three drowned in calm water. His tallystick is frozen into the ice of the ThingHolm. If it ever thaws, he will walk again.
- **Adars Ravens (The Witness):** Adar is said to have two ravens, Memory and Thought, who fly across the world each day and return to whisper in his ear. A Linn skald who prays to Adar may ask one question about a forgotten weight; the GM must answer truthfully, though cryptically. The price is a memory the skald forgets something unimportant, but it may become important later.
- **Rorg's Hammer (The Xhak'thul):** The Storm Father's hammer is said to be lodged in a cliff on the highest skerry. A character who touches the hammer and survives the lightning

may invoke Rorg’s wrath once per session: all enemies within Near must test Resolve (DV 4) or be Stunned for one exchange. The cost is that the character is marked by the storm they will be struck by lightning at the worst possible moment (GM’s discretion).

- **The TideWashed Covenant (The Hospice of the Salted Anchor):** A greyrobed healer runs a hospice on the edge of the Mistlands, treating wounded raiders and fogmad sailors alike. She asks no payment, but she writes every name in a book that never dries. Linn captains leave offerings of fresh water before a voyage; those who refuse find their ship plagued by the drowned. The book is said to be a copy of the frost tally but written in salt water, not ice.
- **The Ninth:** In any longhouse, the ninth horn blown at a feast summons the Hollow. The wise stop at eight. Those who blow the ninth are said to see a pale figure standing at the high table waiting to collect a weight. The figure is Adar, checking his tallystick.

Linn Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over the gunwale before a voyage. Ignore the first *Black Squall* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Oar:** Tie a single knot in your oar’s leather grip. Cancel *Keel-Rot Rumor* or take 1 die on your next rowing check (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the tide. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the SeaQueen. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Drink to the Storm:** Pour a cup of mead into the sea before a raid. Rorg will grant you favourable winds but he will also expect a share of the plunder. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **coastal guards or rival crews**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **ships or harbor watch**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-pilots**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.
- **Frost Notch:** The GM may spend 1 SB to add a segment to a character’s Frost Notch clock (as the community remembers a forgotten weight).

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local jarl or harbor master** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift or reef hazard**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival crew or levy force** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.
- **Season Turns:** The GM may spend 2 SB to advance the season to the next phase, with associated bonuses/penalties.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **ships, warriors, or skalds** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes **storm hits/oath invoked/feud declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.
- **Frost Tally Opens:** The Thing is convened. The party must defend their weights or be forced into a quest.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Sea-Queen, High Jarl, or Volva** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically **storm rises/reef shifts/mist closes in**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.
- **Adar's Judgment:** The AllFather appears (or sends a raven). He demands that a broken oath be mended or a weight paid in full. Refusal costs 2 SB.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Linn (Storm-Oaths):** Sudden calm, breaking waves speak names, verses come unbidden to lips.
- **Linn (Mistlands):** Channels shift without sound, voices call from reedbeds, compass spins.
- **Linn (Thing-Law):** Witnesses appear, oaths are demanded, skald begins composing your saga.
- **Linn (Frost Tally):** Tallysticks crack, ice sheets groan, a forgotten weight surfaces in a dream.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your color, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal)

- **The Net-Father (Nine Nets) Phases:** Harbor Favours → Orchestrated Wrecks → Thing Coup. *Cracks:* cut a cord lineage; reveal swapped verdict; survive a staged squall.
- **The Blue Cantor (Brine-Gospel) Phases:** Drownings Called Mercy → Procession at Reef → Tide-Baptism of a Jarl. *Cracks:* relic earplugs, survivor testimony, storm turning against them.

- **The Frost Jarl (Tally-Keeper)** *Phases:* Notch Calls → Ice Cracks → The Thing of Winter. *Cracks:* pay a forgotten wergild, speak a true name from the frost tally, survive a night in the ThingHolm with the Draugr Jarl.

Patronage & Power

Among the Linn, power flows through oaths, kinship, and the spoken word and through the notches carved in ice. Jarls maintain authority through successful raids and wise judgments, while skalds wield influence through their ability to immortalize deeds in verse or damn names through satire. The SeaQueen holds sway over the coastlands, but her rule depends on the respect of the High Jarl and the Thingspeakers who interpret ancient laws. And beneath all of them lies the frost tally the true account of who owes what, written in a language that only the Volva can read.

For the GM: Power in Linn society is fluid and performancebased. Patronage often takes the form of fosterbonds, oarshares, or raidtruces each binding the recipient to service and reputation. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, banners, verses) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival jarls issue conflicting claims, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the Thingholm and harbor gatherings as arenas for social contests, where oaths are sworn and broken.
- Introduce the Frost Notch as a recurring pressure. Every gift from a Linn comes with a weight. Players who ignore their notches may find themselves summoned to the Thing in winter.
- Let the seasons change. A winter scene should feel different from a summer raid. Use the Season’s Turn to reinforce the cyclical nature of Linn life.

In Linn society, your word is your bond, and your reputation is your greatest treasure. But the frost tally is patient. It waits for spring.

12.1.1 Temple Crusade Mini-Generators

Temple Pressure Events (d6)

Roll when the Northern Crusade advances or when the GM needs a story beat.

1. **Grain Fleet Arrives.** Temple ships unload cheap southern grain. Prices drop, but the old shrine offerings are forgotten. *Effect:* +1 tick on **Temple Pressure** clock; +1d on social rolls with hungry villagers for one scene.
2. **Synod Court Opens.** A Thepyrgosi judge hears the first case. Feuds may be settled with penance instead of blood-silver. *Effect:* Shrine-devout characters suffer 1 Position in this settlement until they prove their loyalty.
3. **Bell Tower Consecrated.** A bronze bell rings nine times at dawn. The old shrine bells fall silent. *Effect:* Temple-leaning characters gain +1d on faith actions; every midnight, the GM may spend 1 SB to have the ninth bell attract a hungry ghost.
4. **Schoolmaster Arrives.** Children learn to write Temple script. Old oral traditions are called “superstition.” *Effect:* The next generation will have +1 Temple Devotion; players may attempt a **Synthesis Scene** to save one shrine teaching.

5. **Bishop's Progress.** A high-ranking cleric tours the coast, consecrating altars. Refusal to host him marks you as an enemy of the Light. *Effect:* Begin a **Bishop's Favour** [4] clock; if it fills, the bishop demands a public oath of loyalty.
6. **Iconoclasm.** Zealots burn a seastack shrine or break a Thing's oath-ring. The old patrons are furious. *Effect:* Shrine-devout characters gain a free **Vengeance Oath** String; weather and tide hazards become one step worse for 1d4 days.

Linn Reactions to the Temple (d12)

How a community (or a crew) responds to the crusade's advance.

1. **Desperate Acceptance.** "We ate their grain. We owe them." *Tag:* GratefulSullen.
2. **Silent Resistance.** Shrine offerings are left in secret; Temple priests are given cold hearths. *Tag:* IceHospitality.
3. **Open Feud.** A clan declares the Temple an enemy. Raids on granaries begin. *Clock:* **Feud with Temple** [6].
4. **Syncretic Curiosity.** Elders ask the priest to bless a shrine. "Both fires warm the hall." *Opportunity:* Earn a **Synthesis Token**.
5. **Pragmatic Split.** The jarl converts; half the thing follows, half walks out. *Clock:* **Thing Schism** [6].
6. **Conversion as Revenge.** A family spurned by the old patrons embraces the Temple to spite them. *Tag:* BitterRighteous.
7. **Bread Bells.** The village accepts the Temple but keeps a hidden shrine to Hvítabjörn. *Tag:* DoubleAltar.
8. **Heretic Burnings.** Temple zealots execute a shrine-keeper. The hall is now **Contested Ground**.
9. **The Bishop's Bastard.** A priest's secret child is now a Linn raider. *String:* **BloodSecret**.
10. **WaveFather's Answer.** A storm wrecks a Temple grain ship. Shrine-devout see a sign. *Effect:* +2 on a shrine-related roll this session.
11. **OathRing Saved.** A Temple judge rules that the old oath-ring is still lawful a rare bridge-builder. *Reward:* **Ambassador Status** (one scene of neutral faith ground).
12. **The Silent Bell.** The new tower's bell cracks on the ninth toll. No one can explain it. *Omen:* GM gains 2 SB for fog- or ghost-related twists.

Temple Missions (d6)

Quests the Temple of Light might offer to a mixed or Temple-leaning crew.

1. **Recover a Stolen Relic.** A shrine-devout crew has taken a fragment of the True Candle. Find it by negotiation or force.
2. **Escort the Bishop.** Take a southern prelate through a contested fjord. Protect him from "pagan" ambushes or arrange one.
3. **Convert a Hall.** A jarl sits on the fence. Persuade him (or his skald) that the Light is good for trade. *Clock:* **Conversion** [6].
4. **Burn the Shrine.** A remote seastack shrine is a navigation hazard and a gathering point for resisters. The Temple offers silver for its destruction.

5. **Rescue a Synod Judge.** He was taken hostage after a biased ruling. Infiltrate the clan’s winter hall and bring him out alive.
6. **Forgive a Blood-Debt.** The Temple wants to end a feud by paying blood-silver from its own coffers. You must convince both sides to accept a delicate parley.

Faith Tension Scenes (d6)

Quick scene starters for religious conflict.

1. **The Thinglet at the Hearth.** Shrine-devout and Temple-leaning families argue over a broken betrothal. *Position:* Controlled Desperate if you take sides openly.
2. **Midnight at the Bell Tower.** Someone has silenced the ninth bell by stuffing it with wool from a white bear’s pelt. *Complication:* **Spiritual Conflict** Condition begins.
3. **The Convert’s Shame.** A Temple-leaning Linn begs you to smuggle her family heirloom (a shrine totem) out of the village before the bishop’s agents find it.
4. **Storm over the Synod Court.** Vélki answers a shrine-devout’s prayer with a lightning strike on the Temple granary. *GM:* Spend 2 SB to have a priest accuse the party of witchcraft.
5. **The Wandering Skald.** A singer arrives with a verse that claims the crew has a secret shrine oath. The verse is false but now everyone believes it.
6. **Dual Oath at Dusk.** A dying warrior asks to swear by both Hrævkn and the Light. The shrine-keeper and the Temple priest each demand you witness only their rite. *Reward:* A **Synthesis Token** if you honour both.

Syncretic Outcomes (d6)

When players successfully blend shrine and Temple practices, roll (or choose) a lasting effect.

1. **The Shared Cairn.** A new shrine uses a Temple candle to light the old oath-ring. *Effect:* This site is now **Mixed Quarter** permanently; once per session, any character may reroll a failed faith-related roll here.
2. **Witness of Both.** The crew is known as bridge-builders. *Effect:* Gain **Ambassador Status** (convert a faith-based Position penalty into a bonus once per session).
3. **The Ninth Bell Silent.** The village agrees to ring only eight bells, leaving the ninth for the old patrons. *Effect:* Shrine-devout characters no longer suffer 1 Position in this village.
4. **The Skald’s Compromise.** A Temple hymn is set to an old shrine tune. *Effect:* Any Audience tag that includes “Suspicious” downgrades to “Curious” in this region.
5. **Blood-Silver to the Poor.** A feud is settled by paying wergild to the Temple’s poor fund but the shrine witnesses the payment. *Effect:* The settlement counts as both a **Thing Verdict** and a **Synod Absolution**. The GM may not use this feud as a complication again.
6. **The Unbroken Spiral.** A new rite is born: a white candle and a raven’s feather are offered together. *Effect:* The crew gains a permanent **Synthesis Token** that refreshes every season (instead of being one-use).